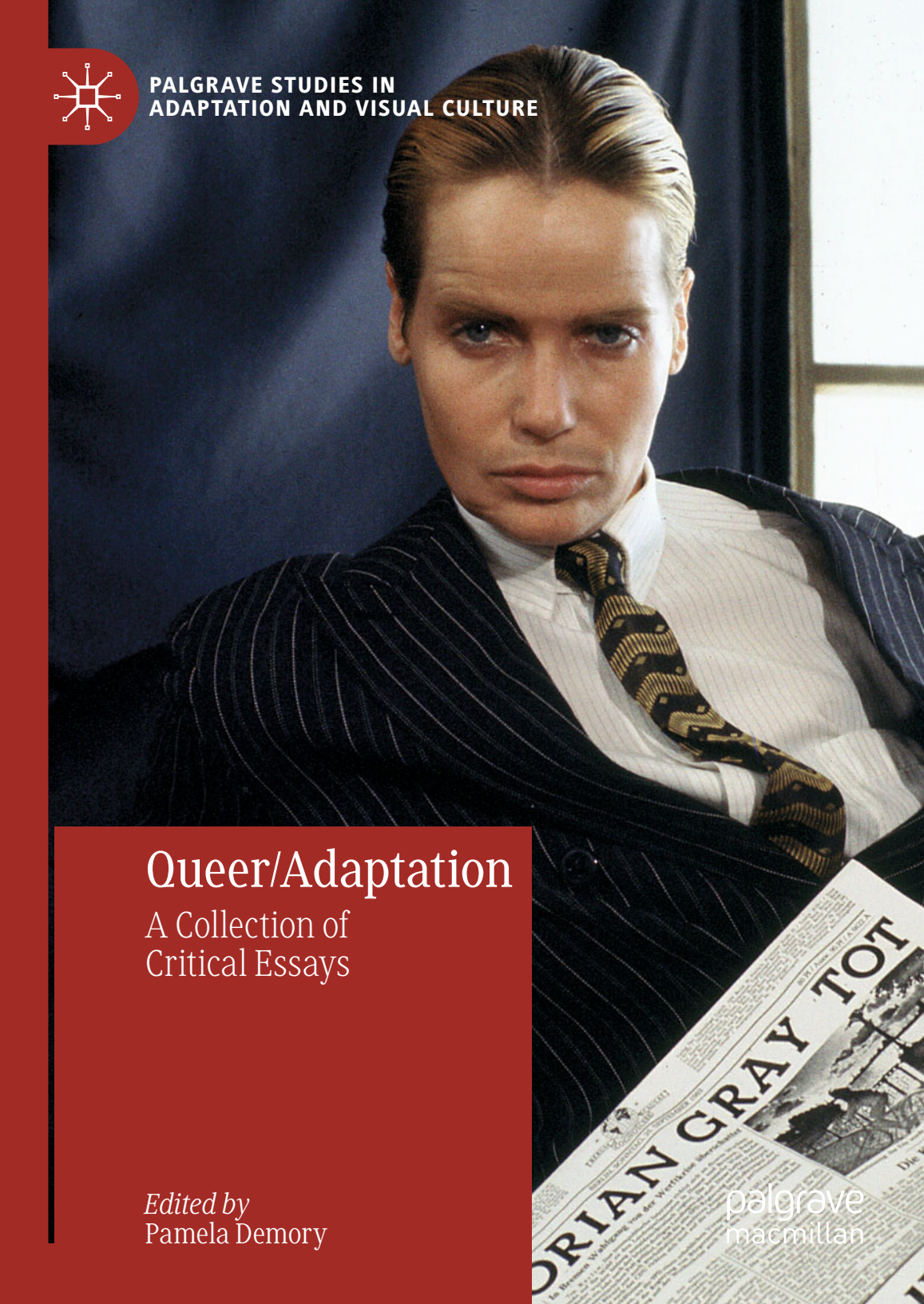


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Queer/Adaptation

A Collection of Critical Essays

Edited by
Pamela Demory

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CHAPTER 1

Queer/Adaptation: An Introduction

Pamela Demory

This book explores the overlap between queer and adaptation. Not just queer adaptation—adaptation modified by queerness—but queer/adaptation. That is, the essays here are exploring not just adaptations that are *about* LGBTQ identity or composed or adapted by queer authors but adaptation understood as in some way already queer. The slash in the title is purposeful; it suggests that the two terms are parallel theoretical constructs that can both orient the way we approach or think about a given text or texts. To adapt is to modify, to evolve, to transform, to repeat, imitate, parody, make new. To queer something is to make it strange or odd, but also to turn or transform it. To queer, then, may be to adapt; to adapt is to queer. Both adaptation and queerness suffer from the stereotype of being secondary, somehow less authentic. To identify something as an adaptation is to recognize it in relation to something else—something prior, something that for at least some people is more original and more true. Similarly, to identify something as queer is to place it in relation to something that seems to have been already established as "normal" or "straight." Foundational to both disciplines—queer studies and adaptation studies—is a critical challenge

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to those assumptions about originality, authenticity, and value. The essays in this volume explore a variety of specific ways that queerness and adaptation intersect to support that challenge.[1]

Queer is often used as a handy umbrella term for LGBTQIA+ identity, and so thinking about the intersection of queerness and adaptation will probably focus our attention first on issues of gender and sexuality. And certainly it is the case that most of the essays in this volume explore gender identity in some way—drawing our attention to gay or lesbian (or queer) screenwriters, authors, directors, characters, readers, and spectators. But queer also signifies something much more capacious and difficult to pin down. For some, its very resistance to definition is its most salient characteristic. For Chris Berry and Annamarie Jagose, for example, queer is "an ongoing and necessarily unfixed site of engagement and contestation" (qtd. in Sullivan 43); for Alexander Doty, it is "a flexible space for the expression of all aspects of non- (anti-, contra-) straight cultural production and reception" (3). Others emphasize what queerness can *do*: for Harry Benshoff, it "disrupts narrative equilibrium and sets in motion a questioning of the status quo" (5); for Michele Aaron, its power, "its sheer force, is not to do with its content so much as its stance, its very oppositionality to conservative culture" ("The New Queer Spectator" 198). Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick emphasizes the positive implications of queerness: "the open mesh of possibilities, gaps, overlaps, dissonances and resonances, lapses and excesses of meaning when the constituent elements of anyone's gender, of anyone's sexuality aren't made (or *can't* be made) to signify monolithically" (8). Defined most broadly, queer is "*whatever* is at odds with the normal, the legitimate, the dominant" (Halperin 62).

The promiscuous multiplicity of queer theory fits very well with contemporary adaptation studies theory, which is currently enjoying a growth period. Simply scanning the tables of contents of the recently published *Oxford Handbook to Adaptation Studies* (Leitch) and the *Routledge Companion to Adaptation Studies* (Cutchins et al.) reveals the comprehensiveness and diversity of approaches to adaptation being taken by scholars worldwide: from histories of the field, to reassessments of canonical literature and film, to popular culture, the role of technology and digital media, and the material conditions of production; from questions of identity, national origin, reception, performance, and genre, to interdisciplinary connections with biology, music, art, history, and translation studies. Adaptations are theorized and/or defined as allusion,

embedding, appropriation, palimpsest, pastiche, parody, version, interpretation, imitation—to name just a few of the terms Timothy Corrigan has collected in "Defining Adaptation" (25–27). The proliferation of approaches in these two volumes suggests a general consensus among the leading scholars in the field that more is better: Kamilla Elliott notes that adaptations are themselves "theoretically promiscuous" (682) and theory ought to follow suit. Cartmell and Whelehan profess excitement at the prospect of being able "to draw promiscuously on theoretical tendencies in film and literary studies" (22), and Thomas Leitch argues that the "strongest position" of his edited *Oxford Handbook* is "its resistance to the dream of settling the fundamental questions in adaptation studies" ("Introduction" 18). These concepts—pleasure in promiscuity, resistance to singular definitions—suggest that adaptation theory is already queer. So in this volume I am not proposing a new theory for adaptation studies; what I am proposing is that a queer perspective or orientation can illuminate adaptation—both in terms of its relationship to sexuality and gender and to the way it can help us understand the process of adapting.

Queer theory and recent adaptation theory intersect in a number of interesting ways. In what follows I identify a few specific interconnections/themes that recur throughout the essays in this volume: repetition, resistance, reception, pleasure, and performance.

Repetition is fundamental to both queer theory and adaptation. Judith Butler argues that gender is constituted through a series of repetitions: "in a sense, all signification takes place within the orbit of the compulsion to repeat" (*Gender Trouble* 198). Gender, she writes, is "a kind of imitation" ("Imitation" 361). Using similar language, Linda Hutcheon defines adaptation as "repetition, but repetition without replication" (7). In both cases, the focus on the repetition itself can call into question the identity or even existence of an original. Butler argues that "*gender is a kind of imitation for which there is no original.* … the entire framework of copy and origin proves radically unstable as each position inverts into the other and confounds the possibility of any stable way to locate the temporal or logical priority of either term" ("Imitation" 361). If we think of queer as a verb, as a doing rather than a being, then to queer something is to deconstruct it, to demonstrate the instability of all those apparently obvious oppositions—male/female, homosexuality/heterosexuality, normal/deviant—that structure our understanding of ourselves and others. The oppositions of original/copy, faithful/unfaithful are being dismantled by contemporary adaptation studies

scholars. Robert Stam has explicitly connected the poststructuralist dismantling of hierarchies to adaptation: "the prestige of the original is *created* by the copies, without which the very idea of originality has no meaning…. The 'original' always turns out to be partially 'copied' from something earlier" (8).

One of the most interesting connections between adaptation and queer theories has to do with resistance—to heteronormative conventions of culture, narrative, time and space, not to mention normative ideas about sexuality. As Robert Stam has pointed out, queer theory has in common with feminist, postcolonial, and race theories an "egalitarian thrust, … [a] critique of quietly assumed, unmarked normativities which place whiteness, Europeanness, maleness, and heterosexuality at the center, while marginalizing all that is not normative" (11). He goes on to list several implications of these theories for adaptation studies, including "a revisionist view of the literary canon" that would include more "minority, postcolonial, and queer writers" and "revisionist adaptations" (11). Julie Sanders, similarly, groups queer theory with feminist and postcolonial theories, pointing out that adaptations of canonical texts can "write back" to "an informing original from a new and revised perspective" and "highlight often perplexing gaps, absences and silences within the original" (126). She also ties this idea of resistance to what Adrienne Rich describes as "Re-vision, the act of looking back, of seeing with fresh eyes, of entering an old text from a new critical direction…. not to pass on a tradition but to break its hold over us" (qtd. in Sanders 12). A queer perspective on adaptation can be a way of resisting normative ideologies and of revealing the fissures, absences, or silences of canonical texts. As Julie Sanders points out, adaptations (and appropriations) of canonical texts don't necessarily accept those texts uncritically. When adaptations "write back" to their source texts, they often "have a deep political and literary investment in giving voice to characters or events which appear to have been oppressed or repressed in the original" (126).

Resistance for both queerness and adaptation is also intimately concerned both with the language of gender and sexuality—and with resistance to conservative ideologies. Shelley Cobb has argued persuasively that the value of fidelity—so persistent in popular discourse on adaptation—is rooted in deeply held cultural assumptions about the masculine/feminine gender roles and the "normality" of the heterosexual romance plot: "The language of fidelity constructs a gendered possession of authority and paternity for the source text within adaptation: the film

as faithful wife to the novel as paternal husband" (30). Cobb's feminist critique of the heteronormative assumptions buried in the discourse of adaptation could also be said to be queer. Conventional narrative (particularly in Hollywood film) centers on a heterosexual couple and implies a "natural" progression from childhood to adulthood, marriage, reproduction, and death. For Judith Halberstam, queerness "has the potential to open up new life narratives and alternative relations to time and space" (2). An adaptation, by critiquing or resisting a source text's conventional narrative structure or normative ideologies, might be said to tamper with the temporal dimension of its source text and, in so doing, queer that text.

Resistance may also manifest itself in the acceptance of what is apparently negative, low, or monstrous. A significant strain of queer theory insists on the value of recognizing, even celebrating, queer's negative connotations. In the words of Sue Ellen Case, "The queer, unlike the rather polite categories of gay and lesbian, revels in the discourse of the loathsome, the outcast, the idiomatically proscribed position of same-sex desire…. The queer is the taboo-breaker, the monstrous, the uncanny" (qtd. in Benshoff 5). To "queer" something once meant to "spoil" or "ruin" it, and to refer to a person as "queer" was to mark that person as disgusting. In the early 1990s, groups such as Queer Nation and ACT UP appropriated the epithet, using it as a shock tactic and taking pride in what mainstream society saw as contemptible. "Queer" came to mean a "militant sense of difference" that asserts the value of the "erotically 'marginal'" (Doty 3). Now, what Michele Aaron refers to as queer's "nasty history … keeps it on its toes, keeps it daring, dancing, and not only astute to the nastiness of the present, but capable of undermining it" ("Towards Queer Television" 64).

Adaptation has also been theorized as monstrous or grotesque. Julie Grossman, for example, argues that any adaptation might be termed "monstrous" in the way it resists the "original desires" of its source text, and—like the queer theorists who have reclaimed negative language for the purposes of critique—her goal is to "reclaim the suppressed language of monstrosity in order to expose the extent to which the label 'monstrous' is really an insistence on a particular, usually exclusionary, perspective" (18). Similarly, Dennis Cutchins, drawing on the work of Mikhail Bakhtin, argues that adaptations are (or can be) "grotesque." Bakhtin conceptualizes the "grotesque" text as a body that "is never finished, never completed; it is continually built, created, and builds and

creates another body" (qtd. in Cutchins 82). As Cutchins points out, this "suggests that grotesque texts create their own co-texts, and in the case of adaptation, generate their own adaptations" (83). This process—operating as it does outside the bounds of heterosexual coupling—could be termed queer reproduction.

So far, in identifying how queerness and adaptation function as repetition and as resistance, I've been focusing on what texts *do* or (implicitly) what authors do when they queer or adapt a work. This perspective assumes that the meaning of a given work lies with the author's intention or within the text itself. But reception theory holds that meaning does not inhere in the text but is created by the reader or spectator within a particular context. Queer reading, or reading against the grain—what Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick refers to as being "a perverse reader"—means deliberately reading texts outside the matrix of heteronormative convention (5). Such readings, or interpretations, can bring to light a "complex range of queerness" (Doty 16) within cultural texts that might not be visible to another point of view. This kind of reading might be viewed as adaptation—as Timothy Corrigan points out, postmodern adaptation theory suggests that "a 'writerly' text can produce an engagement—beyond traditional and passive 'readerly' relations—that encourages an active 'adapting' of it by a reader or viewer" (27).

The reverse may also be true—some theorists argue that the text adapts—or queers—the reader or spectator. Cutchins and Meeks argue that adaptation may best be understood as the reader or viewer's response to adaptation, that "those who listen to stories, read books, or watch films or television are actually in the process (at least potentially) of self-creation" (305). Michele Aaron argues that there is something queer about spectatorship itself, as it encourages us to cross-identify with characters whose expressions of gender and sexuality may be other than our own ("The New Queer" 187). Because of the erotic possibilities that Alexander Doty describes when we "playfully occupy" (4) queer spectatorial positions, any of us might experience "queer moments" (4) when watching a film or play, reading a novel or comic, listening to a woman singing a song written for a man, or inhabiting a video game avatar. Linda Hutcheon identifies a moment in Sally Potter's film *Orlando* that illustrates the power of an adaptation to change its audience: Near the end of the film when Orlando's daughter takes the video camera and starts filming, "she, like Potter and her generation of female filmmakers, does possess the power of the male gaze that women were said to have

lost with the medium of film.... the filming girl and her film together solicit a female gaze from the audience: changing the adapted text here leads to a change in the adapting medium, defying audience expectations" (126) and, I would argue, in that defiance, queers the audience.

A focus on the reader or viewer's experience of adaptation leads naturally to a discussion of pleasure, which is inherent to both adaptation and queerness. Adaptations exist because people find them pleasurable. For Linda Hutcheon, the pleasure of adaptation has largely to do with repetition—the reader or spectator finds pleasure in revisiting favorite stories or genres or worlds or experiences and in seeing them refreshed or updated or varied (114–116). The "knowing" reader or viewer who has, for example, read the book on which a movie is based also experiences the intellectual pleasure of intertextuality, enjoying the oscillation between the adapted text being experienced and the source text being remembered (117). For other theorists, the pleasure in adaptations has a distinctly erotic charge. Consider, for example, Robert Stam's description of adaptation as an "amorous exchange of textual fluids" (46). Or Gérard Genette's observation that "one who really loves texts must wish from time to time to love (at least) two together" (qtd. in Sanders 10). Bodily pleasure, promiscuity, infidelity, multiple partners, erotic play are all terms that appear in recent discussions of adaptation—all suggest resistance to normative ideas about sexual morality and thus are queer. Queer resists the categories of proper/improper, appropriate/inappropriate, moral/immoral, faithful/unfaithful. As Alexander Doty notes, "through playfully occupying various queer positions in relation to the fantasy/dream elements involved in cultural production and reception, we (whether straight-, gay- lesbian-, or bi-identifying) are offered spaces to express a range of erotic desire" that is deemed "unacceptable" or "immature" in mainstream culture (4). Using similar language, Sanders points out that it's usually "at the very point of infidelity or departure that the most creative acts of adaptation take place" (24); Fiona Handyside suggests that "infidelity can offer new explorations of identity and desire" (59).

Playful acts of queer adaptation might be located not only in the reception of a text but also in its performance. One of the basic tenets of queer theory is that gender identity is constituted through a series of performative acts. This conception of the way we "act" our identities has "had radical implications," as James Loxley explains, "for how we might think about the relation between theatrical performance and the

apparently real or serious world offstage" (3). The conception of gender identity as performance has implications for the relationship between an adaptation and its source text as well, particularly in theatrical adaptations, but potentially for any adaptation. Thomas Leitch has argued that one might define adaptation as performance, which would mean treating the source as a "performance text," "a recipe for a new creation" ("Adaptation and Intertextuality" 100). Anna Blackwell and Katja Krebs have both argued that adaptation scholars might productively focus their attention on the bodies of actors. Katja Krebs argues that the body itself can be understood as "writing," as "text" (207), and Anna Blackwell notes that "[a]n actor-based approach to adaptation studies … allows us to refocus the critical gaze by considering how the actor shapes the adaptation, not only in their performance but through their intertextual physicality" (351). Certain kinds of performances such as drag and camp have long been associated with queer culture and might also be seen as acts of adaptation. Drag performers use costume, makeup, wigs, and mannerisms to perform identities that may or may not align with their own gender expressions. Camp performances rely on a strategy of parody, exaggeration, and humor to draw attention to "the performative character of gender [and] sexuality …. to denaturalize, or queer, heteronormative notions of identity" (Sullivan 193). Any adaptation that plays with gender roles and/or sexuality—such as a Shakespearean play in which the romantic leads are played by two women, or a theatrical run of any play in which the gender of the actors changes from performance to performance—would be queer, and would be also an adaptation—through performance—of the source text.

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The essays in this book are organized into three parts. The essays in Part I—Adapting as Queering/Queering as Adapting—look at adaptations that deliberately queer their source texts. All four essays analyze this queering process and locate that queerness in the imagination and craft of the screenwriter and/or director. Each author defines queerness in a slightly different way. For Nick Bamford, who examines his own process of adapting Puccini's *Madama Butterfly* for the screen, queerness has to do with same-sex romance. His screenplay moves the story from nineteenth-century Nagasaki to twenty-first-century Bangkok and centers on an older man's romance with a young man rather than a young woman. For Tison Pugh, who examines the film adaptation of Agatha Christie's

The Mirror Crack'd, queerness is a result of campy excess rather than gay or lesbian identity. Likewise, for Scott Stoddart, who explores Tom Ford's film adaptations, queerness is not so much an effect of the characters or plots (only one of the films has a central gay character); instead it is something produced through the director's specific aesthetic vision. And for Mat Daniel, who examines Bryan Fuller's television series *Hannibal* in relation to the series of novels by Thomas Harris on which it was based, queerness has to do with an expansive ambiguity of both sexual and gender identity. Despite these different approaches, all four essays suggest that a queer adaptation (an adaptation that queers) has the potential to disrupt and disorient heteronormative narrative and stylistic conventions.

The essays in Part II—Bodies, Time, and Space—analyze what happens when filmmakers and producers push against boundaries of various kinds—time and space, texts and bodies, genres and formats. These essays are about the queerness of form. In my discussion of *Moonlight*—Barry Jenkins's film based on an unpublished, and inaccessible, play by Tarell Alvin McCraney—I focus on the way both play and film play with or queer a normative sense of time and space. Chiara Pellegrini, studying the adaptation of short story collection *The Safety of Objects* to film, analyzes the parallel between texts and bodies and notes that the boundaries of both text and self are permeable, allowing a queer exchange of identity. Queer J. Thomas focuses on *Interior. Leather Bar.*, a film by James Franco and Travis Mathews which purportedly adapts a missing sequence from William Friedkin's 1980 film *Cruising*. The essay examines the blurring of boundaries between documentary and fiction, between performance and identity, and between conventional morality and what the filmmakers refer to as "fuck-scripting." Whitney Monaghan and Stuart Richards explore what happens when queer filmmakers blur the boundaries of their own work—adapting and expanding successful short films into feature-length films. And John Lessard asks what happens when gender-bending television dramas cross national boundaries, confronting different cultural values and assumptions about sexuality and gender identity. In these five essays, the boundary between original and copy dissolves. The distinction between source text and adaptation is less important than the intertextual, palimpsestic relation between (or among) the texts.

The essays in Part III—Queerer and Queerer: Promiscuity and Multiplicity—explore adaptations that proliferate in promiscuous multiplicity, when one text generates multiple adaptations, or when one text adapts multiple

sources. These are also explicitly subversive adaptations, exploring transgressive or perverse desires. The first three of these chapters explore low-budget films that are, at least for some viewers, bad films. The subject of Shannon Brownlee's chapter, *Dorian Gray im Spiegel der Boulevardpresse* (*Dorian Gray in the Mirror of the Yellow Press*), is slow-paced and not particularly coherent or pleasurable. The horror films that Shelby Wilson analyzes—all based (at least loosely) on Sheridan le Fanu's 1872 *Carmilla*—are sexually explicit, violent, and suffer from low production values and "bad acting," as do the Italian and Spanish films that Fernando Gabriel Pagnoni Berns discusses in his chapter. And yet, as the authors here demonstrate, the adaptations are all worthy of study, particularly as adaptations, as *queer* adaptations, adaptations that queer, that reach out to queer viewers, and that express queer sensibilities and experiences.

Shannon Brownlee demonstrates the way that *Dorian Gray im Spiegel* wrangles queerly with its adapted texts at the level of its narrative structure as well as characterization, weaving multiplicity into its very fabric. Shelby Wilson argues that the *Carmilla* films, which perpetuate the fantasy of the queer female vampire on film, should be reconsidered as possible sites of feminist recuperation because they create an interstice for resistant viewing. The Euro horror films discussed by Fernando Pagnoni Berns rewrite Hitchcock, thus blurring the boundary dividing high art from lowbrow entertainment. And by moving away from heteronormative narrative tropes to focus on female subjectivity and deviant sex, they invite a queer reading in which heterosexuality itself is strange.

The last two chapters explore adaptations whose source texts have mainstream literary value (Truman Capote's *In Cold Blood*, in Michael Perez's chapter, and Alexander Dumas' *Lady of the Camellias*, in Jamie Hook's chapter), but these, too, explore transgressive desires. Michael Perez explores the queer textual iterations of the 1959 murder of the Clutter family, a terrible crime that made no sense as news or art, and argues that the cumulative effect of *In Cold Blood* adaptations constitutes a gradual increase of queerness that is only fully revealed in the 2006 film *Infamous*, which exposes Truman Capote as queer auteur and reveals the brutal effects of homophobia. And finally, Jamie Hook examines two adaptations of Alexandre Dumas' 1848 novel *La dame aux camélias*—Radley Metzger's "highbrow" erotica, *Camille 2000* (1969), and the Ridiculous Theatrical Company's stage play *Camille* (1973) by Charles Ludlam. These adaptations evoke Susan Sontag's dichotomy between naïve and deliberate camp, complicate the artificial binary between

notions of adaptive faithfulness versus infidelity, and open critical space for a queerer understanding of textual relationships to take hold.

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Although each of the three parts of this collection cohere nicely, the essays refuse to stay neatly inside the boundaries of the section to which they've been assigned—as befits a collection of essays on queerness and adaptation. They speak to (flirt with, cruise, echo) each other across those lines. They discuss a wide variety of texts—(a) the high art of opera (Bamford and Hook), canonical literature (Bamford, Perez, Hook), and classic film (Pagnoni Berns); (b) genre fiction (Pugh, Daniel, Wilson), mainstream movies (Stoddart, Thomas, Demory, Perez), popular television (Daniel), fanfiction (Lessard), and musicals (Hook); (c) international film and television (Brownlee, Lessard, Pagnoni Berns); (d) documentary and nonfiction (Thomas, Perez), contemporary literary fiction, (Stoddart, Pellegrini), drama (Bamford, Demory, Hook), and arthouse film (Stoddart, Pellegrini, Monaghan and Richards); and (e) low-budget horror (Wilson, Pagnoni Berns), camp classics (Pugh, Hook), and cult and experimental film (Thomas, Brownlee, Hook). Altogether, the essays in this volume provide an appropriately promiscuous introduction to the myriad ways in which queer and adaptation intersect, an introduction that I hope will provide inspiration and generate further scholarship.

Note

1. While this is the first book to explore the relationship between queer and adaptation, it is not the first academic exploration of the topic. See Fiona Handyside and Joanna Mansbridge for excellent analyses of queer/adaptation. Other articles that offer interesting/useful discussions of queerness and adaptation include those by Bolton, Carroll, Furneaux, Garrison, and Greer. Also see my chapter in the *Routledge Companion to Adaptation*, edited by Cutchins et al. Some material in that chapter has been adapted for this essay.

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PART I

Adapting as Queering/Queering as Adapting

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CHAPTER 2

Emancipating *Madame Butterfly*

Nick Bamford

In his book *The Celluloid Closet* Vito Russo argues: "It is an old stereotype that homosexuality has to do only with sex while heterosexuality is multifaceted and embraces love and romance" (132). In an attempt to redress this stereotype, I embarked, many years ago, on a project to create homosexual versions of iconic heterosexual love stories that had been delivered in that most romantic of media—opera. My intention then was to demonstrate that a love affair between two men can be as rich, as complex, and as romantic as one between a man and a woman. In the twenty-first century, the possibility of this kind of love story is more widely accepted, at least in the Western world. But the way such affairs tend to operate, in terms of the "rules of the game" remains intrinsically different. To provide just one example, heterosexual relationships tend to proceed from social intercourse to sexual, whereas in gay male relationships the reverse tends to be true. It is in exploring these sorts of differences that my interest in this kind of adaptation persists.

My first adaptation was a stage play, *Rough Trade* [staged in Bristol in 1988], relocating Dumas' *La dame aux camélias* (1852)—on which Verdi's *La traviata* (1853) was based—to the 1980s, and transforming the character of Marguerite/Violetta into a rent boy suffering from

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AIDS who embarks on a relationship with a young man coming to terms with his sexual identity. My second was a screenplay, *Love and War* [as yet unproduced], which adapted Merimée's *Carmen* (1846), which had inspired Bizet's 1875 opera of the same name. To explore the violence intrinsic to the story and its close relationship with male sexual arousal, I transformed the character of Carmen into an openly gay soldier, Carl, who seduces the dangerously violent repressed homosexual Joe (Don Jose) before going off with a boy band rock star, Eddie (Escamillo).

For my third adaptation, I chose *Madame Butterfly*, written by John Luther Long (1898) and adapted first into a play by David Belasco (produced 1900, published 1928), then immortalized by Puccini as the opera *Madama Butterfly* (1904). I saw clear contemporary echoes in this story—effectively one of sex tourism at the turn of nineteenth-century Nagasaki—in the sex trade, both gay and straight, to be found in twenty-first-century Bangkok. This was the artifact for my PhD by practice, completed in 2016, entitled *Emancipating 'Madame Butterfly': Intention and Process in Adapting and Queering a Text*. It is the process of developing and writing this script that I will discuss in this chapter.

In her key text, *A Theory of Adaptation*, Linda Hutcheon writes: "It is obvious adapters must have their own personal reasons for deciding first to do an adaptation and then choosing which adapted work and what medium to do it in. They not only interpret that work but in doing so they also take a position on it" (92). My main reason for choosing *Madama Butterfly* was that it is an iconic and powerful story, which had already been a novella, a play, an opera, several films, and a musical, *Miss Saigon* (1989). The opera is not, perhaps, as romantic as Puccini's music might seduce us into thinking—it is more about callous abuse and exploitation than about genuine love, though subsequent adaptations such as *Miss Saigon* have remedied that. Transposing it into the twenty-first century and making it homosexual would demonstrate that while so much has changed in terms of social attitudes and behavior, little has changed at all in the underlying story of the stronger West exploiting the weaker East, and so there was a political purpose to my adaptation as well as the one of sexuality. The remediation from opera to screen would require me to make the story more naturalistic and complex and the characters more psychologically real and multilayered, and it would require me to engage and move an audience through character and story rather than through music.

Although it is Puccini's opera that inspired me, and to which I principally refer, his version of the story is actually quite thin, lacking the credibility and depth of character to be found in Long's original novella or in other, later versions, such as *Miss Saigon*. The opera changes Long's simple, spirited working girl who speaks a kind of pidgin English into a demure, eloquent heroine whose Italian is exactly the same as that of all the other characters, whether they are American or Japanese, a characterization that lacks psychological and sociological realism. As suggested, the remediation to the screen required me to address this problem, but by far the most profound changes to the story were triggered by the process of making the relationship homosexual. With two men now loving each other, the heteronormative mold which contains—and constrains—the original was broken, and the consequences of this proved far more pervasive than simply changing the gender and sexual identity of the protagonists. If we accept David Halperin's definition of "queer" as not just a synonym for "homosexual," but as denoting "whatever is at odds with the normal, the legitimate, the dominant" (62), then what I have done with *Madama Butterfly* is, most definitely, to queer the story.

In essence, the story of this opera is disarmingly simple. An American naval officer—B. F. Pinkerton—is stationed at the port of Nagasaki in Japan. While there he decides to engage in a "Japanese marriage"—a common custom at that time by which European visitors would marry local geisha girls, knowing that they could end the marriage at any time simply by walking out. This custom provided a veneer of respectability over what was effectively prostitution. The girl he chooses is the fifteen-year-old Cio Cio San, known as Madama Butterfly. After a few weeks he returns to the United States, promising to return in the spring, unaware that he has left his wife pregnant with his child. Utterly in love with him, and rejected by her family, she bears his son, Trouble, and waits for him, along with her maid Suzuki. She rejects an offer from another, Japanese, suitor called Yamadori. After three years Pinkerton finally returns, bringing with him his American wife, Kate. Devastated, and following the Samurai code of her father that it is better to "die with honor when one can no longer live with honor," Cio Cio San kills herself with his sword, leaving her son to be cared for by his father.

As I approached the task of queering this story, I decided early on that I wanted to move away from the "coming-out" stories that, even to this day, tend to pervade gay-themed novels, plays, and films. Both my earlier adaptations had been such stories, but in the twenty-first century,

while plenty of people, particularly those living under illiberal regimes, still do struggle with their sexual identity, I felt that there were stories to be told beyond that process. So, as I began to identify my characters, I rejected the early thought that my "Pinkerton" could be married to a woman but be sexually ambivalent and visiting Bangkok to explore his homosexuality. And as I explored the social context of unashamedly gay relationships, civil partnerships, and marriages that now exists (at least in the West), new possibilities presented themselves that began to make those pervasive changes to the story and its themes of love and betrayal.

The emotionally faithful, but sexually open, relationship is common among gay male couples. In their broad-ranging 2001 study of contemporary gay lifestyles, *Same Sex Intimacies: Families of Choice and Other Life Experiments*, Weeks et al. examine this paradigm:

> Intimacies often survive the waning of sexual interest. A number of partnerships are asexual, but are seen as no less real and enduring than sexual relationships. Dan, now in his seventies, provides a good example of this. He considers his relationship with Simon to be the most important one in his life. While it is no longer a sexual relationship, it remains central to both of them. As Dan says: "We're not lovers any more and we have separate sex lives, but he's the most important person in the world to me." (122–123)

So Ben, as my "Pinkerton" would be called, sharing his literary ancestor's Christian name, could be in a pre-existing, sexually open, gay relationship. His sexual exploits in Bangkok would therefore not be intrinsically transgressive, unlike Pinkerton's behavior in the original story. At the start of the opera, he states clearly that he looks forward to marrying an American wife when he gets home, but he still proceeds to marry Cio Cio San with no intention of this being a permanent arrangement. Because his behavior is so clearly unacceptable, this character has presented many problems to other adapters of the story. In a 2012 email interview Richard Maltby, Jr., lyricist of the 1989 musical adaptation of the story, *Miss Saigon*, reported to me:

> Pinkerton was always the liability in Madame Butterfly. He was a shit and who cared about him, or really about Cio Cio San for loving him? I felt we had to correct this. They had to fall in love.

Although I did not feel the need to exonerate Ben to the extent that Chris is exonerated in *Miss Saigon*—where the separation of the lovers is caused by the *force majeure* of the fall of Saigon, not the callous desertion seen in the original story—I did want him to be a more multifaceted, complex, morally ambiguous character.

So, as his seventeen-year relationship grows tired, Ben takes advantage of a business posting to Bangkok to seek new sexual encounters. Cio Cio San became Chai, a young man who has come from the poor province of Isaan to make money in the city and hopefully find an older Westerner who will offer him a new life. Bangkok abounds with such young men who find their way into the sex industry, as reported by Peter Tatchell in his 1989 *Gay Times* article:

> The principal reason for working in the sex industry is poverty. "There's a lot of unemployment and jobs usually pay very little," says Lop, a twenty-year-old bar boy. "It's a good job and much better than going hungry."

But many of these boys are straight and simply do what they do for the money, quickly becoming cynical "money boys." This was to be a love story, so Chai needed to fall in love with Ben and therefore to be genuinely gay himself. That would give him an additional motive for leaving his village, because although homosexuality is largely accepted, or at least tolerated, in Bangkok, in the rural villages of Thailand it is not. Like his literary ancestors, Cio Cio San in *Madame Butterfly* and Kim in *Miss Saigon*, both of whom we presume to be virgins until they meet Pinkerton and Chris, Chai, despite working in the sex industry, needed not to be an experienced prostitute.

When it came to deciding his age, I encountered an interesting paradox. In the opera Cio Cio San is fifteen:

Butterfly: *Quindici netti, netti.* [slyly] *sono vecchia diggià.* (fifteen exactly—I am already old)
Sharpless: *Quindici anni!* (fifteen!)
Pinkerton: *Quindici anni!*
Sharpless: *L'età dei giochi* … (an age for games …)
Pinkerton: … *e dei confetti.* (… and of sweetmeats.) (act 1, translation mine)

Pinkerton's age is not mentioned, but he is clearly significantly older. To a modern audience, the idea of an adult man entering into a

sexual relationship with a fifteen-year-old would be controversial, if not outright criminal, and yet rarely is the opera seen as a story about child abuse. Little is made of this age difference in the text of the opera, and rarely is it made clear in production, though at least part of the reason for this might be that it takes a mature and experienced soprano to sing the very demanding role, and so the character's age is easily forgotten.

In today's world, at least in the West, while homosexuality is no longer widely condemned, nor even remarkable, the sexual abuse of children and young people is very much so, with the sex trade in Bangkok coming in for a great deal of suspicion and criticism in this regard. Had Chai shared Cio Cio San's age of fifteen, then my story would have risked being perceived as one principally about child abuse. I therefore made him sixteen—the age of consent in the UK (although in Thailand it is fifteen) and made it very clear that, when it happens, it is he who instigates the sex. But the age difference is still significant—especially as I decided to make Ben's age around forty, older than we assume Pinkerton to be—and this led to a crucial change of theme from the opera, albeit prompted by a lyric which is found there. In "*Bimba dagli occhi …,*" the famous love duet, Cio Cio San sings to Pinkerton: "*Vogliatemi bene, un bene piccolino, un bene da bambino* (please want me, like a little one, like a child)" (act 1, translation mine). With Ben around twenty-four years older than Chai, and Chai actively looking for an older man—he has lost his real father at a young age—that paternal element could be developed.

Gay men tend not to have children, yet their paternal instincts can still be strong and can become confused and conflated with sexual desire. Christopher Isherwood, for example, who was forty-eight in 1953 when he met the eighteen-year-old Don Bachardy, wrote in his diary: "I feel a special kind of love for Don. I suppose I'm just another frustrated father" (xxxvi). They went on to become lovers and lived together until Isherwood's death. Examples of love between an older man and a younger abound in gay stories—in one notable example, Britten's operatic version of *Death in Venice*, Ashenbach says of the boy Tadzio "I might have created him. Perhaps that is why I feel a father's pleasure, a father's warmth in the contemplation of him" (19). Even in literature less explicitly homosexual, we find the theme expressed: Shakespeare wrote over one hundred sonnets to the "Fair Youth" and paired Antonio with Bassanio in *The Merchant of Venice* and another Antonio with Sebastian in *Twelfth Night*. In the twentieth century, examples include Peter Shaffer's Pizarro and Atahuallpa in *The Royal Hunt of the Sun* as

well as Dysart and Alan in *Equus*. In David Lean's 1962 film *Lawrence of Arabia*, though Lawrence's homosexuality could not be made explicit, his paternal relationship with the Arab boys Daud and Farraj clearly suggests a gay subtext. The theme is explored more explicitly in Mordaunt Shairp's *The Green Bay Tree* although inevitably colored by contemporary condemnation.

Even in the context of contemporary emancipation this theme has very rarely been explored explicitly. One notable exception is Robin Campillo's 2015 film *Eastern Boys*, in which a middle-aged man begins a relationship with a teenage rent boy, but then, against the boy's wishes, transforms it into the nonsexual, paternal relationship he perceives the boy to need. As my *Madame Butterfly* version—to be entitled *Bangkok Butterfly*—took shape, this theme began to offer itself as a new, and rich, seam to mine. And as I sought the parallel for another, crucial, central character—the child of Pinkerton and Cio Cio San's relationship—the paternal theme began to move to the center.

Although Trouble is only three years old, and no more than a cipher in the opera,[1] his presence and emotional significance to both parents is essential. There could be no offspring from a gay relationship, but the screenplay needed a character with an emotional connection to both Chai and Ben. If this character were Chai's younger brother, who is similarly attracted to the prospect of life in the West but too young to be sexually interested in or of sexual interest to the older man, then Chai's motivation to stay with Ben would be strengthened and at the same time the "frustrated father" theme would be amplified. Perhaps, as they both progress through middle age, Ben's struggling relationship with his partner—whom I named Alex—is more likely to be fixed by having a focus in the form of a child to nurture than by the sexual variety they are currently seeking. As this theme developed I found an echo of paternalism in the preexisting relationship between Alex, the older man, and Ben the younger and more dependent partner, who has never learned to cook and continues to enjoy being looked after and not taking responsibility even at the age of forty. Chai's brother clearly needed to be older than three—I made him eleven and called him Tam.

In this way, from the problems presented by queering the story sprang a new theme and direction and, with the central characters and situations decided, the other characters fell quickly into place. The consul, Sharpless, became Colin—a colleague of Ben's in the Bangkok office who has lived there many years and knows the Bangkok sex trade well.

The marriage broker, Goro, who introduces Pinkerton and Cio Cio San, became Gee—the manager of the go-go bar where Chai works. As the script developed with the possibility of going into production this character subsequently become a ladyboy—Gamon.[2]

Queering the story had changed it in terms of its theme, as had, of course, the transposition to the new period and location. But as it developed in its new context, the queering process had even more far-reaching consequences. In the introduction to their 1998 essay collection *Fatal Attractions: Rescripting Romance in Contemporary Literature and Film*, Lynne Pearce and Gina Wisker suggest that queering romance involves at least the possibility, if not the inevitability, of subverting the implicit heteronormative conventions. Examining a number of reworkings of the romance genre in film, albeit not adaptations as such, they note:

> the radical potential of such reworkings—the point at which a "retelling" becomes a "re-scripting" lies not only in the extent to which they alter the codes and conventions of traditional romance (e.g., the sexuality of the lovers; the nature of the obstacles they face; the order in which key episodes take place), but whether or not they actively interrogate and destabilize the institutions in which those conventions have become embedded (e.g., heterosexuality, marriage, monogamy, the family or the prescription for same-race relationships). (1)

Madama Butterfly already challenges the last of these, but my ideas for *Bangkok Butterfly* challenged them all, and so the story was well placed to subvert the romance genre—absolutely chiming with my wish to demonstrate the differences between gay and straight relationships.

The story had, of course, been subverted before—in his 1988 play *M. Butterfly*, D. H. Hwang turned it on its head. This play was inspired by a true and extraordinary story Hwang had read of a French diplomat who had had a twenty-year relationship with a person he believed to be a Chinese woman but who was, in fact, a man and a spy. Hwang makes the connection between this and the *Madame Butterfly* story, with the Chinese spy being an opera singer, Song Lilling, who captivates the diplomat, Rene Gallimard, with a performance as Cio Cio San in the opera. The affair blossoms, and a child is even conveniently borrowed, echoing the child in the original story, but when the truth of the affair is

revealed—that Lilling is a man and a spy—and Gallimard is prosecuted, it is Gallimard who dons Madama Butterfly's dress and commits ritual suicide.

Although the affair here is made effectively homosexual, the play is not about homosexuality. Gallimard denies his homosexuality utterly and falls in love with Lilling because he perceives him as "the perfect woman": "Why can't anyone understand? That in China I once loved, and was loved by, very simply the Perfect Woman" (Hwang 76–77). Song himself says "Only a man knows how a woman is supposed to act" (Hwang 63). When offered Song as a man, and the possibility of an honest homosexual relationship—a clever version of the alternative suitor, Yamadori, who is offered to Cio Cio San—Gallimard refuses, preferring to die for his fantasy: "You showed me your true self. When all I loved was the lie. A perfect lie which you let fall to the ground—and now, it's old and soiled" (Hwang 89).

Hwang subverts not only the heteronormativity of the original story but also what he perceives as the assumption of the power of the West over the East. As Lilling says at his trial:

> The West thinks of itself as masculine—big guns, big industry, big money—so the East is feminine—weak, delicate, poor…. You expect Oriental countries to submit to your guns, and you expect Oriental women to be submissive to your men. That's why you say they make the best wives. … being an Oriental, I could never be completely a man. (Hwang 83)

As *Bangkok Butterfly* took shape, and Ben and Chai began their journeys through the story, it became clear that the stereotypical financially driven power of West over East that Hwang was repudiating remained and was a driving force behind the story. At the same time, the power balance between the lovers was very different from the heteronormative. While Hwang is exploring the dominant male/submissive female trope which defines that heteronormativity, in my version of the story, when the lovers are both the same sex—and acknowledging that—then the power, as defined by gender, is more balanced, and the relationship is therefore intrinsically more flexible, not least in terms of the sexual role.

Ben has the power of his money, while Chai has the sexual power of his youth and good looks. Chai is also the stronger personality. As the relationship develops, although initially Ben, as the older man, assumes the active sexual role, this is reversed when Chai takes emotional control.

Cio Cio San is without question a stronger personality than the weak-willed Pinkerton, who does not even have the courage to face her on his return, leaving all communication to Kate, his American wife. But because Cio Co San is a woman, and an Eastern woman at that, she cannot take that control. He is the man and has, de facto, the power his gender awards him, despite his intrinsic weakness.

The context in which Ben and Chai meet also demonstrates the ambiguity of power. The Bangkok sex industry exists because it enables rich Westerners to sexually exploit poor Easterners. But within that world the "money boys," as well as the girls, mercilessly exploit rich but lonely Westerners who lack sexual power. Peter Tatchell quotes Lek, a bar boy:

> "Are the bar boys exploited?" asks Lek. Answering his own question, he replies: "Foreign tourists come here, fall in love and leave broken-hearted. The boys earn a standard of living they could never otherwise enjoy. So who's exploiting who?"

While in *Madama Butterfly* there is no question but that the Western Pinkerton is exploiting the Eastern Cio Cio San, in *Bangkok Butterfly* that question of who is exploiting whom remains open.

Ben is looking for sex, and then, as he becomes increasingly disillusioned by the commerciality of what he finds, company in his loneliness. He is used to being looked after by Alex and does not function well by himself. Chai's avowed desire from the start is to find a Western man who will offer him a ticket out of Thailand. When they meet they both think they have found what they are looking for.

But that they are both deluding themselves soon becomes clear, partly because of the open relationship Ben enjoys with Alex. This paradigm, with its attendant questions of how to reconcile the physical intimacy of sex with a stranger and the emotional intimacy of a committed relationship with a partner, became another important theme of this story. It was also a theme of my unproduced 2009 script *Higamus Hogamus*, which tells of a straight couple who attempt to emulate their gay friends' open relationship but find themselves up against a variety of social pressures. Weeks et al. explore the forces at work in such relationships and observe that, "At an abstract level at least, the majority of men we interviewed could separate 'sex' from 'love.' But, interestingly, this is easier to put into practice for those who are in committed emotional relationships" (144). They go on to suggest that while single men use sex as a means

of finding a partner, those who already have an emotional commitment, find the pure physicality of casual sex easier, echoing Blumstein and Schwartz, who say that "in such relationships, sexual non-monogamy may be balanced by strong emotional monogamy" (qtd. in Weeks et al. 144). In *Bangkok Butterfly* these observations very much inform the relationship between Ben and Chai, with the former still emotionally attached to Alex, however troubled that relationship might currently be, while the latter is easily seduced emotionally because that is absolutely what he wants. His readiness to fall in love is exacerbated because he is young and because Ben is his first lover.

As I suggested earlier, this emotional connection was crucial to what was always a love story, even if a one-sided one in the opera. At the very least, it had to be a love story for Chai, and, given that I wanted Ben to be less callous than Pinkerton, for him too. So while Chai dances in a go-go bar, surrounded by "money boys," he steadfastly refuses to sell his body. As he later makes clear to Ben: "Man who get Chai heart get Chai cock" (scene 30). Ben's first sexual encounter in Bangkok is with one of these "money boys" who is straight and living with his girlfriend, and he finds it very unsatisfying. In the end, it is Ben's need for someone to look after him and cook his meals that leads him to employ Chai, albeit he is also far from immune to the young man's sexual charms. This attraction, meeting Chai's own sexual needs as well as his quest for a Westerner, results, inevitably, in a sexual relationship, and Chai surrenders his virginity to Ben. The emotional involvement follows because it meets both of their immediate needs.

Ben is still in occasional touch with Alex, but exchanges become increasingly testy, especially when Alex realizes that Ben is taking Chai out to dinner as well as to bed, thus suggesting more than a purely sexual relationship. This reaction from Alex illustrates a paradoxical inversion of heteronormativity that comes with the open relationship paradigm, where sex with another person is acceptable, but having dinner, with its implications of at least some kind of emotional connection, is not. Annoyed by these communications, and after taking Chai out for his birthday, Ben offers the boy what he wants—a life in the UK. Convinced he has now found his dream, Chai persuades Ben to allow his family—his mother Sumana, Uncle Banyat, and brother Tam—to visit. But the visit goes horribly wrong, and just as Bonze, Cio Cio San's uncle in *Madama Butterfly*, condemns her relationship with Pinkerton, so Banyat condemns Ben and Chai's and takes the family home, leaving Chai now utterly dependent on Ben.

In this turn of the plot, my story follows the original, except that Pinkerton says he will return to Nagasaki while Chai is to come to Ben's homeland. Like Pinkerton, once Ben has returned home he soon forgets Chai, settling back into his existing relationship and increasingly not responding to internet contacts. Meanwhile, Chai struggles to eke out a living working in a restaurant because he does not want to go back to the bar. His financial plight is exacerbated by the arrival of Tam, his brother, who is taken with Ben, and, more particularly, with the idea of life in the UK, and has also been sent to Bangkok to earn money.

In my story, because Chai is male he has a power unavailable to Cio Cio San—the power to find his own way to the UK. He also has sexual power, which he can use to earn the money to buy tickets for both himself and Tam and to blackmail a consulate official to get visas. But the cost is that he has to become the rent boy he always vowed not to be. And, when he arrives in the UK and learns the truth about Ben and Alex, it becomes clear that with no education nor leave to remain in the country, that is the only power he has—the power to exploit his body in order to make a living.

I have suggested how queering the story had already led my screenplay in a very different direction from that of Puccini's opera. At this point in the plot, that difference was expanded as the new theme—of frustrated fatherhood—came to the center. *Madama Butterfly* ends as the disillusioned Cio Cio San takes her life. The opera tells us nothing of Trouble's subsequent life in America with his father and stepmother,[3] and Pinkerton faces no retribution, beyond guilt, for his callous abuse. But in *Bangkok Butterfly* the refocused story plays out as Ben comes to realize the true nature of his relationship with Alex—that he has been protected like a son but now needs to grow up and at least share responsibility for the two boys—Chai and Tam—he has brought into his and Alex's lives. As is true for his literary predecessor, responsibility is not something he deals with well. The final part of my story, as the gay couple grapples with becoming parents, is a substantial narrative element entirely absent from all other versions of the story.

These new themes that germinated and grew during the process of queering *Madama Butterfly* enable it to be a new story while still echoing its literary ancestor. Audiences can enjoy the story for what it is, but if they know the opera which inspired it they can also enjoy another level of appreciation. As Linda Hutcheon puts it, "Recognition and remembrance are part of the pleasure (and risk) of experiencing an adaptation;

so too is change"; she adds that adaptations offer "the comfort of ritual combined with the piquancy of surprise" (20). Because I had broken the heteronormative mold, I found that my characters had more choices than did their ancestors and the story could have gone in many different directions. If Cio Cio San is the ultimate victim, trapped by her gender as well as by her race and guilty of nothing more than naïveté, in this version of her story I hope I have emancipated her in the character of Chai. He is still a victim of his circumstances, but he takes a more active role in his downfall and indeed exploits others in pursuit of his ambitions. He is no angel. Jule Selbo points out that "truly tragic characters must cause their own demise" and that their downfall is "due to a character flaw or major error in judgement" (75), so in that sense he is a classic tragic hero, just like his literary forebears.

If we accept Jule Selbo's definition of a romance as "an adventure" and "a journey," as a narrative that is about "wanting love, finding love, losing love or gaining love," and also about "examin[ing] the notion of true love" (92), *Bangkok Butterfly* remains in this genre. But I would define it as what Pearce and Wisker call a "subversive" romance because it "actively interrogates and destabilizes the institutions" (1)—marriage, monogamy, and heterosexuality—that are intrinsic to the romance genre.

I described my original intention to create stories that were "as rich, as complex, and as romantic" as their heterosexual forebears; I would argue that the freedom my gay characters enjoy because they have been released from the constraints of the heteronormative mold has, in the end, made my story richer and more complex—and at least as romantic as *Madama Butterfly*, if not more so in that the love is genuinely reciprocated. Furthermore, my research into the author of the text which prompted the original *Madame Butterfly* story suggests that I might be bringing it full circle.

Long's novella was clearly written as a critique of the earlier *Madame Chrysanthème* (1887) by Pierre Loti. Loti was the pen name of French Naval Officer Julien Viaud, who had enjoyed a "Japanese marriage" and who writes a fictionalized, and utterly solipsistic, account of it entirely from his own perspective with no regard for the girl. Outraged by Viaud's attitude and also inspired by another true story he had heard from his sister, Jennie Correll, who lived in Nagasaki, of another "Japanese wife" who had been cruelly abandoned, long wrote *Madame Butterfly* entirely from the girl's perspective to highlight the consequences of this kind of behavior. Berrong and Burke-Gaffney both

contend that Viaud was in fact homosexual, which goes some way to explain his utter lack of feeling for his Japanese wife. He could not relate to her because she was a woman. He certainly seems closer to his friend who might, or might not, be a rival for her affections and clearly enjoys looking at the scantily clad rickshaw boys. If *Madame Butterfly* began as the story of a closeted homosexual, then how appropriate that it should become an openly gay story in the twenty-first century, reflecting the dramatic social changes which have taken place in the intervening years?

In writing *Bangkok Butterfly*, I wanted primarily to tell an engaging, involving, and emotional story, albeit with sociological and political overtones. Without the raw power of music Puccini could rely on, I had to offer fuller, deeper, more multilayered characters in whom the audience could believe and to whom they could relate in order to elicit anything like the emotional response the opera achieves. Ben is no saint, but he is less of a pantomime villain than Pinkerton. Similarly, as I have suggested, Chai is a long way from Puccini's pure, demure Cio Cio San. I hope I have enriched the story, at least psychologically. If I have, that added richness is, very largely, a result of the far-reaching changes which the queering process instigated, in terms not only of the gender and sexual identity of the characters but also of everything they do. I hope I have not only created a story which can be enjoyed by anyone, whether or not they know *Madama Butterfly*, but also offered more for them to reflect on if they do.

Notes

1. Interestingly, and appropriately, he was played in Anthony Minghella's 2006 production by a puppet.
2. As the script develops toward possible production, many changes are still being made, more names might change, and some characters might go—reinforcing the point that characters in the source text have no automatic right to a place in the adaptation, which must become its own story.
3. This is explored in David Rain's 2012 novel *The Heat of the Sun*.

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CHAPTER 3

Queering Dame Agatha Christie: Barry Sandler's Camp Adaptation of *The Mirror Crack'd* (1980)

Tison Pugh

With such films as *Kansas City Bomber* (1972), *Gable and Lombard* (1976), and *The Duchess and the Dirtwater Fox* (1976), screenwriter Barry Sandler established his name in the 1970s as one of Hollywood's freshest and most prolific talents. In the 1980s he penned *Making Love* (1982), the first major studio release depicting a gay romance, and *Crimes of Passion* (1984), a thriller recognized as one of director Ken Russell's most daring and engrossing films. Among the other notable highlights of his career, Sandler transformed Dame Agatha Christie's *The Mirror Crack'd* (novel 1962; film 1980) into a campy gem through his gleefully decadent screenplay. Following the success of producers John Brabourne and Richard Goodwin's blockbuster adaptations of Christie's *Murder on the Orient Express* (1974) and *Death on the Nile* (1978), and with similar over-the-top Hollywood panache, the film adaptation of *The Mirror Crack'd* features an all-star cast, notably Angela Lansbury as Christie's beloved detective Miss Marple, along with Elizabeth Taylor,

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Rock Hudson, Tony Curtis, Kim Novak, and other celebrities. Director Guy Hamilton, who is best remembered for his work on the James Bond franchise, including *Goldfinger* (1964), *Diamonds Are Forever* (1971), *Live and Let Die* (1973), and *The Man with the Golden Gun* (1974), joined this talented screenwriter and these big stars. With this pedigree, *The Mirror Crack'd* promised a familiar formula of cinematic adaptation yet one that Sandler leavened with unexpected camp pleasures.

Within cinema's collaborative milieu, screenwriters seeking a camp effect face the challenge of achieving their humorous vision through the coordinated efforts of the director, actors, and other professionals creatively contributing to the film's production. Given these conditions, *The Mirror Crack'd* illustrates the potential and pitfalls of queer adaptation, particularly when the director's vision fails to align with the screenwriter's. Within the ambit of this essay, the term *queer adaptation* refers to any of the variety of ways in which a source text is repurposed for another medium while highlighting the expression of transgressive desires, whether those desires are grounded in the erotic, aesthetic, or another field. In so doing, a queer adaptation might accelerate or contain the queerness depicted in its source. Acceleration and containment are exemplified, respectively, by Frank Perry's over-the-top staging of Christina Crawford's *Mommie Dearest* (memoir 1978; film 1981), which transmutes the horrors of child abuse into campy hysterics, and Steven Spielberg's restrained staging of Alice Walker's *The Color Purple* (novel 1982; film 1985), which cloaks the lesbianism at the novel's heart. Balancing this binary, certain queer adaptations aim for fidelity—an admittedly conflicted term in adaptation studies but one that appears appropriate for such films as James Ivory's version of E. M. Forster's *Maurice* (novel written 1913–14 and published 1971; film 1987) and Ang Lee's version of Annie Proulx's *Brokeback Mountain* (short story 1997; film 2005).

At first glance, Christie's *The Mirror Crack'd* would not appear a particularly apt vehicle for camp humor, as it follows the traditional and rather staid parameters of the murder mystery, and so Sandler's rollicking adaptation belongs firmly to the accelerative mode of queer adaptation. Susan Sontag famously defined camp as "a vision of the world in terms of style—but a particular kind of style. It is the love of the exaggerated, the 'off,' of things-being-what-they-are-not" (279). She further suggests, "Camp is art that proposes itself seriously, but cannot be taken altogether seriously because it is 'too much'" (284). Camp often begins with

parody, yet as Moe Meyer proposes, "Camp emerges as specifically queer parody possessing cultural and ideological analytic potential. . . . Parody becomes the process whereby the marginalized and disenfranchised advance their own interests" (11). With this form of queer parody, camp enables artists to speak back to dominant forms of discourse, even to such light genres like detective fiction. Of key importance in understanding the ways in which camp functions in *The Mirror Crack'd* is the way in which subversive humor builds queer communities, as Philip Core argues: "Besides being a signal, camp was and remains the way in which homosexuals and other groups of people with double lives can find a *lingua franca*" (9). Yet for screenwriters, the challenges of camp are magnified in the fact that they can parody existing cultural artifacts and pen camp dialogue but cannot ensure camp stagings and camp performances to capture their vision. That is to say, queer screenwriters can never ensure that Hollywood's power structures—most clearly enforced by the producers bankrolling the project and the directors controlling its filming—will respect their artistic vision and instead seek to normalize any transgressive pleasures they aspire to create.

On his way to creating a camp gem, Sandler was confronted with a decidedly non-campy source text in *The Mirror Crack'd*. Eliot Singer observes of the murder mystery's foundational structure that "there be an apparent crime (usually a murder), that someone seek to solve that crime, and that the reader not learn of the solution until the final epiphany" (166). In the novel (and with these storylines followed in the film), victim Heather Badcock dies at a reception hosted by actress Marina Gregg (Elizabeth Taylor), but investigators soon become convinced that Marina was the killer's intended victim. Sidelined by the infirmities of age, Miss Marple (Angela Lansbury) relies on her nephew, Inspector Craddock (Edward Fox), to keep her apprised of the investigation's progress as he interviews the many suspects. (This stricture limits the screenwriter, as Sandler avers: "Miss Marple can't launch an investigation; she has to do it through [Craddock's] investigation." Given these conditions, Sandler was "kind of saddled with that; it's hard to make her an active heroine.") Craddock pursues his investigation by interrogating the prime suspects, including Marina's husband Jason Rudd (Rock Hudson); Jason's infatuated secretary Ella Zielinsky (Geraldine Chaplin); Marina's former romantic rival Lola Brewster (Kim Novak); and producer Ardwyck Fenn, renamed Martin N. Fenn in the film (Tony Curtis). Through her keen attention to detail and her powers of deduction, Miss Marple

solves the crime. Following a chance encounter many years ago, Heather infected Marina with German measles while she was pregnant, resulting in her child being born with severe intellectual disabilities. Stunned to meet the woman who precipitated such emotional agony, Marina poisons her own drink, surreptitiously jogs Heather's elbow, and then insists that Heather take her drink, with the victim expiring soon after.

For many readers, the chief attraction of murder mysteries arises in the puzzles that authors have created, with interpretive pleasure sparked as they match wits with fictional detectives. Adaptations dramatizing these narratives, whether on stage or screen, face the difficulty of imbuing deeper emotional resonance to a cerebral challenge populated, for the most part, with characters requiring simply a reasonable motive for murder rather than a fully drawn emotional core. Beatrix Hesse hypothesizes that "the detective novel is mainly interested in Knowledge, [whereas] the crime play is more concerned with Emotion" (196).[1] Furthermore, many mystery novels, notwithstanding the emotional impact of a murder or other such heinous crime, often metamorphose into a somewhat static narrative trajectory, in which the detective simply interviews the various suspects. A story that begins with a shocking action devolves into a series of conversations, and so authors frequently depict additional murders to accelerate this framework. Such a rigid narrative structure would, in many ways, appear unamenable to the visual and kinetic nature of film, let alone to the freewheeling and excessive antics of camp.

The film version of *The Mirror Crack'd* adheres to the basic trajectory of Christie's plot, which, as Sandler declares, was required by the film's licensing agreement: "according to the terms of the Christie estate, you had to stick to the exact plot; you couldn't change the killer or suspects." Expanding on this point, Sandler mentions the filmmakers were granted a degree of artistic license in that they "could create new dialogue and conflicts, [and] could change settings." Along with any such contractual requirements, cinematic adaptations frequently must streamline their source narrative due to film's standard temporal parameters of roughly ninety minutes to two hours. In light of these constraints, several peripheral characters were omitted, including Miss Knight, Miss Marple's officious and annoying companion assisting her during her convalescence; Arthur Badcock, Heather Badcock's husband and Marina Gregg's first husband; Hailey Preston, Jason Rudd's assistant; and Dr. Gilchrist, Marina's physician. Margot Bence remains in the film

as the photographer who captures the shot of Marina standing frozen while Heather Badcock prattles, but she loses her status as a suspect. The plotline concerning Marina's adopted and then abandoned children, of whom Margot is one, is mentioned briefly yet remains undeveloped as a potential motive. Numerous other minor changes could be mentioned, but more significant than any shift in the plotline is Sandler's campy shift in tone and dialogue, resulting in a film illustrating the humorous possibilities of queer adaptation.

Comedy provides a critical means for screenwriters to energize the pacing of a murder mystery that might otherwise consist mainly of a series of interviews, and as Philip Jenkinson notes, "[many] Agatha Christie adaptations have attempted to up-date their material with humour" (177). *Death on the Nile* illustrates this practice, with Christie's novel enlivened by Angela Lansbury stealing scenes as the oft-inebriated Mrs. Salome Otterbourne. Bette Davis and Maggie Smith's petty bickering in their roles as Mrs. Van Schuyler and Miss Bowers leavens the seriousness of murder with humor, not to mention the image of young Egyptian boys mooning Bette Davis / Mrs. Van Schuyler as she serenely sits on the boat's deck observing the view. Of course, this is not to suggest that Christie's novels are themselves humorless. On the contrary, Christie often intersperses moments of wry comedy into her storylines, such as in *The Mirror Crack'd* when Miss Knight suggests that she will make Miss Marple a "nice eggnog" and pedantically prompts, "We'd like that, wouldn't we?" to which Miss Marple demurely replies with sweet yet arch irony: "I don't know whether *you* would like it. . . . *I* should be delighted for you to have it if you would like it" (164–165; italics in original). Indeed, Marty Knepper identifies *Murder in the Vicarage*, Miss Marple's debut novel, as "a marvelous comedy of manners" (68)—a testimony to Christie's comedic talents that her mysteries have at times eclipsed.

This central ingredient of humor in the Christie canon, both in its literary and cinematic incarnations, was notably absent in the first draft of the screenplay for *The Mirror Crack'd*, which was penned by British writer Jonathan Hales. Hales achieved notable success in the 1970s with such television programs as *Manhunt* and *The Guardians*, with his most commercial triumph coming later in his career with *Star Wars: Episode 2—Attack of the Clones* (2002). As is common with Hollywood screenwriting, although Hales and Sandler share a screen credit, they did not collaborate on the project. As Sandler explains, "The script wasn't

quite working," and so "the producers wanted an American writer to modernize it." He further observes, "Hales's script was very British, and the Americans were subsidiary characters. They had no life, no color, and so I wanted to give it a bitchier sensibility. The producers said, 'Great! Go for it!'" And go for it, he did, with great gusto.

Although Christie's humor does not fall within the purview of camp, nor do most of the adaptations of her work, she evinces a keen interest in theatricality, with the exaggerations of this trope conducive to camp humor. As R. A. York comments, "Theatricality is in fact one of the basic concerns and one of the basic mechanisms of the Christie novels," noting further that "many of the central characters in her novels are professional actors" (41). Because they are adept at assuming roles and feigning emotions, actors frequently appear as suspects in Christie's cast of characters, and her murderers must by necessity hone their skills in dissembling—until they are revealed as the killers. With a formulation readily applicable to Marina Gregg, Merja Makinen affirms, "The type of the Hollywood actress comes to stand for self-absorbed egotism in Christie's work" (82). "Self-absorbed egotism" is also the hallmark of divas and drag queens in the exaggerated theatricality that stands as camp's hallmark. This is not to suggest that Sandler transforms Elizabeth Taylor into a drag queen in her role—although the excessive performance of gender allows such a reading—but that he exploited the big egos and bigger insecurities rampant in the entertainment industry for the deep humor of shallow behavior.

In accentuating Christie's interest in Hollywood, film, and performativity throughout *The Mirror Crack'd*, Sandler highlights recurring themes in Christie's corpus, which he further imbues with camp humor. Sandler's screenplay begins with a parody of the murder mystery genre, both in its novelistic and cinematic incarnations, in order simultaneously to pay homage to and to subvert the genre's foundations. A story filmed in black and white unfolds on the screen, with the establishing shot of an English manor house accompanied by the sound of thunder cracking to create the effect of a (clichéd) "dark and stormy night." As the camera moves inside, viewers observe the (clichéd) butler greeting the (clichéd) detective clad in a (clichéd and obviously inspired by Sherlock Holmes) tweed coat. The detective enters the drawing room and (clichéd) dialogue ensues. Mr. Montrose, one of the suspects in the murder of Lord Fenley, protests, "Inspector, you're not trying to imply that one of us could have actually performed such a loathsome deed?" to which

the Inspector gravely replies, "Not only do I believe it, Mr. Montrose, but I have the evidence to prove it. All of you had sufficient motive. It could have been … any one of you." The Inspector then expostulates at length upon the various suspects and their potential (and convoluted) motives for the murder as he leads up to this scene's final cliché: the grand reveal of the murderer's identity. "Very well, then," the Inspector declares, "Lord Fenley's murderer …" A broken projector ends this film within a film, and it is here that the purposeful clichés of *The Mirror Crack'd* end as well. This film that viewers might have presumed they are watching is revealed to be a macguffin, a distraction entitled *Murder at Midnight* rather than the titular film itself and one that Miss Marple breezily solves for her fellow audience members. As Sandler details, "the opening scene establishes Marple as the heroine," for she sees through the tropes of the mystery genre that Sandler exposes so that he may then supersede them as the film progresses. Later in the film, Jason Rudd tells Inspector Craddock, "You've been seeing too many Charlie Chan movies, Inspector"—another sure sign that Sandler knows the tropes of the murder mystery genre and deploys them atypically and, ultimately, to camp ends.

A key trope of camp humor is simultaneously to revel in and to strip away the artifice of art and performance. As Richard Dyer suggests: "Camp, by drawing attention to the artifices employed by artists, can constantly remind us that what we are seeing is only a view of life. This doesn't stop us enjoying it, but it does stop us believing too readily everything we are shown" (13). In Christie's *The Mirror Crack'd*, readers are informed of Marina's and Lola's shared occupation as actresses yet the novel does not thematize the artifice of performance to take advantage of the duplicities available from their rivalry. In contrast, Sandler sets much of the film directly in the cinematic world to exploit the untapped humor of Hollywood egos invading the small English village of St. Mary Mead. Sandler's Miss Marple echoes Dyer's viewpoint in her assessment of the cinematic world: "I read not too long ago about Hollywood: 'Underneath all that phony tinsel lies the real tinsel.'" Her words provide a suitable theme for the film as a whole, for Sandler creates the film's "real tinsel"—its humor—underneath the standard plotline of a Christie mystery novel. This delight in artifice emerges as well in various characters' constructions of themselves for public consumption. When producer Martin N. Fenn is asked what his middle initial stands for, he puffily replies, "I'll tell you what it stands for. Nothing. But it

sure looks great on that big silver screen, doesn't it?" In a camp world, artifice is the only reality that matters.

Certainly, a key camp pleasure of the film *The Mirror Crack'd* arises in the pitched battles between Marina and Lola, a plot point that supplies its wittiest, bitchiest dialogue. While forcing smiles for a photographer, the two actresses spar, with Marina drawing first blood: "What are you supposed to be, a birthday cake? Too bad everybody's had a piece." As the photographer requests, "Can we have a big smile, ladies?" Lola obliges, as she also coolly counterattacks: "Chin up, darling. Both of them." The photographer then encourages the women, "A little bit closer, please, ladies," and Marina prepares her enemy for the coup de grâce: "Lola, dear, you know there really are only two things I dislike about you." Taking the bait, Lola queries, "Really? What are they?" Marina graciously snarls: "Your face." Wearing big hats, standing in contrasting costuming of pink and purple, and plastering on wearied smiles, Taylor and Novak play their catfight with steely determination and cutting humor (see Fig. 3.1). And as Sandler recalls, although Taylor and Novak did not share any longstanding animosity, a slight professional rivalry arose over staging, with Novak concerned that Taylor was receiving a more flattering framing from the key lighting. The director of photography assuaged Novak's concerns, consoling her that Taylor "needs it more than you do." While such a behind-the-scenes anecdote may appear inconsequential to a reading of the resulting film, it highlights the Hollywood duplicities and humor that Sandler sought to bring to the screen. In many ways, Hollywood cannot help but be camp.

Within Sandler's camp reimagining of the characters, it is not only Marina and Lola who are reimagined as bitchy divas. Ella Zielinsky stands as a rather unremarkable character in Christie's novel, with her primary narrative interest emerging when she is murdered for blackmailing the killer. In Sandler's hands, Ella blossoms through the addition of her biting, acerbic commentary on the Hollywood divas surrounding her. Commenting on Marina's overuse of sleeping pills, she dryly declares, "You shake her, she rattles." Upon observing the impending conflict between Marina and Lola, she resignedly sighs, "Uh-oh. Mary Queen of Sluts and Baby Bernhardt under the same roof. That's all we need." When discussing these actresses with producer Marty Fenn, she pointedly reminds him of their mutual enmity: "Remember, they used to grind glass in each other's cold cream." Her assessment of Fenn likewise reveals a woman exhausted by the duplicities of her workplace—"Marty



Fig. 3.1 Kim Novak and Elizabeth Taylor smile for the cameras while exchanging cutting insults, with the duality between surface expression and actual sentiment creating a masterful camp staging

Fenn is a producer. He only lies when he speaks"—yet capable of transmuting the dross of others' egotism into comic gold.

Camp, a larger-than-life style, benefits from larger-than-life performances. In short, the true camp artist is the biggest ham, and the script of *The Mirror Crack'd* offers its stars numerous opportunities to exaggerate their characters into campy caricatures. In an appropriately over-the-top performance, Tony Curtis delivers such memorable lines as "Of course I'm a bastard. I'm the producer!" When the local vicar, bewildered by the intricacies of filmmaking, wonders aloud, "But who chooses the leading lady?" Curtis deadpans, "Whoever's sleeping with her." He also generously offers to demystify the cinematic world for the vicar: "What would you like to know, Vicar, baby?" In her performance as Lola Brewster, Kim Novak plays the egomaniacal diva, virtually puffing up in each scene to accentuate the character's excessive glamor and unbridled ego. Concerned about her hairstyle for the film, Fenn reminds her, "Queen Elizabeth was bald," to which she snappily replies, "Not in

this movie, she ain't." She snipes at Jason Rudd's last directorial effort, "I could eat a can of Kodak and puke a better movie." Great actors must avoid degrading their performances into emoting, but great camp actors indulge the pleasure of tossing out the nuance in favor of exaggeration.

In his adaptation of Christie's murder mystery, Sandler faced the challenge of balancing between her interest in crime and his interest in camp, lest the crime be lost altogether. And so whereas Curtis and Novak can indulge in the campy excess of their supporting characters, Elizabeth Taylor cannot aim solely for humor in her performance as Marina Gregg because this character fears for her life—or at least she must pretend to do so. As explored above, Marina's sparring with Lola allows her to exaggeratedly enact the bitchiness of the grande dame, yet she also displays the emotional fatigue of stardom, as evidenced in her resigned doggerel while looking in the mirror and regretting the inexorable march of time: "Bags, bags, go away / Come right back on Doris Day." Sandler recalls his trepidation that Taylor might take umbrage at his jokes at Marina's expense and apologized to her—"I hope you aren't too upset with some of the jokes I wrote." Taylor's reply—"They'll love me for them!"—indicates that she understood the camp appeal of his words and her performance. It is intriguing to ponder as well whom Taylor might have intended with her pronoun "they." Surely she is referring to her audience, but it seems at least plausible, given Taylor's longstanding support of the gay community, that she realized the camp appeal of her performance and the ways in which her gay fans both identified with and adored her. Sandler states as well that Taylor "was the only actor who said every line exactly as written"—a testament to her commitment to her performance even when the jokes at Marina's expense also reflect Taylor's metamorphosis from her youth of stunning beauty to her middle-aged years of a more Rubenesque stature. Stars are separate from their roles, except not really, for a star must be appropriate for her roles, and thus the overlap between the star and her roles that builds her star persona. One can trace the erosion of Taylor's beauty from her lead role in *Cleopatra* in 1963 to Marina Gregg in 1980, but this latter performance evidences as well her gracious and humorous resignation to time's inevitable march. Further imbuing his film with camp tropes, Sandler here plays on the "aging diva phenomenon"—a character type most memorable in Gloria Swanson's performance in *Sunset Boulevard* (1950)—but rather than rejecting the excess of such a role, Taylor embraced it.[2]

Further in his characterization of Marina, Sandler portrays her as a woman so immersed in the world of filmmaking that the other characters (and thus viewers as well) must discern whether she is reacting honestly to the dire circumstances surrounding her or merely playing her part. In this light, the doubleness of "playing a part," both for the screenwriter who writes the role and the actor who enacts it, offers another avenue for camp adaptation. This aspect of Marina's character surfaces during her interview with Inspector Craddock when Taylor's performance verges on hysteria and the hysterical: "Oh, God! It was me, wasn't it? It was me they were trying to poison, wasn't it? Who am I kidding? Somebody is trying to kill me, aren't they? Somebody is trying to … poison me, aren't they? Somebody is trying to kill me, aren't they? Aren't they? I know it! I can …" As Marina is apparently building up to an emotional breakdown, Craddock interrupts her, continuing her performance—"I can feel it. I can almost hear them coming"—as he then identifies the source of her words: "*Danger in the Dark*. MGM, 1932." A character always ready for the cameras, Marina lives as if on stage, which highlights the ways in which performance permeates the film as a mode of existence. The actors of this film act, as of course they must, but the characters that they play indulge in hyperbolic acting as well, thus multiplying the film's camp effect. To some degree, Sandler modeled Craddock on himself interacting with the stars on set, mentioning that he would "quote a line from one of [Taylor's] movies and see if she could get them." Implicitly rebutting such critical bromides as "the death of the author," Sandler demonstrates the ways in which the author can insert himself both through the screenplay he writes and through his comic mode of interacting with the performers.

With Sandler's deft comic touches, even the film's pointedly dry moments advance its overarching humor. At Marina Gregg's reception, the camera appears to bypass various townspeople when moving to or following more central characters, yet the audience hears snippets of their conversation that are virtually shocking in their stultifying tenor. One villager says, "I told you I lost my borage last year in the frost?" to which his interlocutor replies, "I'm sorry about that. You know what to do, don't you? Cut it right down to the ground." In another deadening exchange, a villager states, apropos of little, "Your dear wife had a cat." His companion complains, "Yes, but it always suffered from eczema," to which the first speaker proposes, "Carrots. Mashed carrots and a little warm milk work wonders." With this eczema-afflicted cat, the film

satirizes the deadening ennui of cocktail conversation, leaving viewers amused by the inanity of small talk and eager for the campy characters to seize control of the scene.

As camp offers screenwriters endless potential to queer an adaptation, such a vision must be endorsed by the director if it is to succeed, and any such contrast in artistic visions threatens to contain the camp unleashed in the screenplay. *The Mirror Crack'd* delights with its bitchy camp, yet it is regrettable that Hamilton did not more fully accommodate Sandler's humorous vision. Sandler says of Hamilton, "He was not what you would call a sensitive, woman's director; he was stern, British, and he didn't have a lot of humor," explaining further, "I don't think he's a comedy director. He signed up for an Agatha Christie mystery, but I turned it into a campy backstage comedy." Regrettably, Hamilton rejected some of Sandler's most daring comic touches. As much as Novak triumphs in her performance as Lola Brewster, Sandler advocated casting Debbie Reynolds to elevate the tension between the stars and their roles, owing to the obvious overlap between Christie's plotline concerning Marina's marriages and Taylor's life when she married Eddie Fisher after he left Reynolds for her. For a bit of physical humor alluding to Taylor's recent weight gain, Sandler wanted the bed to collapse when she jumps in bed with Hudson; as he tersely summarizes of this idea: "didn't happen." In a scene cut from the film, Marina runs panicked from the set after drinking her purportedly poisoned tea; Novak's Lola files her nails and deadpans, "Huh! You'd think she just spotted her diet doctor!" According to Sandler, Hamilton thought this joke dissipated the tension of the moment and he wanted to play the scene for its suspense rather than for its comedy. Mystery and comedy can be successfully merged—e.g., *The Thin Man* films—but it is also a challenge to unite disparate narrative modes, with one seeking to build suspense and the other seeking to release cathartic laughter. In this instance, Hamilton opted for mystery over camp, only to find that, in the final analysis, Sandler's camp humor made the film immeasurably more memorable.

Now heralded as a camp classic, several contemporary reviewers of *The Mirror Crack'd* apparently could not see the joke. The *Newsweek* reviewer derided the film as a "starchy effort that is not only set in 1952 but appears to have been made then," denouncing in particular "Guy Hamilton's mothball-scented direction" ("Tea-Cozy Mischief" 20). The *New York* reviewer declared, "Every poky, pawky Christie crotchet—so delightful to the true fan—has been reverently preserved, but Hamilton can't find a style

for the fussiness that would make it witty. It's a stupefyingly methodical movie" ("Review" 48). *Maclean's* dismissed the film for its leisurely tempo: "Poorly lit, hastily edited and paced like a particularly boring game of Clue, the movie has the feel of a parish hall and the vitality of a vicar" ("Stay Home" 58). With similar terms, Rex Reed, writing for *Vogue*, sniped: "If anything creaks, it's not the doors of the inner sanctum, it's the direction of Guy Hamilton. This is a slow, soft little film with an annoying lack of pace" (27). From these opinions, it would appear that *The Mirror Crack'd* should have quickly faded into obscurity, a footnote to film history memorable only as a regrettable effort in the otherwise stellar cinematographies of Taylor, Lansbury, and Hudson.

Camp films, however, must be assessed through camp hermeneutics rather than through a standard critical lens, and a quick overview of camp classics demonstrates that such disparaging reviews are disappointingly predictable, as few mainstream reviewers appreciate or even recognize camp. Classics of the form, including *Beat the Devil* (dir. John Huston, 1953), *Suddenly Last Summer* (dir. Joseph L. Mankiewicz, 1959), *The Rocky Horror Picture Show* (dir. Jim Sharman, 1975), and *Showgirls* (dir. Paul Verhoeven, 1995), to name only a few, have been critically dismissed only for audiences more receptive to their pleasures to find them as the years pass. Several of the more positive reviews of *The Mirror Crack'd* praised Sandler's campy script while assailing its stilted direction, thus foreshadowing such a shift in its critical reception. In this regard, the *Time* reviewer came closest to the mark, noting that "the good lines make *Mirror* more fun to watch than it has any right to be" ("Off the Wall" 59). The *McLean's* reviewer acknowledged that "the very idea of Liz Taylor and Kim Novak playing the Queen of Scots and Elizabeth R is a source of endless amusement, and the [screenwriter has] provided a spectacularly bitchy interplay for these two" ("Stay Home" 58). Rex Reed leavens his criticism by declaring, "When Novak looks in the mirror, rips off her wig, and yells 'Comb it out—you might find Amelia Earhart,' … you don't have to ask who steals the movie or why the mirror cracked" (27). Even the grumpy *Newsweek* reviewer conceded that the film's "bitchy fireworks are … the most arresting moments in this latest all-star Agatha Christie entry" ("Tea-Cozy Mischief" 20).

Certainly, the film's enduring popularity, as evidenced by the enthusiastic reception it received at a January 2017 screening hosted by Outfest in West Hollywood and its recent rerelease on Blu-Ray DVD, testifies both that critics and audiences often seek divergent pleasures from the

screen and that the film has withstood the test of time, particularly for queer audiences. In a recent assessment of Novak's career singling out *The Mirror Crack'd*, Liz Smith states simply, "Every line is classic." Campy pleasures blossom in the margins for resistant viewers who reject the standard trajectories and tropes of narrative and instead appreciate a humor that bends askew yet, for those in the know, never fails to hit its mark. For these reasons, *The Mirror Crack'd* has secured a beloved position in the queer film canon of camp.

Agatha Christie has delighted countless readers since publishing *The Mysterious Affair at Styles* in 1920, yet for the most part, her corpus affords little queer pleasure. Few gay characters enter her pages, and as R. A. York proposes, "she shows simple distaste for male homosexuals" in her depictions of them (69). (In *The Mirror Crack'd*, a minor character is disparaged as a "pansy" [160], in a mostly unremarkable yet telling example of Christie's depiction of gay men.) Yet camp's power as a comic mode allows it to circulate subversively where one might least expect it: in this instance, in *The Mirror Crack'd*—a cozy little murder mystery featuring the keen-witted Miss Marple that snaps to life in Sandler's queer and campy adaptation. And despite the disjunction between Sandler's and Christie's styles, he also worked on the 1982 adaptation of her *Evil Under the Sun*—although the credits show only Anthony Shaffer as the screenwriter—and her *And Then There Were None* inspired the basic narrative structure of his *Knock 'Em Dead* (2014). Agatha Christie's novels may not spring to mind as a wellspring of camp comedy, but Sandler has proved the queer compatibility of her murders and his bitchy humor.

Notes

1. With these words, Hesse specifically refers to theatrical adaptations, yet her point applies equally well to cinematic adaptations.
2. On the "aging diva phenomenon," see Caryl Flynn, who cites "Elizabeth Taylor on the cover of *Hollywood Babylon II*" to illustrate this stock figure of camp (444).

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CHAPTER 4

The Queer Aesthetics of Tom Ford's Film Adaptations: *A Single Man* and *Nocturnal Animals*

Scott F. Stoddart

In an interview with Ben Mankiewicz in the *New York Times*, Tom Ford explained why his turn from *fashionista* to film director was not as wild as many believed:

> This will sound crazy, but they're not so dissimilar. The most important thing, in both, is that you have a message, something you really need to say. Then you surround yourself with great teams and create a process for saying it. Remember: I've been a fashion designer for 30 years … I already had a sense of framing and telling stories. And I'm vain. I know where I need a key light and a little fill. If you love film, and you're obsessed about it, you start to learn: "Oh, look how she said that!" "Look how he walked in". (Galanes 15)

Since 2009, when he released *A Single Man*, Tom Ford has revealed how similar his fashion life and his filmic life are—both saturated in his love of classic cinema: "TCM runs in my house, on every television,

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all day long" (Galanes 14). He claims that George Cukor's stylish ensemble comedy *The Women* (1939) is his favorite, and that *Dinner at Eight* (1933), another Cukor film, provides him with constant inspiration: "It's so modern. It's hysterical; it's sad; it's tragic" (Galanes 14). Just like Mr. Mankiewicz, we film critics sit stunned that the man who says, "We live in a throwaway culture that I, literally, helped create" (Galanes 15), can be the same man who wrote, designed, directed, and produced two of the most distinctly queer film adaptations made in the past ten years.

Tom Ford has emerged as a provocative auteur of films steeped in a particular aesthetic, decidedly personal *and* queer, an aesthetic that consciously marries contemporary stories with cinematic tropes that, when combined, produce films that critics embrace as important. His first film, *A Single Man*, went on to be nominated for one Oscar, three Golden Globes, and was named "Movie of the Year" by the American Film Institute, who remarked that the film "marks the singular and stylish debut of writer-director Tom Ford, whose astoundingly assured transition from fashion to film—from the human body to the human spirit—is a perfect fit for Christopher Isherwood's story of love and loss" ("AFI"). Six years later, his second film *Nocturnal Animals* (2016) was nominated for another Oscar, three Golden Globes (winning one), and nine BAFTA awards, and Ford was named Best Director at the Venice Film Festival.

Perhaps it is no accident that Ford identifies with the sophisticated elements of George Cukor's work. Like Cukor's films, Ford's—whether placed in the past or present—are steeped in a contemporary ideology that is not immediately obvious, in line with the invisible principles of American filmmaking during Hollywood's "Golden Age": "The ideology becomes subordinate to the text. It no longer has an independent existence: It is *presented* by the film" (Comolli and Narboni 687). And, as with Cukor, the ideology presented by Ford's films can be attributed to what Alexander Doty refers to as "a queer cultural authorship." In discussing Cukor, Doty notes that "certain unconventional elements of a director's biography and ideology could be expressed within the conventional texts of a capitalist's industry—even if sporadically and in heavily coded forms" (25). These "unconventional elements" constitute a queer aesthetic, visibly invisible to the critical eye. In explaining his method for reading "queerly"—seeking "textual signs that complicate or resist the coherent presentation of conventional, straight ideology" (25)—Doty might very well be speaking of Ford, who uses conventional filmic

tools—framing, close-up, color, motif—just as Cukor might have done, to tell *his* version of these stories.

At first glance, there appears to be no common denominator in the source material for Ford's adaptations: Christopher Isherwood's *A Single Man* (1964) and Austin Wright's *Tony and Susan* (1993). Isherwood's novella is a melancholy look at life as a homosexual man in 1960s America, articulating the protagonist George's grief in the aftermath of his "longtime companion's" death. Wright's revenge thriller, on the other hand, examines the past and present of an unhappily-divorced heterosexual couple brought together by a novel written by the angry husband, who views his work as a comeuppance aimed at his once cheating wife. In fact, the only commonality that appears to connect these two works is their noted obscurity, until brought to the forefront by Ford's interest.

As adaptations, the films seem aligned with the theories of André Bazin, who felt, in regard to adaptations, that "faithfulness to form, literary or otherwise, was illusory: what matters is the *equivalence in meaning of the forms*" (20 italics in the original). One could never argue that either *A Single Man* or *Nocturnal Animals* is a literal translation from one medium to another, but the essence of the novels is present in the films. Each adaptation appears as a meditation on its source, which has been treated not as a fixed text to be reproduced, but, as suggested by Linda Hutcheon, as "something to be interpreted and recreated" (78). In these two case studies, I argue that Ford's fascination with classic Hollywood cinema and his artistic sense as a queer filmmaker have led him to develop a queer aesthetic—one that uses cinematic grammar to underscore both emotional connection and alienation, in both gay and straight stories, to create films that speak to queer sensibilities but appeal as well to the general spectator.

A Single Man

In adapting Isherwood's classic queer text to the screen, Ford transfers much of Isherwood's prose directly to the screenplay that tells of the final day in the life of George Falconer (Colin Firth). But to fully convey the deep-seated grief and terminal loneliness of the middle-aged English professor, Ford relies on his deeply personal response to Isherwood's text and on his own experiences and his love for Hollywood film. He then employs a particular cinematic grammar—including a highly

stylized use of tempo, framing, and color—to create his interpretation of Isherwood's novel.

In his screenplay, Ford freely admits to taking things from his own life to add dimension to Isherwood's original. By naming George fully in the film—George Carlyle Falconer—he now "shares Ford's own middle name and the surname of his first lover, well-known illustrator and designer Ian Falconer (whose professions, like Ford's, trade on perceiving beautiful surfaces)" (Stevens 105). Adding names from his own life reveals the deep emotional commitment Ford has to this version of George's story—as if Ford is in conversation with both Isherwood *and* his spectator: as if to say, "This happened to me …." In fact, while Ford literally adapts the opening of Isherwood's text with George thinking, "Waking up begins with saying *am* and *now*" (9), he confesses that George's final interior monologue, spoken as he drifts from consciousness, is a reflection from his own life.

Ford also provides George with a motive for *knowing* this will be his final day. In Isherwood's original, George simply dies of heart failure, but Ford found this to lack drama, and so he decided to have George go through his day having consciously decided to commit suicide. As actor Colin Firth says, "Ending his life today in a conscious manner gives poignancy to the narrative" ("Making of *A Single Man*"). It also ties George's story more strongly to Ford, who claims to have suffered from clinical depression since the age of eight, and who says that he often thought of suicide as a way of reckoning with his decidedly different nature (Galloway 53). Reading Isherwood's text, which is steeped in George's depression following the death of Jim, his partner of sixteen years, triggered Ford's memories, and he added this dimension to the story. He relates in the Blu-ray commentary that George's unsuccessful midday attempt at suicide, moving from the bed to the shower to the sleeping bag (intended to contain the mess that shooting himself would make) is based in his own family (Ford). He also realized that the seminal conversation George has with Jim's disembodied cousin, who calls to relate the details of Jim's death, could trigger George's depressive state. This aesthetic touch—exploring George's day through Ford's own visceral response to the story—helps make the drama real for his audience.

Another of Ford's aesthetic touches is his way of filming some added scenes in a heightened manner to highlight key moments in the text. One such example is George's compulsive obsession with and repulsion of the suburban family next door. In the book, George reflects for pages

on how he and Jim would malign the infiltration of families into their quiet little Mecca created by "the tacky and cheerful and defiantly bohemian" renegades escaping "the soul-destroying commercialism of the city" (18):

> The Change began in the late forties, when the World War Two vets came swarming out of the East with their just-married wives, in search of new and better breeding grounds in the sunny Southland … So, one by one, the cottages which used to reek of bathtub gin and reverberate with the poetry of Hart Crane have fallen to the occupying army of Coke-drinking television watchers. (18)

George's subsequent pondering of the Strunks "who live opposite"—the Mrs. who "dutifully scolds her children from time to time … grown wearily gentle from toiling around the house at her chores"; the Mr. who "tries to nail him down with a word. *Queer*, he doubtless growls" (25–27); and their devilish children—become sport for Ford, who films the family in candied colors that pop out from George's gray palette. George's few interactions with the children do not occur in the novella, but the slow-motion sequences showing the family outdoors leaving for school—beautifully fragile, cracking under the strain of respectable appearance—reveal Isherwood's sardonic tone via Ford's George. One of those moments shows George en route to Charley's (Julianne Moore) home, when he is accosted by Christopher (Paul Butler), the cowboy-clothed varmint from across the street; in close-up, we see the little tyke holding George at gunpoint and George responding by urinating in his face. While this happens only in George's wishful imagination, the message is clear: suburbia is a not a harmonious utopia for homosexuals.

Another facet of Ford's aesthetic re-visioning of Isherwood are his allusions to Hollywood classics. As a self-proclaimed obsessive film fan, Ford's adaptation freely applies a number of filmic references meant to underscore what he sees as connections between art and reality. One of these relates to George and the Strunks: George has just finished cleaning out his safe deposit box and sits for a moment to collect his thoughts. He opens his eyes to see a pair of vibrantly blue patent leather Mary Janes in front of him, and the camera replicates George's vision as his eyes move up the equally vibrant blue pinafore to the face of Jennifer (Ryan Simpkins), the youngest daughter. Ford admits that he wanted

this shot to remind the viewer of *The Wizard of Oz* (1939); this scene, including the subsequent conversation about her pet scorpion named "Charlton Heston," recalls Ford's own childhood. And when George lights pink cigarettes two at a time for Charley later that evening, he's alluding to Paul Henreid and Bette Davis in *Now, Voyager* (1942): "A reference every homosexual should know," according to the director (Ford).

Another sequence added by Ford helps to underscore his emphasis on "eyes and fears … embodied in one image" (Ford). George stops for liquor on his way home and encounters a friendly young hustler, Carlos (Jon Kortajarena). As seen in Fig. 4.1, the encounter takes place outside the store under the watchful gaze of Marion Crane (Janet Leigh) emblazoned across the sky in an advertisement for Hitchcock's *Psycho* (1960). Ford tells us that the close-ups on eyes help underscore his way of feeling about the text, because eyes, being the window to the soul, are the



Fig. 4.1 From *A Single Man*: George Falconer (Colin Firth) meets up with Carlos (Jon Kortajarena) under the horrified gaze of Janet Leigh from *Psycho*

point of connection between humans. Leigh's look of fear—visible in the pictured billboard (Fig. 4.1)—implies not connection, but the fear that connection will not be made. When Carlos openly tries to pick up the unsuspecting George, the moment, blooming into full Technicolor, is consciously edited between the men in medium close-up, standing together under Leigh's frightened gaze. A number of extreme close-ups follow, showing Carlos' vibrant green eyes and his sensuous mouth exhaling smoke as he gingerly tries to seduce George. The charged moment plays out like a coy melodrama of the 1950s, with Carlos making innuendoes that George skillfully recognizes—further evidence that Ford's aesthetic influences the manner in which he records George's final day.

When translating the screenplay to film, Ford uses color to convey tone and adds recurring imagery not present in Isherwood's novel, which heightens the emotions imbued in the text. George's world, colored by his deep depression, is one muted in grays and earth tones, drained of any real color since the evening he received the phone call telling him of Jim's death. While George lives in a nearly all-glass home in Venice, California, his is a world that seems somber and chilled—bereft of disinfecting sunlight—reflective of his depressive state. This attention to color is, perhaps, the most prominent filmic tool that Ford uses to underscore George's emotional state.

Color functions throughout the film to help the spectator identify with George and thus to understand his queerness. For instance, the film opens with a shocking image of a winter road, snow falling on a wrecked car, a handsome yet bloodied man, obviously dead and, nearby, a dead dog—all in striking Technicolor. We then see George, walking toward the dead man and kneeling down to cradle his broken head. As he bends down further to kiss the dead man's lips, we sense the connection. The dead man, who turns out to be Jim (Matthew Goode), holds the key to George's inner grief, a grief he cannot express openly. When the scene cuts to George's present, as he readies himself for work and prepares for his evening activity—his carefully planned suicide—the color washes out of the frame, representing how color has bled out of George's life without Jim. This feeling of loss and hopelessness is captured further in a recurring image of a naked George floating under water. The fact that George in these sequences never fights against the suffocating water allows us to feel how his grief has only made him desire to join Jim.

In fact, Ford's use of color throughout underscores how George sees his world and how he experiences his grief. The gray and sepia tones that predominate as George goes through the routine of his day are only transformed to Technicolor when he reflects on his life with Jim—even in that seminal scene where he learns of Jim's death via a phone call from a relative who tells George not to attend the "family" service. When George finds himself in a conversation with a colleague, talking of collegiate banalities, the surrounding campus is gray and dull. All of a sudden, George's gaze is diverted by the image of two shirtless men playing tennis. As he gazes at the men's young, vibrant bodies, the camera slows and the colors bloom: the extreme close-ups of naked torsos glistening with sweat in the sunlight. The sequence illustrates George's mind operating; while in his physical world he might be focused on killing himself, his inner life is still very much attracted to the sensual pleasures of his life with Jim. A sequence later in the film recapturing the night of their initial meeting—the night that World War II ended—links the sight of the half-naked men to Jim, and both images convey love and life through their very color.

Another sequence, purposely filmed in Technicolor with Ford's palette of vibrant oranges, is George's final evening with Charley (Julianne Moore), a fading beauty who deals with her disappointments in life by drinking quarts of gin. The sequence is endearingly intimate, as we know this is meant to be George's last visit before killing himself. However, Ford's use of close-ups and natural colors underscore that this is meant to be a night of business to George, not sexy in the way that Charley yearns for. Ford explains in his Blu-ray commentary that to George, Charley "is Technicolor" and her environment reflects her desire to live life as a film, her home feeling like an all-too-perfect set for her particular midlife crisis. When Charley begins to drunkenly chastise George for not moving on after Jim's death—claiming that he should seek a "real" relationship—George's anger finally gives rise. The bright colors of Charley's well-appointed home appear to imprison him, showing that *this* heteronormative existence is the artificial life, and that the one built with Jim, depicted in Technicolor, is the *real* life that George misses.

The sequence that ends the film—George's encounter with his inquisitive student Kenny (Nicholas Hoult)—reminds George that he should be lucky to be alive; but blinded by grief, he can see only despair ahead of him. Not until an evening swim with Kenny, who rescues George from a swift undercurrent, does George begin to see his life in full color,

making the film's ending all the more tragic. As the two meet in the local bar—which through flashbacks the audience is told is the bar where he met Jim in 1945—Kenny blooms from the dark shadows into full Technicolor as his sharp, intensely blue eyes drink in the conversation he has with George, bringing the professor back to the brink of happiness for one last time. The moment is openly seductive as George begins to see an alternative path out from his depression; and his decision later in the evening, while Kenny sleeps on the sofa, to burn his suicide notes and put away his gun (which Kenny had already tucked under his own sleeping arm for safe-keeping), demonstrates George's realization that a future might be possible. It is just at that moment of hopefulness that Isherwood, and Ford, give George his fatal heart attack, rendering him immobile but conscious for one moment more: one final Technicolor moment where Jim, dressed in a fashionable tuxedo, enters the frame to bend toward the prostrate George, giving him a final "kiss of death," thus escorting George toward acceptance. The sequence bookends the opening scene, which imagines George kissing his newly killed lover, each a sad reminder that "connection is what keeps us going" (Ford), and signifying the harmonization between the original author and the writer-director's own aesthetic embellishments.

Nocturnal Animals

Ford optioned Austin Wright's *Tony and Susan* (1993) immediately after filming *A Single Man* and locked himself away to compose the film's screenplay. Ford makes clear that when he first read the novel, it immediately spoke to him:

> Susan is quite literally me … She's someone who has material things but realizes—maybe this happened to me seven or eight years ago—those aren't the things that are important. She is struggling with the world that I lie in: the world of the absurd rich, the hollowness and emptiness I perceive in our culture. (Galloway 52)

This is interesting because, on the surface, Wright's heteronormative thriller is not anything like this reading. But understanding how Ford reads shows us how he seeks connection to the character, identifying with George in *A Single Man* and with Susan in this text because something in Susan's inner being speaks directly to him.

Because it is a tale of heteronormative relations, *Tony and Susan* would seem to be more difficult to "queer" than *A Single Man*. It is a story of a bored middle-class housewife who, one day, receives a package in the mail: the manuscript of a novel written by her boring ex-husband, whom she left for a doctor, thinking he could give her a happier life. The manuscript, titled *Nocturnal Animals*, simultaneously disturbs and fascinates her; she understands it as the inner life of her seemingly milquetoast ex, who has used the writing of the novel to exorcize the feelings of inadequacy and disillusion brought about by the affair that ended their marriage. Wright's self-reflexive noir is an entertaining romp that causes us to see how an inner life can take over a psyche, damaging it beyond repair as it fuels revenge.

Ford's adaptation reveals as much about him as a writer-director as it does about his reading. Like his Isherwood adaptation, Ford embellishes the tale with thoughts and experiences from his own life, literally applying a queer aesthetic to his screenplay: renaming the film *Nocturnal Animals*, rather than keeping its original title, underscores that its main characters Susan Morrow (Amy Adams) and Tony Hastings (Jake Gyllenhaal) are going to be coping with their own inner "animal" as they fight to maintain societal decorum in the face of passionate engagement. Rather than keeping Susan a bored housewife, burdened by her children and inattentive husband, Ford makes her a successful art dealer, ensconced in a world of high society fashion and excess, highlighting the mask Susan wears in public—similar to those societal masks that gay men wear to remain hidden in the closet. Screening this story against this backdrop makes Tony's novel of symbolic revenge take on the patina of a veiled threat against Susan, exposing her as a hypocrite within a vapid society of privilege—one that she gained only through her decision to dissolve her first marriage.

To begin, Ford says he consciously "put" things into the film so they would bring together the inner story and the outer story subconsciously for the spectator: "All the worlds converge in one way or another" ("Making *Nocturnal Animals*"). When actor Jake Gyllenhaal signed on to the project to play Tony/Edward, he reported that, at his first meeting with Ford, "He had thousands of research photographs. He had a palette for each character. Everything was packed with thought and detail" (Galloway 55). Each of the three sections of the film has a distinct look, but Ford sought to make a coherent thread throughout so as to lead the audience through each story and to feel the inter-relatedness.

1. *Susan's Current World*: filled with photographic symmetry, an absence of vivid color. These scenes utilize a tonal range that is bluer and desaturated; when there is color, it is garish—such as the crimson swatch across her office, or the vibrantly vulgar red, white, and blue installation that opens the film.
2. *Flashbacks to Susan's Past World*: richer and warmer, because this is how Susan recollects them. Passion is magnified through the deeper, richer tones.
3. *The Novel's Inner World*: sun-drenched, moved from the woods of Pennsylvania to Marta, Texas, where Ford grew up. Technicolor is key here to reflect the imagination, such as the scorched browns, painful yellows, or the vibrant green of the hotel bath.

Making Susan a surrogate *for him* via a form of cross-identification allows Ford to employ another filmic tool that creates a motif throughout the film. Ford immerses Susan in artworks that reflect her spirit—a spirit at once deadened to the disposable world around her, and one yearning to reconnect to the vibrancy of life. According to Mirra Prudowska, there are more than fifteen works of contemporary art showcased in the film and each one is used to expand the story, visually, and to operate subconsciously to/on the spectator. As detailed by the film's production designer, Shane Valentino, Ford himself reached out to some artists for specific pieces, such as Jeff Koons for his sculpture *Balloon Dog* (featured on the lawn of Susan's suburban home) and Damien Hirst, whose sculpture *St. Sebastian, Exquisite Pain*, sits in the foyer. As seen in Fig. 4.2, Ford hangs John Currin's *Nude in Convex Mirror* in Susan's office to be read alongside her: "We ended up using John Currin's painting and I feel like in that scene specifically—she's all in white and has red hair and walls—you can only use one piece in the background. There's a dialogue between her restraint and how explicit the painting is" (Rosenthal 4).

One of the film's most haunting images follows Susan wandering through her home following an abrupt cut from Tony's Western ordeal; the color palette shifts from the lurid brightness of the mind to the stark coolness of Susan's reality. Susan finds herself standing in front of Richard Misrach's *Desert Fires #153*, a photo from Ford's personal collection: "It was an early reference on my mood board … it captured some of the ideas we were trying to articulate—desperation, confusion, and fear" (Rosenthal).



Fig. 4.2 From *Nocturnal Animals*: Susan Morrow (Amy Adams) in her office at the art gallery; John Currin's "Nude in a Convex Mirror" hangs on the wall behind her

Designer Valentino continues,

> The photo has a man pointing a rifle at another man who is smiling to the camera. Normally, it could be interpreted as a playful moment between two men, the threat of annihilation diffused by a simple smile, but by placing the action, or "capturing" the moment within an environment consumed by smoke and fire, the playfulness evaporates and the imminent danger is highlighted. The photo does an incredible job of capturing this tension, a tension duplicated in the highway scene between Tony's family and Ray's gang. (Rosenthal)

Working through a viscerally visual frame of reference permits Ford to tell his version of the novel in a particularly haunting fashion. For instance, in Wright's novel, when Susan reads of the discovery of Tony's wife and daughter, the language is direct and specific—even when framed in metaphors:

> He [Tony] saw someone had been here, the red kerchief and dark sweater and pair of jeans draped on the bushes across the grass. When Bobby Andes moved his head, he [Tony] saw the lovers naked under the bush, their naked limbs asleep ….

> Boy and girl, though which was which he was not yet sure, one lying on her back, the other close by, face down. It was possible, he realized as he approached, that they were dead, not asleep, that they might have been killed by someone. If so, that was proper business for his officer companions, not him.
>
> It wasn't Laura and Helen because these two were naked and looked like children sprawled asleep, or stunned, or knocked out on the head, in a coma, or possibly dead. He was walking fast, away from Bobby Andes who was trying to hold him back, because he wanted to make sure they were not Laura and Helen. He was not running because he knew of course they were not.
>
> Only they were. (75–76)

In the film, Ford stylizes the moment consciously in a number of ways so we can experience it as Susan reads and internalizes the horror. By casting actresses Ilsa Fisher and Ellie Bamber as wife and daughter, he has selected one woman who looks enough like Amy Adams to imply that Susan sees herself as the victim; the other who is a likely result of Susan and Edward's coupling, possibly the very daughter she aborted. Ford then places the entangled corpses like "lovers," not on the grassy knoll, but draping them on a red velvet sofa, abandoned to the prairie, in a macabre embrace—an image made only more haunting later when we watch Susan, in a flashback, reading a draft of Edward's novel draped on the same red velvet sofa. Going one step further, after Susan reads of the murders, she calls her daughter: the scene cuts to an image of her naked daughter (India Menuez) in bed with her equally naked boyfriend (Neil Jackson) in a postcoital repose, bringing to mind not only the dead daughter of Edward's novel, but the John Currin painting hanging over Susan's desk in her office. This conscious, constant referencing is one key to understanding Ford's adaptation of the novel—helping to show how this story resonates through him onto film.

This sensibility translates to the additional plot points that Ford adds to the telling of Susan's odyssey. Ford opens the film with an audacious credit sequence that features naked, obese women looking straight into the camera, dancing in slow motion and armed with patriotic paraphernalia. At first, the images are alarming, running counter to the images one usually relates to Ford's other life as a fashion designer—each woman disarms the spectator as she looks directly into the camera, smiling, laughing, teasing in a playful manner associated with confident porn stars. It is only when we move from the credits to the story that we realize that the women are part of an art installation, an event that

introduces us to Susan's profession—one that she has already begun to question. It is through this event that we learn of trouble in Susan's marriage to Hutton (Armie Hammer) when he fails to show at the opening, and later when they attend a society gathering hosted by Alessia (Andrea Riseborough) and Carlos (Michael Sheen), a straight woman and her gay husband who appear to be Susan's only real friends. During the sequence, Susan admits that funds are running low and that sex between husband and wife is problematic at best. And while Carlos claims Susan's installation to be "genius," she responds by calling it "junk"—our second indication that all that surrounds Susan is about to be questioned. This appears to be the guiding principle of Ford's aesthetic: "Materialism is fun but don't get carried away with it. I parody today's world and the superficiality of it—which I helped contribute to" (Gray).

The film and novel end in dramatically distinct manners, showing just how Ford wants his spectator to experience his particular frame of reference. Wright ends the novel with a poetic vision of Tony's death, who, after shooting Ray, his wife and daughter's rapist/murderer, shoots himself accidentally, and dies dreaming of his family reunited once more, at their lake house in Maine:

> Only their heads were above the surface, laughing and encouraging him, as he moved gingerly in the bitter cold water … it rose from his ankles to his knees, from his knees to his groin and groin to hips. It seized him freezing around his belly. It crept up to his chest, it covered his heart, it clutched his neck. Then still rising still freezing it reached his mouth and filled his nose and closed his burning eyes. (309)

Susan, now finished with Edward's novel, reflects on what he is saying to her: "She wonders if they are real or only her imagination and how long it will take her, if ever, to know. The secret fight she keeps dodging in her mind somewhere: that's her private problem. It has nothing to do with the book" (312). Susan internalizes Tony's struggle—she knows that she would fight differently if she and her family were ever attacked, and realizes that they have been—Arnold, her second husband (in the novel), has been cheating on her, and Edward's novel has helped her to see things more clearly, causing her to realize that she will fight back: "She wanted to punish Arnold too, but the only thing she could think of was to make him read the book. He would do that if she insisted,

but she doubted he would see anything" (326). Wright's Susan uses the reading of the novel as a form of empowerment, defying both the wounded Edward and the cheating Arnold and asserting her own will.

Ford's ending for his film, however, is dramatically different. Freely acknowledging Hutton's cheating, Susan makes a date with Edward to discuss his novel: she dresses in a deep emerald dress, motors to the appointed rendezvous, and sips a bourbon on the rocks while she waits … and waits … and waits. The gradual time-lapse shows Susan waiting for hours; eventually the restaurant is empty, and Susan is left sitting alone, with no further exposition. In interviews, Ford has said that he believes the spectator is to view the moment subjectively: Edward's motive in writing is to show Susan, "this is what you did to me; you killed me, you killed our family. But guess what? It took me twenty years, and I prevailed. I stuck with what I believed in, I stuck with it, I wrote a novel; it's great, and by the way, while you're reading this novel, you will fall in love with me all over again" ("Making *Nocturnal Animals*").

This haunting moment puts all of the onus on Susan—either way, we see that it is she, and her life, that is empty: "Susan … is dead inside" ("Making *Nocturnal Animals*"). Ford's sensibilities, though, color what we see:

> A lot of people will look at the end of this film and think it is incredibly sad. Maybe there is something incredibly wrong with me, because, yes, it's sad, but you know what? There are a lot of sad moments in life, and we can grow from them. Whatever is going to happen with this woman, she has made a break from her life—the life that is not making her happy is finished. Reading this book, which was quite painful, is transformative. ("Making *Nocturnal Animals*")

Ford adapts Wright's novel to suit both his own reading of the novel and his message regarding Susan's decisions: "I wasn't trying to be likable … Life isn't always likable. The story spoke to me about what happens when you buy into certain things in contemporary culture. We live in a culture where everything is disposable. Fire them! Divorce them! Toss it away!" (Galloway 54).

In closing, it makes sense to once more think of Ford's connection to Cukor who, while openly despising auteur theory, embraced both the skill of writing and the aesthetic control the director executes in filmmaking:

> I'm not an auteur, alas. And the whole auteur theory disconcerts me. To begin with, damn few directors can write. I have too much respect for good writers to think of taking over that job. Also, to be frank, not all directors can direct … I suppose I influence a great deal in many ways. I have ideas about a script, I influence the performances very much, and visually I go on a great deal about sets and clothes … That, I choose to say, is style. You make big decisions and small decisions and decisions you aren't even consciously aware of. You do unexpected things on the set. You have a vision. (13–14)

While Ford might readily embrace the modicum of auteur, his commitment to his particular vision (embodied in his screen adaptations) exudes the very "style" and "vision" Cukor embraced. With his filmic retellings of *A Single Man* and *Nocturnal Animals*, Tom Ford proves that his métier as an adapter blends his use of the personal with his choice of literature to tell stories that pulsate through a unique perspective, queering his films in a way intended to resonate with his spectator, regardless of their own sexual orientation. In this way, through his method and frank public reflection on it, Ford openly shows us what a Hollywood master like Cukor could only suggest—that a queer aesthetic can make films political through being personal.

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CHAPTER 5

Hannibal: Beginning to Bloom

Mat Daniel

Hannibal Lecter looms large in the public imagination across three distinct mediums. The three volumes of Thomas Harris's Hannibal Lecter trilogy—*Red Dragon*, *The Silence of the Lambs*, and *Hannibal*—were published in 1981, 1988, and 1999, respectively, while a prequel to the trilogy—*Hannibal Rising*—was written in 2006.[1] Each of these books was adapted for film at least once, most notably for Jonathan Demme's *The Silence of the Lambs* (1991), which won five Academy Awards, including Best Picture. However, Demme's film was also greeted by controversy due to the way it represents queerness.[2] That contentious relationship to queerness is not exclusive to Demme's film, with both the novels and other films marked by their problematic representation—or erasure—of queer individuals. In contrast, Bryan Fuller's recent series *Hannibal* (2013–2015) is partly notable for the manner in which it adapts and revises its source material to allow for complex representations and conceptions of queerness. Drawing on the work of Judith Halberstam,[3] specifically her 1991 "Skinflick: Posthuman Gender in Jonathan Demme's *The Silence of the Lambs*" and the 2011 *The Queer Art of Failure*, this chapter interrogates the representation of sexuality within the various iterations of the Hannibal Lecter canon in order to demonstrate the manner in which Fuller's adaptation—particularly in

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contrast to Demme's *The Silence of the Lambs*—transforms a previously contentious space of queer representation into one capable of accommodating greater nuance.

Despite the broad acclaim it received upon its release, *The Silence of the Lambs* was not universally praised. Queer groups including Queer Nation and ACT UP protested the representation of the film's villain, a serial killer named Buffalo Bill. Within the context of the novel and film adaptation, Buffalo Bill is a serial killer who abducts and murders women in an attempt to create a "person suit." As characterized, Bill identifies as a woman, but Jonathan Demme specified that the character was not intended to be interpreted as homosexual or transgender. In a 2014 interview, Demme stated that Bill "didn't wish to be another gender. He didn't really have a sexual preference. He loathed himself—he wanted to transform himself so there was no sense of him in the 'new' him [and] becoming a woman, that was his method of doing it" (Wong). At least superficially, Demme's film reinforces that reading. During a psychological evaluation of Buffalo Bill, Hannibal states that the killer is "not a real transsexual. But he thinks he is," going on to say that Bill "hates his own identity, you see, and he thinks that makes him a transsexual." Both Harris's novel and Demme's film specify in dialogue that transgender individuals have no natural inclination toward violence. The novel, in particular, provides lengthy exposition to clarify why Bill's transgender identification would not be accepted by medical institutions. Regardless of these statements—inside and outside of the diegesis—the character's effeminacy and gender identity led many spectators—especially queer ones—to interpret Buffalo Bill as a queer individual, whether homosexual or transgender. Regardless of Buffalo Bill's gender identity, it is impossible to escape the fact that the character's threat is tied inextricably to nonconformity to gender norms.

Judith Halberstam's "Skinflick: Posthuman Gender in Jonathan Demme's *The Silence of The Lambs*"—published the same year as the film's release—offers a reading of the film that is contrary to many responses from the queer community. Instead of reading Bill as a transgender individual, Halberstam suggests that the character exists beyond gender, in a similar manner to Demme's claim that Bill "didn't really have a sexual preference." Halberstam asserts that Bill "hates identity, he is simply at odds with any identity whatsoever; no body, no gender will do and so he has to sit at home with his skins and fashion a completely new one. What he constructs is a posthuman gender; a gender beyond

the body, beyond human, a carnage of identity" (39). Halberstam's suggestion of Bill's posthumanity places the film's representation of gender and sexuality beyond criticism in a manner that ignores the film's use of gender nonconformity to generate tension.[4] Halberstam refers to Hannibal's psychological profile of Bill, stating that "Hannibal's remark to Starling that this man is not a transsexual and not a homosexual suggests that if he were the first, Buffalo Bill would be simply confused about his genitals; if he were the second, he would be confused about an object choice" (41–42). Halberstam's reference to transgender individuals is unusual in that it seems to conceive of trans identity exclusively in the context of biological characteristics. Her argument—and Demme's statements—pre-empt criticisms of Bill's characterization by positioning the killer *beyond* both gender and sexuality. On Demme's part, at least, that positioning is intended to generate thematic cohesion: *The Silence of the Lambs* dedicates much of its running time to dramatizing the difficulties of women navigating a patriarchal society, and presenting Bill as male allows for another iteration of those dangers. Ironically, the superficial treatment of Bill's gender identity allows for a feminist counter-reading about the difficulties that individuals who do not conform to gender norms face in navigating that same society. Even in allowing for that reading, it is undeniable that Bill functions as the narrative's antagonist, an obstacle to be overcome in the film's climax. Although Halberstam attempts to divorce *The Silence of the Lambs* from homophobia and transphobia, her arguments prematurely dismiss the film's use of gender nonconformity as the primary trait of its antagonist.

Although the argument Halberstam presents in "Skinflick" is compelling, it also has the detrimental effect of positioning the film as apolitical. Within the context of *The Silence of the Lambs*, Bill functions as an obstacle to be overcome instead of an individual with a complex inner life. There is a traditional narrative structure at play, wherein Bill causes a disruption to the hegemonic order that can be resolved only through death. On a literal level, that disruption is caused by Bill killing a number of women, but as stated earlier, those actions are inextricably tied to Bill's unconventional relationship to gender. That characterization is even more striking when compared to the film's central character, Clarice Starling; as one of the few women training to be an FBI agent, a traditionally masculine space, Clarice is repeatedly shown as out of place, but the film's narrative celebrates her presence in that space. In contrast, Bill's occupation of a traditionally feminine space is clearly marked as a

transgression. Clarice and Bill are united in that each of them occupies a contentious gendered space, but Clarice's adoption of a traditionally masculine role is celebrated while Bill's blurring of the boundaries between genders defines his role as the film's antagonist. Despite the film's dedicated critique of the implicit and explicit violence that underpins traditional conceptions of masculinity, its portrayal of Bill denies complex engagement with gender identity. In positioning Bill beyond gender, Halberstam's "Skinflick" denies any engagement with these contradictory discourses. That disengagement is even more striking in the wake of Fuller's *Hannibal*, a series that presents several morally ambiguous queer figures and affords them a depth of characterization that Demme's film denies Bill.

Bryan Fuller's *Hannibal* differs substantially from its source material and previous adaptations in the space it provides for queerness. It is difficult to mount any direct comparison between Fuller's series and previous adaptations, due to the substantial changes to the characters and narrative. Further, because the series was canceled at the end of its third season and because of difficulties obtaining the rights to the novel, the series did not directly adapt *The Silence of the Lambs*. Consequently, it is impossible to say how Fuller would have depicted Buffalo Bill. Regardless, Fuller's handling of queer narratives is surprisingly sensitive in its engagement with multiple permutations of queerness, both explicit, as in the depiction of a lesbian relationship, and implicit, as in the obsession of the show's central male characters with one another.

Hannibal begins as a crime procedural in which Will Graham is recruited by the FBI to help them capture murderers. Concurrently, Hannibal Lecter becomes Will's psychiatrist. Toward the end of *Hannibal*'s first episode, Hannibal and Will locate a killer known as the Minnesota Shrike. Hannibal warns the killer of their approach, manipulating Will into a position where he kills the Shrike in self-defense. There is a clear continuity between these events and the final episode of the series, in which Will kills another murderer, this time as part of a partnership with Hannibal instead of as his pawn. The relationship between Will and Hannibal provides a consistent emotional core—however unconventional—to a series that intentionally and repeatedly reinvents itself and its source material. It also resonates with Halberstam's conception of queerness in her 2011 *The Queer Art of Failure*. Within that text, Halberstam argues that "success in a heteronormative, capitalist society equates too easily to specific forms

of reproductive maturity combined with wealth accumulation" (2). Halberstam outlines a specific set of values—specifically heterosexuality and reproductive capacity—that are perceived as necessary in the continuation of a capitalist society. She creates an association between queerness and "failure," with the latter term here denoting the inability to satisfy societal norms. Within that context, failure "allows us to escape the punishing norms that discipline behavior and manage human development with the goal of delivering us from unruly childhoods to orderly and predictable adulthoods" (3). Viewed through the lens of Halberstam's text, *Hannibal*'s narrative arc can be read as a depiction of Will transforming from his initial—albeit ill-fitting—adherence to hegemonic values to an embrace of queer societal deviance alongside Hannibal. Further, viewing *The Silence of the Lambs* through the lens of *The Queer Art of Failure* allows for a critique of that film's restrictive, noncommittal representation of queerness. As a series, *Hannibal* regularly embodies the queer mode of failure that Halberstam conceptualizes in its denial of hegemonic norms.

Although Will and Hannibal's relationship is central to the series and its overarching narrative, the characters' feelings towards each other are often suggested implicitly. Throughout the first season, this is largely accomplished through their relationship to the Minnesota Shrike's daughter, Abigail. Abigail barely survives her father's attempt on her life, leaving Will—and possibly Hannibal, although it is often difficult to discern his true motivations—feeling responsible for her safety. The final scene of the first episode shows Will entering Abigail's hospital room to find Hannibal asleep by her bed. He sits as well, completing an image that recalls two concerned parents sitting by their child's side (Fig. 5.1). That image embodies the first season's thematic content, with much of its running time depicting the relationships that form between Will, Hannibal, and Abigail. By the end of the third episode, Hannibal has manipulated Abigail into a position where she too kills in self-defense, much like Will in the first episode. In that sense, Will, Hannibal, and Abigail form a perverse family unit founded not in the creation of life, but in taking life. Within *The Queer Art of Failure*, Halberstam outlines the ideas of Lee Edelman, another queer theorist who emphasizes ideas of failure and negativity. In summariing Edelman's perspective, Halberstam writes that queer subjects have conventionally "been bound epistemologically to negativity, to nonsense, to antiproduction, and to unintelligibility, and instead of fighting this characterization by dragging

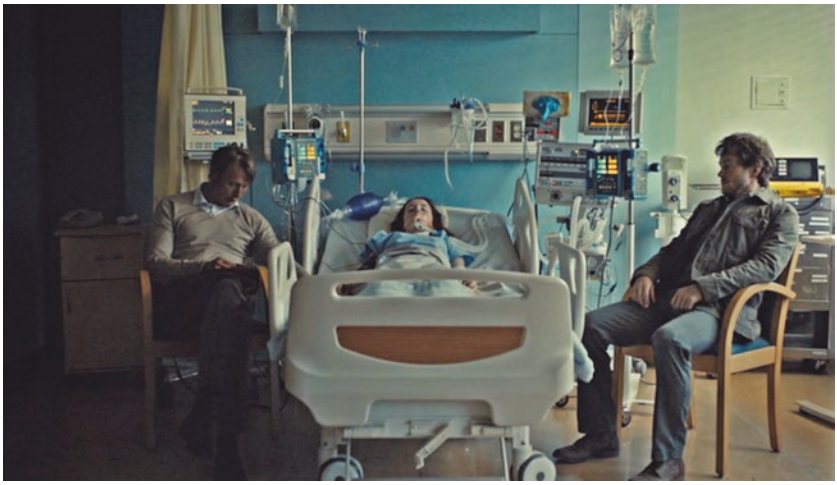


Fig. 5.1 Hannibal (Mads Mikkelsen) and Will (Hugh Dancy) sit by Abigail's (Kacey Rohl) bed in the hospital room

queerness into recognition, he proposes that we embrace the negativity that we anyway structurally represent" (106). Halberstam and Edelman both explore the hegemonic norms that structure society and the liberatory potential that can be derived from the queer defiance of those norms. The family unit that Will and Hannibal form—in its reconfiguration of a traditional family structure into a mode that defies hegemony—is one of these liberatory queer constructions.

Hannibal's queering of family structures is paralleled by its queering of heterosexual romance. This is especially true of its first two seasons, as embodied by Alana Bloom, a character who is romantically attached to both Will and Hannibal. She is connected more intimately to Will throughout the first season, but she is reluctant to pursue any romantic attachment due to what she perceives as his "instability," which is at that point being exacerbated by Hannibal's manipulations. After Alana rejects Will's romantic advances, Will drives—in Hannibal's words—"an hour in the snow to tell me about it." In that moment, and many others, the repeatedly thwarted relationship between Will and Alana is viewed through the lens of Will and Hannibal's intimate, combative relationship. The second season upends that relationship—and the show's entire status quo—with Will institutionalized due to Hannibal's machinations.

Will's increasingly aggressive insistence that Hannibal is behind a spate of murders that he had been investigating with the FBI pushes Alana and Hannibal closer together. Following an incident in which Hannibal and Alana cut contact with Will, the pair begin a sexual relationship. In part, Hannibal instigates the romantic relationship to provide an alibi for a crime he commits while Alana is sleeping. However, the pair's discussion about funerals increasing sex drive refers implicitly to Will, suggesting that they are both mourning the loss of that relationship. *Hannibal*'s framing of even its ostensibly heterosexual relationships through the lens of Will and Hannibal's obsession with one another renders its representation of heterosexuality inextricably queer.

A sex scene midway through *Hannibal*'s second season is emblematic of its treatment of sexuality. Two couples—Alana and Hannibal, and Margot and Will—are shown having sex in separate locations.[5] The crosscutting and montage techniques used to depict these sexual encounters allow the series to suggest the various desires of each character. Most notably, a shot toward the end of the sequence depicts Hannibal, Alana, and Will sharing a bed, forcing the viewer to reflect on the complex dynamic that exists between them (Fig. 5.2). The positioning of Will's hand on Alana's shoulder recalls their would-be romantic connection, but the choice to place the three characters in the same shot instead of isolating Will and Alana suggests Hannibal and Will's implicit desire for each other. Further, placing Alana between Hannibal and Will visually represents the sublimation of their desire for each other into a more conventional heterosexual relationship. *Hannibal* therefore imbues its representation of heterosexuality with traces of queerness in a manner that suggests the central characters' unspoken desires.

In its final season, *Hannibal*'s queer subtext is brought closer to the surface. Ironically, given her role as a presumably heterosexual love interest in the first two seasons, queerness is explored most explicitly through Alana. In the final season of the series, Alana begins a lesbian relationship with Margot, the other participant in the second season's sex scene. The relationship that follows is perhaps most noteworthy in that it did not—and could not—exist within the novels. Within the source material, Alana exists only as a peripheral character named Alan Bloom, a heterosexual man, described in *Red Dragon* as "a small round man with sad eyes" (38). Margot has undertaken a less radical transformation, but Fuller still significantly alters the details of the character, especially in terms of her appearance. In Harris's novel *Hannibal* (1999), the author



Fig. 5.2 Hannibal (Mads Mikkelsen), Alana (Caroline Dhavernas), and Will (Hugh Dancy) share a bed

describes "a broad-shouldered person with short blonde hair" (62). His description conforms to masculine stereotypes of lesbianism, as demonstrated by the following passage: "At close inspection she was a woman, holding out her hand, arm extended straight from the shoulder. Clearly Margot Verger was a bodybuilder. Beneath her corded neck, her massive shoulders and arms stretched the mesh of her tennis shirt" (62). It is noteworthy that Buffalo Bill and Margot, the two queer characters from Harris's original series, conform to queer inversion archetypes: the effeminate male villain and the butch lesbian, respectively. These representations of queerness tie that queerness inextricably to gender identity. Fuller's conception of Margot is noticeably feminized, perhaps in an attempt to avoid perpetuating stereotypes of lesbianism. Fuller also alters several aspects of Margot's characterization. Within the novels, Margot's voice is "scratchy, but deep like Mason's from the hormones she had taken." In a somewhat convoluted scenario, Harris's Margot asks her heterosexual brother Mason for his sperm to produce their family's heir with her female partner—who is depicted only fleetingly—because her excessive steroid usage has rendered her sterile. In contrast, Fuller shows Mason, one of the primary antagonists of the series, forcibly removing Margot's uterus after she becomes pregnant following her

participation in the previously discussed sex scene. Within the novels, then, Margot's infertility is a means of reinforcing her masculine characterization. Within Fuller's adaptation, it becomes a metaphor for the oppression that queer individuals face. That oppression is reinforced by the stipulation of her father's will that the family fortune can be inherited only by a male heir. Fuller's adaptation creates more room for queerness while simultaneously disavowing the characterization of queerness within the source material.

Hannibal's depiction of a lesbian relationship also presents a metaphor for queer individuals escaping the circumstances of their oppression. Margot's characterization within the series could be questioned in that she is defined almost exclusively by her abuse at the hands of her brother and by her desire to have a child. That latter desire especially could be read as a concession to hegemonic modes of living. Halberstam suggests that "the concept of *family*, whether in hetero or homo contexts, almost always introduces normative understandings of time and transmission" (71). Superficially, then, Margot's desire to procreate evinces normative connotations. However, the particulars of her narrative are far from normative, as Margot eventually kills her brother and takes his semen, subsequently using it to inseminate Alana and produce a male heir. Margot's father and brother represent the exclusion of queer individuals from hegemonic structures. Margot is positioned within hegemonic norms in her desire to have a child, but she engages with those norms in a manner that satisfies her own desires while simultaneously rejecting the misogyny and homophobia of her family. Further, her narrative is a metaphorical representation of queer liberation that rejects the normative connotations that ideologies of reproduction and family frequently engage. Fuller's depiction of Margot resonates more strongly as a queer narrative than Harris's does in that it depicts a queer individual defeating the prejudiced agents of her oppression, rather than struggling with self-imposed circumstances, as in the original Margot's steroid-based sterility.

Hannibal's aforementioned reinscription of the traditional conception of family suggests the potential for the revision of normative modes of social organization. Much of the discourse surrounding queerness revolves around the possibility of queer individuals being assimilated into dominant society, such as the desire to legalize marriage for same-sex individuals. Instead of considering how queer individuals could become a part of dominant structures, *Hannibal* presents a vision of queerness

transforming those structures. In many ways, the family unit that Margot and Alana form with their child is a mirror of the one that Hannibal and Will form with Abigail. Both trios include two same-sex parents, whether literally or metaphorically. It is also noteworthy that the child belongs—genetically, at least—to Mason rather than Margot, as in Will and Hannibal's dynamic with Abigail, disconnecting *Hannibal*'s conception of family from the idea of generational continuity. These families represent a reconfiguration of the traditional family, which is usually conceived as containing an opposite-sex couple who are capable of producing children together. Halberstam's opposition to the family as a unit of social organization derives from her assertion that the concept of family frequently generates a "false narrative of continuity" (71). Specifically, the centrality of family to dominant society has the effect of delegitimizing other potential modes of social organization. Halberstam suggests the possibility of women and queer people "jamming the smooth operations of the normal and the ordinary. Generally speaking, these operations take on an air of inevitability and naturalness simply by virtue of being passed on from one generation to another" (70). Although *Hannibal* does not decentralize family as a mode of social organization as Halberstam desires, it does reject the normative values that underpin it. That rejection can be seen explicitly in the fact that each of these families requires the dissolution of a traditional family connection before they can be formed: Abigail's father and Margot's brother are both sacrificed in the formation of these new, fundamentally queer families. *Hannibal*'s families represent a queer revision of traditional structures in that their existence forces the viewer to reconsider the parameters of what a family can be.

The queerness of Fuller's adaptation of *Hannibal* becomes increasingly overt as the series progresses. For instance, Alana and Margot's relationship does not—and could not—exist in any other iteration of the series, which is true not only because of Alana's original conception as Alan Bloom within the novel, but also because Margot was not included within the earlier film adaptation of *Hannibal*, despite her centrality to the novel's events. The first depiction of Margot and Alana's sexual relationship, which comes midway through the third season, recalls the previously discussed sex scene. Their sexual encounter is even more stylized than that previous scene, a giddy and explicit affirmation of the implicit queerness within the earlier scene. Fuller presents the two women within a kaleidoscopic composition that demonstrates their intimacy and revises

the audience's prior conceptions of Alana's sexuality (see Fig. 5.3). Stylistic choices also serve to enhance the subtextual queerness between Will and Hannibal. Towards the end of Margot and Alana's kaleidoscopic sex scene, Fuller presents a superimposition that merges Alana and Margot. That superimposition is explicitly echoed later in the episode, when Will and Hannibal reunite after not sharing the screen for a full five episodes (Fig. 5.4). That superimposition does not necessarily confirm a sexual—or even romantic—relationship between Will and Hannibal, but it does position these two pairings as similarly entwined. As in its earlier complication of heterosexuality, *Hannibal*'s depiction of explicit queerness also deepens the implicit queerness of Will and Hannibal.

The relationship between Will and Hannibal was not initially intended as homoerotic; this was something that developed over the course of the series, partly in response to the show's queer fan base. In an interview published midway through *Hannibal*'s second season, Bryan Fuller stated: "Will Graham is very definitely heterosexual, but that does not necessarily prevent us from a homoerotic subtext" ("Bryan Fuller Breaks Down Homoerotic Charge"). Fuller seemed reluctant to make a definitive statement about Hannibal's sexuality, but in the same interview he stated that "it is that intimacy between heterosexual men that I'm fascinated with because it does go beyond physical parameters to this very

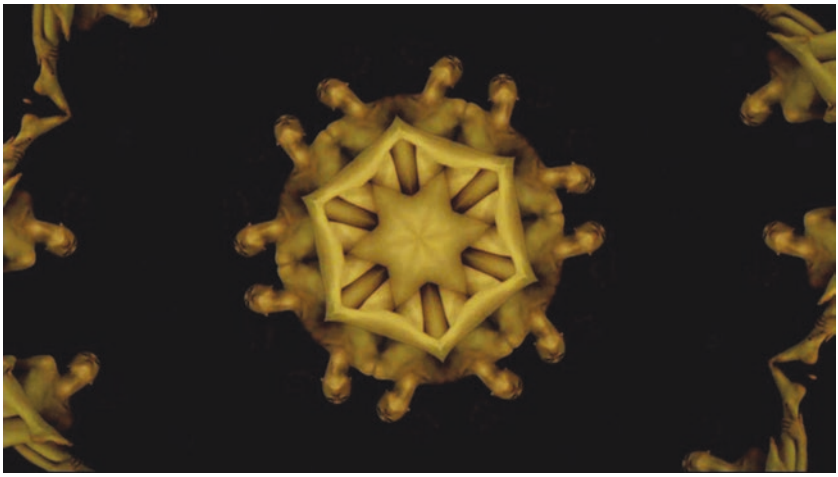


Fig. 5.3 A stylized shot illustrating implicit queerness



Fig. 5.4 In one superimposed shot, Alana (Caroline Dhavernas) and Margot (Katharine Isabelle) merge (top). In another, Will (Hugh Dancy) and Hannibal (Mads Mikkelsen) merge (bottom)

primal basic male bonding place." These statements are particularly interesting in light of the third season of the series, which makes the romantic relationship between Will and Hannibal almost undeniable, including a scene in which Will directly asks Hannibal's psychiatrist if

Hannibal is in love with him. When Fuller was asked about the textual confirmation of Will and Hannibal's romance following the conclusion of the third season, he remarked, "it just felt organic to me, so I guess I had been fooling myself about how obvious that element of the story was. Maybe I had been reacting to the feedback in the Twitterverse, where there was a lot of Hannigram wish fulfilment" ("*Hannibal*: Bryan Fuller talks season 4").[6] There is a clear trajectory here from Fuller's earlier use of subtextual queerness to explore Will and Hannibal's relationship to his eventual realization that the queerness of the series could be textual as well as subtextual. That trajectory is even more significant in terms of how it was influenced by the passion of *Hannibal*'s fan base.[7] *Hannibal*'s fans engaged in their own acts of queer adaptation—including fan fiction and artwork depicting Hannibal and Will in romantic contexts—which deviated from Fuller's initial vision of the relationship between the characters, but eventually informed it significantly.

The steadily increasing presence of queerness within *Hannibal* is in line with the themes of the series, which consistently dwells on the process and consequences of transformation. Hannibal himself often dwells on the transformations of others. For Will, that transformation comes not necessarily in a realization of his sexual orientation, but in his partnership—literal or metaphorical—with Hannibal. In the third season, Will places another character into a position where she must kill to save her own life, a clear repetition of Hannibal's early manipulations of Will. That already-undeniable association is heightened when Will organizes the body in an extravagant firefly-inspired tableau, in an image that recalls Hannibal's extravagant presentation of his victims (Fig. 5.5). It also explicitly recalls a passage of dialogue from Hannibal himself a few episodes earlier: "I kept cochlear gardens as a young man to attract fireflies. Their larvae would devour many times their own body weight in snails. Fuel to power a transformation into a delicate creature of such beauty." That dialogue has resonance for most of the characters in the series, but especially Will and Alana, who end the series as significantly different people than they were when it began. *Hannibal*'s increasing queerness is textually reflected by the series' consistent consideration of transformation.

Fuller's self-conscious mode of adaptation allows the viewer to reflect on his adaptation of the source material. One prominent example of that has already been discussed in the rewriting of Alana Bloom and the inclusion of her relationship with Margot Verger. Another instance of adaptation can be seen in Fuller's repurposing of iconic images from the



Fig. 5.5 Will (Hugh Dancy) organizes a body in an extravagant firefly-inspired tableau (top) that mimics Hannibal's (Mads Mikkelsen) extravagant presentation of one of his victims (bottom)

earlier films: when Will is temporarily institutionalized during the second season, he is at one point depicted in a costume that is strikingly similar to Hannibal's restraints in Demme's adaptation of *The Silence of the Lambs* (Fig. 5.6). That image—and many others throughout the



Fig. 5.6 When Will (Hugh Dancy) is arrested, he is restrained in a costume (top) strikingly similar to that of Hannibal (Anthony Hopkins) in *The Silence of the Lambs* (bottom)

series—generates different associations based on the viewer's familiarity with Hannibal Lecter across various mediums. Spectators who have seen Demme's film will be struck by Fuller's reappropriation of images, while those who have read Thomas Harris's novels will know that Will is never

imprisoned within them, and is, in fact, only featured in the first of them. Fuller self-consciously foregrounds the process of adaptation by repurposing elements from earlier iterations of the Hannibal Lecter narrative, whether the viewer's knowledge is derived from the novels, the films, or the character's prominence in popular culture.

Hannibal's transformation motif can be observed not only within the characterization and adaptation of the source material, but also in the very structure of the series. At the outset, *Hannibal* presents a combination of episodic and serialized elements. The episodic elements come from the murderers that Will and the FBI pursue in each episode. The serialized element comes in the relationship between Will and Hannibal, as Hannibal undermines Will's already precarious mental state. There are further elements of serialization within the FBI narrative in the hunt for the Chesapeake Ripper, a prolific serial killer who is quickly revealed—to the viewer, at least—to be Hannibal himself. The first season ends with Hannibal framing Will for Abigail's death, resulting in Will being institutionalized. Throughout the second season, Hannibal fills a similar role for the FBI as Will did in the first season, while Will tries to prove Hannibal's guilt. That new dynamic simultaneously revises and sustains the initial status quo of the series as the conflict between Will and Hannibal occupies more screen time, though the FBI still plays an important role. At the end of the second season, the aftermath of the discovery of Hannibal's guilt leaves Will, Alana, Jack, and Abigail wounded and possibly dead, while Hannibal himself flees to Europe. The first half of the third season sheds any semblance of the episodic nature of the early series, discarding the FBI setting entirely and telling an entirely serialized narrative about the attempt to capture Hannibal. Instead of allowing that narrative to unfold throughout the entirety of its third season, though, the hunt for Hannibal concludes midway through the season. The series subsequently establishes *another* status quo, with Hannibal imprisoned and Will helping the FBI hunt for another serial killer. The series reinvents itself repeatedly, shuffling its characters in a manner that subverts the viewer's expectations. In that sense, *Hannibal*'s structural reinventions represent another iteration of the transformation motif that drives the entire series.

The final half of *Hannibal*'s third season returns to many of the elements that defined its earlier, more episodic iterations, including the return of the FBI setting and its related ensemble. These last episodes also provide a new iteration of the transformation motif, in the repeated

insistence that its villain is "becoming" something new. The word attains an almost mythic status, as when Will says, "The Jacobis were the first to help him, the first to lift him into the Glory of his Becoming." In its usage of the present tense, the word is also emblematic of *Hannibal*'s representation of queerness. The queerness of *Hannibal*'s characters does not exist exclusively in their sexual orientations, but also in their transformations. Hannibal articulates that message when he says, "Even if you know the state of who you are today, you can't predict who you'll be tomorrow. You're defined up to now, not beyond." Viewed within this context, queerness is not defined through a rigid opposition to heterosexuality. Instead, it is the fluidity of the characters—their sexuality, their relationships, their shifting values—that makes them fundamentally queer. The consistent consideration of transformation echoes Halberstam's treatment of queerness and culture in the tendency of her work to move "back and forth between high and low culture, high and low theory, popular culture and esoteric knowledge, in order to push through the division between life and art, practice and theory, thinking and doing, and into a more chaotic realm of knowing and unknowing" (2). The conclusion of the series embodies Halberstam's preoccupation with negativity and transformation. Within the novels, the Red Dragon escapes capture and attacks Will, only to be shot and killed by Will's wife. In other words, Will is saved by the power of heterosexuality.[8] In Fuller's adaptation, Hannibal and Will kill the Red Dragon together. Will subsequently realizes how much he enjoyed the experience and pulls Hannibal over the edge of a cliff. Their physical proximity in that moment is akin to a lover's embrace (Fig. 5.7). In the preceding episodes, Will finally begins to realize the depth of Hannibal's feelings for him, going so far as to ask Hannibal's psychiatrist if Hannibal is in love with him. Will and Hannibal's killing of the Red Dragon, then, functions as a kind of consummation that nonetheless refuses to explicitly articulate their feelings for one another. Due to the subsequent cancelation of the series, their fates are left ambiguous in the final episode of the series. Although unsatisfying on a conventional dramatic level, that ambiguity is the perfect culmination of a relationship—and a series—that dwelled largely in spaces of uncertainty.

It is possible to imagine a reading of *Hannibal* that understands it as a straightforward perpetuation of stereotypically villainous queers, as some have considered *The Silence of the Lambs*. However, that reading would misrepresent Fuller's adaptation of Thomas Harris's source material.



Fig. 5.7 The physical proximity of Hannibal (Mads Mikkelsen) and Will (Hugh Dancy) in this shot is akin to a lover's embrace

In Fuller's series, as in the novels, Hannibal is a remorseless killer. However, the series presents Hannibal and Will's tortured, queer relationship as its emotional and narrative center, a luxury not afforded to Buffalo Bill in Demme's *The Silence of the Lambs.* There is no easy delineation of heroes or villains within *Hannibal*, especially by the end of its third season, indicating an ambiguous and nuanced approach to character and sexuality. That ambiguity is embodied in its consistent reflection on transformation, or "becoming," a process that can be observed in the characters, the structure of the series, and in the adaptation itself. That approach echoes Judith Halberstam's own approach to queerness in *The Queer Art of Failure*, which positions the failure to conform to hegemony as one of its fundamental traits. However, Halberstam's interpretation of queerness in that text is at odds with her earlier reading of *The Silence of the Lambs*, which interprets the film in a manner that renders it apolitical. The difference between Demme's *The Silence of the Lambs* and Fuller's *Hannibal* is especially striking in this context: the former text's Buffalo Bill is trapped within a narrative and ideological framework that is defined by its rigidity, while *Hannibal* embraces its characters' perverse complexities and eschews easy moral oppositions. Fuller's adaptation of *Hannibal* creates room for various

permutations of queerness, both implicit and explicit, within a narrative space that has previously marginalized or villainized queer figures.

Notes

1. I will refer to Harris's novel *Hannibal* as *Hannibal* (1999) and the series simply as *Hannibal* to prevent any confusion.
2. Christopher Sharrett's 1992 "Hollywood Homophobia" notes that protesters at the Academy Awards were protesting the representation of queerness in *The Silence of the Lambs*, *JFK* (Stone 1991), and *Basic Instinct* (Verhoeven 1992). Sharrett argues that within *Silence*, "transsexuals are thrown into the same poisoned stew as mentally disturbed people, as the film shows absolutely no interest in the causes of mental illness or serial violence, or in the plight of those scapegoated by the majority."
3. Halberstam is also commonly identified as Jack Halberstam but is reportedly comfortable with both male and female pronouns. The texts in question are published under the name Judith, so that name—as well as feminine pronouns—will be used throughout to avoid confusion.
4. In this context, "gender nonconformity" refers to a form of gender expression that does not match with traditional conceptions of gender. *The Silence of the Lambs* derives much of its horror from Bill's effeminacy and stated desire to be—or at least embody—a woman.
5. Margot is introduced midway through the second season. She identifies as lesbian; her participation in the sex scene with Will is part of a plan to escape the oppression of her brother, Mason.
6. "Hannigram" is the portmanteau most commonly used in reference to the Will/Hannibal pairing.
7. Fuller's engagement with *Hannibal*'s fandom—and in particular with fans of the Hannigram pairing—is also evident on social media, as in his posting of fan art depicting the pair in a sexual context (Fuller 2017).
8. That moment is somewhat undercut when an offhand line of dialogue in *The Silence of the Lambs* establishes that Will's wife subsequently left him, but it retains its ideological weight in the context of the original novel.

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PART II

Bodies, Time, and Space

Check for updates

CHAPTER 6

Moonlight, Adaptation, and Queer Time

Pamela Demory

In February 2017 I was flipping through the Datebook section of the *San Francisco Chronicle* when I came upon a short article stating that Barry Jenkins's film *Moonlight* had been nominated for Best Adapted Screenplay by the Writers Guild of America *and* Best Original Screenplay by the Academy of Motion Arts and Pictures (it would go on to win both awards) (Ordoña). How, I wondered, could a screenplay be *both* "original" and "adapted"? Aren't these two different things? And yet the more I thought about it, the more I began to think that the very ambiguity of the film's identity might say something important about the nature of adaptation more generally. We tend to toss off the terms "original" and "adaptation" rather lightly, but they aren't quite that clear cut. Every so-called original text is in some intertextual relationship with prior texts, and the adaptation may, in fact, be the first text someone encounters—making it the "original," at least for that person. For me, the fact that *Moonlight* was lauded as both an original and an adaptation struck me as interestingly odd—queer, in fact. That queer sense was only intensified when—in the by-now infamous flubbing of the Oscar for Best Picture announcement—the film became not only both an original and an adaptation but also both a loser and a winner. I realized that the

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film's ambiguous identity, which dissolved boundaries of various kinds, would aptly illustrate the intersection of queer and adaptation that I had been thinking seriously about for the previous year.

Moonlight is based on an unpublished play titled *In Moonlight Black Boys Look Blue* by Tarell Alvin McCraney, who wrote it as a drama school project in 2003. But the play has never been published or performed. (The Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences defines adaptation as something that is based on a "published" work—thus the award for "original" screenplay.) In 2010, Barry Jenkins got hold of the manuscript through mutual friends in the Miami arts scene, and he loved it: "When I first read Tarell's play, I told him it was like he took a memory of my memories and placed them into this fever dream" (Gould 19). It turns out the two men had grown up in the same Liberty City area of Miami in the 1980s and early '90s. Both had grown up with single mothers who suffered from drug addiction; they even knew some of the same people, and yet they didn't meet until after Jenkins had read the play in 2010. So the play resonated with Jenkins in a very personal way. McCraney had already played with the idea of turning the story into a filmscript—in fact, he says, he had already written in filmic transitions, such as "cut to…" (Anderson)—but he was interested in writing plays,[1] not movies, and so hadn't pursued the film angle. But when Jenkins decided to take it on, he enlisted McCraney's input, and the result is very much a collaborative effort.

So why study the film *as* an adaptation? What is to be gained? After all, the source material is unavailable—there's no text to compare (and McCraney insists he has no plans to publish it [Allen]). Linda Hutcheon argues that "to experience [a text] *as an adaptation*, … we need to recognize it as such and to know its adapted text, thus allowing the latter to oscillate in our memories with what we are experiencing" (120–121). And yet that isn't possible here. All we can know about the source text is what we can glean from the DVD extras and what McCraney and Jenkins say in interviews. Yet, as Colleen Kennedy-Karpat and Eric Sandberg note, these sorts of "paratextual and metatextual discourses can frame adaptations and intertexts more overtly than the adaptive text itself.… The critical response produces less of an evaluation of the new text vis-à-vis its canonical hypotext, and more of an invitation to consider how an adaptive connection adds layers of depth to a work" (16). Even though we can't read the play, we can get a sense of how the play would have been constructed, how it would have worked, from the comments

by McCraney and Jenkins—and this can help us see the text as a palimpsest, "a form of adaptation in which an original work may exist only as a trace or as an unseen foundation" (Corrigan 26). The layers of the palimpsest include McCraney's play, the life experiences of both McCraney and Jenkins, and a mythology that according to McCraney "goes back into antiquity" (Jung).

In an interview, McCraney described the story as a series of "what if" scenarios: what if, for example, "I [had] decided to follow in the footsteps of one of the persons I greatly admired as a child and become a drug dealer?" (Jung). What's interesting to me is that "it" is not clearly defined here—he could be talking about the movie, about his own play, about the screenplay—the lines between these various texts blur. The film is just the top layer of the palimpsestic text, through which we can glimpse the traces of the play and the lives of the authors. And perhaps this way of seeing the text presents a strategy for approaching other adaptations. Hutcheon suggests that motivations for adaptation might include to "consume and erase the memory of the adapted text or to call it into question" or "to pay tribute" (7). Yet *Moonlight* suggests something else—adaptation not as some sort of contest between two separate—competing—works (which one's better? which one's more authentic?), but as a collaboration among artists and readers and commentators and spectators. This definition is more in line with Timothy Corrigan's suggestion that we think of adaptation as what happens in "the interval, or the 'in between,'" that it emerges out of the confluence of "process, product, and reception" (32). Queerness, too, resides in what can't quite be pinned down definitively, in (as José Esteban Muñoz writes) "ephemeral traces, flickering illuminations from other times and places … [that] assist those of us who wish to follow queerness's promise, its still unrealized potential, to see something else" (28). Looking at *Moonlight as* an adaptation is useful, then, because doing so reveals the queer potential of adaptation. Doing so also reveals layers of interpretation that would otherwise not be visible. Specifically, it helps us to see the film's essential queerness, which has to do not just with its focus on a gay character but with its construction of time and space, its resistance to—and revision of—conventional narrative patterns.

Time

As far as I can glean from what McCraney and Jenkins have said in interviews, the basic elements of character and plot are similar in both play and film. It's the story of Chiron, a black boy growing up in a poverty-stricken area of Miami called Liberty City, with a single mother who is addicted to crack cocaine. Both film and play focus on his life at three distinct periods: when he is eleven years old, when he is sixteen, and when he is twenty-five. At eleven, he is befriended by Juan, the neighborhood drug dealer, who is both the source of his mother's drug habit and a benevolent father figure. Juan and Teresa (Juan's partner) provide Chiron with a safe place to stay when his mother is too high to care about him. At school, Chiron is bullied by the other boys, who seem to sense that he is gay even before he himself realizes it. He has one great friend, Kevin, who is popular and also looks after Chiron, urging him to stand up for himself against their bullying. As teenagers, Chiron and Kevin tentatively begin a sexual relationship, but Kevin, struggling to maintain his popularity at school, lets himself be manipulated into fighting Chiron, and the resulting mêlée ends with Chiron being arrested. As young adults, both Chiron and Kevin have spent time in prison, but their lives have otherwise gone in very different directions, and the film ends with them finally reconnecting.

In the play, according to McCraney, the protagonist is depicted as three characters—the child, teenager, and young adult, all of whom would be on stage at the same time, repeating each others' actions. So, for example, we might see the child waking up and brushing his teeth, and then the adolescent would brush his teeth, and then the young adult would brush his. "It was simultaneous," McCraney said in an interview. "So you saw pretty much a day in the life of each character at the same time" (Allen). But it was unstageable, according to McCraney: "it's not a play," he says. "You realize halfway through the script that it's … the same person, but it moves at a swiftness you couldn't do on stage" (Allen). The challenge for Jenkins in adapting the play for the film was to make the story legible. So he untangled the narrative, gave it a three-act structure, and spaced it out chronologically. At first it might seem that the film "de-queers" the play: a straight director rewrites a gay playwright's story to emphasize his own experience, straightening out the story—literally and metaphorically. Its very mainstream success as a critically acclaimed Oscar-winning film seems opposed to queerness. But a

close look at the film in relation to what we can glean about the source text suggests otherwise.

For one thing, the film doesn't proceed according to the "normal" rules of narrative development: cause–effect logic, clear linear development, steady pacing. It illustrates, instead, what queer theorists call "queer time." The concept of queer time emerged from the AIDS crisis, when so many gay men (in particular) were living in "the shadow of an epidemic."[2] Judith Halberstam writes that the threat of having "no future" produced an "urgency of being [that] also expands the potential of the moment and … squeezes new possibilities out of the time at hand" (2). Halberstam argues that this queer temporality—the intense focus on "the now"—applies also to "women, transgenders, and queers," particularly "queer people of color" (3). It would also apply to the characters in *Moonlight*, who are living under a similar threat of "no future"—in this case due to pervasive poverty, violence, and drugs.

And yet, writes Halberstam, queer time is not only about focusing on the "now," it is also about

> the potentiality of a life unscripted by the conventions of family, inheritance, and child rearing.… Queer subcultures produce alternative temporalities by allowing their participants to believe that their futures can be imagined according to logics that lie outside of those paradigmatic markers of life experience—namely, birth, marriage, reproduction, and death. (2)

Consider the way conventional narrative patterns follow this paradigm: the bildungsroman that follows the protagonist from childhood, to adolescence, to adulthood signified by career (for men) and marriage (for women). Or the romance, which follows the protagonist from lonely singleness to heterosexual coupledom. Narratives that resist these conventional patterns, then, might be described as queer. "Alternative temporalities" might include more than simply alternative plot patterns; they might include (as Elizabeth Freeman writes) "textual moments of asynchrony, anachronism, anastrophe, belatedness, compression, delay, [or] ellipsis" (xxii). These sorts of "queer temporalities," she argues, function as "points of resistance," strategies for resisting conventional or scripted patterns—in literature and in life.

As a playwright, McCraney tends toward representations of time that align with these definitions of queer time. He says he often tells people his plays take place in "the distant present," a phrasing that suggests a

time that is "just out of reach, yet not quite fully in the time of the now. But it is close enough to register as familiar" (Roman 188). The concept is similar to what Valerie Rohy calls an "expanded present tense" (253) or what Carolyn Dinshaw calls "the multitemporality of the *now*" (qtd. in Rohy 253). It's clear from the way he talks about *In Moonlight Black Boys Look Blue* that this sense of queer time operated there, too, especially in the circular structure of the play, with the three different versions of the character playing out their lives at the same time.

Jenkins, in changing the structure, created a linear narrative out of this circularity that might at first seem to be a capitulation to the demands of conventional filmmaking, but which instead captures the claustrophobic feeling of the play by constructing the film as a series of *moments*. Overall, the film's narrative does proceed in linear fashion. Its three chapters depict the protagonist at eleven years old (when he's known as "Little"), seventeen years old (when he goes by his given name, Chiron), and then twenty-five years old (when he goes by "Black"). And within each chapter, the events depicted develop generally in chronological order. But this forward narrative movement is countered by other strategies that resist what Muñoz calls the "linearity of straight time" (25). Each chapter represents a pivotal *moment* in the character's life. Jenkins comments in the making-of documentary on the DVD that as he worked on "the script it just sort of came out. And it came out in images. Images and sounds and feelings" ("Ensemble"). This focus on the image makes everything seem to be happening "now."

Narrative discontinuity is further emphasized by the extended ellipses between chapters—six years between chapters one and two and eight years between chapters two and three. And events that in a more conventional narrative would be key plot points—Juan's death, Chiron's imprisonment, whatever event or events led Paula (Chiron's mother) to end up in rehab—happen off stage (as it were), referred to in passing, if at all, with no details. Even within chapters, there's little attempt to connect one scene with the next in a linear way. A scene with Little at home with his mother, for example, cuts to a scene of boys playing soccer at school, cuts to a scene of Juan driving through the neighborhood. One doesn't necessarily lead to the next in a cause–effect fashion. The editing of these apparently discontinuous scenes, along with the enormous gaps between chapters, allows for narrative development that relies less on logic and more on contingency, or chance.

The climactic turn in the third chapter depends on just such a chance event. As Jenkins notes in the making-of DVD extra, "sometimes you just meet someone. Or someone from your past returns" ("Ensemble"). The opening of the chapter at first suggests that the narrative is proceeding through conventional logic: shots of Black driving his car are parallel to the shots of Juan driving his car in chapter one, conveying in an economical way what has happened between chapters: Chiron has taken Juan's place as neighborhood drug dealer. We can see the narrative logic of this; he is following in the footsteps of the man who was such a caring father figure for him. But then Kevin calls, and the narrative trajectory is thrown wide open. Why does he call? Because some guy walked into his diner and played a song on the jukebox that reminded him of Chiron. That chance event upsets our expectations. That phone call—and the ellipse of eight years that it collapses—becomes a queer point of resistance, reorienting our sense of who Chiron is and where he is headed.

Perhaps the film's most important—and obvious—alternative narrative strategy is repetition, a key element of the play as well. As McCraney says about the play, "I was trying to figure out what little me and grown me were doing that was the same and not the same.... What patterns I was repeating, what is this life?" (Anderson). This concept of same/not same recalls Linda Hutcheon's definition of adaptation as "repetition without replication" (7), suggesting an analogy between identity construction and textual adaptation.

In the film, the three chapters are almost rigidly parallel. In each chapter we see the same simple acts repeated: eating, washing, walking, sleeping, driving. In a scene early in chapter one, for example, we see Little sitting at a table at a cafe, eating, while Juan looks on. In chapter two, we see Chiron, eating a meal at that same table, while Teresa looks on, and in chapter three, we see Black, sitting at a table at a café while Kevin looks on. Looking at the three scenes next to each other (as in Fig. 6.1), we can see the parallels quite clearly. The repetition creates continuity across all three chapters and creates the illusion that these three very different-looking actors are the same person at different stages in his life.

Small differences within these repetitive sequences economically communicate what has happened between chapters. In chapter one we see a long shot of Little in the bathtub, in profile, his head covered with white soap suds. The camera lingers. In chapter two, after Chiron has been beaten at school, we see him again immersing himself in water, but this time it's a medium close-up shot from the back, showing Chiron



Fig. 6.1 Little (Alex R. Hibbert) eats while Juan (Mahershala Ali) looks on (top). Chiron (Ashton Sanders) eats while Teresa (Janelle Monáe) looks on (middle). Black (Trevante Rhodes) eats while Kevin (André Holland) looks on (bottom)

immersing his face into a sink full of ice water then in slow motion raising his face so that he (and we, the spectators) can see his broken, bloody face. In chapter three, we see Black again immersing his face in the sink, in the same shot composition as chapter two, but this time, he hasn't been beaten up, he's been working out, and when he raises his head, we see him whole and strong (Fig. 6.2). The differences here help us to understand very quickly the change from little boy to bullied adolescent to fit and healthy young man. What we see is the *adaptation* of Little into Chiron and then into Black.

Despite this adaptive process, overall the repetition has the effect of circularity—that queer continuing moment that was characteristic of the play, and Chiron in some fundamental way seems not to change. The film thus reproduces in some ways Judith Butler's concept of identity as performative, as constituted through a compulsion to repeat. And as she notes, "repetition never fully accomplishes identity" (363). There is always something about the subject or the psyche that remains unknown, unexpressed. That unknown is "excess" that is always threatening to erupt "within the intervals of those repeated gestures and acts that construct the apparent uniformity of heterosexual positionalities, indeed which compels the repetition itself, and which guarantees its perpetual failure" (363). It seems to me that that unknown, that unexpressed



Fig. 6.2 In slow motion, we see Chiron (Ashton Sanders) bathing his face in ice water (top left), then raising up to gaze at his bloodied face in the mirror (top right). In a parallel shot, we see Black (Trevante Rhodes) bathing his face in ice water (bottom left) and then raising up to reveal his healthy strong face in the mirror (bottom right)

psyche, is the realm of creative texts that seek to represent and communicate what it means to be human. In other words, the film's repetition might be seen as a corollary to this performative excess—excess as images, moments, both ecstatic and reflective, that together attempt to convey the wholeness of a person. And it is also representative of the process of adaptation—the excess is the "inevitable supplement" (Stam 18) that a film adaptation produces.

The alternative narrative structure—the lack of cause–effect logic, the big gaps in time, and the repetition—all contribute to the sense of the film's continuing present tense, but at the same time the film also looks "maybe a little ahead, maybe a little behind," in McCraney's words (Jung). In many ways, *Moonlight* (and here I'm talking about the whole palimpsestic thing—play, script, movie) participates in the practice of queer history, for queer time is not just about narrative construction; it's about how real people live, people whose lives do not conform to the supposedly "natural" order of human life—childhood, graduation, work, marriage, children, grandchildren, and then death. Queer historians insist on engaging with the painful past. Heather Love, for example, in *Feeling Backward*, talks about the importance of "embracing loss, risking abjection" in order to heal. She points out that increasing visibility and positive outcomes (such as gay marriage) for *some* gay and lesbian people tend to obscure the continuing problems faced by many nonmainstream queer people: "the temptation to forget—to forget the outrages and humiliations of gay and lesbian history and to ignore the ongoing suffering of those not borne up by the rising tide of gay normalization—is stronger than ever" (10).

Both playwright and film director have acknowledged their interest in revisiting their own painful pasts. McCraney told an interviewer that he found the movie difficult to sit through because it is "a palpable snapshot of [his] memories and dreams" (Anderson). The film, as an adaptation, weaves the personal stories of both men together into this new text—queerly reconfigured. The character of Juan is based on a drug drealer "who took [Tarell] under his wing" when he was young (Gould 20), and the relationship between Little and his mother reflects Barry Jenkins's relationship with his mother. One of the most powerful cinematic strategies Jenkins uses to visually represent the way past trauma intrudes into the present is the shot of Little's mother, in the hallway of their home, screaming at him. In chapter one, the sequence is silent—in shot–reverse shots we see him looking at her; we see her screaming at

him, but there is no sound—Little cannot or will not hear her. In chapter three the sequence recurs—in a shocking discontinuity that is all the more traumatic given the otherwise unified temporal coherence of each separate chapter. Jenkins explains in a *Sight & Sound* interview that this scene wasn't in the script. He inserted it and then repeated it in the third chapter to "visually represent a nightmare that this character needed to wake up from" (Gould 19).

Heather Love's idea of "feeling backward" is perhaps best dramatized in the last chapter when Kevin asks Black if he remembers the last time they saw each other—presumably the day that Kevin and the other boys beat him bloody in the schoolyard. Black's response is typical of a progressivist stance toward bad history: "Nah, tried to forget all those times." But, clearly, forgetting has not helped him to craft an individual identity. Instead of moving on from that trauma, he has become mired in a repetitive cycle. Both his mother and Kevin repeatedly tell him that being a drug dealer "is not you." Although the ending of the movie leaves Black's future open, Kevin's reappearance in his life, prompting him to look back, perhaps signals his ability to now accept himself as a gay man who might not have to be a drug dealer.

The film's interest in history is not only personal but also cultural. As Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick has noted, "a lot of the most exciting recent work around 'queer' spins the term outward along dimensions that can't be subsumed under gender and sexuality at all" (8); class, race, ethnicity, nationality, and other identity discourses intersect. Tarell McCraney has participated in this kind of queer historiography in his other work; for example, in his play *Choir Boy*, he inserts a gay character into a setting familiar to African-American experience—the southern Black church. In a plot line very similar to that in *Moonlight*, the protagonist "is bullied for defying—with relentless audacity and even flamboyance—traditional forms of black masculinity" (Román 189).

Moonlight, too, participates in this kind of work, rewriting the conventional narratives of African-American experience and specifically the experience of African-American gay men. The setting of *Moonlight* seems at first to be the stage for what Gaylene Gould in *Sight & Sound* calls the "ubiquitous" story of "cruel and aggressive hypermasculinity" in a poor African-American community (18). That story seems to fall into one of two patterns: the narrative trajectory in which the hero battles crime, drugs, violence, and then rises above, escapes; and the less optimistic story of the hero who battles but fails to rise above the violence

and ends up dead or imprisoned. *Moonlight* resists both of these narratives: it has an ambivalent gay hero who is a tough drug dealer, a young man who is cruelly neglected by his mother but then weeps when she begs him to forgive her. The narrative doesn't have a clear-cut trajectory from poverty/crime to middle-class respectability, nor does it provide a clear pessimistic alternative.

Space

Narratives take place in space as well as time, and so (as Halberstam notes), "a 'queer' adjustment in the way in which we think about time … requires and produces new conceptions of space" (6). In a key speech, Juan tells Little: "Let me tell you somethin': it's black people *everywhere*, you remember that, okay? Ain't no place in the world ain't what got no black people, we was the first ones on this planet" (Jenkins 19). He goes on to tell Little about growing up in Cuba and how an old neighborhood lady, teasing him about running around and acting like a little fool at night, tells him, "In moonlight … black boys look blue. You blue … that's what I'm gone call you" (Jenkins 20). It's a theatrical moment that directs our attention to space in two ways: in the specific reminder that there are black people *everywhere* on the planet—not just confined to poor urban housing projects, as Little might assume from his limited experience, and in its allusion to McCraney's play (*In Moonlight Black Boys Look Blue*). Although the play was never performed, McCraney did at one point envision it as something to be acted out live in front of an audience. As a play, the audience's relationship to the character and to the actions would be quite different than in the film. For one thing, the liveness of the actors means the actions are embodied in a way that is very physical—unlike the pixels of the digital image. And because the performance would have been live, there would always be the potential for some surprise, some unforeseen event to cause a disruption or to turn the action in a different way. And in a theatrical production the spectator is in charge of the point of view—choosing what in particular to pay attention to, what to notice, what not to notice. And while of course the actors, the set and objects, the sounds, and—perhaps most crucially—the lighting will all direct the audience's attention, each person is free to look somewhere else, to notice something that's outside the intended effects of lighting, staging, sound.

Film, on the other hand, while literally two-dimensional and made solely of light and sound waves, has the paradoxical illusion of greater verisimilitude. On stage, Miami could only have been suggested by set decoration and lighting; the filmmakers, on the other hand, are free to film on location, to capture the light, the streets, the housing projects, and the people within all those spaces quite vividly and in full color. And while there's a little bit of the same freedom for the spectator to choose what to focus on in a given shot, the filmmaker has much more power to direct our attention, though close-up shots, camera movements, cuts, and lighting.

In some ways, then, the play seems inherently queerer—both in its narrative structure and in the very artificiality of the stage as a theatrical space, where the difference between actor and character, between life as it would be lived in the world and life as it is imitated on stage, is obvious. Yet Jenkins manages to capture a sense of queer space in the film by emphasizing ordinary places—such as home, school, and beach—and then injecting some new or different element that reorients our sense of the familiar. Juan and Teresa's home, for example, has everything we might expect from a middle-class, heteronormative family: a single-family house, with a carefully tended, tree-shaded lawn, simple but neat furnishings, a dining room, and a guest bedroom with bright white sheets. But Juan is a drug dealer, not a middle-class family man with a wife and a mortgage; when he hears an unexpected knock on the door, he pulls out a handgun. School scenes are in many ways typical: shots of hallways filled with bustling students, a cafeteria with groups of kids eating and goofing off, classrooms with biology lessons and kids alternately taking notes and looking bored. But the school is plain, the furnishings worn, the soccer ball the kids are playing with just a bundle of rags. And then there's Miami, which, at least in my mind, is associated with South Beach, with wealthy, beautiful (mostly white) people sunning themselves, sailing in fancy boats, eating fine cuisine, and drinking cleverly named cocktails. But in this movie, everyone is black, most are poor, and the beach is where a drug dealer gives swimming lessons to a little boy from the projects and where a young black boy has his first sexual experience with another boy.

And in all these spaces we see Chiron apart from the others. He doesn't fit, and the shot composition throughout the film effectively communicates Chiron's queer difference. These images reorient our sense of place, thus reclaiming (to paraphrase Schoonover and Galt) "a space for queers in [black American] history" (261).

Utopia

Despite the fact that Chiron's mother becomes so consumed with addiction that she neglects him, steals from him, strikes him; despite the fact that he gets beaten up at school and in striking back ends up getting arrested; despite the fact that as an adult he turns to dealing drugs himself—despite all this, a sense of hope emanates from every chapter that could be described as utopian. "Queerness," writes José Esteban Muñoz, "is a longing that propels us onward, beyond romances of the negative and toiling in the present. Queerness is that thing that lets us feel that this world is not enough, that indeed something is missing" (1); and a few pages later, he continues: "[I]n the face of hopeless heteronormative maps of the present," he continues, there is a "queer feeling of hope" (28).

We can sense this "queer feeling of hope" in specific scenes in the film: in chapter two, when Kevin and Chiron kiss on the beach, for example, and in the luminescent scene in chapter one when Juan teaches Little to swim. In this shot (see Fig. 6.3), the low angle emphasizes the characters' relationship to water and sky—and in that space, anything might be possible. As McCraney points out in the DVD making-of film, "these things exist at the same time—being bullied, beat up, and called a faggot, and this roaring, beautiful ocean and the moonlight on your body" ("Cruel"). The lighting, for McCraney, is a key to the entire story:



Fig. 6.3 Juan (Mahershala Ali) teaches Little (Alex R. Hibbert) to swim in the ocean

> It's probably under the moonlight that we see that black boys *can* be blue, *can* be sad and sullen and intimate…. because we rarely see ourselves in those hues or under that gaze. We see ourselves in the harsh police light or the amber of street lights, but what is it when the reflection of the sun or the moon is sitting on these bodies? What beauty can we see? (Anderson)

The film's cinematographer, James Layton, emphasizes the sense of utopian potential in the film by capturing both the grim housing projects and the ocean in golden daylight and serene blue moonlight, and through repeated shots of the horizon. For Jenkins, the horizon signifies both setting and character: "in Miami you're surrounded by water and the horizon is infinite. That also says a lot about a character who is always surrounded by open space and yet feels so locked into himself" (Gould 20). The horizon also signifies that longing for utopia to which Muñoz refers and a certain timelessness that is conveyed through repeated still shots of the ocean and pans up to gaze at the moon.

In the last two shots of the film past, present, and future all merge. According to Jenkins, the film's final scene was not in the source material: "The third story was just the two phone calls between Black and Kevin, but I thought we had to complete the journey these phone calls start…. The whole film is working to earn the right for that awkwardness and that tension, that moment when a man slowly rises to the surface" (Gould 20–21). The play's radical queer openness thus becomes completion and return. Yet the story is not closed. Apparently, Jenkins had originally intended to make the ending much more explicit. In the published filmscript, we hear Kevin and Black having sex in the last scene:

> The SOUND of bodies touching, the beginning of things … And mingling with that rush of waves, the sound of lips and hands, the joining of bodies, somewhere in this darkness Black and Kevin re-learning one another …. (Jenkins 97)

But in the finished film, the intimacy between Kevin and Black is much simpler (and to my mind more effective): Black rests his head upon Kevin's shoulder and Kevin gently caresses him. This gesture continues the promise of that teenage encounter on the beach but leaves it somewhat open to potential.

The film then cuts to a shot of Little, on the beach, first looking out at the ocean and then turning to face … us? or himself as a grown man?

We are left with that startlingly simple image of the little boy in white against the dark blue of the ocean in the moonlight. The boundary between man and child collapses, like the boundary between play and film, original and adaptation. We are left in the interval between. As José Muñoz writes, "Queerness is not yet here …. but we can feel it as the warm illumination of a horizon imbued with potentiality" (1).

Notes

1. McCraney, an acclaimed playwright and winner of numerous awards, including a 2013 MacArthur Fellowship, was the Royal Shakespeare Company's International Playwright in Residence from 2009–2011 and is currently Chair and Professor in the Practice of Playwriting at the Yale School of Drama and is the Yale Repertory Theatre Playwright-in-Residence.
2. Here Halberstam is paraphrasing language from Michael Cunningham's *The Hours*, his "queer adaptation" of Virginia Woolf's *Mrs. Dalloway*.

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CHAPTER 7

Adaptation as Queer Touching in *The Safety of Objects*: Transgressing the Boundaries of Bodies and Texts

Chiara Pellegrini

Recently, scholars studying adaptation have begun to question the notion of a clear boundary between the source text and its adaptation and have sought less hierarchical ways to describe that relationship. This move—inspired by poststructuralist challenges to notions of origin, identity, presence and plenitude—can be conceived of as a desire to "queer" adaptation. Concern with textual boundaries and nonhierarchical contact echoes recent queer writing on the body and touching. In this chapter, I juxtapose the concerns of adaptation studies and queer theory, drawing them together in a methodological touching to analyze texts already engaged in queer tensions and themes, A. M. Homes' short story collection *The Safety of Objects* (1990) and Rose Troche's 2001 film adaptation by the same name.

In both adaptation studies and queer theory it is possible to identify a desire to subvert how identity (textual or human) is traditionally perceived. New perspectives on adaptation seek to displace the notion of an original or primary text, conscious of how the fantasy of an

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incontestable origin, pure and self-identical, which controls the meaning of its copies, has been attacked by a tradition of poststructuralist writing (e.g., Derrida). Adaptation is a "two-way process instead of a form of one-way transport" (Bruhn 73); it is "relative, dynamic and interactive rather than unidirectional, fixed and hierarchical" (Schober 95). The dialogue between two texts reveals how they influence each other in a way that can never be traced back to an original gesture of influence: as both texts exist in the mind of the audience, the source is the result of the adaptation as much as the reverse. Similarly, queer writing on the body, as well as some feminist thought (e.g., Kristeva, Grosz), is also concerned with the interdependence of the individual and its others. Cutting the body off from what is "other" and insisting on its perfect intelligibility and internal coherence is seen as an exclusionary gesture attempting to control more fluid and fragmented ways to live identity. As I explore in detail below, certain phenomenological experiences as well as certain textual operations can be conceived as "moments of touching" that transgress these forceful separations. The boundaries of the self, just like the boundaries of the text, are permeable and allow exchange with its outside: through this exchange, or what I call here queer touching, individual identities are transformed. Queer touching is a moment of transformative contact that challenges the fundamental distinctions on which original and autonomous identity, in the Cartesian tradition, is founded: the distinction between self and other, inside and outside, part and whole. This type of exchange upsets the hierarchy of subject and object, exemplified by the fact that the person touching is also touched in return. The effect is similar to displacing the primacy of the "original" text in relation to its adaptations: individual identity is not only connected to, but formed through others.

Textual Walls, Bodily Contours

While not concerned specifically with queer sexuality or with explicitly gender variant identities, both A. M. Homes' short story collection *The Safety of Objects* and its film adaptation by Rose Troche enact queer tensions in line with some reflections about bodies found in queer theory. My aim is to draw out these tensions and show how they are intensified through the queer effects of the adaptation process itself. Homes' short stories depict a variety of solitary embodiments, as each story is strictly focalized through one character and

most have bodily experiences at their center. Several stories represent the effort of keeping bodies and identities well delineated, usually by taking an object or a body part as token of their integrity; at the same time, the collection is haunted by uncontrollable embodiments. Apart from the story that opens the book, which has been adapted by Homes herself into a novel and may have been left out for this reason, only two other stories are missing from the film, "The I of It" and "Yours Truly," both of which are comprised almost entirely of reflections on embodied feelings without much external action. While it might be tempting to explain their absence by resorting to the cliché that cinema cannot adequately represent interiority (see Hutcheon 56), I argue that it is the characters' isolation that motivates this exclusion, as the film chooses to focus on stories that represent relationships.

Homes' characters are constantly preoccupied with consolidating their precarious sense of identity, especially when it comes to normative gender roles. In the story that concludes the volume, "A Real Doll," a young boy negotiates his complex feelings about masculinity and femininity through Barbie dolls. In a series of half real, half fantasized sexual encounters with Barbie (and sometimes with Ken), he is confronted with the ambiguity and fragility of gender identity found in the dolls, the commercial signifiers that are meant to secure it. Homes' characters keep assuming that objects can be used to consolidate the hierarchy between the unified, controlling self and what is external to it; yet objects, like Barbie, become disturbing tokens of the impossibility of achieving a coherent and well-contoured identity. Another story, "The Bullet Catcher," centers on a radio contest in which participants try to win a car by keeping their hands on it longer than anyone else. As the hours pass, touching the car—initially a gesture of ownership, meant to reassure the subject of capitalism a free and powerful self—becomes more and more absurd, as bodies start to collapse and become transformed through the effort of continuous contact. If the subject is formed by distancing itself from objects, passive beings under its control, touching always has the potential to upset this; the participants are not only touching the car, but they are touched—and altered—by it.

The characters' attempts to secure a solid identity recall the operations of Lacan's mirror stage, where an imaginary sense of plenitude and contoured integrity is achieved when the infant sees its own image in the mirror. While necessary in conferring individual identity to the

self and the body, this event marks a certain loss: as Judith Butler notes when exploring the queer potential of Lacanian psychoanalysis, "any sense of bodily contour, as projected, is articulated through a necessary self-division and self-estrangement" (71). The child's experiences of disorganized motility and diffuse sensations, and of the body as uncontrollable and contour-less, are disavowed in this fundamental misrecognition: in recognizing the self in the external image, the child also perceives the disconnect between the image's integrity and its actual sense of bodily chaos and disunity. Crucially for Butler's project of providing alternative body morphologies, the selves instituted through boundaries "are never simply *made* or *achieved*; they are insistently constituted, contested and negotiated" (76, emphasis in original). This instability is exactly what creates the anxiety that leads us to police these boundaries, as well as the opportunity to reconfigure normative relationships between sex, gender and desire through different ways of materializing bodies. Most of Homes' characters grapple with these anxieties, experiencing the precarious nature of their neatly formed identities, fashioned to fit in the rigid social roles of the suburban family.

Several stories describe attempts to conform to culturally sanctioned bodily configurations. In "Slumber Party," two young friends enact the discovery of sexual difference made famous by Freud and much contested by his feminist critics: while Sally between her legs "has nothing … [an] empty space" (136), Ben's "part" is unambiguously and powerfully present, as Sally observes: "His hard-on stood apart from him, independent, as though it had a life and mind of its own" (140). As Butler points out, the misrecognition of the self in the mirror image also occurs with the phallus: a symbolization and idealization of the penis, this signifier participates in "the imaginary elaboration of the ego's bodily boundary, token and 'proof' of its integrity and control" (Butler 77). The bounded organ, standing in for the bounded body, then "provide[s] the structure of relations to the Other and to the world of objects" (Butler 79): the relations established with the aid of the phallus are ones of self-preservation, based on a hierarchical control. The body part, in its idealized and symbolized version, does not pose a threat to the bodily integrity found in the mirror image because, instead of breaking up the whole, it comes to *stand in* for this integrity through a "synecdochal function" that ensures that "a decentered body is transfigured into a totality with a center" (Butler 79). The individual resolves the sense of

fragmentation that the part announces by seeing how the part resembles the whole, symbolizes it, in its autonomy secured by neat contours.

However, what seems like a token of secure and undisturbed masculinity (the phallus) always risks becoming the part that reminds the body of its irresolvable fragmentation. The story "The I of It" centers on the collapse of the plenitude of masculinity, as the protagonist, having been apparently diagnosed HIV positive, addresses his penis' "betrayal." The penis has served to secure his identity as different from his mother and sisters (147) and has later become a joyous symbol of his sexual desire and desirability. The diagnosis means the penis is no longer a controllable part, and the protagonist reflects: "I cannot possess myself as I did before. I can never again possess it, as it possesses me" (148). The subordinated role of the part is subverted and a section of the body bursts from its boundaries to contaminate the whole self. The increasingly ambiguous location of the self in "The I of It" is signaled by the use of pronouns: "*I* look down on *it* and begin to weep. *I* am sickened by *myself*, and yet cannot stand the sensation of being so revolted. *It* is *me*, *I* tell *myself*" (147, emphasis added). The reverse of the idealization of the phallus is the nightmare of dismemberment, not recognizing the body part as one's own and facing the possibility that some portion of the self has been lost or that something external has invaded it.

Someone who conceives of the body as something other than a perfectly bounded whole, as something that allows exchange and extends the self in reaching toward others, may be able to view ambiguity and fluidity as empowering rather than threatening. A more playful approach to the part–whole relationship is adopted by the narrator of "Yours Truly"—another story that traces the displacement of the self across pronouns, as the protagonist writes mental letters to herself. This character declares, "I'm trying to find some piece of myself that is truly me, a part that I would be willing to wear like a jewel around my neck" (114), and ends up finding this reassurance in her foot. This apparently arbitrary choice, which pointedly avoids selecting a marker of sexual difference as the representative of identity, leads the protagonist to learn self-love. The foot is not used as proof of the unambiguous presence of the self, as the penis is in "The I of It"; here, the body part is invested with a more fluid desire.

The story "Yours Truly" offers an alternative to the perfect (but illusory) integrity of the mirror image. Other alternatives have been suggested by queer theorists in an effort to conceive of bodies in more

inclusive ways. Gayle Salamon,[1] for instance, uses Merleau-Ponty's description of the body invested by desire to challenge the exclusionary logic of the perfectly contoured body, the autonomous self and the phallic control over external objects. In this view, sexuality is a "'general function' which causes a body part to be animated" (Salamon 51), and this function can invest not only a "proper" body part but also "a region of the body that is not individuated into a part, or a bodily auxiliary that is not organically attached to the body" (51). The invested part, which may therefore be unbounded or outside bodily boundaries, does not serve the unification fantasy of the phallus; instead, it causes the contour of the body to appear more permeable and malleable. Salamon notes that when desiring another "I am suddenly spread out as a sensing subject, located both in my body and that toward which my body bends" (54): the location of the self becomes more ambiguous and difficult to pin down, to cut off from the nonself. This experience of uncontrollable embodiment can be threatening, as in "The I of It," but also empowering.

Uncontrollable experiences of embodiment can be found throughout Homes' short story collection: drugged bodies, paralyzed bodies, diseased bodies. One story, "Chunky in Heat," explicitly stages the tensions between the expansiveness of bodies and the efforts to contain them. The story presents an overweight teenage girl masturbating in her garden and is centered entirely on touching and flesh. As "Chunky," the protagonist nicknamed for her size, takes off her clothes, she reflects on their function of "divid[ing] her body into *reasonable* sections, arms and legs that need to be kept apart from other arms and legs, safe from the possibility of skin touching skin and rubbing itself raw" (59, emphasis added). The boundaries of clothing, "like the protective coating on a cold capsule" (59) allow her body to conform to the "reasonable" requirements of normativity, containing the anxiety of flesh touching flesh and restoring the possibility of distinguishing one part from the other, thereby properly contouring the whole of the body. Chunky questions this anxiety by noticing that her overflowing body "feels good, every square inch has incredible sensations, as if skin when stretched becomes hypersensitive" (61). As with Salamon's subject "spread out" in desire, the boundaries of Chunky's flesh expand and stretch out to

reach the world in erotic contact. Throughout the collection, Homes' stories push toward alternative bodily configurations, which can in turn be linked to new configurations of texts.

Bodies/Touch/Texts

Theories of queer touching argue that the anxiety of losing oneself through openness and exchange can be transformed into a new sense of wholeness through that bodily exchange. Margrit Shildrick, for example, writes of the pervasive anxiety, often expressed around sexuality, that "the body of the other … will enter into the space of my own body and effect the very transformations that would disturb my claim to autonomous selfhood" (328). She theorizes touch as an "undecidable moment of exchange" (330) that causes the subject "to compromise control, to feel [the] sense of wholeness and self-sufficiency dissolve" (330) as the body extends its touch to objects but is also touched back, becomes the object of touching. Like Butler, Shildrick emphasizes that "the unity of the embodied self is never finally secured but remains precarious" (341), and this insecurity allows for the potential of alternative bodily configurations. Rose Troche, in adapting Homes' stories, shows the characters struggling with isolation and anxiety but ultimately suggests strategies for breaching the alienation of the isolated subject and making them reach toward each other.

As the characters breach the boundaries of their isolated identities and reach toward each other, so too do the texts. I see *The Safety of Objects* as a whole text; the walls between the individual stories, and between the book and its adaptation, are breached. In making this argument, I take up John Bryant's conception of adaptation as a "fluid text" that is "the sum of its versions" (47). Bryant describes his fluid text approach in ways that are strikingly in line with queer theory's focus on transgressing identity boundaries, by reminding us that "textual walls are permeable and often breached through adaptation" (62) and by proposing to "breach that wall" (49) enclosing the identity of the work. This language resonates with queer theory, conveying a similar sense of crossing imaginary bodily boundaries. Along with the idea of queer touching, queer writer Iain Morland proposes the idea of queer reaching in order to include diverse embodied experiences. He argues that reaching, like touching, is a "dynamic 'moving toward'" (304) that involves the material body as well as those "parts" that have a more ambivalent status, no-longer or

not-yet-material; an emphasis on reaching, in his view, includes postsurgical intersex bodies in the nonhierarchical pleasure of touching. Salamon also discusses reaching as an experience that causes the subject to call into question corporeal boundaries and the location of the self, as the body has a way of "disappearing" when it tends toward something and "[t]he object of desire supplants the self as center" (53). The experience of reaching is one not only of dispersion but also of consolidation, as the self becomes "purposefulness" (53); this alternative way of conceiving the embodied subject maintains its identity but configures it as shifting, oriented toward objects and others, continually reinvested with meaning.

In the film, Troche pulls the characters together into families and places them into the same neighborhood; more importantly, she makes each of them embody a few different characters from the stories. The subjects of the film are thus condensed and overdetermined, and Homes' disconnected protagonists now find themselves sharing bodies: self and other are thus superimposed and confounded, and bodies exist in an ambiguous materiality, reaching back toward their multiple literary versions. Within the film, characters are pulled closer together spatially and reach toward each other by repeatedly looking through each other's windows, fences, and glass doors. The final scene explicitly represents touching, as a character from one family extends her hand to touch that of another, from a different family and a different story. While the film begins by neatly arranging the characters into distinct and "whole" families and by showing the normalized routine of breakfast, the ending features some of these families, incomplete and changed by crises and losses, gathered around a table for a meal. The touch that closes the film represents a move from the fictitious integrity of the suburban family and its highly hierarchical organization to a more open-ended model of community forged through moments of contact.

Formal techniques such as montage and sound also help to create an atmosphere of touching.[2] Early in the film, a montage connects several characters at the same moment in time, by representing their thoughts through increasingly overlapping voice-overs and showing them in rapid sequence. The screen version of "Chunky," here called Julie, acts in this montage as a point of connection and exchange for other characters. In one scene, the camera zooms into the forehead of one character, lingers on the texture of the skin until the image begins to swirl, and then zooms out again to reveal Julie's face instead, as if the two momentarily shared the same flesh. An intermediate shot, shown in Fig. 7.1,



Fig. 7.1 The camera zooms into one character's forehead, lingers on the skin, and then zooms out to reveal someone else

blends the characters' skin tones, creating a moment when spectators are unable to distinguish between the two characters: this visual mixing of flesh conveys not only an ordinary gesture of touching but one that acts to dissolve the boundaries of individual identity. Shortly afterwards, the camera zooms in on Julie's mouth as she breathes in, then zooms out on a different character's exhale. This camera movement guides the spectators' vision inside different heads and bodies, almost as if they all shared a space there, an overlapping interiority. During the same montage, diegetic music plays in one scene and then bleeds into other scenes, where characters stop to listen to it even though they cannot logically hear it because they do not occupy the same space as the source of the music. Overlapping voice-overs and quick montages continually reduce the distance between characters' bodies and minds.

The most remarkable and decidedly queer effect of *The Safety of Objects*—conceived of as a fluid text—are the intertextual bodies created through the touching of the two works. To a viewer who has read Homes' book, film characters will inevitably appear haunted by their multiple literary versions, with different names, written at different times and scattered across the collection of stories. The character of Chunky is adapted on the screen as Julie, who also appears in "The Bullet Catcher," where her mother participates in the car-touching contest. Julie is played by Jessica Campbell, a slim actress, but the erasure of Chunky's expansive and uncontrollable body is not achieved without comment: it is hinted at by zooming in on Julie's flat stomach and by representing some of her obsessive thoughts about food and dieting. The effect is that of creating a sort of narrative across the two texts (and within the fluid text). Spectators can ask whether Julie used to be Chunky and has since been on a diet, and the adaptation hints at a possible effort made by Julie to restrict and control the expanding and chaotic body described in such detail in Homes' story.

A more striking example is the creation of an intertextually transgender identity. In the film, Sam (played by Kristen Stewart) embodies at least two characters that in the book are boys. In Homes' "Looking for Johnny," a boy called Erol is kidnapped by a stranger, Randy, who keeps referring to him as "Johnny" and ends up releasing him after a few days when Erol fails to live up to Randy's expectations of a healthy and cheerful young boy. The film version of this narrative makes clear that "Johnny" is Randy's brother, who recently died in a car accident, thus explaining Randy's motive for the abduction as a misplaced wish to

spend more time with Johnny. On the screen, Erol becomes Sam and the misidentification as "Johnny" becomes more striking since Sam is a girl. Her full name, "Samantha," is uttered at a strategic point in the film: Randy reads it on her basketball when he lets her go, finally realizing that he cannot carry on with the fantasy that Sam is his lost brother. Otherwise, Sam goes by the gender-neutral abbreviation and has a markedly masculine appearance. To emphasize this, she is forced to put on a dress to go to lunch with her absent father, so that he can remark: "I can't believe what a little lady you've become," but in no other scene wears feminine clothing.

In addition to embodying Erol, Sam plays a role in the adaptation of "Slumber Party," the story in which a boy (Ben) and a girl (Sally) contemplate their sexual difference. In the film, Sam is inserted into Sally's story from the beginning and she is the friend who is going to stay for a sleepover. As Sally's mother announces that a neighbor named Jake will also be staying with them that night, Sally protests: "But Sam is already staying over!" marking the disruptive entrance of a male character whose place seemed already taken by a female friend. Jake only reappears later in the film, to enact the sexual difference scene, where he offers to show Sally his erection while she admits that she has nothing to show him. The rest of Sally and Ben's narrative is enacted by Sally and Sam. Moreover, other characters in the film continue to gender Sam as a boy. For instance, at Sally's family dinner, while the other women are fetching the salt and tidying up, Sam remains seated. In the short story, it is made clear that sitting down is a privilege reserved for men, in a moment that consolidates Sally's understanding of the division of domestic labor along gender lines. "Sitting down" is thus gendered in the written text and, when reading the two works together as one fluid text, this action is gendered in the film as well. Sam's body, between the written story and the film, crosses gender boundaries, as it exists, in Salamon's formulation, "between the material and the ideal," between the real and the phantasmatic (62); between the visible body in the film and the actress's "known" sex; between the male bodies remembered from the book and the gendering of this body by others. Troche's gender-bending choices thus represent a further queer manipulation of the already queer process of adaptation.

Between Part and Whole

I have shown how the case of *The Safety of Objects* throws light on some of the queer possibilities of the process of adaptation. My discussion of Homes has also focused on how the text thematizes some queer tensions between parts and whole when it comes to the bodies of her protagonists. Tensions between parts and whole are also achieved at a formal level with Troche's choice to adapt a short story collection instead of a single short story. Adaptation of short stories to film can be particularly challenging. Rachel Lister notes that this is because the short story form is characterized by "openness, indirection and restraint" (44), as well as a certain "mystery," an enigmatic opacity. Therefore, films based on a single short story find themselves having to expand on the material available, thereby, Lister argues, risking a reductionist interpretation of the story's ambiguities. *The Safety of Objects*, however, adapts not a single short story but a collection, a form which exists ambiguously between parts and whole.

In Troche's film, the additional material used to flesh out the characters comes, in a sense, from the "original text" itself, or at least from something that is contiguous to it (a neighboring short story); the effect is to emphasize the short story collection as something in between a whole and its parts, since the source text for different sections of the film narrative both is and is not the same. By conflating more than one character into a single character and by having a single character play roles in various disconnected narratives, the film creates new motivations and new meanings. For instance, in the film, the boy who is having a relationship with his sister's Barbie doll is Jake, the friend of Sally's who seems so interested in showing her his erection. This creates a new narrative about the boy's sexuality and can prompt the audience to find causal connections between his love story with Barbie and his sexual confrontation with a "real girl," thereby lending new meaning to both scenes. Reaching back to influence the literary text, the film creates "impossible" causal or temporal connections between different characters across the boundaries of different stories, so that one character's action becomes the consequence of the action of another who inhabits a different storyworld.

Similarly to the intertextual bodies described earlier, these causal and temporal connections lead me to conceive of the adaptation process as a queer gesture of traversing textual boundaries and calling autonomous

identity into question. By focusing on a text that overtly shows and even manipulates the queer potential of adaptation, I have elucidated a connection between the queering of bodies by queer theory and the queering of texts by adaptation studies. Queer writers such as Butler, Salamon, Shildrick and Morland show a preoccupation with boundaries, a search for more malleable and open-ended identities and for nonhierarchical relationships between self and other, part and whole, origin and derivation. Their goal is the search for alternative bodily morphologies that can attend to more diverse experiences of gender and sexuality. If adaptation studies is looking to challenge notions such as the primacy of the "original text" over its adaptation, or readings that take different texts as having separate identities that need to be studied in isolation, queer theory can offer methodological tools to formulate these challenges. As I have shown, an especially rich site of intersection between queer concerns about bodies and adaptation's concerns about texts can be characters' bodies as they exist between works: as they are present, absent or changed in the passage from one work to another.

Never definitely resolved into a whole, Homes' self-sufficient short stories haunt the film and threaten to pull it apart. In a similar way, the missing protagonists of "Yours Truly" and "The I of It," with their preoccupation with body parts and locations of the self, inhabit the text (in the sense of a fluid whole comprising book and film) as phantasmatic presences, both material and imagined/remembered. Due to the always open-ended status of an adapted work, the film's conclusion, rather than representing a final unity, simply pulls in a different direction, toward a malleable and heterogeneous whole. The different texts remain in a dynamic tension with each other, allowing critics and audiences to actively forge or underline the connections between them and to help characters' bodies reach toward each other and engage in queer exchange.

Notes

1. I use Salamon's text as queer theory even though it also engages with trans theory, a field that has developed partly in opposition to queer theory. I am motivated to do so by Salamon's explicit alignment with queer theory in the arguments that I focus on here, especially when it comes to psychoanalytic and phenomenological notions of identity. I am, however, aware

of her more complex position between different fields of scholarship, a full discussion of which is beyond the scope of this paper.

2. This way of reading corporeality as an atmosphere is in line with Daniel Punday's proposal (76–77) of analyzing bodies in narrative not only as individual, isolated entities, but also as more general vehicles that allow textual elements and readers to "touch."

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CHAPTER 8

Fuck-Scripting: Becoming-Queer in *Interior. Leather Bar*

Queer J. Thomas

Interior. Leather Bar. (2013) provides an alternative mode of queer adaptation in filmmaking, an experimental docu-fiction that uses what I refer to as "fuck-scripting" to blur boundaries between documentary and fiction as well as between performance and identity. The film relies on the queer sensibilities of filmmakers and cast to reify "becoming-queer," a term connoting queerness not as a particular fixed sexuality but as a transformational state wherein citizens adapt to something strange and unfamiliar, adaptations that invoke receptions where watching and reading construct queerness.

Interior's opening sequence establishes the film's nexus and premise: The 1980 film *Cruising* stars Al Pacino as an undercover cop investigating a series of murders in New York City's leather bar scene. The gay community protested the film, claiming it was homophobic. Director William Friedkin received death threats, and he battled the Motion Picture Association of America (MPAA), which forced him to cut forty minutes

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to avoid an X rating. This footage has never been screened publicly. James Franco and Travis Mathews collaborated to imagine their own lost footage.

Critics suggest *Interior* is a bait-and-switch project because it strays from its advertised premise—recreating forty minutes of *Cruising*'s cut footage. The reimagined footage comprises less than fifteen minutes of the film; the rest is comprised of interviews and dialogue among actors and cast as they film scenes seemingly aimed at advancing a pro-queer sociopolitical agenda. But *Interior* gives viewers more than an imagined sequence from a 1980s film. It is a savvy film that uses experimental methods informed by queer theory to destabilize extant thinking about the roles of sex in film and society.

This chapter addresses the role of scripts in *Interior* in connection with shifting norms of (adaptations to) queer visibility. I argue that explicit queer sex is not only a useful storytelling tool, as the filmmakers note, but also a tool for increasing queerness horizontally (memetically) within and across cultures. Because *Interior* is an adapted work whose source material is unknowable (cut scenes that were never screened publicly), this analysis moves beyond fidelity arguments in adaptation studies. Valuations of the film are not hog-tied to inquiries and commentaries aimed at assessing the extent to which *Interior* hews to or strays from an essential element of an original. Instead, the analysis illuminates adaptation theories that emphasize viewer reception through engagement with the sexually unfamiliar. Rather than censoring sex, especially queer sex as Friedkin was forced to do, *Interior*'s filmmakers amp up the sex and expose cultural fictions surrounding sexual construction, allowing viewers (as well as *Interior*'s cast) to deepen their queer sensibilities. This essay argues that there is value in queer adaptation—engaging with unfamiliar subjects, methods, and queernesses—not only to disrupt extant thinking about the role of sexual construction in society, but also as a way to bring into the light queer adaptations already present in contemporary cultures and to foreshadow those yet to come. These engagements underscore sociocultural adaptations that complicate binaristic thinking—queer/nonqueer, authenticity/performance, documentary/fiction, and porn/art—complications that facilitate becoming-queer. Complicating (or eviscerating) distinctions between queer and adaptation opens theoretical space not only so queer theory can, as Pamela Demory notes, "help us understand the nature of adaptation itself" (155), but also so adaptation theory can help us understand queerness and queer theorizing. Fuck-scripting is a tool for both.

Queer Adaptation and Fuck-Scripting

Interior is unlike traditional adaptations in that there is no primary text upon which the film is based. It is a film about making a film imagining footage cut from another film. The filmmakers acknowledge the impractability of replicating the cut footage, which neither the filmmakers nor film viewers have seen, so the extent to which the adaptation is faithful to Friedkin's vision becomes less of a criterion to gauge the film's value. This method of adaptation (largely unscripted) functions like radical queer performances unconcerned with replicating, for example, heteronormativity. Moving beyond fidelity frameworks and into theoretical spaces aligned with possibility and transformation underscores Timothy Corrigan's claim that contemporary adaptations, which are replete throughout culture in technology, politics, and economics, do not lend themselves easily to definitional clarity (34), much like evolving queer theories and queer sensibilities that refuse fixity and stability. Here, I adapt to queer theory Corrigan's assertion: "Because its activities and perspectives continue to evolve rapidly, there cannot be any single or stable definition of adaptation [or queer theory]" (34).

Arguably *Cruising*—even with its cut, unknown scenes—is the primary text; but rather than adapting *Cruising*'s text, the film adapts one of the film's concepts that continues to be relevant in contemporary sexual politics—the discomfort people experience being in unfamiliar sex spaces. The filmmakers' methods help convey this concept. Docu-fiction and fuck-scripting provide a dimension of authenticity, allowing the film's protagonist to portray believably his discomfort navigating unfamiliar sex spaces. These methods create space for the filmmakers' fiction to emerge organically and spontaneously among the cast. The result is that viewers have a deeper connection with discomfort and greater opportunities to formulate their own queer sensibilities. One way that the film creates discomfort is in its emphasis on the filming of sex scenes themselves. In the scene depicted in Fig. 8.1, for example, the sex scene that Franco (in the foreground) and the other camera operator are filming would probably make straight viewers uncomfortable; if it were cropped to frame just the two men on the couch, it might be a shot from a porn movie. As it is, the wide shot, showing both the men having sex and the filmmakers shooting the men having sex provides a double layer of defamiliarization. On the one hand, the cameras, the filmmakers, the ladder, the space of the set itself signal to the viewer that this is a movie shoot—it's not "real" and so it's more comfortable. On the other hand, the



Fig. 8.1 James Franco films a queer sex scene

filmmakers are casually and rather intrusively present in what might ordinarily be a private moment, calling attention to the fact that the viewer, too, is watching this act. Engaging the unfamiliar, especially that which is socially constructed to lack a sense of rightness (or fidelity to an established script or text), is *Interior*'s primary concept.

Fuck-scripting—a queer method that disrupts dominant heteronormative scripts—derives from *Interior*'s dialogue. Principal actor Val Lauren, a self-identified straight man, participates in the gay leather film project, where in Lauren's words, "Dicks are out. Balls are out. People are paddling each other in the ass. There's bruises. There's fucking welts. Sucking, fucking, armpits, balls, assholes. Everything's out." But there's no detailed script. Responding to Lauren's articulated discomfort, Franco says, "Fuck scripts." Fuck-scripting sets aside dominant narratives and methods that prescribe how citizens should, inter alia, make films or engage in sexual conduct. Fuck-scripting also interrogates anew socially constructed fears that repel and marginalize certain sexual conduct.

In its explicit depictions of gay leather erotica, *Interior* engages the types of embodied, messy sex scholars suggest are missing from queer theory (O'Rourke). In one scene, a man performs fellatio on another, while a third man watches and rubs his own erect penis. In another scene, Franco and Lauren, with other cast and crew, perform as voyeurs

watching and filming two men engage in fellatio, mutual masturbation, penis-frottage, spitting, and mild face-smacking. What dominant US culture considers messy about sex and sexuality—that is, what the MPAA, heteronormativists, conservative gays and lesbians, and even queer theorists insist we "mop up" in order to be "squeaky clean" (O'Rourke 5)—is in Franco's words, "a valuable storytelling tool" and "something beautiful." Franco and Mathews confront the messiness of queer sex and find value substantively and symbolically in detritus—Friedkin's forty minutes of cut footage. In an exchange with Franco, Lauren says the explicit gay leather sex is "too much," and that they should make it more "palatable" by leaving something to the imagination. Franco replies:

> It's not a porn for titillation. It's something else. We're telling a story … about a guy, who is uncomfortable, goes undercover into this world. And in the original movie, it was as if he was going down into a deep dark place. He was going into an evil place. That's the way they depicted it whether Friedkin intended to or not, by giving it a backdrop of murder. He was going into a dark deep evil place and he had to go "undercover" and be gay, undercover. We're doing that. You're playing a guy who is going undercover. But to me, he's not going to a dark evil place. He's going to, actually, a place that's, I think, beautiful and attractive.

Franco's efforts to destigmatize queer sex are largely successful. Many scenes are shot in the full light of day, which removes the stigma of cruising under cover of night. But Mathews and Franco retain a portion of gay leather's grunge. Most footage is shot in a warehouse, parking lot, and adjacent alley. It is questionable whether Lauren enters a place that is literally beautiful and attractive, but the film works well to destigmatize gay leather's ostensible evils. In a scene near the end of the film, actors debrief an intimate BDSM scene, where we learn that two BDSM actors are lovers off camera. This revelation appears pivotal for Lauren. Watching a scene of unfamiliar, messy queer sex, sometimes violently performed, transforms his discomfort into a connection with queer others. Lauren says,

> I think I've learned something. I don't know what it is, but I'm definitely not the same guy I was when I came in here this morning…. You two are really sweet together… You just kind of were there in such a gentle cool, kind of a supportive way. I could tell you're a couple. It was actually really, really…. Maybe it's the idea of things are so much fucking bigger than they actually are when you see them and do them.

In this regard, the film disrupts gay leather's stigmas and related discomforts connected with the unfamiliar. Seeing and doing queer sex allays fears and related powers of the unknown: what once seemed malignant becomes benign, what once was shocking and strange becomes sensual and familiar.

Interior confronts queer difference without perpetuating stigmas and stereotypes. Iris Marion Young reminds us that "focusing on difference risks recreating the stigma of that difference," and she also reminds us that "an assimilationist ideal amounts to genocide" (169–182). In 1980, there were no contemporaneous films that normalized gayness to serve as a counterpoint to *Cruising*. Leather stigmas and stereotypes, then, make reasonable the backlash *Cruising* received from gay individuals concerned that gay leather was much different from their own sex lives. In movements for equality, groups often marginalize members who are more different and label them as deviants in order for the mainstream to accept the members who are less different. The most assimilated sacrifice the least assimilated, the former emphasizing its sameness by highlighting the latter's difference. This type of political posturing creates the dilemma of difference: difference cannot be accepted unless it is first known, but difference also avoids discrimination if it is concealed. Today, normalized gayness is common in film, culture, and politics, making it less risky for films like *Interior* to focus on difference. Shifting cultural, political, and legal norms made it possible for Franco and Mathews to develop a modern, less controversial adaptation of *Cruising*'s lost footage.

While the film's use of explicit queer sex as a storytelling tool helps desensitize viewers and perhaps disrupt stigmas surrounding gay leather, the fact that these actors are in a committed relationship suggests that heteronormativity continues to constrain queer adaptation. Much of the power of the BDSM scene derives from the implication that two men who did not know one another prior to the project engage in a casual, sexual relationship that one might expect in a cruisy leather bar. It is as if Franco and Mathews tempered queerness with heteronormativity to make it possible for mainstream viewers (and Lauren) to transform their attitudes toward BDSM as intimate rather than perverse only because the performers are a couple in a long-term committed relationship. In this way, the scene (Fig. 8.1) that contributes to watchers' unease about men engaging in unprotected sex with near strangers we later understand to be a manipulated unease when we learn about the actors' relationship.

Through a queer lens, the filmmakers might be seen to pander to nonqueer audiences by offering them a heteronormative touchstone. Since cruising is about locating the strange, not the familiar, hiring actors who did not know one another prior to the project would have added a layer of queer authenticity. Still, watching a couple in a committed relationship perform explicit queer sex acts is not the norm for mainstream films. Franco and Mathews use sex to shift norms toward a queerer society, if only incrementally.

Apart from the film's engagement with the embodied, messy sex that is missing from queer theory, *Interior* engages queer theories that are scarce in film and cultural studies (Halley and Parker 3). Namely, *Interior* confronts that which gets lost when gay and lesbian citizens assimilate to heteronormativity. Like Friedkin's cut footage, what is lost cannot be fully known, but the filmmakers' queer sensibilities help us imagine. In the early minutes of the film, Franco and Mathews discuss influences from Michael Warner, who argues in *The Trouble with Normal* (1999) that if same-sex couples are allowed to marry, gay and lesbian lifestyles will become normalized. Married gay and lesbian citizens then will be expected to assimilate to heteronormativity's other ideals—sexual privacy, monogamy, coupling, parenting, and boring sex—which effectively means gay and lesbian citizens will masquerade as heteronormative agents. Franco and Mathews are troubled with what gets lost in queer assimilation, what is lost when heteronormativity continues to erase queerness from public view.

Franco and Mathews adapt an imagined 1980s queerness intertwined with, if not overshadowed by, contemporary queer sensibilities, emphasizing the ubiquity of sociotechnological adaptations, which are, at once, seemingly unrelated to sexuality's erasure and inextricably linked to it. Telephone technology is an example. Mathews explains to actors the importance of making eye contact with one another because a critical part of cruising is looking and watching—gazing. Unlike contemporary bar patrons whose eyes are commonly fixed on phone devices, the 1980s queers relied on and responded to eye-contact subtleties. Contemporary queers can cruise conveniently using hand-held electronic devices. This indicates progress in queers' abilities to connect with like-minded queers, but these devices reduce the need for queers to gather in leather bars and other quasi-public spaces. If the goal is promoting the value of engaging with the unfamiliar, telephone technologies work against this goal by facilitating greater sexual privacy that requires queers to be seen less in

public. Mathews' directing actors to focus on the looking and watching points to one aspect of queering that has been lost through the normalization of sexual technologies.

The technologies surrounding *Interior*'s screenings and distribution suggest similar tensions in queer citizenship concerning what gets lost to assimilation, namely public sexuality. *Interior* enjoyed a successful festival life, screening at nearly a hundred festivals in 2013. It did not, however, have enormous box office success. According to the Internet Movie Database (IMDb), the film grossed only $41,000 in the United States. Despite its limited availability in theaters, *Interior* has been widely accessible on DVD and Netflix. Of note is that the digital version downloaded from both Amazon and iTunes censors all depictions of penises, including explicit oral sex and masturbation. These distribution technologies increase access to *Interior*, but they also reduce the opportunity to experience queerness with others in public theaters. The result is that film technologies developed since *Cruising* transform the way citizens watch controversial queer films. Viewings are more siloed, immured by the public desexualization imperative and norms of sexual privacy. Most people, like me, watched *Interior* at home, not in public theaters.

Notwithstanding technological double-binds of sexual accessibility and invisibility, *Interior* depicts explicit gay leather sex in a film not dubbed as pornography. Its use of sex as a storytelling tool hits the mark, whereas the final, censored version of *Cruising* misses it. Watching forty minutes of men having sex in a leather bar (if indeed the cut footage contained such scenes) would have forced viewers into spaces of increased unease, stimulated public eroticism, or ignited a range of other unknown perspectives that receptive viewers would have brought with them to the theater. In a public setting, forty minutes can be a long time to be in strange sexual spaces, to be impatient, to be sexually aroused, or to let your mind drift. These forty minutes would have allowed viewers to connect more deeply with the Pacino character's discomfort. Maybe Lauren's character is right that some things should be left to the imagination, but if one has never cruised forty minutes in a leather bar, bathhouse, or after-hours back room watching cis men give other cis men blow jobs, imagination as a storytelling tool has limits. What is lost in Friedkin's film, in its forced assimilation to mainstream and professional norms, is viewer reception mired in discomfort or arousal as well as viewers' opportunities to embrace such states or extricate themselves from them.

Role of the Script

In this film about making a film reimagining cut footage from another film, the script itself is an adaptation functioning as a queer sensibility. It contains general parameters and guidelines for a queer project but lacks the specificity of typical scripts that prescribe in detail directions for actors and crew. Scripts that allow casts to improvise and ad lib are not uncommon. What is unusual are slippages in and out of scripted and unscripted scenes and dialogue, slippages between documentary and fiction that confuse certainty and contribute to viewer unease. Before the denouement, viewers cannot tell whether the documentary-type scenes are scripted. In one scene, Lauren looks over his script while other crew and cast mill about. Not until Mathews says "cut" is it apparent the scene was purposefully constructed to show Lauren looking at a script. The denouement shows Lauren sitting against a wall in the parking lot with the script in his lap reading to himself. The words he reads from the script are "Val sits against a wall in the parking lot. The script is in his lap. He reads to himself. Val sits against a wall in the parking lot. The script is in his lap. He reads to himself." These conditions confuse the script's starting and stopping points and dissolve categorical distinctions, troubling what is real and fake in actors' performances, including their sexualities.

The role of the script in the film parallels the role of scripts in sexual citizens' lived realities; wittingly or otherwise, we follow certain scripts and reject others. Unlike those who conform to heteronormative life patterns, queers have fewer cultural scripts to follow, especially when social conditions often demand that queers not be found out. In these circumstances, making a sexual connection depends not on verbal language but on body language, much like cruising, when participants send and receive signals of interest and disinterest, acceptance and rejection.

Narratives that describe the challenges queer individuals face in navigating oppressive heteronormative cultures are familiar, but narratives describing how sexual majorities engage with queerness are less familiar. It is not only the queer minority who must navigate sexual difference and who can tap queer and heteronormative affinities. As queerness increases, nonqueers increasingly must navigate queer cultures without scripts. This narrative, perhaps more than the narrative of queers navigating heteronormative society, is the strength of *Interior*'s method

and message. After Franco and Lauren watch a sadomasochistic scene, Lauren admits his discomfort. He says he would be more okay with the scene if it involved a man and a woman simply because he would be "a little more used to it." Franco responds to what he finds most bothersome:

> I don't like the fact that I feel like I've been brought up to think a certain way…. I don't like realizing that my mind has been twisted by the way that the world has been set up around me, and what that is, is straight normative kind of behavior. And it's fucking instilled into my brain … Yeah, I'd say it was a little shocking to me at first when I was watching that, but only, I believe, only because of the world around me, because every fucking toilet paper commercial has a guy, a man and a woman, living in a house together, and every fucking love story is a dude that wants to be with a girl. And the only way they're going to end up happy is if they walk off into the sunset together. I'm fucking sick of that shit. So if there's a way for me to just break that up in my own mind, I'm all for it.

For Franco, the effect of seeing queer sex is consciousness-raising. He realizes that he has been manipulated to believe the only acceptable sexualities are "straight normative."

The deconstructive power of *Interior* offers a way forward for filmmakers who want to use sex as a storytelling tool and citizens who want to use sex to construct different stories for their own lives. A critical step for creating alternatives is recognizing that the sex lives of citizens need not follow certain scripts. Adaptation can and does occur. There is and can be greater fluidity and movement in and out of oppressive sexual cultures, between heteronormative and queer sexual conduct. I cannot suggest that all citizens in all circumstances have unfettered abilities to engage in sexual conduct of their choosing: cultural and legal scripts surrounding sexual citizenship have enormous constraining powers. Within constraints, however, citizens (like *Interior*'s actors) have considerable leeway to tap queer sensibilities once they let go of false frames of sexual essentialism and fixed sexual identities. Engaging the unfamiliar (the strange, the queer) in an epistemological sense means, minimally, having knowledge of queerness, the possible etiologies of which are numerous—hearing, reading, watching, smelling, touching, tasting, and imagining. Films like *Interior* not only help us understand how queer sensibilities develop but also, in fact, construct queer sensibilities.

Adaptation as Reception: Watching Is Becoming-Queer

The act of watching *Interior* makes viewers queerer. Like the scholar-writer who is culturally produced, that is, who becomes the language ze uses and constructs, *Interior* watchers are culturally produced queers who become queerer by watching queerness. Watching *Interior* constructs queerness in ways similar to reading queer texts. Valerie Rohy identifies reading scenes of queers reading queer texts as an etiology of queer increase. She suggests queerness is not transferred vertically as biological determinists argue—that is, from parent to child. Rather, queerness transfers horizontally, perhaps memetically, through cultures and environments. Experiencing queerness in a particular moment by watching it contributes to an individual's catalogue of queer sensibilities, whether or not these experiences manifest in transgressive sexual conduct. This form of adaptation—reception—emphasizes that the way readers (or watchers) enjoy or understand a work depends on their backgrounds (Corrigan 23). Here, I argue that although different works operate differently for different watchers, acts of watching contribute to one's catalogue or "digest" of queer sensibilities.[1] Cataloguing and digesting queer acts constitutes a form of becoming-queer.

The potential problem with identifying the etiology of becoming-queer is that it parallels conservative arguments about the spread of queerness and risks validating conservative policy prescriptions, namely censorship. Although queer theorists and conservatives might agree that exposure to queerness begets more queerness, they will not agree about how or whether to govern queer visibility. The queer view values sexual difference and seeks to unburden its social construction (eliminating barriers to queer sexual development), which is not the same as advocating for or disfavoring any particular sexual practice; all sexualities, including conventional ones (heterosexuality, marriage, monogamy, and sexual privacy), are valued in a sexually pluralistic society. The conservative view seeks to extinguish sexual difference through censorship and related containment technologies, meanwhile privileging the bundle of sexual practices that constitute heteronormativity. Whether we allow images of explicit sex (queer or otherwise) to become a benign cultural experience is a political decision, but my point here is that a film (like *Interior*) that celebrates queer sexual relationships exposes false understandings of the naturalness of heteronormativity and spurs possibilities for constructing new forms of sex and sexuality.

An Agent of Adaptation: Franco's Power as a Model Phallic Citizen

Queers adapt. Queers become. Part of becoming-queer is having the courage to tear down barriers and perform sexualities publicly. Becoming-queer means saying to dominant scripts, "Fuck you." Becoming-queer means living without scripts and writing new ones. These roles are familiar to Franco.

Since 1980, queer visibility in US culture has increased substantially, offering citizens a number of alternative queer scripts. Many of these scripts—poetry, literature, art, and film—rely upon shifting legal norms related to constitutionally protected speech, a legal shift familiar to Franco. Franco played Allen Ginsberg in *Howl* (2010), a film about an obscenity case overturning Ginsberg's conviction for publishing his controversial queer book of poetry. This case and other legal developments protect sexual expression in art, literature, and film, making it possible for Franco and Mathews to break new ground by insisting that *Interior* is not pornography. The film met no legal challenges. Taken as a whole, *Interior* is an adaptation that uses sex to tell a political and artistic story about the erasure of sex and sexuality. *Interior* helps explain political power in sexual citizenship: technologies and nuances of censorship, erasure, and invisibility; power and dangers of unquestioned, hegemonic heteronormativity; power of seeing cocks sucked both aggressively and sensually; and the prodigious power of heteronormativity propped up by laws and culture controlled by colossal institutions such as Hollywood.

Making *Interior* was possible, in part, because of shifting sociolegal sexual norms familiar to Franco, but the film's making also depended upon Franco himself. He represents the model phallic citizen—implicitly a straight, white, cisgender, masculine (but not too masculine) man. Shane Phelan suggests that the hypermasculine body (such as the slave or his sons) threatens the masculine body by representing "too much corporeality and not enough time in the armchair" (156). Franco has five graduate degrees and is enrolled in a PhD program at Yale. He can hardly be accused of not spending enough time in an armchair. Too, he performs hypermasculine roles, such as a hiker who cuts off his own arm with a dull pocket knife to escape death in *127 Hours* (2010); but he is also a comic, Gucci model, poet, and one of the hardest working actors in Hollywood, one who has known blockbuster and critical successes. All of these place him in good stead as a model phallic citizen whose

masculinity does not threaten other phallic citizens. He is well poised to champion explicit queer sex in film.

In an interview with himself, Gay James and Straight James respond to questions from one another. Gay James asks Straight James if his preoccupation with playing gay roles would subside if he simply had sex with a man. Straight James explains:

> I'm gay in my art. Or, I should say, *queer* in my art. And I'm not this way for political reasons, although sometimes it becomes political …. [W]hat it's really about is making queer art that destabilizes engrained ways of being, art that challenges hegemonic thinking. (68, emphasis in original)

Whether Franco intends his work to be political, his work invariably confronts sexual politics. Franco views himself as I view him: a change agent (or an agent of adaptation). In response to Gay James telling Straight James that many people believe he has indeed had sex with men, Straight James is pleased:

> I can be a figure for change. I am a figure who can show the straight community that many of their definitions are outdated and boring. And I can also show the gay community that many of the things about themselves that they are giving up to join the straight community are actually valuable and beautiful. (70)

One might be tempted to dismiss questions about Franco's sexuality as unimportant because he is simply someone who might perform his sexuality differently in public than he does in private. I suspect many of us perform sexualities differently when we know others are watching. But the question of sexual performance is central to *Interior* and to queer thinking: sexual essentialism and heteronormativity are fictions guarded by the public desexualization imperative. Franco has no veridical self apart from his performing self. When cameras are off, he still carries with him queer sensibilities developed from the queer acts he performed on camera. He might not fuck queerly off camera, but neither does he abandon his queer sensibilities when he exits public spaces, any more than avowed queers abandon queer sensibilities when they enter public spaces. We carry our experiences with us, and these experiences—always performed, whether as acts of reading, watching, observing, or sucking—inform our queer sensibilities and how we adapt to and shape

sexual culture. The question of Franco's sexuality is relevant because it has potential to disrupt the fictions propped up by the public desexualization imperative: if we never see Franco performing queer acts, he retains heteronormative privilege through silence, by default. *Interior*'s actors, especially the ones who claimed to be straight but performed queer acts on camera, help disrupt the performing-self/veridical-self binary. While I am cautious not to over-criticize Franco (he indeed puts sex and sexuality into the mainstream more than his contemporaries), I look forward to a film in which he does not rely upon the vulnerabilities of others, such as the low-paid actors in *Interior*, and in which his queer sensibilities might compel him to expose his own penis or penetrated body. Such an act from a high-profile, model phallic citizen would be a considerable exercise of power. I suspect Franco is overly concerned about his career; his poetry agonizes over the many men in Hollywood who performed queer acts on and off camera and who are now dead, such as River Phoenix and Brad Renfro (Franco, *Directing*). I doubt exposing his queer vulnerabilities on camera will end Franco's career; it may even have the opposite effect in contemporary cultures where queerness is cool and fresh. To wit, *Interior* was made.

One of Franco's purposes for *Interior* is to put gay sex into the mainstream because gay sex is a storytelling tool. Elsewhere, I have written about fagchild tools: technologies, strategies, behaviors, politics, affects, and materialities that help queers survive, navigate, and reshape oppressive sexual cultures and societies (Thomas). Here, I add explicit gay sex in film to the fagchild's toolbox. This storytelling tool prevents society from tiptoeing around what is already hegemonic but frequently ignored in US culture: sex, porn, queer sex, queer porn, naked bodies that are at once powerful and vulnerable, bodies that throb and fuck. There is truth in Franco's hyperbolic rant: "People like sex. Everybody fucking watches porn. They just don't want to talk about it. They don't want to talk about it in public. Everybody fucking watches porn. There's nothing wrong with it. People have sex."

Imagine for a moment the possibilities of another film titled *Exterior. Leather Bar.*, which might show people watching others engage in various forms of public sexual conduct. Putting queerness in the mainstream requires us collectively to engage discomforts and pleasures, perhaps value other queerness, and create political and sociocultural conditions in which queers no longer must artificially compartmentalize their lives into public ones and sexual ones. Surely queers have done enough

adapting to dominant culture, but until we have the film *Exterior*, I will settle for *Interior* because it nudges us closer toward dominant sexual cultures adapting to queerness. It empowers the sensibility of becoming-queer. While I want more from Franco's queer sensibilities, queer adaptations, and queer performances, at least one middle-aged queer academic, reluctant to expose his own naked body, appreciates the alternative queer script Franco collaborates to construct in *Interior*.

Note

1. See Corrigan, who in discussing André Bazin's "Adaptation, or the Cinema as Digest," suggests that "adaptations should be considered as extended and multiple variations on core myths, stories, or compact 'digests' that accumulate meanings through the history of their numerous social and material incarnations" (30–31).

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CHAPTER 9

Adapting Queer Shorts to Feature Films: Does Size Really Matter?

Whitney Monaghan and Stuart Richards

Traditionally viewed as an accessible stepping stone in a filmmaking career, the short film is a mode of practice within the reach of many queer filmmakers. The LGBTQ/queer film festival circuit offers many identity-based short sessions, an avenue for visibility not provided by mainstream distribution methods (Richards). This accessible film practice offers filmmakers space for "experimentation or as a means of breaking through the barriers of the industry" (Katz 1257). While shorts are a popular addition to many film festivals, the form poses a range of challenges. Films exceeding 15 minutes in duration are difficult to accommodate within a film festival package and there are limited opportunities for distribution outside of the festival circuit. In addition, queer shorts are often distributed within identity-based packages. While film festivals are increasingly programming mixed short sessions to break down the tribes of the LGBTQ audiences (see Galt and Schoonover; Benson; Richards),

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these sessions are still heavily programmed along narrowly defined identity categories. Beyond this, many queer filmmakers face difficulty moving beyond the short form. And finally, critics and audiences often take short films less seriously than feature-length productions.

Several filmmakers have managed to adapt their popular short films into acclaimed feature-length projects. However, this process of adaptation is not a simple task. Adaptation scholars Christa Albrecht-Crane and Dennis Cutchins emphasize this when they argue,

> Adapters … must interpret, re-working the precursor text and choosing the various meanings and sensations they find the most compelling (or most cost effective), then imagine scenes, characters, plot elements, etc., that match their interpretations. (16)

In this chapter, we examine four critically acclaimed films that have been adapted from earlier shorts: *Were the World Mine* (Tom Gustafson, 2008), *Dare* (Adam Salky, 2009), *Pariah* (Dee Rees, 2011), and *The Way He Looks* (Daniel Ribeiro, 2014). Following the lead of Albrecht-Crane and Cutchins, who suggest that studies of adaptation should focus not on the veracity of the interpretation but rather "on the space of disjunction between texts and media to ask what that space … enables" (20), we do not focus simply on the opportunities of feature-length adaptations. Instead, this chapter seeks to answer the following questions: What are the fundamental differences between the short film and its feature-length counterpart? What do these differences mean for the representation of LGBTQ/queer lives and identities? And, most importantly, what are the implications of elongating the condensed and economical narrative structures of the queer short film into the more conventional feature-length format? In answering these questions we draw out two temporalities through which gay, lesbian, and bisexual experiences and identities have been represented in recent years. We do not seek to suggest that one form is better than the other but rather to tease out the queer potential of each.

Adapting Shorts to Feature Films

While discourse on adaptation was once limited to the study of cinematic texts adapted from literature, recent scholarship has moved away from this to encompass a range of media (see Albrecht-Crane and Cutchins;

Hutcheon; Leitch; Stam). This move has also seen the field reject binary oppositions that it once upheld—book versus film, original versus copy, high culture versus mass culture, and so on. Contemporary adaptation theory sets out to challenge the view of adaptation as mere translation (an idea set out within early adaptation texts such as George Bluestone's *Novels into Film: The Metamorphosis of Fiction into Cinema*, published in 1957, and Geoffrey Wagner's *The Novel and the Cinema*, published in 1975). The question of fidelity and infidelity (to the original text) has been supplanted by a broader concern with the processes of adaptation (see Hutcheon 31). Hence, as Thomas Leitch explains, adaptation studies today emphasizes "*adapt* as a verb over *adaptations* as a series of texts" (6).

Queer short film to feature-length adaptations are a unique case for adaptation studies, providing insight into the process of adaptation across different formats of the same medium. These works also bear interesting relation to the binaries once upheld by the field of adaptation studies. While the short films are the original or "precursor" texts, they are generally taken less seriously than their feature-length adaptations. Overwhelmingly, popular discourse seems to assume a "natural" progression in the adaptation process from short to feature-length film. However, rather than identifying the "copy" as inferior, many accounts chart the development of a superior feature-length film from an intriguing but underdeveloped short. As Bell highlights in an article for *Sight & Sound*, "the film industry and the media see shorts mostly as personal ads for would-be feature filmmakers, an information flow to watch warily in case a director of stand-out talent … should show up." Similar sentiments are echoed by Bevin Yeatman, who likens the short to a "game" that filmmakers must pass in order to get to the "'real' business of feature film" production (154). As Cynthia Felando argues, within both popular and academic discourse the short film is "characterized as a transitional form—as a useful practice medium for students or aspiring filmmakers, a way to demonstrate a filmmaker's readiness to move into feature-length filmmaking, and as the very rare theatrical prefeature screening" (6). Such accounts suggest that filmmakers hone their craft in short form productions and may only be able to fully realize their ideas in feature-length works.

The advantages of short form storytelling are largely linked to the brevity of the form. A short may be any film with a running time under the standard 90-minute feature film duration (Ross 1); or "under

60 minutes in final running time" (French 107); or below 30 minutes (Elsey and Kelly; Katz; Konigsberg). While some have suggested that the limited duration of the form and its strict economy of storytelling are restrictive—Jean-Luc Godard famously wrote in 1958, "a short film does not have time to think" (109)—others link this brevity to storytelling opportunities. Derrick Knight and Vincent Porter argue, "The short can provide a welcome contrast to the long, heaving and ponderous super-film" (6). A. O. Scott also suggests the short film may be more artistic than a feature-length film, writing that "a 10- or 15-minute movie requires as much craft and discipline as a feature. Maybe more. A short story can display infelicities of prose less forgivingly than a novel, and there is less room for error in a handful of shots and scenes. And a lot of room for artistry." Felando also highlights several qualities that are distinct to the form: a "focus on moments or 'fragments' of time" (13); "economical and narrowly focused narratives" (47); characters that are not goal-driven (52); and intense endings (57). Hence, she describes the typical short film as having "a simple story that focuses on a single event, character, situation, or moment with no subplots; fewer characters—usually only one or two central characters with few (or no) secondary characters; and a brief story time" (47). For instance, Dee Rees' 27-minute short *Pariah* (2007), which is distributed for educational purposes via New Day Films, is presented in simple terms: "A Bronx lesbian teenager juggles conflicting identities to please friends and family." In Adam Salky's 16-minute short *Dare* (2005), a "teenager has a secret crush on an athletic classmate." Tom Gustafson's 20-minute *Fairies* (2003) is a "musical fantasy come true." In Daniel Ribeiro's 17-minute *I Don't Want to Go Back Alone* (2010), Leonardo, a fifteen-year-old blind teenager, has to deal with the jealousy of his friend Giovana while figuring out the new feelings he's having toward his new friend, Gabriel. These narratives explore these themes through brief moments in their characters' overall stories.

This briefness does not minimize their queerness, however. In his seminal work on queer time, Jack Halberstam (2005) examines how queer time exists outside of reproductive and familial time. Drawing on Foucault and Sedgwick, among others, Halberstam outlines how for queer subjects time and space are highlighted by the risks they are inclined to take, arguing that "we applaud the pursuit of long life (under any circumstances) and pathologize modes of living that show little or no concern for longevity" (152). These films all represent queer youth living

in the now, in brief moments of pleasure. If, according to Halberstam, we see reproductive time and family time as heteronormative time/space models, then time for these characters functions "outside of the logic of capital accumulation" (10). Rather than waiting for it to get better once they reach adulthood, these short films present brief moments as forces of queerness.

Both *Pariah* and *Dare* were adapted into features of the same name in 2011 and 2009 respectively. Daniel Ribeiro adapted *I Don't Want to Go Back Alone* into 2014 *The Way He Looks*. Tom Gustafson adapted *Fairies* into 2008 *Were the World Mine*. As duration is a key differentiating factor in these short film to feature-length adaptations, they are well suited to an analysis framed by temporality. To take such an approach is not simply to consider how feature-length adaptations elongate their precursor texts, but to interrogate the intersection of sexuality and temporality through the process of adaptation. With this in mind, the analyses that follow elucidate two queer temporalities that emerge within the brief short film and the elongated adaptation.

Were the World Mine

Crossing the genre boundaries of the coming-of-age film, musical, romantic comedy, and fantasy, *Were the World Mine* (Tom Gustafson 2008) was a significant hit on the queer film festival circuit and has since become a cult favorite through online streaming platforms. The film sees Timothy (Tanner Cohen) put a queer spell on his conservative small town. Encouraged by his unconventional teacher Ms. Tebbit (Wendy Robie) to play Puck in the school's production of *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, Timothy discovers the recipe for the love-in-idleness flower. Much like Puck in Shakespeare's play, Timothy uses the flower to throw the entire town in chaos by making them fall in love with the first person of the same gender they see, resulting in a "queer happiness but also heterosexual panic" (Silverstone 319).

The 95-minute feature is based on Gustafson's 20-minute short film *Fairies* (2003), with much of the creative team returning to work on the feature. The short opens with a tracking shot that slowly reveals four pairs of legs dangling from an elevated stage. They all wear white socks and white sports shoes. The only variations between them are the length, angle and movement, and the branded patterns of their shoes. Eventually, this sweeping shot reveals another two legs wearing colorful

shoes. This is the economical way Gustafson introduces Timothy, marking his difference from the film's outset without lengthy dialogue or exposition. Narrating only a brief moment in Timothy's use of magic, the short version of the story speaks to Halberstam's approach to queer temporality. Halberstam argues that queer temporality emphasizes "the ephemeral, the fugitive, the contingent" (13) as opposed to a heteronormative temporality, which is largely concerned with linear progress toward a clearly defined goal. In *Fairies*, the form presents Timothy in a different temporality. As he walks down the hallway or sits in class yearning for Jonathan, a combination of editing techniques, such as elided time or jump cuts, break classical constructions of film time. Another example of this is the key musical sequence, which exists outside of the linear temporality of the film. The sequence is presented as a highly stylized and strikingly edited homoerotic fantasy that Timothy conjures in his mind as he creates the magic flower. Shots of schoolboys dancing in tight metallic shorts and fairy wings are edited with repeated romantic gestures between Timothy and Jonathan. Spanning almost a quarter of the film, this sequence functions as a queer utopia. To draw on Dyer's work on the musical (1976), this utopia functions as a form of escape and wish fulfillment. It is where all of Timothy's hopes and dreams combine in a burst of excess. Here *Fairies* is representative of the queer potential of the short film: *Fairies* capitalizes on the brevity of the form to offer rapid-paced and ephemeral queer moments and sensations.

In adapting *Fairies* into the feature-length *Were the World Mine*, Gustafson notes that he was able to add a considerable amount of nuance to the story:

> The short is really a one-joke film—Timothy turns everyone gay—The End. When we decided to expand *Fairies*, we really wanted to use *Midsummer*—the story, the characters—as the real inspiration to all the expansions. So *WTWM* really is much more of a retelling of *Midsummer* than *Fairies*. (qtd. in Soares)

This focus on *A Midsummer Night's Dream* is significant, reminding us that *Were the World Mine* is not simply an adaptation of *Fairies* but an adaptation of an adaptation of Shakespeare's play. In the original *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, temporal dislocation allows for new possibilities of desires, which is evident in the film's camp dream sequences. For Elizabeth Freeman, the play "puts forth a model of time as embodied,

of bodies and their pleasures at once vessels, figures and even causes of temporal (dis)orientation" (16). As such, the affordances of a feature-length narrative allow for greater exploration of these central characters and themes of disorientation. Timothy's strained relationship with his single mother (Judy McLane) is expanded upon, as are her attempts to develop a new career as a makeup saleswoman. Timothy's friendships are expanded with new characters and these platonic relationships play a larger role in his character development. The feature's soundtrack is expanded to include pop songs by gay musicians, including Mika's "Relax, Take It Easy," Patrick Wolf's "The Magical Position," and The Guts' "Rock Star," featuring lead actor Cohen on vocals. As Gustafson says above, the longer format also allows for a deeper engagement with Shakespeare, particularly the motif of Lysander's claim that "The course of true love never did run smooth" (1.1.134) and a chorus of characters in the film's final act singing Oberon's line "Be as thou was wont to be / See as thou was wont to see" (4.1.70–1).

The conclusion to the story is *the* major difference between the two versions. In the short, everyone remains under the spell in a queer utopia. In the feature, Timothy corrects the spell and re-establishes everyone's prior identities. Kozusko argues that this is a "normalisation of queer sexualities so that queerness is merely gay" (179), that this "conclusion ultimately un-queers the movie, Shakespeare, and maybe Timothy himself" (177), while Silverstone argues that in order to heal Timothy's melancholic wounds, the "queer subject is required to exist in a heteronormative world" (323). The feature also fits into a classical construction of causation that Bordwell (20) argues is ideally closed both spatially and temporally and which would be antithetical to queer temporalities as we have discussed them.

Despite this apparent return to heteronormativity, the feature-length adaptation does still retain some moments of queerness. Its longer duration means it has much more room to explore ambiguity in the relationship between Timothy and Jonathan before the queering spell takes place. There are clues hinting to Jonathan's (Nathaniel David Becker) attraction to Timothy—he compliments him on his "nice pipes" after hearing the auditions—and Max and Frankie have an evidently non-normative fashion sense. Moreover, and perhaps more importantly, the longer duration also eschews classical narrative structure. Karl Schoonover suggests that the cultivation of slowness might be a way to circumvent the heteronormativity of linear causation. In "Wastrels of

time: Slow Cinema's Laboring Body, the Political Spectator, and the Queer," he explores the affinities between queerness and the drawn-out temporality of slow cinema, arguing that both look "a lot like wasted time, wasted lives, wasted productivity" (73). Recalling this sensation of queer temporality, the film's narrative slows down before the resolution, embracing, albeit briefly, the queer possibilities of slowness with an uneconomical "excess as a temporality" as Schoonover describes (65). Following the musical interlude of "The Course of True Love," during "All Things Shall Be Peace," Timothy resists the narrative resolution by ending the spell. He embraces a sleeping Jonathan in an alternative dreamscape space. The song ends with the cast sitting in the field of flowers in a narrative moment that breaks from linear narrative time and space. As such, while the feature-length version of the story may seem more conventional than the original short, the longer format does allow Gustafson to build nuance and experiment with storytelling beyond the brief bursts of his original short.

Pariah

Pariah (Dee Rees, 2011) is a coming-of-age drama that premiered at the 2011 Sundance Film Festival. It runs 86 minutes and follows Alike (Adepero Oduye), an African-American lesbian teen who is out among her openly gay friends but forced into a life of obedience, heterosexuality, and hegemonic femininity at home with her Christian parents. Alike's gender expression and sexuality cause tension at home and she is pushed into becoming friends with Bina (Aasha Davis), the daughter of her mother's colleague, who is deemed to be a good influence. A relationship develops between the two girls and eventually Alike's two worlds collide.

US theatrical distributor Focus Features describes *Pariah* (2011) as an "expansion" of Rees' acclaimed short film of the same name. *Pariah* (2007), the 27-minute short, told the first act of the feature; however, the feature film was not a simple extension of Rees' original concept. In several interviews, Rees explains that she initially wrote the script with a longer duration in mind. While she created the short as her thesis film for New York University's Graduate Film Program, her intention for the project was always to produce a feature-length narrative film: "I took the first act from the feature script, and shot it as a short. But the feature has always been the original vision" ("Transforming"). As Rees

originally scripted a feature-length version, "the harder struggle was to take excerpts and [make] a half-hour short. I never had the problem of having to expand [the story]—all the stories were already there" (qtd. in Harris). When asked about how the script developed through the film's various iterations, Rees replies,

> The first thing that changed from the first version to this [feature-length] version is that the rest of the characters became rounded out. The page count shrunk from 140 down to 90, but the characters were more fully developed, it was tighter and every scene went further. (qtd. in Patches)

Given the opportunity to rework the project again as a feature, Rees highlights the complex relationship between an "original" film and its adaptation. Rather than simply going back to the original script, Rees used the short as a starting point through which she imagined new endings, new ways of representing her characters, and new dimensions to those characters.

The feature film fleshes out Alike's characterization as a pariah. Alike doesn't fit in the heteronormative world (the world of her family) because she is attracted to women and because of her discomfort with hegemonic gender expressions. In the first act of the film, we see Alike change outfits twice. On one occasion she covertly removes masculine traces as she rides the bus home after a night out. Her discomfort is palpable as she stares through the bus windows (see Fig. 9.1). On another occasion, she changes out of feminine clothes in the bathroom at school. Later in the film, her mother forces her to wear a pink blouse to church and she complains, stating "this isn't me." What makes *Pariah* more complex is that Alike doesn't fit comfortably within the queer cultural scene either, which also has rules about gender expression and behavior. Alike is caught between these worlds, an idea which is raised in the short film and redeployed in the feature to show, over an extended duration, what it is to experience this sense of dislocation. As in *Were the World Mine*, this longer version of the story evokes Schoonover's theorization of a *queer* temporality emerging via slowness. However, in this film, the queer potential of slowness is intensified. The stretched-out, elongated temporality of the feature is employed strategically to emphasize Alike's complex negotiations of identity. Long takes and the measured rhythm of the feature film encourage scrutiny, allowing audiences to take in subtle details of Oduye's performance of not feeling at home in either space.



Fig. 9.1 Alike (Adepero Oduye), still partly in masculine attire, staring solemnly out of the window

This adaptation also highlights the malleability of a story's depth and breadth. Through a complex process of adaptation (from feature to short to feature), *Pariah* has been condensed on one plane and expanded on many others. It has been pulled in and then stretched out into a new shape, and in a sense, has been queered by this process. This queering extends to both the form and the content of the story as Alike enters the narrative wanting to get a girlfriend but ends up in pursuit of freedom. After confessing her sexuality in the feature-length version, she is rejected by her mother and forced to create a new life for herself. She takes up an early college program and sets off on a bus journey on her own. In the final moments, Alike's poetry forms the narration. She wipes away tears from her eyes as her voice-over states:

> And I am not Running
> I am Choosing
> Running is not a Choice
> From the Breaking
> Breaking is freeing
> Broken is freedom
> I am not broken
> I am free.

The lighting and color palette change in this scene from the film's earlier dark tones to an optimistic and almost golden glow. This reminds us that Alike's narrative is not simply about finding a partner and a linear path toward happiness (the film's open ending actively resists closure), but rather the construction of a queer utopia away from the violence of heteronormativity.

The Third Girl: *Dare* and *The Way He Looks*

Adapted from popular short films on the queer film festival circuit, two feature films saw the inclusion of a love triangle between two young men and a young woman. In the 16-minute short *Dare* (Adam Sulky, 2005), the socially awkward high schooler Ben (Adam Fleming) helps the more popular Johnny (Michael Cassidy) learn his lines for the school play. Once at Johnny's house, the two take a swim in the pool, where Ben performs fellatio on Johnny. The short is brief but it presents an intense expression of queer desire. It concludes with openness: a cheeky smile shared between the two characters, seeming to suggest the potential for something to develop between them in the future.

Dare was adapted into a feature-length production in 2009. The 92-minute *Dare* maintained the focus on queer desire with the pool scene becoming a key moment in the plot. The feature-length narrative allows for greater character development, which provides more nuance to the character's sexuality. Ben (Ashley Springer) remains a closeted young gay man who pursues a romantic relationship with Johnny (Zach Gilford). Ben's close friend Alexa, played by the bankable Emmy Rossum, is expanded to be the lead character in the film. Alexa, who has desires and functions within a goal-oriented narrative, also pursues a romantic relationship with Johnny, whose characterization is fleshed out further to be bisexual. To recall Albrecht-Crane and Cutchins, adaptations interpret and re-work the precursor text. This adaptation allows for a more nuanced queerness in that it breaks down the binary between heterosexuality and homosexuality, presenting audiences with a range of sexual identities that do not exist in the original.

In the 17-minute short *I Don't Want to Go Back Alone* (*Eu não quero voltar sozinho*, Daniel Ribeiro, 2010), Leonardo (Ghilherme Lobo) is a fifteen-year-old blind student who, along with his best friend Giovana

(Tess Amorim), befriends the new student Gabriel (Fabio Audi). As in the 2005 version of *Dare*, the best friend character remains an underdeveloped supporting character. Her most prominent scene is brief: she leans over to Leo expecting him to confess his love for her, only to be rebuffed by his admission that he is falling in love with Gabriel. Also similar to the short version of *Dare*, *I Don't Want to Go Back Alone* largely revolves around a singular moment of queer desire. The film builds to a kiss between Gabriel and Leo, and it concludes with Leo smiling as he realizes that it was Gabriel who in fact kissed him. As there is no exploration of what happens next between these characters, the film's queerness emerges as a condensed surge of passion. This short thus recalls Halberstam's notion of queer temporality as a set of "rapid bursts" (4), struggling against the forward oriented and linear logic of cause and effect.

The film was adapted into the 2014 96-minute feature *The Way He Looks* (*Hoje eu quero voltar sozinho*) and the narrative was developed considerably further. The three lead performers all reprised their previous roles. Several narrative elements of the shorter version remain the same, though there are some key differences: Gabriel cycles in the adaptation, which functions as a narrative device to develop intimacy between him and Leo. In the short, Giovana has feelings for Leo, while in the adaptation, she expresses interest in Gabriel. This shifting of desire evokes new narrative tensions in the feature and provides a means of cultivating queer ambiguity in the relationships that make up the love triangle. This is visually rendered in one scene by the pool with the three characters situated in adjacent sectors of the frame (see Fig. 9.2).

Both *The Way He Looks* and *Dare* demonstrate the adaptation's affordance for nuance. In both films, the characters' sexuality is developed to allow for further narrative conflict through the creation of the love triangle. In particular, the "third girl" figure is elaborated upon to have further agency, rather than being a figure on the periphery. The development of this figure also functions queerly to enable the representation of sexual desires that don't always fit neatly within the binaries of hetero- and homosexuality. Regarding the temporal dimensions of the films, *The Way He Looks* functions similarly to *Were the World Mine* in that the film mostly adheres to a tight cause-and-effect narrative, save for a few key moments of slowness. In *The Way He Looks*, the majority of scenes move along a quickened pace, ending once all the narrative information has been delivered. There are a few exceptions, however, when the characters



Fig. 9.2 The love triangle between Leo (Ghilherme Lobo) (on the left) and Gabriel (Fabio Audi) and Giovana (Tess Amorim) (on the right), depicted visually

are contemplative. The film opens with Leo and Giovana lounging by the pool with Leo asking "what's your laziness level right now?" This scene is repeated again later with Gabriel. Likewise, several intimate scenes are imbued with a sense of slowness, such as when Leo goes to bed with Gabriel's hoodie, which leads to him sniffing it and masturbating, or when Gabriel and Leo shower together, which gives Gabriel the opportunity to look at Leo's naked body unhindered. *Dare*, however, does not have these slower moments. In reviewing this film and comparing it to the other features of this study, we found that the film does not utilize moments of slowness to evoke queerness. *Dare* adheres to a classical narrative with a closed time/space logic, which is perhaps suggestive of the difficulty faced by filmmakers as they attempt to maintain the queer utopian potential of the short in the more conventional feature-length format.

Conclusion

As we have highlighted in this chapter, filmmakers tend to view their feature-length adaptations as an opportunity to expand upon the queerness of their original concept. The short films addressed in this chapter present brief moments in their characters' lives. *Dare* presents a brief sexual

encounter between two students in a pool. *Fairies* and *I Don't Want to Go Back Alone* offer slightly extended stories that explore the development of a relationship between two young men. *Pariah* narrates an episode in a queer girl's journey to self-discovery. Albrecht-Crane and Cutchins argue that the adaptation process requires the filmmaker to "interpret, re-working the precursor text and choosing the various meanings and sensations they find the most compelling" (16). In looking at how these filmmakers adapted their original stories into feature films, we can see that this process of interpretation is a reworking of their characters' very queerness over an extended period of time. In *Were the World Mine* and *Pariah*, the longer duration of the feature film is strategically employed to add nuance, depth, and complexity to characters and relationships presented in the original shorts. In *Dare* and *The Way He Looks,* we also see the development of peripheral characters' sexuality. All four examples provide audiences with the opportunity of seeing and experiencing more of the original concept.

While it might be tempting to argue that feature-length films are longer and therefore better, more complex, or queerer than their shorter counterparts—such an argument would suggest that yes, size does matter—we must be wary of endorsing binary oppositions between the original and copy. As adaptation scholars suggest, such binaries (even when reversed) are not productive. Studies of adaptation should instead "provide a more flexible, animating discourse" around cultural production (Naremore 9). Rather than offer a simple reading of the short film to feature-length adaptation, we have highlighted the queer potential of each form. The short film, with its brevity and strict economy of storytelling, cannot present narrative depth or complexity of character in the same way as a feature film. However, what this form can do is represent LGBTQ lives and identities through queer temporal frameworks: the contingent, the ephemeral, and short bursts. The feature-length format allows for depth and nuance, slowness and stillness, and significantly, for LGBTQ stories to unfold over time. The challenge for filmmakers, then, is transposing these dynamics from one form to the other. As we have discussed in this chapter, maintaining the queerness of the original concept has proven difficult for some filmmakers when adapting their short films into the more conventional feature-length format. Having closely examined our four case studies, we can only come to one conclusion: it's not the size that matters, it's what you do with it.

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CHAPTER 10

Transnational Slash: Korean Drama Formats, Boys' Love Fanfic, and the Place of Queerness in East Asian Media Flows

John Lessard

Introduction

The glossy, pop-cultural forms, fantasies, and fandoms of Hallyu, or the Korean Wave, have come to fascinate a growing base of consumers, fans, and scholars since the sudden popularity of imported South Korean dramas was first noticed by Chinese journalists in the late 1990s (Y. Kim 1). While people outside of Korea often use the term Hallyu to speak of Korean dramas or pop culture more generally, Jeongmee Kim notes that, in Korea, the term refers "only to those dramas that have gained success in the Asian overseas market" (241). With Seoul Broadcasting System's (SBS) 2008 drama *You're Beautiful* (*Minam isineyo*) as my focal point, this essay explores the show's ironic pastiching of slash and Boys' Love (BL) fan fiction (fanfic), particularly insofar as these elements contributed to the transnational appeal both of the show and of Hallyu culture more generally. Despite its relatively lackluster broadcast ratings, the show's doubled recourse to both K-pop pleasures and queer fanfic

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tropes helped it to deliver a committed enough fandom to warrant both Tokyo Broadcasting System's (TBS) 2011 adaptation, *You're Handsome* (*Ikemen desu ne*), and Formosa Television's (FTV) 2012 production, *Fabulous Boys* (*Yuan lai shi mei nan*) (Oh 147). That is to say, the show's mobilization of queer imagery, fandoms, and fanfic discourses have contributed in important ways to its visibility and viability as an East Asian format adaptation.

In contrast to more traditional models of "'canned' television"—i.e., television exports—television formats are specifically packaged and licensed for adaptation across multiple national and regional markets. Due to the format trade's amenability to transcultural adaptation and its correspondingly flexible economies of production, it has already begun to "revolutioniz[e] television industrial, creative, and marketing strategies around the world, as players in previously hopelessly marginalized markets now successfully compete in this ever expanding market" (Oren and Shahaf 3). Though distinct, the "global 'format frenzy' of the last two decades" (Oren and Shahaf 4) also coincides, roughly, with the rise of internet culture, queer online communities, and related modes of networked queer fandom.

You're Beautiful follows a young nun novitiate, Go Mi Nyeo, who joins the popular boy band A. N. JELL disguised as her twin brother to cover for him as he heals from a cosmetic surgery fiasco. Initially hesitant to take on her brother, Go Mi Nam's, identity, Mi Nyeo nevertheless postpones her plans to become a nun once she learns her brother's real reason for pursuing celebrity: to find the long-lost mother whose fate and name remain unknown to them. Unlike the obsessive cosplaying fangirls who follow A. N. JELL and police their online image, the orphaned Mi Nyeo was raised in a convent and has little experience with either cis/heterosexuality or pop culture. After getting drunk during her debut party, Mi Nyeo passes out and viewers are invited into a dreamscape that closes the first episode. Walking through convent gardens that are studded with both naked male statues and the white-clad band members, Mi Nyeo walks past them with long hair and wearing one of the most glamorous and conventionally feminine dresses that we ever see her in. The camera then cuts to a close up of her as she closes her eyes and asks her Mother Superior "do you think I came back from heaven?" After that image has faded to white, we cut to another close up of Mi Nyeo, her eyes still closed but her head laying on a yellow pillow and once again sporting the shorter hair that Mi Nyeo adopted after joining the band. She then opens her eyes, drowsy but smiling, as the camera cranes

up to reveal Go Mi Nyeo laying down, head to head with her semi-dressed bandmates as rose petals fall gently all around then (as seen in Fig. 10.1). After Mi Nyeo moves in with the band, this intoxicated fascination quickly wears off and she finds herself unintentionally butting heads with, but also attracted to, the band's talented yet arrogant lead singer, Hwang Tae Kyung, a man whose parental traumas turn out to be bound up with her own. Mi Nyeo's now-dead father was deeply in love with her mother, but jealous pop star Mo Hwa Ran caused their parents to separate shortly before her mother died giving birth to the twins. Due to her obsessive, yet unrequited, love for Mi Nyeo's father, Hwa Ran even ends up abandoning Tae Kyung, her own son by another man. These past generational traumas are revived in the diegetical present when Mi Nyeo then becomes romantically entangled with Tae Kyung. When Mi Nyeo and Tae Kyung eventually unravel these buried generational secrets, they realize that, by loving each other, they have inadvertently fallen in love with the child of someone they hold responsible for the breakup of their family.



Fig. 10.1 In order to find her long-lost mother, Go Mi Nyeo (Shin-Hye Park) agrees to move in with the other band members

Even though its narrative conflicts are ultimately resolved through a cis/heteronormative romantic union, *You're Beautiful* abounds with both implicit and explicit invocations of queer desires, identifications, and discourse. That is to say, the show's particular forms and modes of queerness are inscribed by, but also exceed or traverse various national, local, regional, and global traditions and cultural economies that themselves often intersect even when they remain distinct. Among *You're Beautiful*'s more important nods to queer fangirl cultural codes is the gender-bending premise of the show itself, which couples drag performativity with an inverted "harem" scenario (featuring multiple men competing for the attentions of one character) that would be familiar, in terms of genre and tropes, to consumers of manga, anime, and BL fanfic (Clements and McCarthy 542). What makes *You're Beautiful* of particular interest is the way that it both exploits these features of "Hallyu 2.0" and integrates them with queer cultural traditions and media flows that traverse the local, national, regional, and global. Hallyu queerness thus emerges through or as a series of material, psychic, and symbolic displacements: of desires, affects, identities, and embodiments, but also of the geographies and economies in which they circulate.

To better reflect the ways that the South Korean culture industries have adapted to such changes since the late 1990s, Sangjoon Lee differentiates between "Hallyu 1.0," with its "one-way flow of Korean pop culture from artist to fans in Asia," and the much more participatory, digital-era practices of "Hallyu 2.0," which has successfully exploited social media and media-convergence trends to "embrac[e] new fans, markets, and consumers" across the globe (16). In this regard, the recalibration of Hallyu scholarship to account for networked culture in the digital age aligns well with Thomas Leitch's account of scholarship within adaptation studies: whereas "medium specificity was the lodestar of Adaptation Studies 1.0, [and] intertextuality was the leading principle of Adaptation Studies 2.0" ("Introduction" 3), Adaptation Studies 3.0 has instead been shaped, among other things, by "an embrace of digital technologies … [and] what Lawrence Lessig has called a Read/Write Literacy, as opposed to Read/Only Literacy" ("Introduction" 5). In keeping with Robert Stam's call for adaptation studies to address the "post-celluloid world of the new media" (11), *You're Beautiful*'s queer allure and transnational fandoms thrive in precisely such digital transformations and the liminal cultural spaces, flows, and encounters that they have in turn opened up. For the same reasons, *You're Beautiful*

does not conform neatly to older models of adaptation, such as those privileging "exclusively cinematic" adaptations "involving only films that are based on novels or plays or stories" (Leitch, "Adaptation and Intertextuality" 89). Taken together with its format adaptations, *You're Beautiful* instead entails multiple, intersecting layers or modes of adaptation. Indeed, these transnational flows, adaptive practices, and fandoms are the condition of possibility for this very essay, which is deeply indebted, among other things, to the labor and generosity of fan subbers, including the WITH S2 Written In The Heavens Subbing Squad.

While its licensed formatting for Japanese and Taiwanese television entails the transcultural, translocal adaptation of a parent text for other regional markets and audiences, it nevertheless defies simplistic assumptions that "adaptations are exclusively intermedial, involving the transfer of narrative elements from one medium to another" (Leitch, "Adaptation and Intertextuality" 91). In addressing the show's complex, multidirectional circuitry of cultural adaptation, we must also be careful to account for *You're Beautiful*'s deliberate accommodation and courtship of both larger broadcast audiences and niche fandoms, including transnational queer fandoms. This courtship happens both indirectly, through its appropriation of codes and discourses specific to those fandoms, and directly, through its diegetic inclusion of queer fanfic plot elements that in turn shape the show's own narrative logic and possibilities. This essay accordingly pursues two related lines of inquiry: (1) To what extent does queerness (broadly conceived) serve finally to mobilize and stimulate, rather than inhibit, transnational adaptation and cultural flows? (2) What is the place of queerness in Hallyu's cultural flows and format trade? As I will show, *You're Beautiful*'s transnational format adaptations make a strong case for queerness's capacity to drive and lubricate, rather than slow or inhibit, East Asian media flows. *You're Beautiful*'s queer tropes and sensibilities should be understood not as a queer modulation of otherwise nonqueer Hallyu cultural forms, but rather as an immanent aspect of Hallyu itself.

The Nun and the Fangirl

Foregrounding its gender-bending elements, *You're Beautiful*'s first episode exploits nun gags and gender performativity much more explicitly than many of the subsequent episodes. By the second episode, however, two of A. N. JELL's three band members (Kang Shin Woo and Tae

Kyung) have already discovered Mi Nyeo's gender secret, thus deflecting some of the first episode's queer energies (the A storyline) and paving the way instead for more traditional melodramatic (B) and romantic (C) storylines. Not insignificantly, these two band members also happen to be the two men who compete most strongly for Mi Nyeo's affections. With the gender-bending A storyline already redirected to its more conventional B and C storylines in episode two, the narrative arc of episodes three through sixteen continues to foreground Mi Nyeo and Tae Kyung's developing romance, along with the familial secrets that threaten to disrupt it. Even though Tae Kyung's discovery of Mi Nyeo's secret ostensibly forestalls a queer explanation for his developing romantic interest in her, it would be a mistake to assume that *You're Beautiful*'s queer pleasures are thereby voided. On the contrary, it is the show's high-concept gender-bending premise that most defines its cultural visibility, and therefore too its marketability as an adaptable drama format. When Mi Nyeo commits to joining the band, shots of the reporter-packed showcase for her debut are intercut with rear tracking shots of Mi Nyeo as she looks in a mirror while cutting her hair and binding her chest (see Fig. 10.2). The use of parallel editing here effectively aligns the band's public performances with the performativity of Mi Nyeo's gender-bending transformation. Insofar as the show's generic and narrative displacements allow it to court both more general and more niche audiences, they also clear space for the insertion of queer pleasures into otherwise cis/heteronormative frameworks.

Within the first ten minutes of episode one, for example, we learn that Mi Nyeo's experience with male sexuality at the convent is limited to her relationship with three nude statues (David, Julian, and Thomas) that clearly foreshadow the three idols with whom she'll soon be living. Tracking behind David's torso before tilting up to rest on Mi Nyeo's face, the camera highlights David's left buttock, which remains exposed in the foreground despite the sheet that she has tied around his waist to cover up his genitals. While this sequence clearly highlights Mi Nyeo's sexual naïveté, if also curiosity, her apparently joyful contentment with convent life nevertheless resists the suggestion that she is a reluctant ascetic in need of heteroromantic salvation. Mi Nyeo's love for her Mother Superior and visible satisfaction with her decision to become a nun instead suggests that she is happily impervious, at least initially, to conventional gender pressures and heterosexual or reproductive expectations. In that sense, *You're Beautiful* presents the nun less as a figure



Fig. 10.2 Go Mi Nyeo's gender-bending performance as her pop-idol twin brother begins when she cuts her hair and binds her chest

of thwarted heterosexual development and more as a kind of ultimate fangirl whose devotion to God parallels that of the fanatical pop-idol fangirls dramatized elsewhere on the program.

In fact, when Mi Nyeo first arrives at the band's management company to sign her brother's contract for him, she is still wearing her convent clothes. Rather than seeming out of place amidst such glaringly secular devotion, Mi Nyeo is praised by both angel-costumed fangirls and her future bandmate, Jeremy, for what they see as her more unique cosplay outfit. "You really stand out," one of the recurring fangirl characters tells her, "the idea is awesome!" A wide profile shot of Mi Nyeo amidst the fangirls (see Fig. 10.3) highlights the multiplied gazes they direct at her, assessing her costume and belongingness. Even though the camera is not subjectively positioned from the fangirls' perspectives, the shot's emphasis on their gaze allows us to see her through their eyes more than her own. Although *You're Beautiful* revels in these cosplay excesses, some of the more adult characters criticize the fangirls for their fanatical devotion to the band, which leads them to skip both school



Fig. 10.3 *You're Beautiful* presents the figure of the nun as a kind of ultimate fangirl. Here A. N. JELL fangirls confuse Go Mi Nyeo's habit with sophisticated cosplay

and work to catch sight of their beloved A. N. JELL idols. In that sense, the show both delights in fangirl excesses and acknowledges the social criticisms directed at them for their social, economic, and gender nonconformity. Insofar as their desire for the A. N. JELL band members is knowingly premised on the impossibility of its consummation, the fangirls' pop idolatry reproduces cis/hetero desires that it, by its very excesses, also resists and redirects. Even if Mi Nyeo's dedication to the Holy Father and Son preserves some of the hegemonic contours of traditional gender ideologies, her gender-subversive pleasure in the intensities of convent life anticipates the more gender-subversive dimensions of fanatical fandom.

The queer/BL hermeneutics and fanfic discourses woven into *You're Beautiful*'s televisual texture operate precisely through their queering—and therefore their adaptation and appropriation—of cis-, hetero-, and even homonormative narratives and ideologies. In episode fourteen, for example, the show's multiple queer displacements and reflexive engagements with fan discourse are beautifully illustrated by a comic exchange between Tae Kyung and Mi Nyeo. As Tae Kyung expresses his feelings

to Mi Nyeo in an airport parking lot, a bus full of screaming fangirls with cameras pulls up alongside them. When Tae Kyung and Mi Nyeo are eating sushi together in the next scene, he calms her fears that the fangirls might upload queer-suggestive pictures of them: "fans don't really care about us being like that. A novel will come out today also." When Mi Nyeo asks what kind of novel he's referring to, Tae Kyung explains that, "fans write novels with us as the lead characters. There are lots of love stories without a woman involved. That's what they call fanfic … it's usually a love triangle between me, Shin Woo, and Jeremy." As Tae Kyung explains fanfic to Mi Nyeo, an over-the-shoulder close up from Mi Nyeo's perspective (see Fig. 10.4) exploits a doubly ironic positioning of fanfic-savvy viewers of *You're Beautiful*, who are visually positioned both to identify with Mi Nyeo's pop-cultural naïveté, and to enjoy a moment of shared fanfic insidership with the show's diegetic star, Tae Kyung, as well as the actor who plays him (Jang Keun-Suk). As the two characters look upwards, we cut to an imaginative sequence in which Jeremy comes up behind a piano-playing Tae Kyung and puts his hands over his eyes. When Tae Kyung mistakes the hands for Shin Woo's, Jeremy cries that,

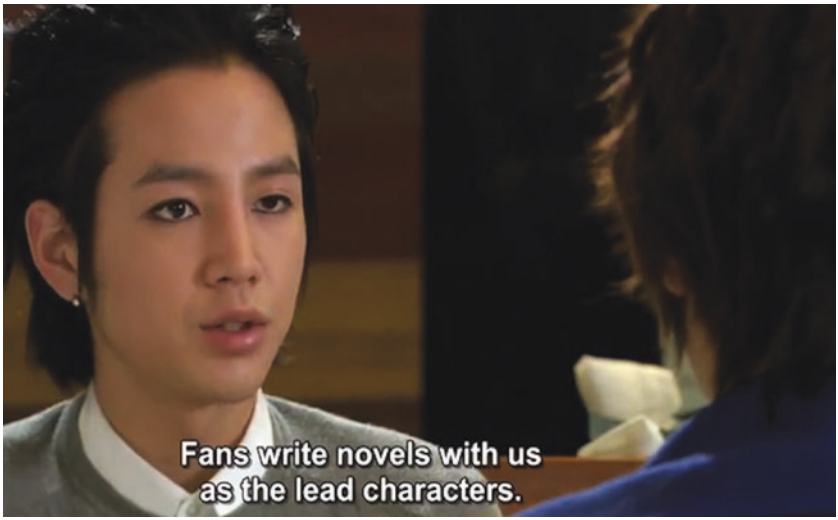


Fig. 10.4 Hwang Tae Kyung (Jang Keun-Suk) explains fanfic to Go Mi Nyeo (Shin-Hye Park)

"you always only look for Shin Woo." The campy excesses of the scene's soft-focus photography and amped-up pop soundtrack clearly differentiate it from the main narrative, but also provide an ironic acknowledgement of the show's own queer excesses, use of love triangles, and pop scoring.

You're Beautiful's ironic endorsement of queer fanfic hermeneutics is once again reiterated in the next scene, which features Jeremy reading the newly released fanfic novel on a computer at the radio station where he is soon to perform. A close-up frontal shot of Jeremy's face as he looks at his laptop reveals his pleasure in the queer narrative into which he has been inserted by his fans. As he reads out the lines spoken by his character in the fanfic novel, their similarity to lines in the previous scene suggests this fan-produced narrative is the same that was previously imagined by Tae Kyung and Mi Nyeo. Jeremy's subsequent praise for the fanfic novel—"This novel is surprisingly quite interesting"—in turn clarifies *You're Beautiful*'s self-reflexive strategies for appropriating fanfic tropes and inserting queer possibility into narratives that otherwise unfold in conventionally cis/heteronormative ways. While these comical interludes highlight the show's interest in queer hermeneutics and niche fandoms, they also serve to introduce these discourses and interpretive lenses to viewers who might be unfamiliar with them.

You're Beautiful's simultaneous centering and displacement of queerness occurs, moreover, within a doubly geographic and generic sense, reflecting perhaps the producers' desire to court mainstream as well as niche audiences, and therefore meanings and values that are aligned with the one and the other. Such displacements serve to centralize, rather than marginalize, queerness even as they speak to the nature, appeal, and mobilization of queerness as such. When Manager Ma first reveals to Mi Nyeo that her brother has gone to America to correct a Westernizing double-eyelid surgery, he frames the show's inciting incident within a fraught cultural geography that is bound up with the show's constructions of transnational fandom. "Mi Nam can't close his eyes," he explains, "[and] it's all my fault. I told him to just get small touch-up. It's not a big deal … it's a service for the fans." Insofar as Mi Nam's departure to the United States is thus due to a plastic surgery to render his eyes more Western, the show's gender-bending imagery is indirectly anchored to ongoing debates regarding the authenticity and Koreanness of Korean pop culture. In response to the question, "Precisely, whose culture is represented? What is 'Korean' in the Korean Wave?" Youna

Kim underscores the "hybrid nature of [its] cultural products, flows, audiences, and identities" and makes the point that "Korean popular culture is not really Korean in the sense that it has not evolved from Korean traditional values but is a mixture of influences" (17). As part of a larger call for a "de-Westernizing academic production of knowledge" and "the establishment of East Asian media culture studies," Koichi Iwabuchi makes the case that "the drastic development of the production of media cultures and their transnational circulation in non-Western regions has posed a serious question about the supremacy of American media cultures and the credence of Euro-American cultural dominion in the world" ("Korean Wave" 44). At the same time, though, he also acknowledges that "de-Westernizing perspectives should be accompanied by de-Asianizing ones too, for the reason that a comprehensive understanding of media and cultural flows in East Asia cannot be achieved via the methodologies developed for the study of 'traditional' cultures" ("De-Westernization" 404). With its national, regional, and global circulation and frames of reference, *You're Beautiful* requires us to think from both of these perspectives simultaneously.

In this regard, the gender-bending show's situating of key narrative moments in the transnational space of an airport proves especially telling. It is at the airport, for example, that Manager Ma confesses her brother's true motivations for becoming a pop star, a revelation that in turn motivates Mi Nyeo's decision to join the band and search for her mother. The fact that a scene of such narrative importance unfolds within an airport underscores, even if only indirectly, the show's fluidly transnational cultural imaginary, which points not only to the United States (where her brother is recuperating), but also to the Vatican (where she was planning to be confirmed as a nun), to Tokyo, and finally, to Seoul. This dispersed symbolic geography further reflects the show's own participation in and reflections on queer media flows that operate on a simultaneously national, intraregional, and global basis. *You're Beautiful* effectively aligns geographic displacements with those tied to gender and sexuality. What one might thus call the show's topography of gender and sexuality, or conversely its gendered spatialities, becomes visible too through an interaction between Mi Nyeo and Shin Woo. Having discovered early on the truth of Mi Nyeo's identity without her knowledge, the smitten Shin Woo can see that her gendered secret is making her anxious and so tries to comfort her by sharing one of his own secrets: the sophisticated Seoul-speaking Shin Woo actually hails from Busan, an area known for

its thickly accented dialect. Shin Woo explains that when he first arrived in Seoul, he lost a girlfriend because she misunderstood his dialect and thought he asked her if she killed dogs. What's intriguing about this revelation are the parallels it suggests between Mi Nyeo's performance of masculinity and Shin Woo's performance of place and tongue. This layering of queer gender displacements and geographical displacement is reiterated again in the last two episodes, when Mi Nyeo's gender identity is nearly unearthed by a reporter. After traveling with the band to Okinawa to promote their music, Mi Nyeo remains in Okinawa to avoid the reporter until her now-healed brother can return from the United States and use his body to convince the reporter of his ostensibly authentic masculinity. In short, queer identities, desires, and displacements repeatedly unfold within a transnational geography that shares its contours with that of East Asian pop-cultural media flows more generally.

Television Formats and the Transnational Geography of Slash/BL Fiction

Produced primarily though not exclusively by Korea's three national networks (SBS, KBS, and MBC), Hallyu drama exports are generally hour-long episodes that run for sixteen to twenty-four episodes, but may also include shows with fifty to sixty episode runs, such as the longer historical dramas—i.e., *saeguk*—or more outrageously soapy—i.e., *makjang*—melodramas (Y. Kim 6). Hallyu's regional successes were first triggered by a sharp rise in Korean drama exports to China in the late 1990s. Later, in 2003, the unexpected popularity of KBS's *Winter Sonata (Gyeoul yeonga)* among Japanese audiences further contributed to Hallyu's widening circle of influence in Japan and other East Asian markets (Jin 48). Dal Yong Jin points out that "the total value of Korean television program exports increased by as much as 27.4 times between 1995 and 2007, up from $5.5 million in 1995 to $151 million in 2007," with drama exports "tak[ing] the largest share, up from 76.8 percent in 2002 to 91.9 percent in 2008" (48). Identified by scholars as the start of the so-called Hallyu 2.0 era, 2008 thus turned out to be both a peak year and the beginning of downward trajectory that has since led to numerous industrial changes, including a general shift away from drama exports and toward drama formats.

Due to their cheaper production costs and the greater ease of adapting them to the specificities of local and national culture, reality and game

formats have traditionally been the focus of the global format trade. In contrast to the more easily formulized premises of game or reality shows, a marketable drama format requires producers to navigate between more conventional and more unique story elements. To both motivate licensed format adaptations and deter unofficial, and therefore unpaid, appropriations or imitations, a format package must thus include story elements that are sufficiently distinct to generate cultural visibility and animate both general viewers and loyal fans. As Dal Yong Jin explains, though, "Korean broadcasters have developed and exported three major formats: drama, reality audition show, and quiz show [but] … the majority of format programs are dramas, followed by entertainment and quiz shows" (55). The predominance of Korea's drama format sales is thus rather atypical, and reflects the regional and increasingly global clout that Korean dramas have accrued in the wake of the Korean Wave.

Despite unimpressive viewer ratings, which one of the show's directors ascribed to its competition with the action drama *IRIS* (*Airiseu*), *You're Beautiful* successfully "provoked greater audience discussions and praise" and led to format licensing deals with both Japanese and Taiwanese broadcasters (Oh 147). That is to say, *You're Beautiful*'s capacity to generate high levels of user engagement and fan interactivity helped to compensate for the original broadcast's relatively unimpressive audience shares. Youjeong Oh characterizes *You're Beautiful*'s reception as that of a "mania drama," which she defines as one that fails to "achieve commercial success because … [it does] not appeal to a broader audience," but that, for the same reason, engages "mania fans" by "touch[ing] the subcultural sensibilities of viewers" (146). In keeping with the post-broadcast era's embrace of niche marketing and "narrowcasting," the show's queer subcultural sensibility was arguably critical to its subsequent viability as a drama format. In that sense, *You're Beautiful* provides an illuminating example of the ways that the East Asian format trade has opened itself to, and benefited from, queer forms of fan activity that Oh refers to as "the collective and collaborative discursive consumption of television dramas" (137). As will become clear below, it's nevertheless important to recognize the fact that *You're Beautiful*'s queer tropes draw on a range of genres and discourses from both East and West. In this regard, *You're Beautiful*'s mainstream appropriation of queer sensibilities and fanfic tropes provides an illuminating index of larger queer-cultural shifts that were already underway at the start of the Hallyu 2.0 era.

In her account of gender, desire, and online identity, Sharen Cumberland discerns in online fanfic "three major forms [including] 'het' or 'heterosexual fiction,' 'alt,' or lesbian fiction, and 'slash' or homoerotic fiction" (268). While the third of those categories now refers broadly to "fan stories positing homoerotic affairs between series protagonists," Henry Jenkins explains that "slash originated as a genre of fan writing within *Star Trek* fandom in the early 1970s," its name referring to "the convention of employing a stroke or 'slash' to signify a same-sex relationship between two characters (Kirk/Spock or K/S)" (192). In Japan and East Asia, a number of categories have been used to describe phenomena that are similar, though not identical to slash, including the terms *yaoi* and BL (boys' love). First used in 1979 by creators of Japanese *dōjinshi*—i.e., "fan-created literature, most often manga, encompassing magazines, books, and other media" (Levi et al. 258)—*yaoi* emerged as "an acronym for 'Yamanashi, Ochinashi, Iminashi,' or 'no climax, no point, no meaning'" (Levi et al. 262; cf. McLelland and Welker 5). Roughly synonymous with *yaoi* is another popular term, boys' love, or BL, which is "most frequently used as a label for commercially published manga and light novels," even though it can also be "used as a label for non-commercial works" (McLelland and Welker 5). While the term boys' love, "pronounced 'bōizu rabu,'" had "first appeared in [Japan in] the commercial BL sphere at the beginning of the 1990s," McLelland and Welker note that BL communities nevertheless have a substantive history of producing and consuming both "derivative works based on the characters and plots of existing manga, anime" and stories about the "imagined experiences of actual celebrities and athletes" (4). While the dialogue of *You're Beautiful* explicitly references the English term fanfic, the show's queer mediations are thoroughly transnational and draw heavily on yaoi/BL generic traditions and cultural flows that similarly cut across national, regional, and global registers.

Highlighting the differences rather than similarities between BL and slash, Antonia Levi et al. attribute a "greater lability of gender and sex" to Japanese culture that has allowed BL literature to be relatively more integral to, or at least less visibly opposed to, dominant narrative and cultural traditions. By contrast, they note that Western slash fiction tends to stand out "more dramatically against other Western mainstream cultural works," such that "there is, as yet, no systematic commercial production of slash or slash-like romances or erotica" (4). Without reducing the differences between them, Levi et al. nevertheless warn against an

"overstate[ment of] the differences between boys' love and slash," not only because they developed contemporaneously in the 1970s, "a time marked by a global questioning of gender and sex," but also because writers and fans of both slash and BL have acknowledged their interest in and indebtedness to one another (4). Considering Korea's fraught post-colonial relationship with Japan, not to mention its intensified political proximity to the United States during and after the Korean War, such a global framing of these phenomena is in turn instructive for our understanding of *You're Beautiful*'s cross-cultural engagements with slash and BL discourses and traditions. While Levi et al. and Meyer are focused on Japanese rather than Korean cultural traditions relative to the West, their respective examinations of slash and BL fiction provide helpfully nuanced models for analyzing the transcultural circulation of queer themes and discourses.

One of the most important yaoi/BL tropes that *You're Beautiful* activates, without ever explicitly naming, is that of the so-called *fujoshi*, or "rotten woman," a pejorative but often ironically embraced term for "female fan(s) of boys' love manga, anime and/or video games" (Levi et al. 259). The figure of the *fujoshi* is implicit in *You're Beautiful*'s inclusion of yaoi/BL/fanfic communities as part of the storyline, but also in its choice of protagonist. In many respects, *You're Beautiful* accounts for Mi Nyeo's sexual innocence and romantic confusions by emphasizing her cloistered upbringing in the Church. At the same time, though, Mi Nyeo's visible contrast with other, more recognizably heteronormative female characters effectively aligns her with the gender non-normative terms that have often been attributed to *fujoshi*. Much like the gender-nonconforming nun that Mi Nyeo almost becomes, *fujoshi* communities are often criticized or even pathologized because of their interest in consuming and/or producing BL and related cultural forms.

Observing that BL fandom is a predominantly female-driven subcultural outgrowth of "otaku" culture more generally, Okabe and Ishida explain that "more females than males are otaku of this type," and that "these women refer to themselves by the playfully self-critical term fujoshi [which literally means] 'rotten women'… a pun on the homonym with different Chinese characters that means 'respectable women'" (207). In her comparison of *fujoshi* culture and queer-theoretical methodologies, Uli Meyer links the *fujoshi* fan's simultaneously linguistic and ideological subversion of the word—i.e., the "respectable lady"

reconceived through homophony as a "rotten woman"—to queer deconstructive strategies that are figured in terms of a queer gaze (232). Likening BL hermeneutics to queer-theoretical "reading[s] of queer subtext into straight texts" (235), Meyer argues that BL fantasies are similarly, which is not to say identically, generated by the queer gaze of a fujoshi fan who reinterprets gender-hegemonic texts through "yaoi megane ('yaoi glasses')" (232). In this regard, slash and BL are not just genres of fan-produced fiction, they are also modes of reading and interpretation used both to challenge dominant gender ideologies and imagine alternative possibilities.

And as *You're Beautiful*'s transnational engagement of fanfic and *yaoi*/BL subcultural traditions suggests, these challenges to dominant gender ideologies emerge and circulate within but also cut across multiple national, regional, and global lines. Given that *You're Beautiful* was produced after Korea's official ban on Japanese popular cultural imports ended in the late 1990s (J. Kim 240), the decision to format (rather than export) it was made at a moment of continued Japanese interest in Korean cultural imports, but also of cultural tensions regarding the same. Despite the prominence and successes of regional media flows and economies within East Asia, the very successes of such flows can also trigger or tap into broader transnational tensions and resentment. Basil Glynn and Jeongmee Kim note that "cultural tensions have been aroused by the export of Korean dramas to some receiving nations and Korean Wave drama has become something of a political 'hot potato' in Asian countries that have found this alternative to American cultural imperialism equally objectional" (40–1). That is to say, the transnational can serve as both an interruption or transcendence of the national, but also of its reassertion.

Despite the cultural frictions that can thus emerge alongside such transnational media flows, BL and other queer discourses are nevertheless accruing an increasingly strong transnational visibility both within East Asian media ecologies and globally. That is to say, the universe of gender-bending and queer-themed dramas has continued to expand rather dramatically. To further underscore the multidirectionality and intensity of such flows, we might also consider another gender-bending drama aired by SBS in 2012, *To the Beautiful You* (*Areumdawun geodaeege*). Whereas *You're Beautiful* started as a Korean drama before being adapted to other markets, *To the Beautiful You* first appeared on television in Taiwan in 2006, but was itself an adaptation

of the popular Japanese manga *Hanazakari no Kimitachi e*. Alongside its initial Taiwanese (2006) and subsequent Korean televisual iterations (2012), the Japanese story on which both were based was itself then adapted for Japanese television in 2007. In her analysis of *Hanazakari no Kimitachi e* and other Taiwanese idol-dramas, W. Michelle Wang notes that such "inter-Asian" or "trans-Asian" adaptations are "flourishing in spite of language differences … many audience members are likely to have seen multiple adaptations in different languages" (115). While *You're Beautiful* can't therefore be credited with initiating the larger East Asian circulation of gender-bending drama formats, it successfully integrated its gender-bending narrative into the East Asian pop universe, a shift in keeping with contemporaneous trends toward media convergence and cross-platform selling. And like the convoluted history of *Hanazakari no Kimitachi e* adaptations, *You're Beautiful* both draws on and contributes to a thriving traffic in queer transnational media and fandoms.

With social media platforms and online fandoms exerting an ever-greater influence on East Asian creative industries, the circulation and networking of queer culture continues to develop in new and interesting ways. In 2015, for example, the popular K-pop group EXO-K—a Korean-language boy band created in tandem with its Mandarin iteration, EXO-M—released a popular web drama (sixteen episodes, roughly fifteen minutes each) that similarly integrates slash/BL fanfic references, K-pop stardom, and a fangirl-focused storyline. Released on Naver TV Cast, an online network created by the Korean web portal company Naver, *EXO Next Door* underscores the technological, economic, cultural, and political shifts that continue to transform the circulation of queer-cultural forms and content within East Asia's media economies. Due in part to relaxed censorship regulations for online media, online broadcasting and OTT ("over-the-top," i.e., web-based, content) platforms have similarly opened up new ways to help queer/BL programs find interested audiences ("Reboot"). Recent examples include online BL broadcasts by LINE TV in Thailand (e.g., *Two Moons* or *SOTUS*), and by Choco TV in Taiwan (e.g., the *HIStory* web series). As one senior producer in CHOCOLABS's content department explains, "There's a particular issue in traditional broadcasting companies in Taiwan concerning copyright trading, so they carefully choose the topic of the production that limits their development. We (CHOCO TV) can cover those genres that they wanted to do but have not realized such

as homosexual, horror, and detective, etc." (Weng). In China's more massive mediascape, popular web dramas have also been used to explore, with varying degrees of regulative blowback, either fully BL storylines (as with *Addicted*) or fandom-reflexive programs with gender-bending and BL elements (such as *Proud of Love, My Girlfriend's Boyfriend,* and *It's Not Easy Being King*). While *You're Beautiful* is in no way solely or even primarily responsible for these subsequent developments, its successful exploitation of queer fandoms, reflexive pop-cultural pleasures, and online modalities nevertheless embodies and anticipates many of these continually evolving and happily growing trends. Paying greater attention to the pace, scale, and cultural complexity of these developments can in turn help adaptation studies better adapt to the emerging technologies, queer potentialities, and transnational cultural economies of contemporary networked culture.

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PART III

Queerer and Queerer: Promiscuity and Multiplicity

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CHAPTER 11

Queer Many Ways: Ulrike Ottinger's *Dorian Gray im Spiegel der Boulevardpresse* (1984)

Shannon Brownlee

Many theorists have proposed taxonomies of adaptation: Dudley Andrew, Linda Hutcheon, and Robert Stam are among the most notable. These may be applied productively to queer adaptations as well, but they also suggest that additional terms and theories may be needed to understand how an adaptation is queer or, more precisely, how it *adapts queerly*. Does it adapt a text about a same-sex relationship, make explicit a subtextual same-sex relationship in the adapted text, or change a character's gender to introduce a new same-sex relationship? Does it mingle queer histories into the fabric of the adapted texts, drawing on events such as Stonewall or the lives of queer figures such as Langston Hughes? Is it the work of a queer artist and/or does it become part of a canon of queer literature, theater, cinema, etc.? Derek Jarman's *The Garden* (1990) retells the stories of the Garden of Eden and the Crucifixion with a gay couple as the protagonists; this highly experimental film works in very different ways from Todd Haynes's big-budget *Carol* (2015), adapted from Patricia Highsmith's 1952 lesbian novel. Jarman is militant

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and psychologically alienating, queering a pillar of Western culture as an act of defiance, while Haynes is emotionally engaging and fetishistic, paying homage to a relatively recent work of explicitly queer fiction. Addressing such films outside of adaptation theory is important, but different insights may appear at the *intersection* of the terms "queer" and "adaptation."

The case study of this chapter is queer many ways. *Dorian Gray im Spiegel der Boulevardpresse* (Ulrike Ottinger 1984), known in English as *Dorian Gray in the Mirror of the Yellow Press*, is not its director's most accomplished or well-known work: despite its truly stunning and creative visual design, it is slow-paced, and although permeated by puns and a "sullen, abrasive black humor" (Perlmutter 168), it can be rather hard going at times. However, it truly shines when viewed as an *adaptation*, and especially as a *queer* adaptation, an adaptation that queers, that reaches out to a queer viewer, and that creates a queer space. It responds to the texts and histories it adapts—some of which are cornerstones of queer culture and some of which are not—with great imagination, intelligence, and variety. It is thus a rich exemplar of modes of queer adaptation and a testament to the potential coexistence, though not necessarily the compatibility, of those modes within a single text. Most obviously, the film's two main characters are female performers in masculine roles, though in very disparate ways. Less obviously, recent discussions of queer temporalities illuminate how it wrangles queerly with its adapted texts at the level of its narrative structure as well as characterization. Ultimately, its multifaceted and even contradictory modes show that, while queer adaptation is not a completely different beast from adaptation more generally, it brings desire and ambiguity into focus in a way that usefully contributes to adaptation discourse.

While no adaptation and adapted text exist in a vacuum, *Dorian Gray im Spiegel der Boulevardpresse* foregrounds *multi*textuality more than most. In its simplest terms, it is an adaptation of Oscar Wilde's 1891 novel, *The Picture of Dorian Gray*: it explores themes of artifice and representation and their relation to sexual desire as it charts the downfall of a wealthy, virtuous young man whom a mass media magnate leads astray and exploits as a scurrilous subject for newspapers and television broadcasts. The media magnate takes Dorian on a tour of the underworld, arranges for him to fall in love with an opera singer (the film's correlate to Wilde's Shakespearean actress, Sibyl Vane), and then has her murdered when her loyalty shifts decisively to Dorian. Dorian's

own funeral follows soon afterwards, although the film's double ending also shows him alive and well and murdering the media magnate, just as Wilde's Dorian stabs both the portraitist Basil Hallward and his own portrait. This summary, however, does not do justice to *Dorian Gray im Spiegel*'s heterogeneity, for the film explicitly adapts two texts, not one: it also adapts the series of *Dr. Mabuse* films that began with Fritz Lang's *Dr. Mabuse, der Spieler* in 1922 (itself an adaptation of the 1921 novel by Norbert Jacques) and that chronicle the crimes of manipulative villains who use advanced technologies of surveillance and persuasion to amass wealth. The naming of Ottinger's media magnate, Frau Dr. Mabuse, foregrounds this other textual history, and *Dorian Gray im Spiegel* makes specific visual references to the earlier films. *Dorian Gray im Spiegel* thus weaves multiplicity into its very fabric and proposes that one way of adapting queerly is to call into question the binary, monogamous relationship of adaptation to adapted text, instead opting for a polyamorous encounter among texts with different roles to play. While neither multitextuality nor polyamory is necessarily queer, this mode of adaptation may be an effective tool in the queer adaptation toolbox.

Two other threads that run throughout *Dorian Gray im Spiegel* are grounded in queer biographies rather than fiction. Wilde's own iconic status and persecution for gross indecency overdetermines his *Dorian Gray* novel, which was offered as evidence of his homosexuality during his legal hearings (Bristow 211–212; Cohen 3–4) despite the "notorious invisibility" (Bristow 204) of same-sex desire and practices in the novel. Same-sex relationships in *Dorian Gray im Spiegel* thus pay tribute to Wilde's life as well as the novel's subtext in a way that a more "faithful" adaptation may not. In addition, Ulrike Ottinger's own status as a feminist, lesbian filmmaker has guided audiences' interpretation of the film. Ottinger was first celebrated on the avant-garde, feminist, and queer[1] circuits with the female pirate film, *Madame X—Eine absolute Herrscherin* (1978), and with *Bildnis einer Trinkerin* (1979), often known in English as *Ticket of No Return*, a deconstruction of woman's to-be-looked-at-ness in a patriarchal visual economy. This auteurist thread is available only to those who know something of her work, but knowledgeable audiences of *Dorian Gray im Spiegel* recognized Ottinger's tendency to fuse source texts, as in her *Freak Orlando* (1981), a fusion of Tod Browning's *Freaks* (1932), and Virginia Woolf's *Orlando* (1928). While these biographical or auteurist threads are not adapted texts as such, they are also important interpretive elements and demonstrate the proximity

of queer *adaptation* to queer *authorship*. As multitextuality is not a *requirement* of queer adaptation, queer authorship is not a crucial mode but may be a powerful one.

The effect of this polyamorous, multitextual fusion of texts, lived experience, and authorship is expressed by the complexity of the film's postmodern aesthetics. Ottinger's authorial identity is substantially grounded in her remarkable audiovisual style, and *Dorian Gray im Spiegel* is an audiovisual collage that references all of its textual and historical antecedents. It brings together European artistic movements from Wilde's *fin de siècle* with 1920s modernism that evokes Mabuse's origin and wraps them up in a 1980s science fiction vision. At one moment, beeping communicators, synthesizer music, and shiny metal and plastic allude to Mabuse's propensity for cutting-edge technologies; the next minute, Dorian pounds on Andamana's neoclassical door in a spectacle more appropriate to a nineteenth-century romantic drama. Symptomatic of the tendency to fusion and cross-pollination, the design around Dorian situates him more in Mabuse's modernist period than Wilde's late nineteenth-century aestheticism: his house is a Bauhaus design and some of his costuming is reminiscent of Mayakovsky (Mueller 191). Other elements are less clearly related to the adapted texts but contribute to the postmodern collage effect: we spend a full twenty minutes watching a modernist opera staged on a beach and framed by a flat cardboard likeness of a proscenium arch with motifs by Gustave Moreau (Mueller 191). Throughout, the aestheticism associated with *The Picture of Dorian Gray* and Wilde's authorial persona is evident in the emphasis on glossy surfaces to such a degree that "the whole film is a celebration of materiality" (Mueller 192), and its slow pace allows the viewer to contemplate these surfaces, their auditory counterparts, and their textual and historical references at length. The eclecticism of the audiovisuals demonstrates the value the film places on multitextuality rather than the one-to-one relationship to Wilde's text.

Dorian Gray

Perhaps the most complex audiovisual element of the film is Dorian himself. Alice Kuzniar states that the "major question this film raises is … how to read the opaque signs of Dorian's gender" (146). The character appears to be understood as male by the other characters within the diegesis: they use the male pronoun, and Frau Dr. Mabuse refers to him

as a "beautiful and somewhat dull and inexperienced young man." His narrative position is also conventionally masculine as the romantic subject to Andamana's romantic object. Her thinly sketched character does little more than answer his desire for her, and she dies so that Dorian can fulfill his heroic narrative role by killing Frau Dr. Mabuse. However, Dorian is played by 1960s supermodel Veruschka von Lehndorff, who is perhaps best known to film audiences as the visual object of the heterosexual male photographer—and audience—in a five-minute, sexually charged photo shoot in *Blow-Up* (Michelangelo Antonioni, 1966), a sequence iconic enough to appear on the film's poster and to have been spoofed in *Austin Powers: International Man of Mystery* (Jay Roach, 1997). Dorian is represented through conflicting audiovisual signifiers. On the one hand, as seen in the film still (Fig. 11.1), von Lehndorff is athletically built and consistently costumed in men's shirts, ties, and jackets in a way that obscures the gender we assign to the performer; on the other hand, Dorian's upper lip and eyebrows are darkened in a



Fig. 11.1 Dorian Gray (Veruschka v. Lehndorff). Context: *Dorian Gray in the Mirror of the Yellow Press*, Berlin, 1983 © Ulrike Ottinger. Dorian reads of his own death in the final scene

non-naturalistic way that obviously owes more to make-up than testosterone. Von Lehndorff's voice performance is contralto, but when she/Dorian appears in the opera sequence, the role is voiced by a tenor. All of these signifiers are further complicated by the fact that von Lehndorff is not a trained actress, and her woodenness exemplifies Brecht's arguments about the distancing effects of nonprofessional acting. These narrative and audiovisual cues give Dorian's gender an ambiguity that arises both from the film text and from its varied modes of adaptation and relationships to other textual references.

There are several ways of interpreting these cues. As Roswitha Mueller does, one may posit a binary distinction between femaleness on the side of the performer and maleness on the side of the performed, as confirmed by the gender pronouns invariably applied to each (188). Alternatively, although Ruth Perlmutter implicitly posits such a binary, she insists on encompassing two genders in her discussion of the "playboy/girl" (174); Chris Straayer uses a similar technique (ctd. in Kuzniar 152). Kuzniar, however, proposes mutually exclusive interpretations. While she is most invested in a reading of Dorian as a lesbian who mocks and mimicks masculinity, she also notes that Wilde's novel may invite an interpretation of him as a gay man (150). When I first saw the film, I saw the cinematic Dorian as a mannish lesbian strikingly similar to the protagonist of Radclyffe Hall's *The Well of Loneliness* (1928) as analyzed by Teresa de Lauretis, a woman whose masculine signifiers operate as fetish objects through which the lesbian disavows the loss of the *female* body—a body she has lost by having a phallic or masculine body. On the other hand, today it may be most natural and obvious to view Dorian as a transgender man. Finally, he may be a cisgender man whose feminine signifiers are detectable only to the film's audience, or as a cisgender woman for whom drag signifies something other than a fetishistic disavowal of loss. The possibilities are limited only by one's imagination and desire. Although not specific to queer *adaptation*, its queer *work* resides partly in the way this film extends the configurations of gender and sexuality one can imagine; however, in this way it echoes the ambiguity of Wilde's own novella.

This multiplicity of sexual and especially gender identity is not simply a feature of the film, but also one of its primary modes of spectatorial fantasy, desire, and pleasure and thus its power as a queer adaptation. Kuzniar argues that the contradictions in the construction of Dorian's

gender—and the film's denial of spectatorial mastery over the mystery of this gender—are one of its central pleasures:

> Ottinger knows even better than [Frau] Dr. Mabuse that eroticism lies in the play between secrecy and disclosure. As a personal, rather burlesque confession of such blindness yet also captivation: when I first saw the film, I entered the theater with no forewarning as to what it was about. I missed the clue in the initial credits that its title character was played by a woman. Thus I was profoundly disturbed every time his/her image appeared on the screen. I was confused by the appearance of the five-o'clock shadow and anxiously looked for the tell-tale swelling of the breasts, which I didn't find. … Veruschka von Lehndorff aroused a scopic fascination that was insatiable. (152)

Kuzniar's confession is highly illuminating. She writes that "*visible* contradictions in Dorian's gender are erased" (154, emphasis added), but she was clearly open to the possibility of non-normative gender performance even if she could not pin it to specific audiovisual cues. This challenge is, for her, the great value of this film: "Dorian's androgyny functions anamorphotically, as a stain that both provokes yet ultimately blocks one's vision. His body and dress are a constant reminder of the viewer's scotoma. His queerness functions as a scintillating surface or screen behind which the viewer cannot see" (152). The unresolved ambiguity is not simply a dry fact but an invitation to engage passionately with the text.

Kuzniar's queer response to a queer adaptation demonstrates the importance of both conscious knowledge of adapted texts and the role of spectatorial fantasy and desire in the interpretation of adaptations. Hutcheon rightly notes that the audience's prior knowledge is crucial to the status of an adaptation as such (120–22). Kuzniar's response affirms this observation and also adds another dimension to it—a dimension that queer adaptation is particularly good at illuminating. Not only *knowledge* but also *fantasy* and *desire* permeate the reception of an adaptation—passionate relationships to both the adaptation and the adapted texts. As queer viewers have often read texts against the grain and identified obliquely, reading queer *adaptations* and reading adaptations queerly may amplify this effect.

Frau Dr. Mabuse

The figure of Frau Dr. Mabuse is a more straightforwardly gendered character than Dorian and presents a different type of relationship to *Dorian Gray im Spiegel*'s adapted texts. Frau Dr. Mabuse is played by Delphine Seyrig, who is perhaps now best known to audiences from *Jeanne Dielman, 23 Quai du commerce, 1080 Bruxelles* (Chantal Akerman, 1975), although some may remember her most fondly as Elizabeth Bathory in the cult lesbian vampire film, *Daughters of Darkness* (Harry Kümel, 1971). In *Dorian Gray im Spiegel*, she is, unlike Dorian, unequivocally a cisgender woman, despite her male namesake and exercise of traditionally masculine power: she is a "Frau" assigned the female pronoun and, as we see in an image from the "Press Ball" (Fig. 11.2), she is glamorously made up, costumed in skirts, and wearing pearls, in contrast with the more ambiguous design of Dorian's costume, make-up, and hair. However, insofar as we read this Dorian as a female object of



Fig. 11.2 Press Ball (Delphine Seyrig, Veruschka v. Lehndorff) a.o. Context: *Dorian Gray in the Mirror of the Yellow Press*, Berlin, 1983 © Ulrike Ottinger. Dorian (left) and Frau Dr. Mabuse (center) embody very different constructions of gender

Frau Dr. Mabuse's considerable drive, this gender construction retains the voyeuristically and sadistically homoerotic dynamic among Wilde's Dorian, his corrupter and his portraitist. That said, Frau Dr. Mabuse's most important function in the film is to pose a primarily feminist rather than queer question about how women may assume phallic power.

Although apparently more straightforward than Dorian, in her narrative function and speech, Frau Dr. Mabuse is a fusion of both Wilde's Dorian and the *Mabuse* films and the histories around them. She is partly an authorial figure: she refers to her plans to publicize Dorian's ruination as a "serialized novel," which *The Picture of Dorian Gray* and the novel of *Dr. Mabuse, der Spieler* both originally were; and she uses both French terms—*réaliser* and *mettre en scène*—for directing a film, thus following in the footsteps of Fritz Lang as well as other directors of the *Mabuse* films and the many *Dorian Gray* film adaptations. Kuzniar notes that she is also both Basil Hallward, the portrait painter in Wilde's novel, and its Lord Henry Wotton, who "plays up to Dorian's egocentrism and creates the reactions he wants to see in him" (149). The power of Lord Henry's "beautiful voice" (Wilde 40), his instrument of beguilement, is transposed to the screen not only in Seyrig's own famously melodious tones but also in the fact that she switches apparently randomly between German, English and French. These are the native languages of the original Mabuse, Ottinger and Lang, Wilde and his Dorian, and Seyrig herself; they also evoke Wilde's legendary linguistic wit, Lang's working languages before and after fleeing Nazi Germany, and the fact that only the French-language version of the second *Mabuse* film was available for decades because the Nazis banned the German-language version (Kalat, "Three Faces"). Since none of the other characters seems to notice this vocal idiosyncrasy, it operates as an extradiegetic signifier analogous to the opacity of Dorian's gender signifiers. In her language and narrative position, Frau Dr. Mabuse adapts several male characters and thus embodies the polyamory or multitextuality of this adaptation while also perhaps making a feminist point that one woman can do the job of many men.

Fittingly, this polyamory indicates that fidelity and infidelity in adaptation are not always mutually exclusive. Mueller states that a female Dr. Mabuse is "provocative" (180), a term that is often code for "unfaithful" in adaptation discourse. However, *Mabuse* novelist Norbert Jacques's 1930 sequel, which only ever reached draft stage, featured a female villain succeeding to Mabuse's legacy (Kalat, Commentary); although

Lang ultimately took the story in other directions for *Das Testament des Dr. Mabuse* (1933), Ottinger's film fulfills the "original" artist's intentions. Second, because Lang's 1933 sequel establishes the name "Dr. Mabuse" as an explicitly shifting signifier attached to a new figure in each film, any new Mabuse both extends the legacy and takes it in new directions. *Dorian Gray im Spiegel* can, from a certain point of view, be seen as simply the next installment in the adaptable Mabuse structure, although its queerness, its art-house aesthetics, and its female-centered universe would make it almost unrecognizable to the more conventional among Mabuse fans. Frau Dr. Mabuse and the film's relation to the other Mabuse films cannot be reduced to a binarism of fidelity and infidelity, likeness and difference. As with polyamorous multitextuality, this refusal of binary textual relationships is not necessarily queer, but is potentially very queer-positive.

The film's first dialogue scene, in which Frau Dr. Mabuse outlines her plans for Dorian to her coterie of male editors, encapsulates the complexity of the adaptation's relation to its adapted texts. It is a direct visual reference to a scene early in *Die 1000 Augen des Dr. Mabuse* (Fritz Lang, 1960) in which the camera slowly recedes from the Chair of the meeting, revealing more attendees seated around a table placed perpendicular to the frame. Mueller reads the scene in *Dorian Gray im Spiegel* as unequivocal statements of Frau Dr. Mabuse's power (186), but if we compare it with *1000 Augen*, which Mueller does not, it is more ambivalent. It begins with a close-up on Frau Dr. Mabuse's reflection in the mirror-like surface of the table before tilting up to frame her face, while the corresponding close-up in *1000 Augen* is of a book; thus, the female subject of speech and capitalist power is pictured, albeit self-reflexively, as the fetishized object of the cinematic gaze.[2] The shot in *Dorian Gray im Spiegel* is much longer in duration and more formal than that in *1000 Augen*, which emphasizes the fact that as the camera moves back to encompass speakers around the table, the figure at the head of the table becomes smaller, more remote, even belittled. The final speaker, who counters Frau Dr. Mabuse's corporate sensationalism with an appeal to journalistic ethics, is especially significant: this Dr. Spiegelwelt (Dr. "Mirror World" or "World of Mirrors") is a Dr. who has lost his Mabuse to the castrating woman at the head of the table, but his name is reflected in both the title of Ottinger's film and in the name Frau Dr. Mabuse gives her plans for Dorian: Operation Mirror. Frau Dr. Mabuse mocks this "little doctor," as she calls him, but seems discomfited and haunted by him,

and his words are geared to elicit the empathy of an avant-garde cinema audience. Her power, it seems, is both guaranteed by this vestige of the earlier, male Mabuse, and also compromised by it. This concurrence of guarantee and compromise might be a metaphor for an adaptation's relation to its adapted text or texts, an ambivalence that is perhaps particularly keen when an adaptation changes the gender and/or sexuality of characters.

Endings

Dorian Gray im Spiegel's double ending is a prime example of the way the film operates in the field of tension between pairs, an ambivalence that echoes the film's allegiance to the two main adapted texts. The two storylines of the ending begin to split near the end when Dorian is given poison and thus, we assume, sentenced to death. However, the death we witness is Frau Dr. Mabuse's, when Dorian—alive and well—stabs her ironically but fatally with a retracting-blade knife. This is immediately followed by Dorian's funeral, attended in great state by Frau Dr. Mabuse; like Wilde's eponymous protagonist, when Dorian murders the apparatus that reflects him, he precipitates his own death. Then Dorian himself interrupts this large-scale media event, tearing up in a red sports car and running over the mourners. And in the next and final scene, Dorian himself reads a newspaper bearing the headline "Dorian Gray: The Details of his Death" (see Fig. 11.1). By moving back and forth between the deaths and victories of the two main characters, the film refuses to decide between two possibilities and performs on a narrative level the kind of ambiguity it has already maintained in the signification of Dorian's gender, the fidelity/infidelity of casting a Frau as Dr. Mabuse, and its elaboration of multiple adapted texts and histories.

When the film was released, this double ending was viewed as a counter-patriarchal strategy. Mueller argues that Ottinger's emphasis on causality, greater here than in her previous films, is an "ironic imitation of Fritz Lang's tightly organized plot structure" (180) that Ottinger evokes only in order to contrast it with nonlinear storytelling as well as the "*mater*iality, surface, plurality, process, aspects which, like nonlinear temporalities have been coded as feminine in our culture" (181). While this is compelling, recent work on queer temporalities also inspires a reevaluation of both the double ending and aspects of the film's aesthetics. In particular, the film resonates with Elizabeth Freeman's concepts,

in *Time Binds: Queer Temporalities, Queer Histories*, of chrononormativity, temporal drag, and erotohistoriography.

The refusal of temporal linearity in *Dorian Gray im Spiegel* is both an avant-garde gesture and disruption of what Freeman calls chrononormativity, a conception of time as linear, singular, and oriented toward progress. It encompasses both the heteronormative narrative of reproductive futurism and also narratives such as coming out, development, and liberation important for queer and other social justice movements and theories (xxii). Freeman notes that the film and video medium itself constructs time in this forward-moving way by organizing viewers into a normativized temporal experience as the images unfurl (xviii). However, while narrative art forms often exploit this linearity, they may also attempt to negate it, as both avant-garde and popular work such as the films of Christopher Nolan attest. And, fundamentally, mechanical and digital images always disrupt linear time by wrenching past events into the present (xviii; 21–23). *Dorian Gray im Spiegel* works against the linearity of the film medium throughout, with its extremely slow pace and its digression into the twenty-minute opera sequence as well as its double ending, and thus refutes the forward momentum and closure not only of the Mabuse thrillers but also of Wilde's novel. And yet it does so inconsistently. The story of Andamana and Dorian's relationship is told in a relatively linear fashion, and the last section of the film, up until the two timelines split, is driven by what Mueller calls a linear, "mock thriller" (180) form of narration as Frau Dr. Mabuse seeks to recover the negative of a photo in which she is caught constructing rather than merely documenting Dorian's story. Only after the film teases the audience with linearity do the timelines split. Importantly, it is the ultimate confrontation between Dorian and Frau Dr. Mabuse—the central figures of adaptation, the namesakes of the adapted texts—that gives rise to this extreme nonlinearity of time, rather than the more straightforwardly romantic relationship between Dorian and Andamana. The film's refutation of chrononormativity is more rooted in the dialogue it creates between two disparate adapted texts than in the story—even the queered story—of one of these texts.

One of the specific strategies that disrupts chrononormativity is drag. Freeman writes that *Time Binds* began with the insight that "drag can be seen as the act of plastering the body with outdated rather than just cross-gendered accessories, whose resurrection seems to exceed the axis of gender and begins to talk about, and indeed talk back to, history"

(xxi). If, following Freeman's understanding of drag, we see Dorian Gray as an excess "of the signifier 'history' rather than of 'woman' or 'man'" (62)—or of "history" *as well as* of "woman" and "man"—then the palimpsest that includes a Mayakovsky costume, dandyism, non-naturalistic masculinizing make-up, and von Lehndorff's famous body not only speaks to gender ambiguity but also foregrounds the endurance of the past in the present. Drag is not merely one aspect of the way the overdetermined figure signifies; it is the foundation of the way the figure engages with the past, with adapted texts and other extratextual references.

Finally, the film is distanced from temporal linearity and singularity from the outset by its eclectic mise-en-scène, and the double ending can be seen as the culmination of this tendency. This form of historiography is "distinct from the desire for a fully present past, a restoration of bygone times. Erotohistoriography does not write the lost object into the present so much as encounter it already in the present, by treating the present itself as hybrid" (95). Rather than an attempt to replicate past styles, erotohistoriography emphasizes the visceral, "bodying rather than minding the gap between then and now" (111). The sumptuous visual style of *Dorian Gray im Spiegel* indeed bodies the gap between then and now, its fetishistic, referential costumes and sets counterbalancing its cooler, more cerebral Brechtian tendencies toward distanciation. Although Freeman does not address adaptation theory, this concept of the present as hybrid, as passionately attached to the past it re-embodies, may be a productive way of thinking about the enduring force of the adapted text in the adaptation—a force that is part of the erotics or pleasure of the adaptation.

Dorian Gray im Spiegel der Boulevardpresse is the queerest adaptation I have ever encountered—queer in many ways—and yet it contains no strategies that are inconceivable either in other adaptations or in queer texts that are not adaptations. That is, it does not attest to anything absolutely unique to queer adaptation as such. However, queer adaptation brings certain questions and concerns to the fore in a way that contributes substantially to our understanding of adaptation and deepens our understanding of how queer works of art respond to artistic and lived histories. The importance of multitextuality, of ambivalent relations to the adapted texts, and of forms of queer temporality including temporal drag emphasize a sense of duplicity, of doubleness, which is the core of adaptation and its ongoing dialogue with adapted texts and with the past.

Notes

1. Although Ottinger is out, she has "expressed no interest whatsoever" in being identified as lesbian—which she compares to "being put in a little drawer"—and has "rejected in equal measure the idea" that she produces lesbian films (Flinn 177). Nonetheless, the perception of queerness of both her and her films is a key part of her authorial persona and work. In fact, *Dorian Gray im Spiegel* has often not been seen as a lesbian film, although, with Kuzniar, I see this to be an "unfortunate" oversight that the label "queer" may recuperate (19).
2. Ottinger's *Bildnis einer Trinkerin* is almost entirely about such reflections of the female image. For substantial feminist analyses of this film, see Hansen and Silverman.

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CHAPTER 12

Blood Doubles: A Renegotiation of Sheridan le Fanu's *Carmilla* on Film

Shelby Wilson

As a novella whose claim to fame is the introduction of the first literary female vampire, Sheridan le Fanu's *Carmilla* (1872) has consequently received extensive scholarly as well as popular attention. The story, a frame tale initially narrated—but not completed—by an unnamed male publisher and subsequently continued by the protagonist Laura, details the circumstances surrounding Laura's relationship with the vampire Carmilla Karnstein. Alternately read as an example of exploitative lesbian literature that pathologizes Laura's sexual attraction to Carmilla and as a subversive, inherently feminist text that dismantles phallogocentric structures of meaning through the women's reclamation of their bodies, *Carmilla* has not only spawned a variety of critical scholarship but also generated controversy.[1]

Although le Fanu's novella continues to generate significant scholarly criticism, the same can certainly not be said of the veritable flood of *Carmilla* adaptations that have been produced on film, most prominently during the sexploitation craze of the 1960s and '70s.

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For while scholars seem quite willing to pen academic analyses of a "serious" literary work that is accepted in the larger canon of late nineteenth-century Anglophone literature, *Carmilla*'s numerous film adaptations tend to elicit outright condemnation from feminist critics who simultaneously champion the original tale. As a result, it is often the perceived failure of film adaptations to translate what *Carmilla*'s admirers, like Nina Auerbach, see as the novella's representation of "an elusive female community" headed by a "sharing, individualized vampire," that has warranted their ostracism (40, 46). In contrast to positive readings of the novella such as this, *Carmilla* film adaptations tend to elicit criticism as texts that cater to prurient male interests, demonize lesbian relationships, and revel in gratuitous violence.

Theorists who are invested in the possibilities of the queer vampire as a resistant textual nomad, while acknowledging the subversive potential inherent in the figure of the lesbian vampire, often tend to write off Carmilla on the silver screen as nothing more than an excuse for male titillation. For example, Auerbach declares British horror outlet Hammer Productions' *The Vampire Lovers* (Roy Ward Baker, 1970) to be merely an opportunity to parade about an abundance of "interchangeable stuffed breasts," and Sue Ellen Case grumbles that in Harry Kümel's *Daughters of Darkness* (1971) the lesbian vampiress is portrayed as an "oozing, French dessert cheese" (Auerbach 58; Case 15). While Andrea Weiss recognizes the lesbian vampire as a destabilizing force that questions heteronormative cultural order, neither she nor Bonnie Zimmerman appear to be as concerned with the image of the lesbian vampire so much as the lesbian in general. Images of violence and nudity in *Carmilla* adaptations are thus interpreted as direct attacks against lesbian subjectivity; Zimmerman even goes so far as to argue that the bite should go on behind closed doors. By claiming that "the function of the lesbian vampire is to contain attraction between women within the … boundaries of sexual violence," Zimmerman does not consider the ways in which some of the films she discusses, including the dreaded sexploitation flick, complicate themes of violence and nudity even as they participate in a voyeuristic framework that objectifies female subjects (381–2).

Even a cursory overview of the criticism available on the lesbian vampire film in general, and *Carmilla* adaptations in particular, makes it strikingly obvious that only a specific type of *Carmilla* film is deemed worthy of prolonged analysis.[2] Generally, these are either commercially

successful films such as *Vampire Lovers*—credited with kicking off the general boom in lesbian vampire films in the '70s[3]—or more academic-friendly, artsy fare such as *Daughters of Darkness* or *Blood and Roses* (Roger Vadim, 1960). Despite the frequency of these citations, there are quite a few low-budget, lowbrow *Carmilla* adaptations that, while perhaps mentioned offhand, never seem to warrant sustained scrutiny or critical analysis. Although the critical precedent is to brush off many of these films as simply not worth watching, they should be reconsidered not only as possible sites of feminist recuperation, but as an integral part of the *Carmilla* franchise which, when taken as a whole, is noteworthy in that it spans almost a century and carries the responsibility for perpetuating the fantasy of the queer female vampire on film.

As a series, *Carmilla* films are unusual in that the only thread that ties them together is the character of Carmilla herself. Unlike more mainstream horror franchises such as the *A Nightmare on Elm Street* films or the *Halloween* series, *Carmilla* films do not represent a continuous, mostly linear narrative that follows the same character (often played by the same actor) through a series of semi-connected stories. Instead, Carmilla-as-character becomes a floating signifier that haunts her particular subgenre of horror, a personage whose basic identifiers—lesbianism and vampirism—remain constant but who otherwise shape-shifts to suit the needs of any particular film. She does not have a specific "look" and is played by a variety of actresses who do not attempt to stay true to either le Fanu's narrative or earlier film productions—although they most certainly feed off them, as it were. Consequently, *Carmilla* adaptations, like the character of the female vampire they portray, participate in a queer reproductivity, one that continues to generate doubles of itself that never quite manage to line up as twins.[4] Rather than follow a continuous, linear storyline, *Carmilla* films restlessly circle around the problem of the female vampire and how to depict her and her desire on screen. With this in mind, I ask not why *Carmilla* films either do or do not manage to accurately reproduce what some feminist critics perceive as the "original spirit" of le Fanu's novella, but why they continue to be made at all.[5] What is it about the character of the queer female vampire that has necessitated a cultural repetition compulsion that demands her presence on the silver screen again and again? *Carmilla* films, which constitute their own subgenre of horror, thus participate in an uncanny seriality that, while it follows the exploits of a queer character, is also queer in form.

In order to investigate this question, I read a particular subset of *Carmilla* adaptations that have perhaps generated the most distaste among scholars interested in the lesbian vampire on film: those in the mode of European horror. As an unstable filmic category that spans horror, (s)exploitation, trash cinema, and even softcore porn, Euro horror flicks tick all the boxes on the bad-for-feminism checklist. In fact, the genre has been considered so anathema to feminist politics that Tania Modleski has gone so far as to claim that, "as a rule, [exploitation cinema] was far more misogynist and totally violent in its treatment of women than even the standard hardcore pornographic films" ("Women's Cinema" 49). Rather than read *Carmilla* adaptations as simply exacerbating the "problems" some critics find embedded in le Fanu's novella—voyeurism, demonization of homosexuality, pandering to notions of female hysteria—I reconsider Euro horror adaptations of *Carmilla* not only as productive sites for feminist recuperation but also as valuable contributors to the *Carmilla* franchise that have played an integral part in ensuring that the image of the female vampire remains onscreen.

Ironically, the very qualities that make *Carmilla* tenable for feminist recuperation—its excess, narrative discontinuity, and collapse of signification—are those held against Euro horror to condemn it as academically unreadable. *Carmilla*-inspired Euro horror/sexploitation films carry all the calling cards of the genre: nonlinear plot progression, borrowing/reusing material from other (usually more successful) films, "bad" acting, and nontraditional editing techniques. Rather than read these films as too "low" for academia, what happens when the very qualities that supposedly damn them are recuperated as characteristics that not only "queer" traditional cinematic narrative but also create interstices for resistant viewing? For these films are doubly subversive. Not only do they queer filmic form, but, by stealing Carmilla's name while simultaneously abandoning any faithfulness to the "original" narrative, they also queer the story they purport to tell.

While Euro horror has gone largely undertheorized in academia, there are two main approaches to reading it and other forms of film regarded as "low." One is epitomized in the paracinematic approach of Jeffrey Sconce, who argues that watching trash film such as Euro horror is tantamount to political resistance against mainstream cinema, and that it forces a reading strategy of ironicized distance. The second is exemplified in the work of feminist horror critics such as Carol Clover, Linda Williams, Isabel Pinedo, and Barbara Creed, who all tend to focus on

viewer identification and affect. According to these feminist critics, low genres such as Euro horror, because they revel in excess, abandon plotlines, and seem to care little for establishing a distinct cinematic space in which to tell their story (thin as it may be), simply do not "mean" at all except in relation to the ways they manage to elicit affective responses from spectators. Low genres' focus on producing bodily reactions rather than intellectual stimulation, these critics argue, means that there is no space for sustained, critical close reading of the films themselves. The primacy of these two approaches, which are certainly effective methods for thinking critically about horror film, has also had the perhaps unintentional side effect of foreclosing the possibility of close reading Euro horror and sexploitation films *as narratives* with textual value.

Some of Euro and mainstream horror's less celebrated tendencies—superficiality, nonlinear narrative, nonsynchronous image and sound, blurring of high/low cultural distinctions, and lack of originality—have also led to the genres' tentative postmodern recuperation. For example, Joan Hawkins concedes that low genres such as trash film and exploitation cinema "can be analyzed for serious content and purpose" (6). Pinedo argues that the horror film as postmodern film presents an "unstable [world] in which traditional (dichotomous) categories break down, boundaries blur, institutions fall into question, enlightenment narratives collapse, the inevitability of progress crumbles, and the master status of the universal (read male, white, monied, heterosexual) subject deteriorates" (11). Finally, in a move that extends Pinedo's definition to Euro horror, Ian Olney claims that the genre's tendency to "stage violent disruptions of the everyday world, transgress and violate boundaries, throw into question the validity of rationality, and repudiate narrative closure" mark it as postmodern (49). These qualities of Euro horror—and, I argue, specifically exploitation cinema—not only can lay the foundation for a recuperation of the genre by feminist spectators, but can also act as entry points for critical close readings. The ability to close read exploitation film, however, is often assumed to be a task doomed to failure. Even when presented with a stylistic choice made by the director that suggests an opportunity for resistant reading—against the general claims of the genre's sexism, homophobia, sadism, etc.—critics will credit the moment to (or bill it as a side-effect of) low budget or incompetence.[6] When faced with judgments such as these, a critical close reading of Euro horror/exploitation films that is not geared toward audience identification or affective response seems a necessary first step

in reassessing the potential of this troubled genre. And what better performer for this task than the queer female vampire, a character who, much like the genre of Euro horror itself, disrupts narrative continuity, revels in somatic excess, troubles normalized (phallogocentric) structures of looking and language, and, for reasons unknown, keeps coming back from the dead?

As a horror subgenre whose heroine refuses to stay in her coffin, *Carmilla* films have come to exhibit to a high degree what can be said of horror film in general: "It talks about itself" (Clover 168). Despite the fact that all *Carmilla* adaptations take the same source material as their inspiration, the films, considered as a group, never quite manage to get their stories straight. Consequently, like the genre to which they belong, among the *Carmilla* films there is "no original, no real or right text, but only variants," for "the meaning of the individual example lies outside itself" (Clover 11). *Carmilla* films could thus be said to participate in their own sort of queer reproductivity as a series of narratives—most of them inconclusive—that try but never quite succeed in pinning down the image of the female vampire. Although scholars have argued that *Carmilla* films are characterized by a "linear plot progression that ends with [the female vampire's] destruction and natural order reaffirmed," I argue that the *Carmilla* narrative, through its cultural repetition, keeps the feminine desire it depicts open and malleable (Weiss 27; see also Baker 557–61). For if, as Mulvey argues, phallocentrism "depends on the image of the castrated woman to give order and meaning to its world," then the inconclusiveness of these narratives—for many conclude with the Carmilla character still "alive" and biting—their failure at representing the satisfactorily castrated woman (or of managing to fetishize her), means the desire of the female vampire manages to continue reaching, grasping, searching for a mode of representability that lies outside of the hegemonic parameters of "order and meaning" (803). In short, if the female vampire did not somehow manage to escape celluloid representation, why the need for her repeated on-screen appearances? Taken as a group, the films act as multiples of the body of Carmilla herself, a body occupied by multiple actresses that collectively escapes signification despite individual attempts to render it static and stable. Even more provocative in this context are the films in which the female vampire is not destroyed by story's end, and her desire threatens to escape the boundaries proscribed by the space of the screen.

Female Vampire (1973), which closes on the image of its Carmilla character, Irina Karlstein (Lina Romay), walking alone through the woods, is one such film. Directed by exploitation superstar Jesús "Jess" Franco, it follows the vampiric Countess as she returns to her ancestral home of Madeira and takes up residence at a local resort. In a pornographic twist on the usual bloodsucking gimmick, Irina feeds on her partners' sexual fluids at their moment of climax and thus sucks their lives away. Unsurprisingly, this leads to a lot of failed relationships, but it also creates a film whose structure imitates contemporary feature-length porn flicks that, like *Deep Throat* (Gerard Damiano, 1972), are centered around the problem of a woman's sexual satisfaction (Williams, *Hardcore* 110). However, unlike its pornographic counterparts, *Female Vampire* concludes without Irina ever having found a partner who can give her as much pleasure as she can bestow upon them. Unlike the typical depiction of vampire bloodlust, Irina's desire does not figure into her feedings. It is only after her partner has expired—in the throes of orgasmic ecstasy—that she is able to make a space for her own pleasure through necrophilia. For Irina, sustained, reciprocal desire is impossible, and she mourns it: "I earnestly wish an end would come to this bloody race that I am forced to run on this earth through the ages. Alas, I am a prisoner of the curse that weighs heavily on the Karlsteins…Why has my soul so much the need of peace and love when it cannot obtain it?" As the film progresses and Irina moves from victim to victim in a wardrobe of white crocheted pool cover-ups, flowing black negligees, and knee-high leather boots, she is pursued by the police, who assume her crimes to be the work of a sadistic madman; Dr. Roberts, the medical examiner; Dr. Orloff, a sort of mad scientist who lusts after the possibilities Irina offers for access to the world of the supernatural; and Baron Von Rathony, a casual tourist/occultist and Irina's eventual love interest.

To put it bluntly, *Female Vampire* is a messy piece of work. Rife with the characteristics commonly attributed to Euro horror in order to denigrate it (e.g., "bad" acting, even worse dubbing, seemingly unnecessary cutaways and edits) as well as Franco's less celebrated trademarks (the genital zoom being the most egregious offense), it nevertheless manages to utilize these traits in a manner that makes the film receptive to feminist recuperation. To begin, narrative continuity and expectation are always already thrown askew due to the number of titles associated with the film. In addition, there are also three distinct cuts: *Erotikill* (straight horror in which Irina sucks blood instead of sexual fluids); *The Loves of Irina* or *La*

Comtesse aux seins nus (*The Bare Breasted Countess*; softcore porn); and *Les Avaleuses* (*The Swallowers*; hardcore porn). *Female Vampire*, a title that I assume was tacked on by the distribution company that made the film available on home video, only adds to the confusion. Consequently, just as *Female Vampire*'s loosely adapted plot plays with *Carmilla* as "origin" story, the multiple cuts of the film and excessive number of titles work together to create a series of uncanny doubles in place of any singular, reliable narrative. Although le Fanu's novella is the presumed point of origin for both the Carmilla character and the story that surrounds her, *Female Vampire* and its variants lay waste to the idea of a "true" or "authentic" original. Their textual play, in which storylines feed (bleed) into each other but never merge, is also constitutive of the female vampire as a character who is closely associated with the powers of disease and contagion. In short, Franco's filmmaking, much like the postmodern and the *Carmilla* story in general, "operates on the principles of disruption, transgression, undecidability and uncertainty" (Pinedo 17). This lack of narrative certainty, where viewers of the film discuss scenes that they perceive as having been added or discarded, does not stop at the category of the film as a whole but manages to worm its way into the narrative structure itself, opposing linearity, cause and effect, and authorial intent.

Like Franco's previous two lesbian vampire films, *Vampyros Lesbos* (1971) and *La Fille de Dracula* (*Dracula's Daughter*, 1972), *Female Vampire*'s central concern is with femininity (and vampirism) as a cultural performance based on societal expectations. Throughout the film, these expectations are enforced primarily by men but also by the public at large who treat Irina as a sort of tabloid celebrity whose family's sordid past makes her a prime target for interviews. In the case of both Orloff and Von Rathony, Irina comes to represent a gateway to the supernatural, an undefined and fluid realm of pleasure where the male subject may lose his sense of self. Their viewpoints, coupled with Irina's explicitly sexual means of vampirism, make it quite easy to interpret Irina as representative of the passageway to a pre-subjective, pre-symbolic realm; her body, with its killer mouth, is clearly constitutive of "the abyss, the monstrous vagina, the origin of all life threatening to reabsorb what it once birthed" (Creed, "Horror" 54). To add more fuel to this fire, Irina is mute—the only dialogue we hear from her are voice-over style internal monologues. Irina's nearly complete disassociation from language not only serves to highlight her carnality—she "talks" with her body—but also acts as yet another link between herself and a romanticized realm of (exclusively

male) pre-subject formation and reconnection with the mother. As a result, the main tension in the film is caused not by Irina's vampirism but by the tug of war between herself and characters like Dr. Orloff over who gets control of her body.

Irina's main love interest in the film, Baron Von Rathony (Jack Taylor), does not directly interact with Irina until about halfway through the narrative. However, this does not stop Franco from treating us to quick and seemingly pointless cutaways to him that begin within the first ten minutes of the film. Within these strange inserts, we see Von Rathony reading from a tourist book on Madeira aimed at the casual occultist, writing in his journal, looking out to sea, and, in one particularly mysterious scene, going about his morning ablutions in the nude. While these repetitive cuts to Von Rathony may appear unnecessary and burdensome to the advancement of the narrative, they can also be read as an extension of the weight of male expectation concerning Irina and the figure of the female vampire in general.

In the first of these unexplained cutaways, we move from Irina's murder of a local livestock farmer to Von Rathony relaxing and writing in his journal. In a voice-over meant to mimic his entry, Von Rathony tells us that it is the twenty-second of February. We quickly cut from him to Irina riding in her town car. In a repetition of what we have just heard from Von Rathony, Irina also tells us in journalistic, voice-over narration, "Today is the twenty-second of February, and after only a few hours of my being in Madeira, I have already killed a man." However, much like the open-ended frame tale structure found in *Carmilla*, we never cut back to Von Rathony in order to close the narrative circuit begun by his journal entry. Instead, we follow Irina back to the resort and see her preparing to sunbathe on the pool deck. It is only after this that we cut back to Von Rathony reading from his paperback on Madeira's occult history, a sort of textbook on "Vampire Dating 101" which convinces him that Irina will act as his portal to the supernatural beyond: "It's from those signs that you will recognize the supreme moment, and you will know that you will cross the gates of a world of great mystery: that world to which we all of us aspire." With this initial reading in mind, subsequent cuts to Von Rathony—cuts that often precede or follow Irina's sexual encounters with victims—can be interpreted as repeated but failed attempts to contain Irina's body within a voyeuristic framework of male fantasy that both reads her body as a signifier that bears but does not make meaning and seeks to "force entry, to penetrate, to appropriate

for himself the mystery of this womb where he has been conceived, the secret of his begetting, of his 'origin'" (Irigaray 25).

Even the blind, mad scientist Dr. Orloff, who longs for Irina as the passageway to "a new world" where he will "no longer need eyes to see," can only access the vampire through the bodies she leaves behind. His "examination" of one of these corpses results in his nonchalantly inserting his hand into a woman's vagina in order to determine for himself what the medical examiner had already recorded: that she was "killed by a mouth." Elated that his suspicions have now been confirmed by the punctures left behind by "the two canines [that] pierced the lip and deformed the clitoris," he ecstatically quips that "A world of wonder awaits!" Whether he means to refer to the supernatural void that Irina will give him unfettered access to or to the mysterious and alluring space of Irina's vagina, of which the corpse's acts as a double, is unclear. When Dr. Roberts, the examiner, protests that Irina and her ilk are evil and must be stopped, Orloff responds that to experience transcendent bliss (even as one is dying) and pass into the fluid realms of the beyond far exceeds the price of death at the mouth of the vampire.

Irina's double mouth—the one incapable of speech and which, contrary to the normal reproductive order of things, ingests bodily fluids, and the black hole of her vagina—is desired by both men and women as a point of access for a quick trip (or so they think) to transcendent bliss and reveals her to be bound at both ends by the construction of her body as that which gives but never receives. As a stand-in for the vagina dentata, "The mouth of hell—a terrifying symbol of woman as the 'devil's gateway,'" Irina can only make a small space for her own pleasure in the moments after her partner's heart has stopped beating but before the body has gone cold (Creed, *Monstrous* 106). Her frustrated, frenetic actions, rife with a desperate need to feel something, are for most of the film the only space where her desire is allowed possibility. Caught between mysterious voices in the mountain mists that call her name and seem to represent the disembodied weight of her family history and Von Rathony's and Dr. Orloff's insistence that "I know who you are," she is trapped in a system that defines her body and her desire as open repositories for male anxieties concerning the death drive, the maternal, and feminine pleasure.

Clover has perceptively remarked that in the typical horror film "the female story traces a circle (she becomes again what she was when the film began)," whereas "the male story is linear (he is at the end radically different from what he was at the beginning)" (98). In *Female*

Vampire this is only half true. The film, with its constant stream of sexual encounters set to the same, repetitive, sickly-sweet score, literally leaves Irina where it first found her. However, the male characters' attempts at catharsis are also decidedly anticlimactic. Von Rathony, after a rather overblown confession of "love" in which he discloses his knowledge of Irina's vampiric background and shares his premonition of her appearance as a "diaphanous" figure whose face, "fluid and indistinct," offers "a world of peace," presses for the privilege to follow her "behind the mist" and demands she play her pre-scripted role as deadly seductress: "But I don't want your pity. Because I want to stay with you, understand? I want to be near you, to go with you. Life is not important. I don't want to stay alone. Even if I hadn't known you, I would have left this world." Of course, this soon results in his death-by-orgasm, an event that concludes with him limply slumping down in bed, leaving Irina, once more, all alone. Did he discover the secrets of the mysterious beyond through sex with Irina? Was he able to penetrate the womb of the maternal in order to divine his origin? We never find out, and, what's more, the film doesn't seem to care. This lack of focus on the success or failure of male pleasure—barring ejaculation as the universal benchmark—betrays the film's sympathy for Irina rather than her victims. For the men and women who seek Irina's attentions, she is a means to an end, a gateway to the object of desire—ecstatic death and the "beyond"—rather than the object itself. By immediately dropping characters who die at Irina's hands with no concern for their afterlives, *Female Vampire* effectively illustrates how its queer vampire is merely a cog in a wheel rolling toward satisfaction of the death drive and fights against this figuration by focusing soley on Irina's (lack of) agency.

Von Rathony's death, more than anything else, prompts Irina (who had believed things were going to work out since Von Rathony went into it knowing what she was) to pay a visit to Orloff, whom she informs telepathically that at her call all vampires will retreat back to the cold and lonely comfort of their coffins. Despite Orloff's insistence that all Irina's secrets are now laid bare to him—the ability to speak Irina's words for her standing in for the sexual act itself—because it is *Irina* who penetrates *his* mind, and it is she who demands his mouth speak her truth, Orloff's talk amounts to nothing. While he fervently desires to take part in and become one with Irina's "bloody race" and has consequently been racing after her for the length of the film, she chooses to present herself to him only in order to communicate that the supernatural will forever

be beyond his reach. At the moment she forces him to admit that she alone will "return to the shadows … [and] to the worlds of darkness so as to put to an end the nightmares of phantasms and vampires," he convulses in much the same way Irina's partners do as they experience death-by-orgasm. Consequently, Orloff's "orgasm" is doubly denouncing—not only is he penetrated by Irina instead of the other way around, but the "sexual" act of telepathic communication acts as a bar to his fantasies of entry into the supernatural rather than as a gateway.

As for Irina participating in a circular pattern of character development, this is partially true in that the end of *Female Vampire* repeats its opening. The first scene of the film depicts Irina walking alone through misty woods clad in only knee-high boots, a belt, and a billowing black cape. As the credits roll, the camera takes a trip down the length of Irina's body, culminating in a genital zoom that leaves the screen black and obscures the viewer's access to the vampire's body at a moment when it should be at its most visible. As Irina continues her walk down the path, the camera remains stationary even though she is in motion. This results in Irina physically bumping the camera lens with her mouth, and for an instant she is simultaneously both the vampire Countess and Lina Romay, the actress who portrays her. The camera and the image stagger from the impact, and in this seemingly inconsequential moment Mulvey's three cinematic looks—necessary for film to produce "reality, obviousness, and truth"—collapse.[7] At this moment, Franco's attention to Irina's vagina as a sort of vacuum or black hole, a performative weight she must bear, blurs the boundary between filmic reality and the reality of the viewer if only for the space of the action that serves as its catalyst. By transforming the blank screen of nothing-to-see to the palpable reality of Lina/Irina's body, Franco is able to rework and recuperate not only the intradiegetic males' but also perhaps the extradiegetic viewers' construction of her body as intangible and unsignifiable, more dream than feeling flesh.

Yet another result of Irina/Lina's bump in with the camera is that it draws explicit attention to the fact that what the viewer is watching is not real. By breaking the surface of a hermetically sealed intradiegetic reality, Franco allows everything that follows to come into question. Throughout the remainder of the film, shaky handheld camera work and repeated out-of-focus zooms also draw attention to the identity of *Female Vampire* as a construction and work to displace the extradiegetic spectator from any sort of masterful viewing position. Even characters in the film who purport to "see" Irina clearly (ironically, Orloff is

blind) are, like the spectator of the film, in the end left with more questions than answers. Although Irina reports to Orloff that she and all other vampires will disappear from the face of the earth, the final scene, because it acts as an almost carbon copy of the first, instead gives the impression that the entire show will simply cycle through, and that Irina/Lina/Carmilla must continue to go through the motions once again. Not only does this ending remain faithful to le Fanu's "original"—in which the initial frame narrator never manages to reappear and close the gap of his story, resulting in the promise of Carmilla's eventual return—it also allows the hope that feminine desire will perhaps be able to break free of the male narratives that surround it.

It is my hope that this reading of *Female Vampire* has taken a small step toward a reconsideration of *Carmilla* adaptations in particular and Euro horror in general for feminist analysis. For if a film like *Female Vampire* can only be read either as "emphasi[zing] spectacle instead of story, engaging viewers viscerally instead of invoking them narratively" or as engendering a distanced, disaffected irony, then what is left (Olney 31)? In the space between affective investment and objective distance, is there a place for a resistant but interested gaze? Like Williams, I am inclined to believe that "these gross body genres which may seem so violent and inimical to women cannot be dismissed as evidence of monolithic and unchanging misogyny, as either pure sadism for male viewers or masochism for females" ("Film Bodies" 714). In an uphill battle for both the lesbian vampire on screen and Euro horror, a film about a mute woman burdened by the weight of family history and the masculine gaze seems like a good place to start. For it is the inconclusive nature of *Carmilla* adaptations in general and *Female Vampire* in particular that gives them a queer sense of hope. Unsurprisingly, this inconclusiveness is also a common gripe amongst critics. In a review for the DVD release of the film, Jeff Ulmer complains, "I found the cinematography to be extremely annoying. Nearly every shot contains a zoomed recomposition from wide to closeup back to wide shot, which becomes very distracting after the twentieth time it occurs … there are numerous occasions where the camera zooms in, then seems to be looking for something to focus on." In a similar review, this time for a Blu-ray release of the film, Charlie Hobbs writes, "The cinematography is horribly amateurish, the dialogue sync is frequently off, and Romay's acting consists of little more than walking around slowly wearing nothing but a cape, knee high black boots, and a leather belt …." Despite these criticisms, Hobbs goes on

to admit that, "in spite of all this, there is still something mesmerizing about *Female Vampire* that won't leave me" and remarks particularly on the "repetitive, hypnotic nature" of the film. Like academic criticism on low genres in general, Hobbs finds himself caught between distance and affect. And it is precisely this liminal space that I think might be useful for a reimagining of *Carmilla* as queer adaptation. For if these films all have one thing in common with the material they claim as their source, it is their open-endedness, a position that, I argue, admits new possibilities not only for the depiction of Carmilla on screen but also for the ways we might look at her.

Notes

1. For positivist readings that view *Carmilla* as a tale amenable to feminist analysis, see Thomas, Heller, and Major. For readings of the novella that condemn it for reveling in voyeurism and misogyny, see Stoddart and Walton.
2. For an in-depth overview of why specific lesbian vampire films are condemned by feminist critics and an argument for why these films should not be overlooked, please see Baker, Hanson.
3. See Baker; Brode 115; Weinstock.
4. Here I am thinking particularly of Case's construction of the "two 'she's'" who are "a double trope—a double masquerade" (8).
5. In addition to the recent resurgence of *Carmilla* film adaptations such as *The Curse of Styria* (Chernovetzky and Devendorf, 2014) and *The Unwanted* (Brett Wood, 2014), and a YouTube Series simply titled *Carmilla* (Jordan Hall, 2016), it's worth noting that there is a small but healthy group of cult/exploitation/trash/horror film distributors that consistently release remastered versions of the films from the '60s and '70s on high definition, Blu-ray discs. Often these Blu-rays also come equipped with special features such as making-of documentaries, interviews with the stars, and commentary tracks by fan-scholars.
6. For example, Sconce writes, "While the academy prizes conscious transgressions of conventions by a filmmaker looking to critique the medium aesthetically and/or politically, paracinematic viewers value a stylistic and thematic deviance born, more often than not, from the systematic failure of a film aspiring to *obey* dominant codes of cinematic representation" (original emphasis 385).
7. Mulvey's three cinematic looks are "that of the camera as it records the pro-filmic event, that of the audience as it watches the final product, and that of the characters at each other within the screen illusion" (815–6).

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CHAPTER 13

Hitchcock Goes to Italy and Spain: Euro Horror and Queer Adaptation

Fernando Gabriel Pagnoni Berns

Introduction

Alfred Hitchcock is now considered "the master of suspense," the man who gave the thriller (and, to a lesser extent, horror) some respectability. Yet, as Constantine Verevis points out, "it was not until *after* the reevaluation of Hitchcock's work by the *Cahiers du cinéma* critics" and the popularization of the *politique des auteurs* "that Hitchcock would become one of Hollywood's most imitated directors" (19). But since then, Hitchcock has been imitated across the globe, from Europe to Latin America, to the point that the word "Hitchcockian" has become common usage.

Euro horror, on the other hand, has not been highly esteemed. Trashy and exploitative, filled with gore, nudity and preposterous dubbing, Euro horror has been left in the margins of film studies. Only recently, with the shift in academia toward cultural studies and with the availability of DVD technology and "uncut" copies, has Euro horror begun to receive some kind of recognition as a cycle venturing daringly into the dark corridors of human minds and societies. The exploitative nature of many of these films seems far removed from Hitchcock's subtle work, yet many

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Euro horror films do reference his films. Some offer just passing nods to Hitchcock; some go so far as to rewrite the films, dismantling the narratives to make explicit what in Hitchcock was implicit or foreground as text what in Hitchcock was subtext. Hitchcock is thus re-invented by Euro horror, his ideas and images filtered by the aesthetics of the lowbrow.

In this chapter, I work with two examples of films that may be seen as reworkings of Hitchcock films: the Italian *L'orribile segreto del Dr. Hichcock* (Riccardo Freda, 1962), which pays homage to Hitchcock while remaking *Rebecca* (1940) to Euro horror tastes, and the Spanish *El techo de cristal* ("The Glass Ceiling," Eloy de la Iglesia, 1971), which may be read as an adaptation of Hitchcock's *Rear Window* (1954), framed with the trademark motifs and ideological politics of de la Iglesia: repressed sexuality and social commentary (Lázaro Reboll 178).

Understanding adaptation not as a unidirectional process progressing from an original source to cinematographic illustration, but rather as a process of feedback between works and social and cultural contexts, I use these two adaptations as case studies to show how these lowbrow films queer Hitchcock's work by revealing their indebtedness to the gothic, which, in emphasizing non-normative desire, is inextricably linked with queerness (Hughes 535).

Issues of Adaptation and Interpretation

As Eduardo Grüner argues, when we find resonances, inspirations, or echoes of other works in an artistic text—such as a film—we cannot just turn our heads and look the other way (as if that relationship were not there) due to a principle of "intellectual honesty" and scholarly rigor (Grüner 113). The author of a concrete cultural artifact has willingly connected his or her work to another time/nation/aesthetic, inviting us to read it from our socially and culturally located point of view. Thus, the practice of adaptation is both a strategy of hermeneutic intervention and a form of "political reading" (Grüner 114) that affects the production, circulation, and reception of the film in question.

In this framework, there is *no original source*, only interpretations. The "original" work loses its Benjaminian aura as a unique piece floating amidst a sea of derivative work. Even the primary text—the so-called source—is related to texts that precede it chronologically. So each artistic work answers to the politics of readership and interpretation, mediated

by social and cultural contexts. In other words, a movie is a rewriting that speaks about itself and the society and culture that produced it rather than referring solely to a previous work and its society and culture. Each text also contains zones of ambiguity and indeterminacy. Every narrative choice shuts down other possibilities that do not evaporate but haunt the work. Thus, a rewriting (another interpretation) is a form of materializing the unsaid potentialities *haunting* a previous work.

Like adaptation, queerness itself is "a zone of possibilities" (Edelman 114) always "inflected by a sense of potentiality that it cannot yet quite articulate" (Jagose 2). Queerness resists patriarchal ideologies that are presented as "natural"; it opens the possibility of other ways of being, alternatives to the normative, canonical reading, just as adaptation does. It can be argued, thus, that the process of adaptation always includes a queer component, since it points, inevitably, to the potential for a new way of being.

The gothic, too, is aligned with queerness. In their anthology *Queering the Gothic*, William Hughes and Andrew Smith argue that "gothic has, in a sense, always been 'queer,'" since this genre has marked "the uneasy cultural boundary that separates the acceptable and familiar from the troubling and different" (1). As Paulina Palmer points out, the ambivalent approach to sexuality that gothic texts often display "make[s] the genre admirably suited to treating the tensions and conflicts that the queer individual experiences in coping with the pressures of heteronormative society" (14). It is interesting that so-called nonlegitimate sexual practices (such as sado-masochism, transvestism, transgender bodies, or prostitution) "implicitly [question] the hegemonic binarism of 'heterosexuality' and 'homosexuality'" (Jagose 64) while commenting also on cultural and social difference. As Harry M. Benshoff sharply notes in his groundbreaking book *Monsters in the Closet: Homosexuality and the Horror Film*, "most classical horror films make little or no distinction between homosexuality and any other form of 'sex perversion'" (69): all forms of non-normative sex are connected and thus overlap each other, becoming forms of abnormal monstrosity. In this scenario, deviant sex may be read as both: monstrous/queer sex.

The queer gothic includes, "in addition to sexualities that tend to be regarded as deviant, the vilification of certain sections of society as monstrous" (Palmer 3). *L'orribile segreto del Dr. Hichcock* and *El techo de cristal* both exhibit these qualities of the queer gothic and also are cluttered with references to Hitchcock, creating something new from

previous texts. And they do so through a process of queering: not just adapting other films but adapting *auteur* films, downgrading the narratives to the mud of lowbrow fare, kinkiness, and rearticulation of the (hetero)normative narrative of classic Hollywood.

Queering Hitchcock

One reason critics have not acknowledged the presence of Hitchcock in Freda's and de la Iglesia's films (other than his name in Freda's film) may be that these productions are not remakes in the usual sense. They are, rather, adaptations from one cultural realm (American cinema, auteur film) to another (marginalized exploitation fare) and, in the case of *L'orribile segreto del Dr. Hichcock*, from one genre (thriller) to another (horror). Yet both films refer to Hitchcock explicitly and implicitly: explicitly, in the name "Hitchcock" (minus a T) in Freda's title, the first signpost of a potential connection between the works; implicitly, in the motifs and narratives from Hitchcock's *Rebecca* and *Rear Window* that circulate between the films.

One of Freda's best known works, *L'orribile segreto del Dr. Hichcock* mostly retells *Rebecca* for Italian audiences. In the film, Dr. Hichcock (Robert Flemyng) engages in practices of necrophilia, and his wife Margaretha (Maria Teresa Vianello) happily indulges her husband's paraphilia (defined as sexual disorders characterized by recurrent, sexually arousing "deviant" urges or behaviors) by allowing herself to be injected with an experimental anesthetic that renders her corpse-like during sex. When she dies (due to an overdose), Hichcock returns to the familiar mansion with his new bride Cynthia (Barbara Steele) who soon finds herself haunted by the ghostly figure of the previous wife. She also must contend with her husband's erotic attachment to his deceased wife and with a sinister housekeeper, Martha (Harriet Medin), who immediately forms a grudge against the new mistress of the house, paralleling the character of Mrs. Danvers in *Rebecca*. Black-clad Martha evokes the figure of Mrs. Danvers visually (as seen in Fig. 13.1), as both women are always frowning and wearing a grim expression in their faces.

L'orribile segreto del Dr. Hichcock reworks *Rebecca*, the "ostensible narrative [of which] is that of one woman trying to prove the guilt of another in a manner that restores patriarchy" (Allen 9). In *Rebecca*, it is clear that the main task of the new Mrs. de Winter (Joan Fontaine) is to delve deep into the past of her husband's previous wife to



Fig. 13.1 The creepy housekeeper (Harriet Medin), a Hitchcockian motif

unearth all her dark secrets. Only when the previous Mrs. de Winter is revealed as an evil woman can her ghost disappear from the mansion; her haunting comes to an end and patriarchy is restored. The process of restoring patriarchy began in the passage from the novel to the big screen: in the novel, Maxim has killed his previous wife in a fit of rage and made her death look like an accident, but as Gene Adair remembers, "a plot in which Maxim gets away with murder was something that Hollywood's Production Code … would simply not permit." Thus "the plot was 'fixed': Rebecca's death, in the film version, results from an accident" (67).

Unlike in *Rebecca*, there is no patriarchal lost order to be restored in Freda's film through the investigative actions of the new wife. Bourgeois patriarchy has already been contaminated by paraphilias and deviance and both men and women actively participate in forms of sexual deviance. Bernard Hichcock is the patriarchal figure, the man of the house haunted by the past, but his perverse attachment to his deceased wife and his kinky sexual practices code him as insane. Further, Bernard's kinkiness is the clear opposite of his role as the perfect husband and exemplary citizen. Bernard is a renowned doctor, the creator of a revolutionary anesthetic that allows advancements in surgical practices. He represents the underside of both scientific progress (Enlightenment) and the educated

elite society. The same anesthetic invented and used to save lives he uses, throughout the nights, as a playful tool for sexual perversion and necrophiliac impulses. Thus Freda's film connects scientific invention (the enthroning of the mind) with sexual perversion (the enthroning of the body and the basic instincts). Rather than presenting traditional binary oppositions—educated, elite, heteronormative, respectable vs. working class, irrational, instinctive, deviant—*L'orribile segreto del Dr. Hichcock* challenges them, exploring the slippage between rational and perverse, bourgeois lifestyle and deviant behavior.

Although bourgeois respectability typically acts as a bastion against sexual deviance, here there is no such bulwark and no safe status quo to be restored. The dark aspects of the bourgeois life are emphasized in the first scenes. Bernard comes home after working at the hospital and finds Margaretha playing piano for the upper-class guests who are quickly dismissed so she and her husband can begin their nocturnal kinky practices. Even the housekeeper Martha is aware of the couple's deviations and willingly participates. Margaretha is the distorted image of the Victorian housewife: not only is she sexually active, but she participates in her husband's kinky plays with delight. The smile she gives to Bernard as he gives her a shot of the anesthetic and their locked gazes make it absolutely clear that the game is consensual. Margaretha is not alienated from her own desire and body through masochistic identification but is an active partner. Thus, the couple destabilizes any traditional dyad such as active/passive or victimizer/victim and both become monsters with deviant appetites.

Dr. Hichcock, unsatisfied with the "fake" necrophilia he practices with his wife, uses his position as a respectable doctor to access the morgue at night to sexually molest female corpses, and when he decides to start practicing his old sexual habits after remarrying, his sexual perversion is extended in a scene that implies rape. After injecting Cynthia with the drugs he had used with his deceased wife, a close shot reveals unexpected hidden signs of monstrosity: "Hichcock's face and hands are horribly disfigured, a physical sign of the inevitable eruption of his sexual deviation" (Bondanella 309). His face, lighted in deep red (as seen in Fig. 13.2), seems eaten by leprosy, an external sign of internal illness. The scene cuts to the next morning, with Cynthia lying on a sofa, scared and tired. What actually happened the night before is left ambiguous.

Margaretha, the perfect bourgeois wife (in surface), is also coded as deeply deviant. When she dies, she is buried alive and then "resurrected"



Fig. 13.2 Hichcock's monstrosity

as a vampire (without further explanation of this conversion into the supernatural), needing fresh blood to be kept alive. This vampiric turn emphasizes the monstrous nature of the woman, who now preys on innocent victims, paralleling her husband's recurrent abuse of dead bodies. The shot that reveals Bernard's monstrous nature apparently belongs to Cynthia's hallucinatory state of mind after being drugged. However, it serves to code the couple of vampiric Margaretha and necrophiliac Bernard as monstrous, deviant from the heteronormative norms of marriage and sex.

In his gothic Italian B movie, Freda is able to actualize the perversion lurking in the corners of Hitchcock's oeuvre. Echoes of Hitchcock's corpus abound throughout Freda's film, as Philippe Met notes, "from *Suspicion* (1941), with the poisoned glass of milk, to *Under Capricorn* (1949), with the skull that Cynthia, the persecuted heroine, finds in her bed" (201). An aerial shot framing Margaretha's funeral mirrors a scene in *Foreign Correspondent* (1940), the subjective point of view from a person drinking a glass of milk alludes to *Champagne* (1928) and the necrophiliac theme recalls another masterpiece: *Vertigo*. *Rebecca*, however, is the central adaptation: the second Mrs. De Winter's exploration of *Rebecca*'s bedroom is paralleled in Freda's film in Cynthia's descent through a hidden passage that she undertakes with the purpose

of uncovering her husband's secrets. The spectral residues of Rebecca in Hitchcock's film are here literal: Cynthia finds that Margaretha is materially alive, hiding in the bowels of the mansion. Thus, the ghostly presence of Rebecca in Hitchcock's film is turned into spectrality in Freda's film. Unlike the ghost, the specter involves "carnal apparition" (Appelbaum 30), the carnal always associated with sexuality and sin. The spectral survival of Margaretha works as a metaphor for the return of Bernard's repressed desires which, like his wife, are still pulsating. Unlike the main patriarchal figure in *Rebecca*, Hichcock does not want to leave the past behind to begin a kind of "brand new day" with his new wife: instead, his attachment to the past is completely gothic. Hichcock is locked within a frozen past, continually reliving the same experiences without taking into account the desires and subjectivities of his new wife. For Hichcock, his wives are interchangeable: both must accept his desires and paraphilias as their own, thus revealing a misogynistic personality.

Gothic motifs (such as spectrality, sexual perversion, and the female vampire feeding on the blood of beautiful women) were popular in the Italian horror cinema of the 1960s—when homosexuality was seen as a form of social corruption (Duncan 48), and the parallel between sexual deviance and criminality/perversity was especially strong—and Freda uses these motifs here as a form of counter-discourse, to represent and explore deviant sexuality and the rupture of the sacred values of bourgeois marriage. If the ending of *Rebecca* has been interpreted as "the restoration, and affirmation, of patriarchal marriage" (Rothman 59), there is no such a resolution here. Bernard Hichcock cannot be saved; he must be punished at the end as a way to pass national censure. Freda is engaging with the Hitchcockian in his own terms, rather than merely following the plot to the letter.

Both Hitchcock and Hichcock are united by what Grossman terms "elastextity," each becoming an "indivisible connected" (10) part of the same canvas: Hitchcock's universe. The latter informs the narrative and (to some extent) the aesthetics, while both Freda and de la Iglesia appropriate Hitchcock's texts to queer them and reveal their undersides, their perversities sanitized by "high art" auterism, self-censorship, and Hollywood's ideology.

The same "elastextity" is followed by Eloy de la Iglesia when returning to/rewriting *Rear Window*. Like Freda, the Spanish director uses Euro horror to recuperate and highlight the perversions lurking at the corners of Hitchcock's films, a sexual and social deviance tamed by

American censorship. When doing so, he engages, like Freda, in a critique of the social structures repressing desire and subjectivity. There is a difference, however, that points to all the potentialities of Euro horror: while *L'orribile segreto del Dr. Hichcock* harshly chastises bourgeois hypocrisy, *El techo de cristal* critiques the oppression of female desire and the situation of women in the Spain of the 1970s.

El techo de cristal is set in a small rural apartment house and the narrative revolves around the ordinary daily activities of Marta (Carmen Sevilla). Because her husband Carlos (Fernando Cebrián) is usually out of town on business trips, Marta spends most of her time alone. Already prone to fantasizing as a way to halt her daily boredom and loneliness, Marta begins to suspect that her upstairs neighbor Julia (Patty Shepard) may have murdered her husband. Marta soon finds an amiable ear in her landlord Ricardo (Dean Selmier), a sculptor, who finds himself being drawn to the lonely wife.

The first noticeable change from Hitchcock's film is the gender of the main voyeur. Hitchcock's *Rear Window* centers on professional photographer L. B. Jeffries (James Stewart) who has broken his leg and is confined to a wheelchair in his New York apartment. Out of boredom, he becomes a voyeur, "peeping" on his neighbors across the courtyard until the mysterious goings-on in one apartment catch his attention. Eventually he is convinced that a murder has taken place there and he resolves to expose the killer. In the film, the voyeuristic male gaze is in total control: the audience sees what the male hero sees. Even if Hitchcock plays with and criticizes the voyeuristic gaze, "issues of misogyny clearly inform these dynamics" as the woman observed is "violated through a devouring male gaze" that "prefigures the ultimate literal and physical violation" (Greven 102) when she is later murdered.

El techo de cristal subverts the misogyny of Hitchcock's film. First, the peeping Tom is replaced by a female voyeur, Marta. Thus viewers, both male and female, are obliged to adopt a female point of view, to see through Marta's eyes, because she is the one driving the narrative forward. Thus the film queers the spectator's gaze, since male spectators are forced to adopt this exploratory female look. Second, there is no literal window here but just a "glass ceiling," through which Marta slowly gathers the pieces of the puzzle, relying only on what she can hear (noises of footsteps), discern (facts discovered as lies), see (in brief glimpses), and feel. We see her staring at the ceiling, listening to the noises, but the image provides us with no certainty. All the information

given to the spectators is filtered through the subjectivity of a woman who may be inventing all that is taking place around her. Only in the film's last twenty minutes is the murder revealed as a real thing rather than product of a bored woman's imagination.

All of this produces a rupture of the hegemonic patriarchal gaze, the one that Laura Mulvey (1989) sees as constitutive of the woman as being the bearer of the gaze and the man as the bearer of the look. In mainstream cinema (such as *Rear Window*), the story is constructed through the male gaze; the female eye remains at the margins. *El techo de cristal*, however, is constructed through the female gaze and subjectivity, usurping the male gaze of the film's ostensible source, *Rear Window*. In this way, it is similar to what Mary Ann Doane calls the "paranoid" woman's film of the 1940s, in which a woman feels threatened by a seemingly sadistic male authority figure, usually her husband, and which is structured around the female investigative gaze, firmly centered on the female point of view.

It can be argued that the gaze dominating *El techo de cristal* is feminine, not queer. However, de la Iglesia repeatedly cuts the flow of the main narrative with brief "dream/subjective" scenes that are hard to pin to a specific character, producing a "trans-gender" perspective that emphasizes ambiguity. For example, Rosa (Emma Cohen), who delivers milk to the apartment house every morning, tricks Ricardo. She is milking a cow and asks Ricardo to come closer, then splashes cow's milk at the man's face. The scene is a clear reversal of the "cum shot" of pornographic imagery. Here, it is she who holds the organ—the udder—which "ejaculates" upon the male face. He quickly retorts that she should be punished. The narrative is then cut with an oneiric scene in which Ricardo is spanking Rosa. There is no indication, however, to whom the erotic subjective insert belongs, so audiences must resign themselves to this state of ambiguity rather than follow a clear point of view. Further, brief inserted scenes representing Marta's nightmares suggest repressed sexual desires as she sees herself romantically attached to Ricardo and, in one scene, even to Julia, indicating an unexplored lesbian subjectivity.

Further subverting heteronormative narrative conventions, the one depicted naked from the waist up in many scenes is Ricardo, the handsome male hero, rather than Marta, who remains mostly clothed. The camera emphasizes the queerness shooting them both standing one next to the other (see Fig. 13.3), she prudishly clothed, he half-naked, his



Fig. 13.3 Disrupting the heteronormative gaze: a fully clothed Marta (Carmen Sevilla) and shirtless Ricardo (Dean Selmier)

skin glistening with sweat. Still, there is a diegetic gaze examining Marta in detail; an unknown person spies on and takes provocative pictures of her. The gaze of the male spectator and that of the invisible voyeur overlap in these scenes. The gaze, indeed, is male: in the film's climax, Ricardo is revealed as the voyeur. However, this male gaze is highly improbable, since the photos are taken from an impossibly short distance and in impossible situations. For example, audiences see through the eye of a photographic camera (presumably held by Ricardo) and hear the sound of a click when Marta takes a bath in her bathroom. However, she stands almost next to the camera's eye, so close indeed that it is impossible that she does not notice someone there, in her bathroom, spying on her. Rather than being spied on from a window, the person taking photos of her must be standing *next to her*. So rather than being a plausible plot device, the photos speak to the needs of viewers to situate women under a scrutinizing eye. The film thus produces a *mockery* of the male

gaze framing *Rear Window*, an impossible situation that places under discussion the nature of the voyeur and the male gaze.

Another major change from Hitchcock's film is the reason behind the voyeuristic practices. In *El techo de cristal*, Eloy de la lglesia, an outspoken gay socialist filmmaker, uses genre cinema as a vehicle to articulate ideas about patriarchal institutions at the social, the political, and the sexual levels. While the character of James Stewart starts to spy because he is recovering from an injury, Marta spies because she is always alone. As a housewife, she does not work nor seem to have much to do in the public sphere. She is constantly inviting anyone coming to her door to stay and share a coffee or a conversation, but nobody seems to have time to stay. *El techo de cristal* thus reveals the traditional and suffocating plight of women in the Spain of the late 1960s.

In the 1960s hordes of tourists exposed Spain to new images on gender (until the politics of openness to tourism were tightened in the 1970s), but women mostly remained at home, the changes taking place slowly. The story of *El techo de cristal*, with its ambivalent point of view and its emphasis on the protagonist's conflicted desires, lends itself especially well to representing the tension that the real women in the 1970s experienced between their own desires and societal pressures to conform. Further, the outside world could be dangerous: when Marta invites the grocery delivery man (Javier De Campos) for a drink, he makes a move on her and gets angry when she rejects him. Marta's world is one of boredom and suffocation because there is no space for her (and, by extension, women in general) besides the daily domestic chores. It is Marta who, out of boredom, cannot let the neighbors alone.

The repression of female sexuality and subjectivity frames *El techo de cristal* while denouncing the lack of social progression and obscurantism still surviving in the little towns of Spain under Francisco Franco's dictatorial government. In this sense, Marta is especially grateful when an old friend from the "big city" of Madrid comes to visits her, her only connection with cosmopolitan, modern life. Genre cinema, here adapting and reinterpreting the narrative and codes of mainstream cinema, offers the possibility of exploring contemporary social and political issues through "a fictional space away from the crude realism of a repressive government and of an archaic understanding of what Spanish culture should entail" (Aldana Reyes 200). Thus, the political militancy of the filmmaker spreads outside his communist party affiliation to his cinema, one of "opposition and moral subversion" (Lázaro Reboll 178) as *El techo de cristal* reinterprets *Rear Window* through the

problematic of femininity in a phallocentric culture. This subversive reinterpretation follows his take on Hitchcock's narratives, in which the male gaze and subjectivity are replaced by a distorted ambiguity framing the whole narrative.

Conclusions

L'orribile segreto del Dr. Hichcock and *El techo de cristal* are significant films in a double way: first, both productions rewrite themes and motifs haunting Hitchcock's *oeuvre*, thus "downgrading" auterism to Euro horror and exploitation while blurring any boundary dividing "high art" from low-brow. This permeability is core for cultural studies, vindicating popular culture as a form of expression for values, tastes, and visuality that confronts the (patriarchal) canon. In the films analyzed here the focus shifts toward female subjectivity and deviant sex rather than resting exclusively on (hetero)normative narrative. Second, the examples rewrite Hitchcock, but do so from the perspective of different nationalities (Italy and Spain), thus provoking a wider circulation of motifs that demote any idea of a hierarchy indicating an "original source" and an imitation in favor of a wide and fluid net of signifiers. This shift produces a decentering of America, originality, and auterism. What these films illustrate is adaptation as a process of constant rewriting of themes and ideas with no discernible source. If gothic is haunting, these films mark the way that ideas and visual images resurface in different moments and different places, producing a queer reading in which heterosexuality itself is strange, haunted by paraphilias that disrupt any idea of normalcy and oppression/repression. Euro horror, itself residing at the margins, is the place of privilege to make such readings, due to its linkage with the gothic, the latter (like queer) centered in the overturning of social hierarchies.

The association of the image of the monster with sexualities regarded as deviant is a trope typical of the gothic mode and central to the plot of *L'orribile segreto del Dr. Hichcock*. The blurring of the boundaries between reality and fiction, another gothic device, delineates *El techo de cristal*. Further, Marta's voyeuristic tendencies codify her as deviant, that is, "queer" and, as such, linked to the Hichcock films, all three assaulting the normative sense of "normal" behavior. While Alfred Hitchcock's films are rife with righteous people caught in situations compromising their ethics, both Riccardo Freda and Eloy de la Iglesia discard the lens of heteronormative privilege to favor the deviant queer.

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CHAPTER 14

Dazzle, Gradually: A "Tru" Account of Adapting Capote's *In Cold Blood*

Michael V. Perez

There's a case to be made for Douglas McGrath's *Infamous* (2006) as the best film adaptation of Truman Capote's *In Cold Blood*, even as it is not, strictly, a direct adaptation. Capote's queer sensibility has informed and permeated at least three films about the murders in Holcomb, Kansas. This chapter charts the queer progression of the textual *In Cold Blood* (ICB) and the increasingly homosocial and homonormative portrayals of the killers from film to film, when the release of *Capote* (2005) and then *Infamous* (2006) created a Capote media fest (not to mention a movie book tie-in) almost as legendary as Capote's 1967 Black and White Ball. The stories of the killers' escape, capture, and imprisonment take over in all filmed iterations of ICB and move to a revelation about "what really happened that night." *Infamous*, however, has a surprise in store: the realization—not the subtext, not the inference—of same-sex desire as causational, exhilarative, and (if suppressed) deadly. No matter what really happened that night of November 15, 1959, *Infamous* develops a narrative that not only establishes the consequences of homosexual suppression but also allows for a furtive and potent depiction of

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what can occur when said oppression is freed—all as the focus and drive of a narrative strategy that is surprisingly direct and not merely a wink towards the camera. The entire cumulative effect, from the initial text of *In Cold Blood* in 1965 to 2006's *Infamous*, is that of a measured, increasing release of explicit and dazzling queerdom and fabulosity, wherein suppressed queer desire pressures the closet door to open wide enough to be blown clean off of its hinges.

"Tru"-News: A Locus Source

I take as a basic premise of queer adaptation that queers, adapting through a chain of versions and iterations, become more openly and organically queer, each iteration using homosocial impetus and desire as palimpsest-like transparency, effacement, layers, references, and additions. This process produces the ultimate version of ICB, the feyest and greatest, sometimes in the name of visibility at all costs, sometimes as a revisionary tactic informed by biography, verbal tchotchkes, plot, and gossip.

The starting point for all truthful illusionary adaptations of ICB is the famously under-examined 1959 "true news" item that ran in *The New York Times* on page 39, at the top of the second column to the left. This clipping of journalism is the primary artifact that, being more fact than art, started Capote's creative response and process. Before the coining of the phrase "nonfiction novel," there was this news story, not quite a blurb, powerful (or gruesome) enough to catch Capote's eye and his fancy:

> Wealthy Farmer, 3 of Family Slain
>
> Holcomb, Kan., Nov. 15 (UPI)—A wealthy wheat farmer, his wife and their two young children were found shot to death today in their home. They had been killed by shotgun blasts at close range after being bound and gagged.
>
> The father, 48-year-old Herbert W. Clutter, was found in the basement with his son, Kenyon, 15. His wife Bonnie, 45, and a daughter, Nancy, 16, were in their beds.
>
> There were no signs of a struggle, and nothing had been stolen. The telephone lines had been cut.
>
> "This is apparently the case of a psychopathic killer," Sheriff Earl Robinson said.
>
> [….]

What might have triggered Capote's interest was the quote from Sherriff Robinson. More than being Exhibit A of a news event and the synopsis of a crime scene, this under-considered article is the start of Capote working in an adaptation mode and vein, adopting techniques from his structural acumen as a novelist and applying these to what might be, for the most part, clearly identifiable as fact.

Gradual Dazzle

In Emily Dickinson's poem *Tell all the truth but tell it slant* (or *1263*), she directs the reader to state a complete truth, but at a calibrated, incremental angle—what I interpret as a "gradual dazzle" inherent in the lines "The Truth must dazzle gradually / Or every man be blind—". I imagine this idea is something that Capote would've appreciated, if not espoused, Capote being all dazzle, all the time. The watershed years for Capote adaptations—from nonfiction novel to film to television adaptations and then biopic screenplay and subsequent films—exemplify the queering (read: bedazzling) of the figure known as Truman Capote. This creation, in being openly gay and openly effeminate—becomes a textbook example of how adaptations evolve as the closet of permissible gayness opens wider to admit the backstory and legacy of an openly gay author, to the point where the queer trajectory is exacerbated and used as dialogue and plot points—to where the queerness is adapted to the scenario, and not the other way around.

In Cold Blood's trajectory from notes to published page to both large and small screen iterations asks a fundamental question of its audiences, while staying true to its boilerplate "true crime" genre origins. Beyond the salacious interest in the crimes themselves—evident in the ongoing pageantry of adaptations promising "based on a true story" or "ripped from the headlines"—*Infamous* dares to ask its audience, *What are the outcomes of participation in, or refutation of, an actively homophobic society, and how are these outcomes manifested?*

One of the ways a queer adaptation manifests technically is through, *chez* McGrath, depictions of queering as a way to develop narrative, connection, and intimacy, much like the real Capote might have done with his Park Avenue "Swans" (Babe Paley, "Slim" Keith) over lunch. A *tour de force* scene from *Infamous* with Toby Jones holding court at a Christmas dinner in Holcomb, Kansas, shows how McGrath showcases an actor's skill and scripts a methodology wherein being queer enables connection,

humor, and propels the film's narrative. A similar pivotal scene happens in the earlier film, *Capote*, and has the same premise—that Capote, using his charm and name-dropping to manipulate entry into a previously hostile community and environment, both unifies the community and positions himself to gain access to the citizens of Holcomb, its crime, and eventually the killers, in the name of being fabulous. *Infamous* uses a larger and longer take than *Capote* to show Jones entering into and then masterfully commanding a conversation initially about shawls. As a response to an attempted parlor game where everyone must state the worst gift they ever received, Harper Lee's character mentions that she hates shawls; *Infamous* starts with the shawl and goes bigger, dazzling all the way: "Am I to believe my ears?" Capote states in mock indignation, and then recounts a time when in Italy with John Huston, Humphrey Bogart, Peter Lorre, and Jennifer Jones, filming his screenplay for the irreverent romp *Beat The Devil*, he was hospitalized—and Jennifer (initially he uses the celebrities' first names only) brought him a get-well gift of a Balmain designer shawl. Each time Capote mentions a star, the party guests draw forward, stunned and star struck by Capote's first-name basis with famous people and the offhand way he drops each of their names: "And then Humphrey …" at which one guest stammers "Bogart … You know Humphrey Bogart?!" and Capote shoots back, "You mean *Mr. Lauren Bacall* … !" By the end of his story, Toby Jones punctuates his final remark with a cheeky flourish, stating that in Jennifer Jones's shawl he "felt and looked … (pause, saucy snap of the fingers capped with a finger point) … DREAMY." To this gesture the party guests break into unconstrained laughter, and just like that—thanks to a queer adaptation—Capote is *in*.

During this scene, McGrath creates a touching scenario wherein he cuts to the adolescent son of Alvin Dewey (head investigator of the murders) listening in on the grownups' conversation, smiling and connecting with Capote's sparkling wit and delivery—the implication being that the Dewey son ostensibly hears a queer in his very own home not dialing down his homosocial radar, but perhaps fostering it for the younger man, to his obvious delight—a nice queer adaptation that posits queerness as a legacy that can be passed on and fostered anywhere, even in Kansas in 1960.

An *Infamous* Trajectory

Other queer moments in McGrath's film that build a case for gay desire as narrative impetus are as follows, from most subtle to most open:

- *A Very Long Look*. As the captured killers are transferred back to Holcomb, Kansas, a crowd forms at the courthouse steps, forming a gauntlet. Cut to Jones, and then Craig, in successive close-ups, with Capote staring at Smith, who returns the gaze, meeting and holding Capote's; this is almost an "eyes in the crowd" old school film noir effect to establish the protagonist with his *femme* (in this case *homme*) *fatale*.
- *The Twist Scene*. *Vogue* editor Diana Vreeland takes a photo of Truman, just back in Manhattan from a long period in Kansas and with the killers, as he learns how to do the "new dance that's all the rage," The Twist. Just as her camera flashes, Truman flashes back to Perry looking back at him the first time on the courthouse steps. This "double flash" creates a referential narrative (very *Hiroshima Mon Amour*) based on gay desire that is then solidified and embedded in the narrative at just under one hour of screen time (@ 59:03).
- *The Live "Selfie."* At 1:21:00, Smith confronts Capote about the title of his book, already leaked to the press and which he has heard of from a prison guard. He flings Capote face-first into a corner of his cell, grabs his pants and tears them off, and stuffs his mouth with a cloth: "Open your fucking lying mouth," he says. "You fucked me, now I'm gonna fuck you." But Smith doesn't rape Capote; he grabs a hand mirror and says, "Look … look … that's how your fucking title made me feel" (1:24:00). This image devastatingly shows how McGrath shifts the point of view from the assailant to the victim as an act of disembodied eyewitness wherein Capote's gagged face fills the hand mirror and reflects back to him the subjective price of human objectivity. Both Craig's and Jones' performances are courageous and disturbing, making the nature of their relationship's violence (and potential sexual violence) isolated, disembodied, and visible.
- (… and perhaps the most direct queer adaptation) *The Kiss*. Smith, speaking for the first time as a gay man, not a jailhouse near-rapist, tells Capote: "I'll tell you what punishment is for me. It's hoping there's someone for you … and after years of no one … you find *him … and you can't have him*" [italics mine]. In a beautiful moment, Smith asks for verification: "We connected, right?" and then they (really) kiss. Let's call this the "Anti-Will Smith" moment: Will Smith, refusing to kiss Anthony Michael Hall in *Six*

Degrees of Separation (1996), is filmed from the back leaning into Hall, not really kissing him. Jones and Craig, in contrast, treat the scene as the ecstatic consummation and negation of repression and effaced queerness that it is—thus, the next scene is …

- *Capote, Elated (Briefly)*. Capote returns to his hotel room, stares at the ceiling, at Heaven, perhaps, then at himself, beaming and incredulous—and then, slowly, sobered by the reality of what he and Perry had done and could never do, adding even more poignancy to Perry's earlier words: "I'll tell you what punishment is for me … after years of no one … you find him … *and you can't have him*."
- *Harper Lee Goes There*. At 1:39:00: Over lunch and back in Manhattan, after Truman states that Jack Dunphy, his longtime partner, is funny about Truman discussing Perry: "It's like he (Jack) is jealous …" Lee pauses, and then goes there: "Truman … Are you and Perry …" to which Truman defaults to The Love That Dare Not Speak Its Name: "Please Nelle … (*whispered: he has cut her off*) … I'm begging you!"
- *A Last Kiss*. On his way to the gallows, a shackled Smith leans into whisper "Adios, *amigo*," to Capote, then adeptly kisses Capote on the cheek. Craig lays this kiss on Jones in a fully committed way, lingering just a bit, creating an effect of ephemeral but memorably open and poignant dazzle. Capote then has to endure Smith's hanging, but is unable to watch after he ascends the stairs to the gallows. Capote takes a long, incredulous look up at the gallows (seen in Fig. 14.1), and when Smith begins to hyperventilate as the hood is placed over his head, Capote rushes outside, distraught. This is the price of looking, in contrast to the earlier "Selfie" image, wherein Capote fully understands the awful accruing dazzlement of the love and violence that Perry Smith embodied.
- *The Tyranny of an Empty Yellow Pad*. And then the movement to a final "yellow pad" moment of *Answered Prayers*[1] unanswered, the close-up of its lined yellow blankness perhaps repeating Smith's lines to Capote, "You can't have him." Cue The End, a long slow dissolve of addiction, writer's block, and cocktails; that yellow pad, *chez* McGrath, becomes a talisman for unrealized homo-adaptation: a 1965 queer impetus, delivered in gradual dazzlement in 2006.



Fig. 14.1 Capote (Toby Jones) at Smith's execution: the cost of looking

For the "Record"

Infamous dares not only to represent queer desire explicitly in the relationship depicted between Smith and Capote, but also to demonstrate the deadly effects of homophobia and repression. In McGrath's auteur view, homophobia and bullying led Smith to murder. After being taunted repeatedly and even shoved onto Kenyon Clutter, Hickok brays, "Go ahead … KISS HIM." As Smith pushes Hickok away, McGrath has him deliver the final blow: "Or would you rather kiss his FATHER?!!" Smith responds by cutting Clutter's throat, thinking, according to the later revision of this moment in the book and then (again) as one of

those McGrath "yellow pad" moments, "I thought he was a gentleman … up until the moment I cut his throat."

The murder scene of the Clutter family had never been predicated upon a 1959 depiction of the way homophobia can be manifested as violence. In fact, according to Ralph Voss, while

> Capote took no particular pains to conceal his own homosexuality, … he *did* take pains to conceal, or leave somewhat ambiguous, homosexuality in his writings that appeared in the 1950s and 1960s. That strategy was particularly important to him in *In Cold Blood*, because not only would clear-cut homosexuality between the killers have hurt the book's market, any clear-cut homosexual linkage between the true crime reporter himself and one of the killers would be unacceptable. Capote's compassion for Perry in the narrative is obvious, but his own romantic attraction to Perry is less so. (119)

It's not clear that explicit homosexuality would have harmed book sales; indeed, revealing the nature of the relationship as the strategy behind the murders may have been merely a motive *coup*. Readers and then moviegoers might not have blinked in seeing a gay man executed, if the audience was expected to be complicit in expecting queer punishment on several levels. More than just the expectation of death-by-same-sex desire, titillating revision, or superimposed homosexual agenda as homicide, the bravery of McGrath's film in showing the manifestation and deadliness of homophobia has not fully been given its due.

A Fifties/Sixties [Queer] Couple

Capote could dazzle (be queer) off-screen, but the screen itself could not bear the weight of the homosexual directives at work during and in the creation of *In Cold Blood* itself—lest "every man be blind." A queerer, less closeted time such as the mid-2000s becomes my ultimate destination for full dazzle, gradually calibrated, fully at work as a process of adapting and indeed of adaptation itself. A. O. Scott mentions in his *New York Times* review of *Infamous* that "the release of two movies on the same subject is somewhat unusual, and the arrival in close succession of two good movies that tell more or less identical stories, each one distinguished by real intelligence in conception and execution, is downright uncanny." Far from being just show, or even uncanny, there is a fundamental difference between the Capote films: the rate at which Capote's

character is allowed to dazzle, and the rate at which queer desire is allowed to foster the increasingly dazzling bond between its same-sex protagonists. This gradual queerness dazzles in its trajectory and becomes the impetus for plot, characterization, and narrative coherence by the time of McGrath's *Infamous*.

Yet not everyone agreed. Film critic Pace J. Miller, for example, found *Capote* a more persuasive film:

> I found it interesting that both films focused almost entirely on Capote's relationship with Perry, even though Dick also played a very large role in the book. Nevertheless, I thought *Capote* handled this crucial part of the story better than *Infamous* did. In *Capote*, you really get a sense of the struggle Capote is facing—he clearly feels something for Perry (though exactly what that feeling is is left rather ambiguous) but he also knows he must finish his masterpiece—and that obsession, vanity and selfishness eventually gets the better of him. As for *Infamous* … I didn't fully buy into the relationship, which lacked the emotional power of the earlier film, even though it actually depicted a physical relationship between the two men.

The observation that *Capote* realized the relationship discussed herein better than *Infamous* is precisely the kind of thing that, unintentionally I'm sure, effaces the actual physical and emotional desire between the two characters in lieu of the reductively performed *idea* of their attraction, and thus their fundamental impetus. In other words, *Tell, don't show*; the effect is (gently, dimly) homophobic.

Probably the most problematic (read: sanitized) element in the queer deprogramming therapy approach would be the way Capote and his life partner Jack Dunphy are literally shown but not shown in the filmed Dan Futterman screenplay for *Capote*. We see two men on the phone late at night at different times in both films (only one of whom appears in his undergarments at a time—two men talking on the phone, both in their skivvies in 1959 apparently being illegal); bringing home groceries, and talking across rooms; we hear Catherine Keener's Nelle Harper Lee observing that his relationship with Dunphy might be the thing she likes best about Truman; we see Dunphy admonishing Capote for not celebrating the film release of *To Kill A Mockingbird* and cautioning Capote about needing Perry and Dick to die in order to finish his book. We also see them walking together in Brooklyn early on (signal: a couple!),

debating whether Truman should go to Kansas—but the film never provides any clue that these men are anything but spatial roommates.

To put it sharply, in Futterman's vision for *Capote*, these men never touch—not once. Not even in interior scenes. It's easy to complain of the lack of queer presence in the 2005 *Capote* if all we have of queerness are Hoffman's verbal tics, slurs, and easy adherence to what Truman's arch nemesis Gore Vidal describes in *Infamous* as "the sound a Brussel sprout would make … if a Brussel sprout could talk!" *Infamous*, on the other hand, plays its queerness in several ways: covert, overt, and menacing. While we may not see Dunphy and Capote act much like a couple in this film either, the queerness at the heart of *Infamous'* narrative strategy is not merely implied—it is overt. This effect adds a decidedly twenty-first-century layer of audacity and fabulosity to the events of the 1950s–'60s, when being openly gay brought with it more than the implication of peril.

Being openly, actively queer was not the only casualty of the original text of ICB or of the first Capote film; the truce Capote made between ICB's facts and their adaptation into entertainment turned into a moral debate. After British arts critic Kenneth Tynan's review of *In Cold Blood* implied that Capote wanted an execution so the book would have an effective ending, a feud between Capote and Tynan erupted in the pages of *The Observer*. Tynan wrote,

> We are talking, in the long run, about responsibility; the debt that a writer arguably owes to those who provide him—down to the last autobiographical parentheses—with his subject matter and his livelihood … For the first time an influential writer of the front rank has been placed in a position of privileged intimacy with criminals about to die, and—in my view—done less than he might have to save them. The focus narrows sharply down on priorities: does the work come first, or does life? (qtd. in Allen 1)

Chez Capote, the work came first; the life, not second, but occurring in an alternate universe of queer censorship, dreamscape, and suppression of violence, released slowly, as gradually as if on a gauge and the opposite of bedazzlement: Capote himself, constantly interviewed about the intersection of life and fiction, realness and artifice, eventually became somewhat of a rote responder, the more numb and despondent he became without Perry Smith—surely punishment enough for having helped to bring them in front of the world to the gallows.

Choices

Almost thirty years after Kenneth Tynan's rant in the *Observer*, Tim Appello, in the November 22, 1996, issue of *Entertainment Weekly*, critiqued the television miniseries iteration of ICB—featuring such formidable talents as Eric Roberts, Anthony Edwards, Sam Elliot, and Gwen Verdon—ruminating on the pop-culture impact of Capote's book:

> In these days of *Millennium*, *Seven*, and Dean Koontz novels, this case may strike some as—dare we say it?—tame. But back in 1965—when Capote published his chilling account of Hickok and Smith's crime, months on the run, and capture—violence and mass murder had yet to become pop-culture staples. The groundbreaking in-the-mind-of-real-killers book went on to sell more than 5 million copies, introduced a new genre (the nonfiction novel), and made Capote rich—but at great cost to his mental health. "It did kill me," the stressed-out author later said; indeed, Capote struggled for years with writer's block.

So, apparently, Capote was killed by his ambitious creative output and the subsequent death and retraction of his muse—meaning Smith, surely, as well as the elusive creative process that died slowly starting that night on the gallows. It is clear that a queer adaptation can revive a figure as large and luminous as Capote, and with McGrath's sense of complete and calibrated queer dazzlement, tell the story and correct the dynamic of a murder and its consequences. Maybe the tameness referred to by Appello over twenty years ago needed a queer re-envisioning to create the edge and follow-through horror of the gay panic defense that *Infamous* so clearly delivers.

The audacity of situating a fully responsive (if not *responsible*) Capote into his own narrative where he is both tormented and fulfilled by the antagonist who becomes protagonist and love interest, both of which are removed by the long drop in one fell swoop, clarifies why Capote could not write much from 1967 onward, and why we need to revisit the narrative with fresh adaptive edge (and why there may not be a more fulfilling and more devastating adaptation possible: the gay card has been played, and it is the ace in the hole, the instigating factor, the non-faction element of both fact and fiction that still feels truest today, predicated as it is on the basic narrative *sturm-und-drang* of same-sex desire). Toby Jones's performance and *accoutrement* in the Christmas dinner scene at the Dewey's is played as a remarkably un-gradual dazzlement—Jones in

a floor-length scarf, sporting Capote's imitable "baby-coo-meets-ten-gin-and-tonics" voice, his divine swishiness, unfiltered and definitely not coming out "under the radar," as Bullock's Harper Lee suggests at the start of their time in Holcomb, trying to ingratiate themselves with the locals. "You know how impossible it is for me to modify myself," says Jones's Capote. Indeed: the lack of self-"editing" can be seen as an act of defiance against homophobia—or the threat of more—that runs through McGrath's masterwork, to culminate—where else—in horror and the canceling of lives in the space where homophobia triumphs. New iterations of ICB, seeking edge, may not consider that the nonfiction novelistic element so sought by Capote might have already been achieved on film, ironically by positing Capote himself as a character who figuratively died on the gallows alongside Hickock and Smith, his prayers having been answered and fulfilled. Those prayers: to find love beyond authorial control, and to find a reason to live, even as that love was, as director McGrath put it, "only alive in his imagination" and unobtainable beyond the arc and polish of a pen, a document, a font—or *le stylo* of auteur theory, with its queer shoulder to the wheel.

A Gradual Finale: How Queer Is Queer?

In Cold Blood, then, appears to have been adapted best as a queer standard of adaptation, enacting the love that dare not speak its name (as Jones also enacts, interrupting and shutting down Bullock's question regarding the nature of his relationship with Smith). In the end, even in the highly closeted atmosphere of 1959–1965 when the events herein created the premise of a true crime predicated on how homophobia kills, the closet is the truest adaptation. In watching *Infamous,* we understand the ramifications of the closet, the abnegations that queer men were subjected to, and the concomitant violence that the closet regulated from version to version of ICB. The most revealing adaptation that McGrath and company may offer is to consider how, seven lives and almost sixty years worth of adaptations later (from 1959 to 2018), the closet and its discontents shouldn't have even existed in the first place. McGrath's tactic of having his Truman silence his childhood best friend (Harper Lee), of all people, in stating the truth of his relationship with Smith plays infinitely louder than silence and conjecture heretofore have achieved regarding the nature of the intimacy between both men, on screen or off. It's a clever tactic to dazzle the audience gradually with the nature of

this same-sex desire, as if the revelation of it were happening in real time, from prison cell to Kansas hotel room to big New York City restaurant. In *Infamous*, McGrath enables his audience to acknowledge the basic truth of same-sex desire being subsumed into everyday heteronormative performances and violence.

The final cumulative performativity of ICB, almost sixty years into its many manifestations, its gradual sizzle of homosocial possibilities and revisionary ethos, has created a rich example of how the closet can dissolve like a slow fade around the subtext of desire to become its centrifugal force; or, to adapt the words of Andrew Parker and Eve Sedgwick, "performativity [in ICB] has enabled a powerful appreciation of the ways that identities are constructed iteratively through complex citation processes" (2). Truman Capote has become the impetus for such processes, a long and intricate network of references that seem to have a start—a newspaper clipping, or the act of reading a newspaper clipping that purports to tell the truth, and nothing but—to an end that only restarts itself anew in the open-ended and apparently unstoppable force of the act of phrasing, enacting, and divulging a chronicle as a calibrated tempest of suppressed same-sex desire-in-progress and its repercussions, ostensibly no longer just an act of concealment (or worse—seven deaths' worth, and how many more untold and yet to be told?) for the late McCarthy era in which Capote came of age.

Capote and his iterations—from *New York Times* article to last film version—might be described as diasporadic. These evasive, increasing iterations create their own set of itinerant expectations for presence and absence from version to version, creating a standard that is evasive and relentless, especially within the trajectory displayed by the many guises of ICB. But for Capote, there was no core of pure truth to be reached—only the revisionary genius of sequence. Capote's book ending, for instance, that fabricated meeting at the Clutter grave site between a fictitious friend of Nancy's and the aforementioned detective Alvin Dewey, would be changed in most of the filmed adaptations of ICB, which seems appropriate. For to forge closure on a life, so brutally depicted in the ending of the textual ICB, started a sequence of creative transfer of real lives into fictitious truths that shows no sign of ever completely closing down the curtain on the narrative power of inhumanity. Infamy may always be a fundamental way into regard the events of 1959–1966; what the film *Infamous* achieved is a full depiction of how much both the truth and the shaping of it into commerce, genre, and collateral

damage continue to inform the way we shape and adapt ourselves and our narratives through the kind of nonfictive violence and homophobia that, far from being a period piece or concern, renews itself every day.

What is at the core of the enduring interest for Truman Capote, creator and creation, source and material, human being, artist, and artifact combining the best of art and fact? I take as a final given that Capote, a singular queer in a time difficult for anyone, but certainly for queers, to be visible, productive, successful, becomes—as our referential closet door has opened wider and is finally torn off its hinges for good, Walt Whitman–style, by the necessary ordinariness of being out as LGTBQ people without having to adapt our identities for survival on a daily basis—the ultimate adaptation of life into art, and vice versa. As Sandra Bullock's Harper Lee reminds us to explain her lifelong friend Truman at the end of *Infamous*, "When you're tiny, you have to be tough …. This world isn't kind to little things." Tiny, tough, and dreamy (with a snap)—how best to adapt such an ephemeral flame? The answer is, for Capote, at least since 1959, with adaptations that flicker over and over again—but gayer, and slowly, increasingly, until we can say, with fuller and fuller illumination, *No gayest, there is none*.[2]

Notes

1. The title of Capote's unfinished novel, from the St. Teresa of Avila adage, "More tears are shed over answered prayers than unanswered ones." The quote is sometimes attributed to Capote—no wonder, as he continued to use it whenever he was asked about his long-awaited novel-in-progress. This was the "what's next?" question from 1965 to 1984—around nineteen years.
2. A paraphrase of the title of one of Gerard Manley Hopkins' last sonnets, "*No worst, there is none*."

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Check for updates

CHAPTER 15

Willful Infidelities: Camping *Camille*

Jamie Hook

In a discussion of Warhol superstars Jackie Curtis, Candy Darling, and Holly Woodlawn, cult postwar film critic Parker Tyler describes the three "actress-transvestites" as attaining "the enigmatic veracity of Garbo saying—this was in *Camille* in a scene with Armand—'What are you doing, anyway, with a woman like me?'" (202).[1] Tyler's conversational aside indicates how by the early 1970s *Camille* could serve as an instructive reference point in examining the queer underground with no elaboration needed. Indeed, in the 124 years between 1848, when Marguerite Gautier (or Camille as she has commonly been called in the English-speaking world) entered Western literary history, and 1972, when Tyler's groundbreaking *Screening the Sexes* was first published, the story and character of Camille had managed to accumulate a range of queer meanings, several significant manifestations of which interface with the emergence and mainstreaming of camp as a sensibility, reading strategy, and performance style.

In July 1969—half a decade after Susan Sontag's "Notes on 'Camp'" first appeared in the *Partisan Review*—Radley Metzger's *Camille 2000* opened at New York City's Cine Lido and Cine Malibu theaters. Based

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on Alexander Dumas fils's 1848 novel *La dame aux camélias*, the film (while earning mixed reviews) helped secure Metzger's reputation as an auteur of highbrow erotica for mixed-sex audiences, yet also registers queerly as camp through its ostentatious elegance and glamorized vision of suffering. Just under four years later, in May of 1973, Charles Ludlam of the Ridiculous Theatrical Company opened his own version of *Camille* at New York's Thirteenth Street Theatre, in which he starred in the leading role of the tragic Marguerite. The performance was acclaimed within the downtown theater scene, with *New York Times* critic Clive Barnes writing that "while Mr. Ludlam takes very little pains to convince us that he is a woman … [h]e is a completely convincing Camille" who "plays every scene with total sincerity" (31).

Beyond the adapted text[2] they share, at an initial glance, Metzger's and Ludlam's adaptations could hardly appear more dissimilar. The former is glossy and aesthetically looks like nothing so much as a visual recapitulation of Federico Fellini's *La dolce vita* (1960) in its cynical imaging of a flamboyantly decadent Rome and its jetsetter habitués, an appropriate mid-century surrogate for the nineteenth-century Parisian demimonde of Dumas. Unlike Fellini's popularly carnivalesque mise-en-scène and despite its nuanced and sympathetic representation of Marguerite, Metzger's film still does much to reinforce the heteropatriarchal sexual economy that at the time was being rigorously challenged and rejected outright elsewhere.

Elsewhere—like at the Ridiculous Theatrical Company. In a pioneering history of the off-off-Broadway movement, Stephen J. Bottoms reads Ludlam's *Camille* with respect to contemporaneous feminist debates about the potential for misogyny within drag performance and yet argues that something with much more progressive promise was taking place, largely through Ludlam's anti-illusionism and explicit choice to maintain a tension between his biological sex and gender performance as Marguerite as manifested in variegated signifiers such as the "low-cut gown that showed off his plentiful chest hair" (358).

Despite the not inconsiderable distance that differentiates them aesthetically, economically, and in terms of artistic medium, both adaptations nevertheless reactivated the same source material from over a century earlier in the charged context of a sexual revolutionary mediascape, wherein camp had emerged as a highly visible and pervasive representational trend. With their different imagined audiences (i.e., middle-class heterosexual versus queerly countercultural) and

strikingly divergent investments in the evolving erotic norms and sexual economies of the sexual revolution (i.e., Metzger's as a commercial film and Ludlam's as part of an off-off-Broadway scene as motley as it was vibrant), the texts seemingly evoke Sontag's well-known dichotomy between naïve and deliberate camp. While there may be some degree of truth in this, more interesting is how both in their own ways complicate the problematic binary often drawn between adaptive faithfulness and infidelity. Considering both texts as camp adaptations renders such a dichotomy inoperable and instead opens critical space for a more layered and historiographically informed understanding of their queer textual interrelationships to take hold.

That both can and have been read as camp is indicative of the heterogeneity of the term itself—that mercurial sensibility, which "is almost, but not quite, ineffable" (Sontag 54). The greater the definitional latitude when acknowledging the variable cultural positions out of which camp adaptations might emerge and the attendant ideological functions they might then support, the greater the risk of opening that proverbial can of worms in which we find a series of dichotomous positions that have long animated scholarly debates about camp: whether camp is intensely political (either progressively or reactionarily so) or apolitical; whether it is a quality that inheres in objects or can only be activated through a knowing gaze; whether camp is an elitist discourse dependent on exclusive formations of cultural capital or democratizing in its freewheeling attitude and disregard for entrenched cultural hierarchies; whether it is the restricted province of white gay men or is available to other disenfranchised groups and/or even the mainstream; whether camp that *has* gone mainstream still deserves to be called camp or is better classified as something else entirely, and so on. While it is outside the scope of this chapter to put to rest or even exhaustively summarize the positions that have been advanced with respect to the foregoing problematics surrounding camp, what it can do is consider how some of these questions might inform expressions of camp within artistic production specifically framed as practices of adaptation.

It is not uncommon for camp to be discussed in terms that already encroach on the language of adaptation. In the opening remarks to her now infamous fifty-eight notes, Sontag frames the sensibility of camp as one that "*converts* the serious into the frivolous" (54). Jack Babuscio describes how camp aestheticism "aims to *transform* the ordinary into something more spectacular" (122). For Moe Meyer, camp is

a resolutely queer "*parodic* operation" (1). Pamela Robertson theorizes feminist camp as "*recoding* [stereotypes] according to contemporary tastes and needs," which is in a sense "a form of *recycling*" (142, emphases added). Discussions of conversion, transformation, parodying, recycling, and the like, have long been used by theorists to guide their answers to that hard-to-pin-down question of what precisely adaptation does (i.e., how and through what mechanisms does it convert, transform, and/or recycle an existent text into something else?). In her seminal *A Theory of Adaptation*, Linda Hutcheon suggests it is "no accident that we use the same word—adaptation—to refer to the process and the product" (7). Displaying a not dissimilar linguistic elasticity, the word camp can function as a noun (e.g., Ludlam's *Camille* is camp), an adjective (e.g., Ludlam's camp version of *Camille*), or a verb (e.g., Ludlam camps *Camille*). Thus, in this context, to camp something can be understood as introducing a specific style or tone into the adaptation (process), which ultimately results in an adaptation (product) legible as camp.

This immediately raises the question of fidelity, that ubiquitous hallmark of adaptation analysis. In a commentary detailing the history of adaptation studies as an academic formation, theorist Simone Murray reminds us that not uncommonly "adaptations [interrogate] the political and ideological underpinnings of their source texts, translating works across cultural, gender, racial and sexual boundaries to secure cultural space for marginalized discourses" (10). This means that, more often than is sometimes acknowledged, "willful *in*fidelity [is] in fact the very *point*" of adaptation (10, emphasis in original). In its often dialectical veneration and travestying of the material under adaptation, the camping of canonical sources offers an appropriately flamboyant concretization of this idea.

It is perhaps no coincidence that the matter of (in)fidelity also remains a looming issue within sexual discourses, one that has long carried particular implications within queer cultures. For their part, adaptation theorists have carefully documented how (chiefly film) adaptations are habitually stigmatized through language positively laden with sexual connotations. Robert Stam, for instance, reveals how moralizing terms such as "infidelity," "betrayal," "violation," and "desecration" abound in conventional adaptation discourse (54). James Naremore describes how even commentary on adaptation that strives for objectivity often "betrays certain unexamined ideological concerns … and cannot avoid a gendered language associated with the notion of 'fidelity'" (8).

Of course, challenges to the necessity, desirability, and supposed morality of traditional (read: Western, heteropatriarchal) definitions of fidelity have comprised a vital subject of social debate within the queer communities out of which camp sensibilities and aesthetics first emerged. What does it tell us about sex and its mediated representation that analogous cultural anxieties could underlie such seemingly unrelated phenomena as the stigmatization of a media text's "imperfect" relationship with its prior source(s) *and* the stigmatization of all manner of sexual practices that run counter to that of, to borrow Robin Wood's memorable phrase, "monogamous heterosexual bourgeois patriarchal capitalists" (71)?

In certain significant respects, *La dame aux camélias* is an ideal text through which to explore how adaptation functions in relation to a decidedly queer notion of fidelity. Itself a quasi-*roman à clef* inspired by Dumas's own romance with courtesan Marie Duplessis, the novel has been adapted recurrently since its initial publication in 1848—several times for stage (initially by Dumas himself),[3] as Giuseppe Verdi's canonical opera *La traviata* (1853), a handful of times for ballet, at least once for musical theater, and an almost countless number of times for film in many major national cinemas. Its textual history is therefore fairly described as incredibly fertile and, fittingly, promiscuous. Any potential objection to the manifold uses to which Dumas's story has been put finds a rejoinder within the so-called "sacred" source text itself. Structured using a framing device that has been eliminated in virtually every major stage and screen adaptation, the novel opens after Marguerite's death and follows an unnamed narrator as he befriends a grief-stricken Armand Duval, whose account of his tragic romance then constitutes the body of the novel. Immediately before commencing his recollection, Armand tells the narrator, "It's a very simple tale … and I shall tell it in the order in which it happened. If at some stage you do make something of it, you are perfectly free to tell it another way" (41). Thus to uncover the license to adapt freely, to willfully practice infidelity as it were, artists like Metzger and Ludlam who have themselves retold the story need look no further than the ethics of storytelling as articulated by Dumas's own protagonist.

In an added layer of reflexivity Marguerite, the novel's tragic heroine, is a character defined through her social world's highly codified but perhaps surprisingly nuanced rules of fidelity, rules that she challenges before she is ultimately undone by their incompatibility with the conventional monogamy her love for Armand inspires her to fleetingly pursue.

It is largely through the self-determined management of her sexuality and the romanticized, histrionic suffering this brings that Marguerite/Camille became a figure of identification and high resonance for gay men as stigmatized subjects in a homophobic society. This has in turn opened the narrative up to queer understandings and adaptations of various kinds.[4] Referring to George Cukor's 1936 adaptation for Metro-Goldwyn-Mayer starring gay icon Greta Garbo, queer theorist Alexander Doty admits there was a time when

> I—and thousands of queers—used to cry at the end of *Camille* because of a shifting masochistic identification with both Marguerite's ecstatic death-in-love and the beginnings of Armand's necrophiliac erotic obsession. In either case, not very empowering tears of romanticized self-pity were shed over what queers on- and offscreen supposed was the inevitably tragic fate of "sick" and forbidden desires. (34)

Although he does not mention camp directly, Doty hints that as the years passed these tears took on an ironic, reflexive, and proto-politically queer quality, partially motivated by "a sad sense that Garbo, [Robert] Taylor, and Cukor are pantomiming individual and cultural tragedies, depicting the impossibility of directly expressing the queer desire they all felt, in a film they clearly cared so much about" (34–35). Consequently even this widely distributed, culturally sanctioned, and ostensibly "straight" adaptation allows space for the practice of camp spectatorship; perhaps expectedly, Garbo's portrayal of Marguerite is also the one through which Ludlam admits he first "developed such an identity with the role" (Ludlam and Samuels 36).

As has been well-documented by queer scholars, it was only around the time of post-WWII gay liberation that the word "gay" became strictly equated with homosexuality. "Originally referring simply to things pleasurable," writes George Chauncey, "by the seventeenth century *gay* had come to refer more specifically to a life of *immoral* pleasures and dissipation" (17). Later, in the nineteenth century, it referred to women engaged in prostitution as well as "to something brightly colored or someone showily dressed" (17). Separately and together these definitions affirm that Marguerite Gautier is fairly read as a very gay woman indeed. Thus in adapting her story and serving as the vehicle for her literal embodiment on stage, Ludlam bridged the earlier moment of the novel's creation, when such varied definitions of the term were sustained,

with his own, literalizing Marguerite's gayness in accord with the newly specific vernacular of gay liberation. In contrast, Metzger's Marguerite fulfilled the *Playboy*-consecrated image of the newly sexually available, "liberated" woman largely through French actor Danièle Gaubert's performance and physical presence, which *Variety* credited to "Metzger's eye for luscious, bosomy female sexpot beauty" ("Camille 2000" 6).

In assessing Radley Metzger's place in the rapidly evolving film culture of the 1960s and '70s, Elena Gorfinkel identifies how his films "[mediate] between the high culture status of the foreign art film and the rough-hewn, low-cult material of the sexploitation feature" (27). This is certainly true of *Camille 2000*, which opens with visual nods toward such esteemed European art films as Fellini's *La dolce vita* and Jean-Luc Godard's *Contempt* (1963),[5] while at the same time offering, as *Boxoffice* was quick to assure potential exhibitors, "certainly enough graphic sex to satisfy the peek-a-boo audience" ("Camille 2000" a11). Its status as an adaptation also contributed to the film's high cultural valence. Adaptation had already figured in Metzger's developing authorial reputation; his two most recent films prior to *Camille 2000* also performed erotic adaptations of "respectable" literary material: *Carmen, Baby* (1967; based on Prosper Mérimée's 1845 novella *Carmen*, which most famously served as the source for Georges Bizet's 1875 opera) and *Therese and Isabelle* (1968; based on the 1966 book of the same name by Violette Leduc, a French novelist championed by such luminaries as Albert Camus and Jean-Paul Sartre).

While for critics and audiences such literary origins served to distinguish Metzger's films from those of contemporaries like Russ Meyer, Joe Sarno, and Doris Wishman, for Metzger, adaptation also fulfilled a more practical function. About *Carmen, Baby* he stated, "I felt really insecure about the story. I didn't really understand story construction. I was never trained as a writer. I needed a structure, I had to have a skeleton, something. So, I said, we'll take an old story that's been done and dress it up in modern terms" (qtd in Gallagher). This strategy not only worked but also proved replicable, as these words accurately describe the adaptive approach taken for *Camille 2000*.

In contrast to Ludlam, Metzger was not explicitly associated with camp during this period. Even so, critical response at the time isolated elements of his filmmaking that anticipate and substantiate Gorfinkel's claim that "[i]n assessing Metzger's work in the present, one is struck by its capacity for camp reading" (39). Richard Corliss, for instance,

noted both Metzger's skill "at creating an almost tactile milieu of quasi-aristocratic decadence," but also "the frequent banality and obviousness of his scripts" (19). Such incongruity between style and content is often seen as engendering camp, while Corliss's description of the *quasi*-aristocratic calls to mind those figurative scare quotes with which camp so frequently surrounds its objects (e.g., something is not aristocratic, but "aristocratic"). Regarding *Camille 2000* specifically, *The Independent Film Journal*'s review—which itself opens with the campy quip, "Camille no longer coughs, she swings"—begins with a description of the film's mise-en-scène that evokes camp's oft-cited fetishistic interest in surfaces and textures, calling the film "a plastic movie featuring plastic-looking people encased in a world of clear vinyl" ("Camille 2000" 1061) as reflected, for instance, in the translucent inflatable pillows and diaphanous sheets that adorn Marguerite's futuristic-looking bed (see Fig. 15.1). *Variety* indirectly gestured toward camp's frequent play with history, penchant for anachronism, and blithe intertextuality when it rather condescendingly suggested, "If it seems ridiculous that 19th-century mores and morals are too apparent in the supposed 'now' dolce-vita Roman world of 'Camille 2000,' that perhaps will only serve to increase its mass audience" (6).

This reference to a mass audience is telling insofar as *Camille 2000*'s legibility as camp relies on the emergence shortly before its premiere of a different breed of camp thought to possess mainstream or crossover



Fig. 15.1 Armand (Nino Castelnuovo) and Marguerite (Danièle Gaubert) settled into their "world of clear vinyl" in *Camille 2000*

appeal. Recognized and discussed by scholars such as Andrew Ross ("pop camp"), Moe Meyer ("camp trace"), Chuck Kleinhans ("het camp"), Helene Shugart and Catherine Waggoner ("camp lite"), and Barbara Klinger ("mass camp"), this is a subspecies of many names that, while still legible as camp, seems to fall short of its aesthetic and political ideal. As Klinger summarizes, mass camp shares a "flagrant disregard of traditional aesthetics and heightened consciousness of conventional sex roles," but without taking on any of the same risks as its forerunner, functioning instead as "a sign of social hipness and superiority, without the 'stigma' of subcultural affiliation" (139–140). A few notable exceptions aside, Metzger's early work saw sexual stigma as something to be eschewed through film style—European location shooting, lavish production design, showy framings and camera movements—and indeed, he found ways to successfully (if ultimately imperfectly) do just this through aesthetically negotiating a variety of sociocultural taboos attendant to human sexuality and its mediated representation during this period presaged by the crumbling and ultimate fall of the Motion Picture Production Code in 1968. Metzger's commercially driven goal was to integrate the erotic into a certain tradition of quality, making sex respectable without calling into question the class-based mechanisms of respectability itself. This often came through downplaying or mitigating the most potently iconoclastic potential of the sexually taboo as opposed to aggrandizing and reveling in it in the manner of Ludlam.

About *Camille 2000* Metzger claimed, "Most people were familiar with the Garbo film, but that was adapted from the play Dumas wrote after the huge success of his novel. I went to the novel as the source" (qtd. in Gallagher). Judging by what we see on screen, this is not entirely accurate, given that the finished film actually adheres in quite significant ways to the narrative structure Dumas reconfigured for his play, which had already helped crystalize the story of Camille in the cultural imaginary to a degree that eclipsed the novel itself (as Metzger's comment indicates). The most relevant inheritances from the play—appearing not only in *Camille 2000*, but other major adaptations such as *Camille* (1936) and *La traviata*—include the elimination of the novel's aforementioned framing device, the narratively linear dramatization of Armand's father's insistence that Marguerite abandon his son,[6] and the lovers' heartbreaking reunion shortly before Marguerite's death, unlike the novel in which she dies before Armand is able to return to her bedside.

Precisely because its narrative structure so closely follows the Garbo film (which already follows the basic contours of Dumas's play),[7] scenes in *Camille 2000* sometimes possess an "already seen" quality that works to activate their camp potential. Contemporized reiterations of key moments freely ricochet against memories of their older counterparts, a function of the film as an adaptation as well as simultaneously generative for its camp appreciation. As Hutcheon notes, to experience a text "*as an adaptation* … we need to recognize it as such and to know its adapted text, thus allowing the latter to oscillate in our memories with what we are experiencing" (120–121). In a different context, Klinger calls attention to the close relationship between mass camp and Hollywood cinema:

> The camp sensibility has always gravitated toward objects from the past—the Greta Garbos, *King Kong*s, and *Casablanca*s of the film world, for example. This penchant implicitly relies on the historical otherness of the designated objects, their indelible difference from standards of the present, which makes them completely susceptible to transformation through the camp imagination. (140)

The respective processes described by Hutcheon and Klinger both speak to dialectical configurations between similarity and difference, recognition and transformation. Metzger's *Camille 2000* unabashedly situates the familiar narrative in a swinging sixties aesthetic—a prime milieu for mass camp to flourish—but, does this ultimately render it unfaithful? Or, is there a paradoxical sort of fidelity precisely in mitigating the novel's "historical otherness" by using the *dolce vita* aesthetic and setting as a topical correlative to "the easy morality of the times," (4) as Dumas's narrator describes the mid-nineteenth century? To answer this question, one might take a lesson from the film itself, awash as it is with moments that suggest commitment is not synonymous with fidelity and fidelity itself is not dependent on exclusivity. As Marguerite's maid forcefully reminds a jealous Armand, "There are many kinds of devotion."

An adaptor's devotion to an adapted text does not take any one prescribed form. This is evident when comparing Metzger's and Ludlam's adaptations. Next to *Camille 2000*, Ludlam's *Camille* (subtitled "*A Travesty on* La Dame aux Camélias") is perhaps surprisingly more conventionally faithful to Dumas at least at the level of dialogue, much of which exists as a more or less accurate English translation of Dumas's

own stage adaptation.[8] At the same time, however, adaptations not infrequently adapt *other* existent adaptations of their adapted texts, as is unquestionably the case here; in addition to the amount of dialogue lifted wholesale from Dumas's play, Ludlam restores several elements from the novel that Dumas himself dispensed within his own adaptation as well as inserts several episodes that originate in the Cukor/Garbo film. He also restructures the five acts of the earlier play into three acts and four scenes, which, it is hard to believe coincidentally, precisely mirrors Verdi and librettist Francesco Maria Piave's scenario for *La traviata*. This web of influences was hardly invisible to critics. Clive Barnes commented on its intermediality, writing "Mr. Ludlam says his play is 'freely adapted from "La Dame aux Camelias,"' but it has also had a certain help from Verdi's opera and Garbo's movie" (31), while Steven Weisman curiously used the heroine of *La traviata* as his touchstone: "Mr. Ludlam has adapted the story himself, throwing in reference to all the Violettas you might know, from Garbo's to Verdi's" (38). Approaching Ludlam's adaptation, the question of textual fidelity is already rendered strange from the outset as there exists no single text with which Ludlam's version could reasonably be "monogamously" linked in the first place, especially given that sources like *La traviata* and Cukor's *Camille* are already canonical in their respective mediums. This collage of already adapted "originals" forms the background against which the element of camp is then foregrounded.

Ludlam himself had a vexed relationship with the term, retrospectively stating, "I just didn't see camp in our show. It was a play—very definitely *not* a drag show!" (Ludlam and Samuels 39).[9] Underwriting this disavowal is Ludlam's framing of camp and drag as wholly collapsible enterprises. For central to Ludlam's conception of the play was that he and co-stars Jack Mallory and George Osterman, all of whom portrayed women, *not* give drag impersonations but, rather, sincere interpretations of their characters, who just happened to be of another sex. Accordingly, Ludlam biographer David Kaufman neatly summarizes Ludlam's Marguerite as acted "in a manner that both was and wasn't 'drag'" (186). Ludlam himself, with recourse to his encyclopedic knowledge of theater history, argued:

> In the Kabuki and in the Elizabethan theatre men played women's roles and no one blinked an eye. Originally, all women's roles in Shakespeare were played by men. And, in the reverse, Sarah Bernhardt played Hamlet.

> Hamlet is traditionally a man's part, Marguerite is traditionally a woman's part. What ladies have been given to do in various male impersonations is just what I did in *Camille*. Women are Peter Pan and all the rest of it; I, a man, am Marguerite Gautier. (Ludlam and Samuels 40)

Years before gender theorists produced pioneering works defining gender as a social construct embodied through performance, Ludlam gave life to this idea on stage. Describing his intention to "experiment with female impersonation," he explained how casting and performance in his theater work to produce "different levels of reality and unreality," which ultimately leads to "the rigidity with which we look at sexual roles and reversals break[ing] down" (Ludlam and Samuels 45).

Nowadays it is perhaps easier to recognize how Ludlam's performance occupied a queerly liminal space; it might not have been the same sort of night club-based drag detailed by ethnographer Esther Newton in her groundbreaking anthropological study *Mother Camp* (1972), but it certainly was not *not* drag. Indeed, Ludlam transformed Marguerite into a kind of drag queen not only literally but also tonally through bitchy and politically incorrect one-liners; about the hats her confidante Prudence designs, Marguerite declares, "Dahling, they're beastly. I wouldn't wear one to a dogfight" (11). The interplay between such campy quips and "straight" recitations from Dumas's text makes perfect sense within the affective strategy Ludlam described wherein, "One had moments of being absorbed into the narrative, and moments when one was reminded that one was in a theatre" (Ludlam and Samuels 42). And guided by Doty's reminder that queer readings "result from the recognition and articulation of the complex range of queerness that has been in popular culture texts and their audiences all along" (16), it might be noted how Dumas's own theatrical adaptation technically already included an instance of gender-bending. Here act one ends when, after Marguerite has first consented to Armand's declarations of love, her friends perform a mocking bridal dance, in which the men and women enter "dressed fantastically in each other's hats and bonnets" (Dumas/Heron 19). While only a fleeting moment of humor, it nevertheless exists on a continuum with the extradiegetic work that drag in Ludlam's adaptation is tasked with (i.e., wherein the audience, but not the other characters, attend to the new meanings and resonances opened up through cross-sex casting and dress). This indicates that the mockery of rigidly constructed sex roles, which would fully blossom under Ludlam, was already a seed (however undernourished and differently oriented) in Dumas.

Here and elsewhere, Ludlam's adaptation bespeaks a knowingness concerning the history of earlier camp appreciations of the story. Barnes's description of his performance as "never far away from" but also not merely a copy of Garbo's (31) suggests the dialectically queer space between faithfulness and infidelity his portrayal was able to achieve. For example, when complimented on her looks by her friend Nichette, Marguerite replies, "I always look well when I'm near death" (9), a line that comes directly from Garbo. In the context of Ludlam's quasi-masculine embodiment of the role, the line knowingly mocks previous adaptive choices that sustain a troublesome correlation between feminine beauty and suffering. The distanciation that camp allows here is paradoxically *more* faithful to the novel wherein Marguerite's physical decline is recounted in sobering detail that guides the reader to visualize how her body has become "swathed in burning poultices" (193) and how several days before her death "she lost the use of her limbs" (197). This marks a blunt contrast with the soft lighting, pure white dressing gown, and porcelain face that render Garbo angelic and spiritually virginal—and thus at her most beautiful in its narrative's sexual economy—as she perishes in Cukor's film, an image that has enjoyed high visibility far beyond its own decade (Fig. 15.2).[10]

Sexual humor also generates camp within Ludlam's adaptation and works to transform some of the most indelible aspects of its adapted material in a way congruent with its contemporary moment. In contrast to Metzger's literal updating, however, these moments are often willfully anachronistic. For instance, Ludlam links Marguerite's transgressive sexuality to S&M practices, a contemporary correlative of the sexually taboo; as she entertains one of her wealthy benefactors (in a scene that otherwise directly follows one in Cukor, but not Dumas), Marguerite furnishes fetish accoutrements such as leather masks and a dildo. The curtain falls with Marguerite ludicrously whipping the piano to which the baron, who she keeps around partially for his musical talent, has been handcuffed.[11]

A turning point in most adaptations of the story occurs as Armand asks Marguerite when he can next see her and she answers that it is when the camellia she has previously given him changes color. To this, Ludlam's Armand crushes the flower and says, "Here, it's dead already" (23), breaking the inherited romantic mood with his impatience—campy in its melding of immaturity and ingenuous literality. Ludlam pushes the exchange still further, with Marguerite explaining, "No, no, impossible.



Fig. 15.2 Armand (Robert Taylor) gazes upon Marguerite (Greta Garbo), angelic and spiritually virginal in death in *Camille*

I wear red camellias when I've got the rag on … when the moon is not favorable to pleasure. I'll be wearing white ones tomorrow" (23). Here Ludlam's Marguerite states explicitly what could only be implied by Dumas, whose narrator explains of Marguerite's eponymous flowers, "For twenty-five days in every month the camellias were white, and for five they were red. No one ever knew the reason for this variation in colour which I mention but cannot explain …" (9).

On the one hand, the crudity of Ludlam's turn of phrase might be said to "abject-ify" Marguerite's body and traffic in the kind of misogyny that feminist critiques of drag have been quick to point to when arguing that its practices of exaggerated feminine embodiment are ultimately objectifying. On the other, it should be recalled that Ludlam was hardly invested in gender verisimilitude; rather, his characterization cultivated a downright aggressive anti-illusionism. In this context, the symbology of the camellias opens to meanings beyond menstruation, such as a possible

play on the color coordination of the hanky code widely used within certain gay and bisexual male subcultures of the time to signal sexual availability and express interest in specific erotic roles and activities. Beyond the coarse humor, the camping of a recognized moment such as this works to establish a cultural continuum in which the symbolic flower of a nineteenth-century novel shares space with a newly emergent symbolic vocabulary for publically, but covertly, communicating the willingness to engage in any number of stigmatized sexual activities.

As the pathos of its tragic romance surrounds an unsanctioned relationship, often overshadowed is the fact that the narrative crisis of *La Dame aux camélias* rests on the question of marriage: not the potential for Marguerite and Armand's, but that of Armand's sister; when Armand's father famously pleads with Marguerite to relinquish her love for his son, he pressures Marguerite by informing her that the respectable family his daughter is engaged to marry into will void the arrangement if Armand continues to live in a disgraced state. He asks her: "Do you have the right to destroy her future? Are you strong enough to? In the name of your love and your repentance, Marguerite, give me my daughter's happiness" (185–186). Thus Armand's father places the blame on Marguerite instead of the patriarchal structures of marriage that actually constrain his daughter and are here mobilized by him to further victimize Marguerite. This exchange is duplicated in Ludlam's play and when she readily consents to the requested sacrifice, it seems as though Marguerite's prior feminist-informed views regarding marriage[12] have gone, highlighting the ebb and flow of camp critique that at times invades and at other times retracts from its shading of the text. This ultimately works to support Ludlam's dual desire for his audiences to laugh but "also get the impact of this forbidden love—it is really tragic and shocking" (qtd. in Lester 95). This scene, played straight for all intents and purposes, continues under a more or less unbroken (and literal) patriarchal oppressiveness with no camp ripostes to disrupt the inevitable outcome. Indeed, rather than as an adaptor with total control or iconoclastic designs for his sources, Ludlam positioned himself as virtually a slave of fidelity to what Dumas had laid out nearly a century before: "This play of *Camille* was the ultimate masochism. I went out there to try to have a happy ending every night and got knocked down by every peripeteia of the plot" (Ludlam and Samuels 41).

How Ludlam relentlessly sustains the decidedly un-campy tone of this pathos-driven scene is brilliantly deliberate, for as soon as M. Duval

has departed, Marguerite utters, "Venus Castina give me strength" (38). A queer icon rooted in classical mythology, Venus Castina (literally "Chaste Venus") is a goddess associated with androgynous or more recently trans* identities. As gender theorist G.G. Bolich explains, she "defended her temple at Ascalon by transforming the attacking Scythian men into women. By this name she was also the patron deity of men who have feminine souls caught in male bodies" (339). More than anywhere else in the text, it is easy to imagine Ludlam and Marguerite performatively becoming one at this moment in which she must summon strength for the emotionally destructive performance lying ahead (i.e., the coerced rejection of Armand), which propels characters and audience alike to the play's still tragic conclusion, now thrown into greater relief by the emotional nuances induced by the camping that has preceded it. As critic Mel Gussow quipped, "Once again, poor Camille dies, but this time we laugh" (24), while Barnes, more sensitive to the affective nuances of Ludlam's brand of camp, advised, "remember to question yourself whether all the tears are those of laughter" (31).[13]

While some critics were then surprised by the sincerity of the tragic affect with which Ludlam's *Camille* ended, Metzger's film diverged from the heartbreak with which the story has become synonymous. Here, after Marguerite has perished in an oxygen tent (itself camp in its overstatement and literalization of the dying character's traditional association with spiritual purity), we find Armand drunk with a small group of revelers on the Roman steps in shots that precisely mirror the film's already-referential opening sequence. This suggested circularity cynically undercuts the tragedy of Marguerite's sacrifice and invites into the narrative a glimpse of this era's exhilarated treatment of women as disposable playthings. Reading this moment for its camp potential has the added function of disrupting the traditional pleasures of heterosexual tragedy (rooted, of course, in the cultural primacy of heterosexuality over all other forms of romantic intimacy) and the attendant sanctity of male suffering. Aiding such a reading, the final shot of the film abruptly disrupts this facsimile of its opening scene as the camera closes in on Armand whose laughter now reads as anticipatory of an emotional collapse.

This framing device can be viewed as metaphoric for adaptation itself, which Hutcheon has described broadly as "repetition with variation" (4). Camp is, of course, but one variation any repetition of the Camille story might perform. But it is also one that is itself highly variable as the differences within and divergences between Metzger's film and Ludlam's play

attest. And—in its reliance on narratives, objects, and performance styles from the past in order to disrupt and carve out space to reframe its own here and now in decidedly queer ways—camp ultimately proves a formidable stumbling block to the application of traditional understandings of fidelity in adaptation. Bringing camp and adaptation together encourages us to foreground the importance of thinking about both as active *processes* that precede the ultimate products they generate; the queer transformations that can occur through the individual and collaborative actions of rereading, rethinking, and retelling a beloved story ask us to reevaluate what fidelity means and what value it holds. Camp adaptation insists upon the cultivation and deployment of alternative models for parsing out and making sense of the devoted, yet not exactly faithful, textual relationships it cultivates with the often-promiscuous range of influences it chooses to queerly engage. These two versions of the Camille story—and, indeed, the idea of camp or queer adaptation more generally—demonstrate what can be gained when one chooses to retell a story to which they are unquestionably devoted, yet at the same time recognize they also remain "perfectly free to tell it another way," a way which may in fact prove *more* faithful to its relationship and importance *vis-à-vis* certain identities, histories, and communities the adapted text did not originally address and could not even imagine itself capable of speaking to and for.

Notes

1. Garbo-as-Marguerite actually says, "Why should you care for a woman like me? I'm always nervous or sick, or sad, or too gay."
2. "Adapted text" is the term preferred by theorist Linda Hutcheon over the more connotatively-laden "source" or "original."
3. Dumas wrote the stage script one year after his novel's publication, although controversy would see that it was not performed until 1852.
4. Amateur filmmaker Jerett Robert Austin's own drag adaptation, filmed primarily at Fire Island's Cherry Grove, was shot as early as 1953. This remarkable fifty-minute film, for all intents and purposes an elaborate home movie, has only recently enjoyed public exhibition. While there is no indication Ludlam was aware of Austin's film, he does mention an unfinished 8 mm adaptation by Enrique Grou, suggesting Grou also played the title role (Ludlam and Samuels 41), about which little information seems to exist.

5. Fans of *Contempt* will remember the character played by Brigitte Bardot is—coincidentally or not—named Camille.
6. This is revealed only in the epistolary section that closes the novel, likely making Marguerite's abrupt desertion as shocking and inexplicable to its first readers as it is to Armand.
7. The film's opening credits state it is "From the Play and Novel by Alexandre Dumas Fils."
8. This was not always to have been the case. Earlier ideas involved producing a version set in the twenties, an "ultramodern" version in contemporary dress (perhaps comparable to Metzger's film?), and a production with everyone in drag (Ludlam and Samuels 37–38). Ludlam eventually concluded, "*Camille* is better from a distance" (Ludlam and Samuels 38), choosing to preserve Dumas's time period and setting.
9. In a more general context, however, he writes, "I think camp is great. The more people have told me that I had to get away from the word 'camp,' that it's terrible that people would call my work 'camp,' the more I decided to embrace it" (Ludlam and Samuels 227).
10. It has continued to circulate and reach diverse demographics of viewers in such mainstream texts as, for instance, the film adaptation of Thomas Meehan, Martin Charnin, and Charles Strouse's Broadway musical *Annie* (1982).
11. Metzger also draws on S&M imagery to a different effect in the mise-en-scène of Olympe's party—a mod sex dungeon replete with barred cells for couples to play in (and, of course, be seen doing so). It is here that, after leaving Armand, Marguerite returns as once again a kept woman, now literally chained to her new benefactor.
12. For instance, earlier, when Nichette suggests women can rise in status through marriage, Marguerite counters, "Marriage is nothing but legalized prostitution!" and salutes with her fist (32).
13. This uncannily recalls the moment in Dumas's novel when, trying to enjoy a stolen moment with Marguerite, Armand admits his "excited laughter, which [Prudence and Marguerite] misunderstood, was very close to tears" (96).

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